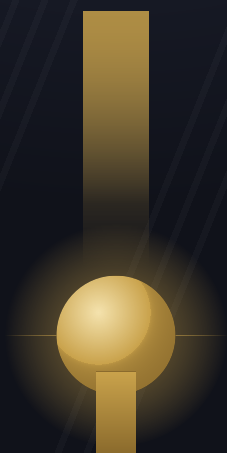


— A MITHILA COURTROOM MYSTERY —



THE SEVENTH WITNESS

सातम साक्षी

The door was locked from inside. The truth was not.

GAJENDRA THAKUR

TRANSLATED FROM THE MAITHILI BY THE AUTHOR

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himself

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Chapter 1 — Four Seventeen in the Rain

The night's rain had refused to acknowledge fatigue even by dawn. Water streamed down the thick walls of the old courthouse building as though some ancient writing were being carefully erased. The courtyard held none of the courthouse clamour of daytime; there was only the spill from the eaves, the gurgle of the drains, and, somewhere far away, an occasional bark from a half-asleep dog. The clock showed four seventeen, but the clock inside the old records room had stopped at that very time—its hands utterly still.

Buchchan Paswan, who kept watch at the rear gate of the building, at first assumed that someone must still be working inside. Such a habit was not new in Vasudha Karn. Once a case took hold of her, the boundary between day and night grew thin. But two hours passed while the rain weakened and swelled again; the yellow light inside did not go out, and no answer came when he knocked on the door.

“Vasudha Didi?” Buchchan called softly at first. Then louder: “Didi, open the door. Dawn is about to break.”

Nothing from within.

He shook the latch. The door was fastened from inside. Through the narrow gap between the old wooden panels, a yellow thread of light spilled outward. For a moment Buchchan thought: lawyers spread out so many papers; perhaps she had fallen asleep among them. Then he remembered the previous evening. Vasudha had gone in, shaking the rain from her umbrella. With her was a thin, dark-complexioned girl whom Buchchan knew as Dulari.

At the thought, a faint tremor passed through his chest.

At the other end of the veranda, Somari Devi, the cleaner, had propped her broom against the wall and was waiting for the rain to stop. Buchchan called her over. Somari came to the door and pressed an eye to the gap, but all she could see was one corner of the table and the back of a chair.

“The window?” Somari whispered.

“Iron grille. Not even mud outside.”

“Then call the officers.”

Within half an hour the mute body of the old building had awakened. Two constables came from the police

station, then a sub-inspector, the courthouse watchman, a clerk from the records department, and, one by one, several others. A fine rain was still falling. Before the door was broken open, everyone was made to stand back. Again and again, their eyes settled first on the same fact: the latch was on the inside.

When the panel gave way, the air inside seemed to exhale a long breath. It carried the dampness of old paper, a faint trace of tobacco, the smell of wet cloth, and the taut sting of something sharp that no one could immediately name.

Vasudha lay on the floor to the left of the table, half seated, half reclined, her back against the lower panel of a cupboard. Near the right side of her head clung a chalk-white dust. Beside her, a small brass-coloured betel-nut box lay open. There were two circular cup marks on the table, but only one cup. On a sheet of paper left open, half a line had been written: "If this paper disappears again..." After that, the stroke of the pen had fallen downward, as though the hand had suddenly gone slack.

Sub-Inspector Vinay Thakur bent down and performed the formality of checking her pulse. The body had already gone cold. The constable beside him said at once, "Locked from inside. And there's writing on the paper. Looks like suicide."

Vinay silenced him with a look. But the word had already escaped into the air. Suicide. Among the people

standing on the veranda, it scattered in every direction like drops of rain.

By the time Madhavi arrived, the pale light of dawn was beginning to climb into the sky. She was not barefoot, but her sandals were so soaked that every step made a wet sucking sound. The lower legs of her salwar were caked with mud; though her dupatta covered her head, half her face was wet with rain. Buchchan's son had brought her the news: "Vasudha Didi, at the courthouse... something terrible has happened."

All the way there, after hearing the word terrible, she had repeated the same thing: no, no, no. The moment she saw the crowd on the courthouse veranda, that no sank inward.

"Madhavi, not inside." Vinay raised a hand to stop her.

"I was going through her papers with her. Until last night—"

"What time did you leave yesterday?"

"Around half past eight. She told me to go. Dulari was due to come."

"Dulari usually came?"

"Yes."

Vinay's eyes sharpened slightly. "Did she come?"

Madhavi looked toward Buchchan. He nodded slowly. “I saw her. A little after nine. She had no umbrella. She went in with a red cloth tucked over her head.”

“When did she leave?”

Buchchan fell silent before answering. Through that rainy night, how many times had he remained awake at the gate, how many times had he dozed? He did not trust even his own recollection. “I didn’t see her leave. But once in the night I thought I heard the gate opening... I can’t say what time.”

A sudden cold ran through Madhavi’s body. Dulari. Vasudha. The unfinished line.

Vinay asked again, “How long had Vasudha ji’s state of mind been bad? Stress? Fear? Trouble at home?”

Something bitter rose inside Madhavi. “Why are you already searching for reasons around a dead person? Shouldn’t we first find out what happened to her?”

“That is why I am asking.”

“She would not kill herself.”

“Nothing has been concluded yet.”

“Everyone outside is already saying it.”

Vinay watched her for a moment. A twenty-year-old girl; her voice trembled, yet she did not retreat. “Then tell me—what was she working on yesterday?”

Madhavi's mouth went dry. Her gaze remained fixed on the paper lying on the table. "The Seven Hamlets land case. She was looking for an old certified copy. Some pages did not agree with the records. She said the figures in the new copy did not match the old one. Yesterday evening an envelope arrived... she did not show me what was inside."

"Who gave it to her?"

"She said, 'Whoever is afraid will not write their name.'"

Vinay made a few notes on a sheet of paper.

At that moment an elderly man came onto the veranda, slowly shaking the rain from his umbrella, and stopped. His hair was almost entirely white; his frame was spare, his eyes steady. No saffron robes—only an ordinary grey kurta, old sandals, and a cloth shoulder-bag. Buchchan straightened at once.

"Jaynarayan Babu?"

Sub-Inspector Vinay recognised him too. "You, this early?"

"Word came from Vasudha's house." Jaynarayan Mandal did not look first at the crowd on the veranda. He looked at the broken door, then at the ground beside it, then at the mud outside. "May I go in?"

Vinay considered for a moment. Jaynarayan was retired, but he was an old courthouse man, had known Vasudha, and stories about the keenness of his eye were still told within the police. “Touch nothing.”

“When does one need to touch?” Jaynarayan smiled faintly. “If the eyes are working properly, half the work can be done from a distance.”

For the first time Madhavi saw him closely. Vasudha had spoken his name many times: “Jaynarayan Kaka reads people’s silences more than their speech.” Until now Madhavi had never quite understood the sentence.

Meanwhile her mind returned to the small things of the previous evening. At seven, standing beside the window and watching the rain, Vasudha had said, “When earth gets wet, old smells rise from it. Paper is the same. What has been buried gives off its scent sooner or later.” Madhavi had laughed then. “Didi, paper doesn’t give off a scent; it grows damp.” Vasudha had replied, “Dampness is testimony too.” Now the words lodged inside her like a thorn. During that time Vasudha had opened and closed her bag three times: first to put away the envelope; the second time to feel for some thick, book-like volume; the third to look at a small ring of keys. Madhavi had paid no attention to any of it then.

While going home that night, she had heard one more sentence from Vasudha: “If Dulari comes, don’t let her go out alone.” Madhavi had asked, “Afraid of whom?” Vasudha had laughed, but the laughter had not reached

her eyes. “In a courthouse, Madhavi, the name of fear is never written down. If it were, half the case would already be simple.”

Guilt now surged so violently through Madhavi that she felt she should never have left that night. Her mother had been alone; three sets of clothes had to be finished and delivered from the sewing at home—but why did every reason seem so small now? What if she had stayed? What if she and Dulari had been there together once Dulari arrived? What if... A crowd of questions drags a person backwards, but time does not turn back. All she could do now was keep looking at the broken door.

On the veranda Kamli Devi had put tea on the stove. People from the courthouse gathered slowly, but every voice was unnaturally low. Those who had argued with Vasudha until yesterday now spoke her name in whispers. One clerk said, “She moved too boldly. People like that are bound to make enemies.” Another murmured, “There were troubles at home too.” Madhavi’s ears burned. Society is quick to lay its own stories over the life of a dead woman; those who said nothing to her face begin dispensing complete justice behind her back. Madhavi wanted to step forward and say, “All of you, be quiet,” but Jaynarayan’s arrival broke the moment.

Jaynarayan stepped through the doorway, then stopped. There was one drop of water on the floor. A

second, a little farther in. No third. He looked up at the ceiling. Dry. The window was shut. The ventilator was a dark square high above. Then his eyes moved to Vasudha's body, the table, the cup marks, the clock, the betel-nut box. His gaze never rested long on any one thing, yet seemed to be measuring everything.

For a few moments he looked at Vasudha's face. To Madhavi, the old man's eyes in that instant seemed no longer the eyes of a policeman, but of someone who had known her.

Jaynarayan looked at Vasudha's right palm. The fingers were half-curved, and under the nails were chalk-white particles. The left palm was clean. There was no watch on her wrist—he asked whether Vasudha usually wore one. Madhavi said, "No. She said it got in the way when she wrote on papers." Behind the table, a page of the calendar hanging on the wall was moving though there seemed to be no wind. Jaynarayan raised his eyes. Beyond the grille of the ventilator lay darkness, but a faint current of air was coming through it.

"The window is closed, the door was fastened from inside—then why is that page moving?" he said, almost to himself.

One of the constables said, "The ventilator."

"Yes. The room is not completely sealed." Jaynarayan said no more.

Near the lower edge of the table there was also a tiny patch of paper ash. So little that at first glance it looked like dust. Jaynarayan bent and smelled it without touching it. “Burnt paper?”

Vinay said, “Could be incense too.”

“Could be.”

Madhavi spoke at once. “Didi never burned incense. She said smoke made her sneeze.”

Jaynarayan looked at her. “Another habit.”

He photographed the ash, then swept the room with his eyes. One door of the cupboard stood slightly open. Inside, the files were upright, but there was a gap in the middle—as if a thick file had been removed. “Make an inventory,” he told Vinay. “Which file was supposed to be here, and what has been taken out.”

Vinay did not object now. The scene was slowly ceasing to be the simple picture of a suicide and becoming a map of broken habits.

“Did she chew betel nut at night?” Jaynarayan asked without turning.

Madhavi was startled. “No. Never after evening. She said it gave her heartburn.”

“Where did she keep the box?”

“At the right-hand corner of the table. Always.”

Jaynarayan looked again at the box. It lay on the floor to the left.

Vinay said, "It may have fallen."

"It may have." Jaynarayan's voice was easy. "We have to see how much a fallen object can tell us."

He bent near the table. Two circular marks. One dark, one faint. He did not touch them. "Two cups?"

Madhavi said, "Vasudha Didi never kept her own cup in the middle of the table. She kept it at the edge so the papers wouldn't get wet."

Jaynarayan looked straight at her. "You were with her every day?"

"Almost."

"Then I will need your help."

Madhavi's throat tightened, but she nodded.

Outside, the rain suddenly grew heavy. Water tapped against the grille of the window. Amid that sound, Jaynarayan's gaze stopped beneath the table. A tiny twist of paper lay there, dry. He signalled to Vinay. A constable put on gloves and picked it up. Inside clung two small grains of sugar and a few dry tea leaves.

"Sugar in Vasudha's tea?" Jaynarayan asked.

Madhavi answered at once. "Never."

For the first time Vinay's face changed. "Then the second cup?"

"No names yet," Jaynarayan said. "Understand only this much: one habit has been broken inside this room. Not one, perhaps three or four."

He looked at the clock. The hands stood at four seventeen.

"Was this clock working?"

The records clerk said, "I saw it running throughout the day yesterday."

"Was there a power cut?"

"This clock runs on its own small battery."

Jaynarayan said nothing. He turned toward the door and looked at the broken inner piece of the latch. The panel had been smashed, but the latch truly had been fastened from inside.

Vinay said softly, "A locked room. The dead woman inside. The last visitor missing. An unfinished sentence. Calling it suicide was not unreasonable."

Walking toward the veranda, Jaynarayan said, "Whether it was wrong or right is not the question yet. But I can say one thing."

"What?"

“When a scene insists too loudly on telling us what it means, we should make it keep quiet for a while and look again.”

Madhavi followed him out. Dawn had arrived, but the colour of the sky was still holding on to the night. Water filled the courthouse courtyard. Beyond the broken door, the yellow light continued to burn.

At that moment Dulari’s name rose again from someone in the crowd. “The girl isn’t at home.”

Madhavi spun around. “What?”

Buchchan’s son was running toward them, breathless. “Her hut is empty. Her mother says she hasn’t come home since last night.”

In the first light of morning, this news seemed darker than anything else.

Jaynarayan immediately watched the crowd’s reaction: fear on one face, curiosity on another, and on yet another that peculiar glimmer with which people, despite themselves, find a trace of pleasure in news of disaster. Patiently, he questioned Buchchan’s son again about Dulari’s house. “Where was her dupatta?” “Inside, on the peg.” “Shoes?” “Beside the cot.” “Bag?” “With her notebooks.” “Was the door open?” “Her mother had opened it.” At every answer Jaynarayan merely nodded.

Then he studied the outer wall of the room with a measuring eye. The mud below the window was even;

there were no deep fresh footprints. Beneath the ventilator, amid the rain streaks on the wall, ran a thin pale line, as though at that spot the water had struck some slender object and divided around it. He showed it to Vinay. "Find an older photograph and see whether this was here before yesterday."

"A wire?" Vinay asked.

"Too soon to say. Cord, vine, a crack in the wall—anything. For now, preserve the mark."

All at once Madhavi understood that an investigation was not only about the event; it was the work of finding the difference between before and now. How different had Vasudha's room been yesterday? Which file had been on the table? How far had the window been open? Where had the box been? She knew these things, yet until now had never told them all together to anyone. She became afraid of her own memory. What if she remembered wrongly? What if grief changed things?

As though he had read her face, Jaynarayan said, "Madhavi, what you remember with certainty, state as certain. What is blurred, state as blurred. If you force memory, it will fill the empty spaces. I do not want spaces that have been filled; I want the empty spaces to remain correct."

The sentence eased something inside Madhavi. To search for truth, it was not necessary to know

everything; admitting what one did not know was also part of the work.

She looked once more at the broken door. Yesterday, while she was leaving through that same doorway, Vasudha had called after her, “Open the umbrella properly; the wind is blowing the wrong way.” Such an ordinary sentence. Death does not always leave behind extraordinary words; sometimes the last memory is simply a warning about an umbrella. Madhavi’s eyes filled again. She told herself: crying later; first preserve what you remember.

She took out her notebook and wrote down five things from the previous evening: the blue cup, the betel-nut box on the right, the envelope, the book-like object in the bag, the instruction not to let Dulari go out alone. As she wrote, she felt that once memory reached paper, fear became a little more ordered. Jaynarayan watched from a distance and said nothing.

Jaynarayan adjusted the strap of his cloth bag on his shoulder. “For now, do not think of Dulari as the guilty person. Think of her as the person we have to find.”

Vinay looked at him. “Why?”

“Because someone who runs away takes a great deal with them. A girl whose shoes are at the door, whose dupatta is inside, and who has not taken even a single rupee—her story of running away seems weak to me, at least for now.”

“You have seen her house?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Jaynarayan’s eyes settled somewhere beyond the rain. “Buchchan’s son said the hut was empty. He did not say her belongings were gone. When people bring news, they bring their interpretation with it. I heard his interpretation.”

For the first time after such a long night, Madhavi drew a deep breath. It seemed to her that everything had broken apart, yet among the broken pieces an old pair of eyes had begun picking up a few threads.

Behind them, the clock in the room was still stuck at four seventeen. Outside, time kept moving.

Chapter 2 — The Betel-Nut Box

Dawn had broken, yet the smell of night still clung to the old courthouse building. The police had sent the body to the hospital, the crowd on the veranda had slowly thinned, and the tea seller had lit her stove. The rain had dwindled to a fine drizzle. Jaynarayan Mandal still had not left.

Vinay Thakur was mildly irritated. Advice from retired officers was received in the police department in two ways: sometimes with respect, sometimes as a burden. Jaynarayan's name belonged to the first category, but in his first major investigation under his own charge, Vinay did not want to work in the shadow of an old officer.

“Will you look at the scene again?” he asked.

“Not look. First listen.”

“To whom?”

“To everyone who saw Vasudha every day. Before we understand the objects, we must understand the habits.”

Vinay pulled a chair closer. “Your famous theory of habits.”

“Not a theory. Ordinary household common sense. Even when people are afraid, they do not abandon many of their habits. And if someone stages a scene without

knowing enough about the dead person's habits, that person makes mistakes.”

Madhavi was called first. She had eaten nothing since the previous night, yet there was no sleep in her eyes, only a hard wakefulness. Jaynarayan asked for tea for her. Kamli Devi sent tea from her stall—one cup without sugar, one with little sugar. Taking the cup in her hands, Madhavi asked, “Yours without sugar?”

Jaynarayan smiled. “Vasudha knew my habits too. But today I am going to ask about yours.”

Madhavi did not understand the question.

“Tell me about yesterday evening from the beginning. Do not keep looking at the clock. Tell it as it comes back to you.”

Madhavi closed her eyes. “Didi had been restless since the afternoon. An old certified copy concerning the Seven Hamlets land case had arrived. On one page the boundary was written as ‘north: pond’; in the new record it said ‘north: road’. The pond is still there. The road came later. Didi said, ‘If the road came later, how did it become an old boundary in the new copy?’ Then Rahmat Kaka came to return an old bound file.”

“Rahmat?”

“A bookbinder. He repairs old papers.”

“And the envelope?”

“At around seven in the evening. A little boy delivered it. He gave no name. The envelope was not wet, though the rain had already begun outside.”

Jaynarayan raised his eyes. “Which means the envelope probably did not come from far away. Where did the boy go?”

“I don’t know. Didi gave him two rupees and he ran off.”

“Did she open the envelope?”

“I was standing there. There was no old paper inside—there was some sort of list on new paper. The moment Didi read it, her face changed. When I asked, she said, ‘The less you know, the better for now.’ That was unlike her. She never kept me at a distance as if I were a child.”

“Then?”

“At about half past eight she sent me home. She said, ‘Your mother will be alone. Go.’ Dulari was expected to come.”

“Why did Vasudha not chew betel nut at night?”

“Heartburn. The doctor had forbidden it.”

“And the box was always on the right?”

“Yes. Didi wrote with her left hand, but she kept the box on the right. She said the left side was for papers.”

Jaynarayan became completely silent. Vinay continued taking notes.

“Where was the box yesterday?”

“On the floor, to the left.”

“Which means it could simply have fallen from someone's hand,” Vinay said.

“It could have,” Jaynarayan agreed. “But for now I am collecting ‘could have’, not ‘did’.”

Madhavi's gaze rested on his face. When Jaynarayan asked a question, he did not shove the answer out by force. He left a space in which memory could walk in on its own.

“Two cups?” he asked.

Madhavi frowned. “Didi's own cup had a blue rim. The cup at the scene was white.”

Vinay spoke at once. “You went inside?”

“After the door was broken, I saw from a distance. I did not see the blue cup.”

“Was the blue cup there yesterday evening?”

“Yes. I had made the tea. No sugar.”

Jaynarayan tapped one finger once on the table. “Call Kamli Devi.”

Kamli Devi was around fifty, sturdily built, with sharp eyes. Her little stall beside the courthouse had no formal lease, but it had stood in the same place for twenty-five years. Lawyers, litigants, constables, clerks, cleaners—her hands themselves remembered how each of them took tea.

“Vasudha, child?” At the question, she wiped her eyes with the end of her sari. “She would not even touch the sugar tin at my stall. She used to say, ‘Kamli Kaki, your tea is sweet by itself; what is the need for sugar?’”

“Was tea sent there last night?”

Kamli scratched her head. “At night? The rain was heavy. Around ten, Buchchan's boy took two cups, but he said they were for the Babu upstairs.”

“Which Babu?”

“No name. What did it matter to me? Whoever asks, I make it. One cup without sugar, the other with two spoonfuls.”

Jaynarayan's eyes brightened, but his voice remained unchanged. “Two cups together?”

“Yes. But listen—the unsweetened tea was in the blue-rimmed cup; the sweet tea was in the white one. I use different cups at my stall.”

Madhavi's fingers tightened around her cup.

Vinay asked, "The blue cup wasn't found at the scene?"

A constable checked the inventory. "One white cup. No blue one."

Without being asked, Kamli Devi added, "I can't remember whether Buchchan's boy returned the cups later. There wasn't a crowd at night, but I was packing up the stall in the rain."

Jaynarayan said quietly, "Find the cup. The drain, the veranda, behind the room—everywhere."

For the first time Vinay obeyed the instruction without argument.

Then Buchchan Paswan came in. His account emerged in small pieces. Dulari had gone inside after nine. At around half past nine, a motorcar had passed in front of the courthouse; whether it had stopped was unclear. Around ten, his son had carried the tea. Between half past ten and a quarter to eleven, the electricity flickered once. After midnight the rain became so fierce that it was difficult to hear the gate. Once or twice he had dozed off in his chair.

"Did you see Dulari leave?"

"No."

"Anyone else?"

“I thought I saw two umbrellas moving away in the distance. But this is a courthouse; it could have been anyone crossing the veranda.”

“At what time?”

“I don't remember.”

“‘I don't remember’ is a good answer,” Jaynarayan said. “Better than guessing.”

Vinay looked at him as though he understood that the sentence was meant for him too.

More detailed news now came from Dulari's house. At dawn her mother had discovered that her daughter was not there. Inside, her dupatta, a pair of shoes, an old bag, and the notebooks she used for her night lessons were all still in place. One worn pair of slippers was missing—presumably the pair on her feet. Money? Twenty-two rupees remained untouched in an earthen container.

Instead of going to Dulari's house at once, Jaynarayan asked her mother to make a list of the belongings. Vinay was surprised. “Wouldn't it be better to see for yourself?”

“I will. But first let us hear what the people of the house saw. Once the police arrive, a house changes—people gather things up, neighbours come in, fear makes someone hide something. The first look belongs to those who live there.”

Dulari's mother, Phulo Sadai, came before the police trembling. Her wet sari clung around her legs, her head was covered, and again and again her hand rose to her mouth. "My girl didn't steal anything, Babu. She goes out at night to study, she works, but she would not touch a single grain belonging to anyone else."

Vinay said, "Did I say anything about theft?"

Phulo stopped short. "People in the village are saying it. They say she ran away with the lady lawyer's papers."

Jaynarayan asked gently, "What did Dulari take from home yesterday?"

"A notebook, a pen, an old umbrella... the umbrella was torn. When the rain became heavy, perhaps she left it there."

"Clothes?"

"Only what she was wearing. A red gamchha over her head. Her dupatta is at home."

"Any quarrel with anyone?"

Phulo lowered her eyes. "People from the land group kept telling us to drop the case. Twice, stones were thrown near our hut at night. Dulari said, 'Ma, don't be afraid. I've written down the names.'"

"Whose names?"

“She did not tell me. She said if I knew them, they would slip out of my mouth.”

Jaynarayan's face grew grave. “Did she write those names somewhere?”

“Maybe in her notebook. The notebook is at home.”

Vinay immediately sent a constable. Madhavi's heart began to pound. Dulari was not merely the last visitor; she was also a witness who had been receiving threats.

As Phulo was about to leave, Jaynarayan asked, “Dulari's phone?”

“There is only one cheap phone in the house. Everyone uses it. She took it yesterday. Her little brother plays games on it too. The number isn't registered in her name; it was taken using a neighbour's papers.”

Abhiram had not yet entered the room, but Jaynarayan understood at once the importance of this small fact. “Vinay Babu, later, if a machine tells you that the phone belongs to Dulari, remember this—the machine recognises a number, not a hand.”

Vinay wrote it down. “Right.”

“Does a person running away leave twenty-two rupees behind?” Jaynarayan asked Vinay.

“She may have run in fear.”

“She may have. But place another ‘may have’ beside that one—someone may have forced her to leave. Or she may have gone in such haste that she expected to return.”

Madhavi said, “Dulari wasn't afraid of Didi. On the contrary, she trusted only her.”

“Why?”

“The land case. Dulari's settlement is one of the Seven Hamlets. She was learning to read old papers. She attended the night school. Her father used to say, ‘What will a girl do by learning to read?’ Vasudha Didi said, ‘First she will learn to read; then she will read your papers for all of you.’”

Jaynarayan's face softened. “Then Dulari is not merely a witness. She is a witness who had begun to understand the documents.”

“Which makes the danger greater,” Madhavi whispered.

A constable called from outside. The blue-rimmed cup had been found—caught in the grille over the drain behind the courthouse. It was not broken, only smeared with mud.

Vinay rose immediately. Jaynarayan stopped him with a hand. “Photograph it first. Then pick it up.”

“You're not with the police anymore,” Vinay said with half a smile.

“That is why I am only saying it.”

They all went to the drain. The cup was caught in such a way that the current had been unable to carry it farther. Its blue rim shone from behind the grille. Jaynarayan looked at the ground. There was mud beside the drain, but no clear shoeprint; the rain had erased everything.

“How did the cup get from the room to here?” Madhavi asked.

Jaynarayan did not answer.

Then they returned to the records room. With the body gone, the objects seemed more naked. At the right-hand corner of the table was a pale square where the betel-nut box appeared always to have stood. The box itself had been found on the floor to the left. The blue cup had now been recovered from the drain. The white cup remained by the table. Of the two circular stains, one matched the breadth of the blue cup, the other the white.

Jaynarayan looked at the chair. Vasudha's chair was not directly behind the table but turned slightly askew. “How did she position the chair when she worked?”

Without thinking, Madhavi moved as if to straighten the chair, then stopped her hand. “Facing the table. She

sat with her left leg folded. If the chair was turned to the right, it would be difficult for her to write.”

“Now the chair is turned to the right.”

Vinay said, “There may have been a struggle.”

“Or the scene was staged.”

“You're going that way again.”

“I am not going any way. I am only asking why these things moved from their usual places.”

Jaynarayan examined the betel-nut box through the evidence bag in which it had been placed. Red-brown catechu powder clung inside the lid. On the rim of the box was a tiny black streak, as though singed cloth or soot had brushed it.

“Which hand did Vasudha use to open the box?” Jaynarayan asked.

Madhavi said, “Her right. The pen would be in her left hand.”

“Did the lid stick tightly?”

“No, it was loose. Like this.” Madhavi demonstrated the motion with her fingers in the air.

Through the evidence bag Jaynarayan studied the bottom of the box. On one side was a fine scratch. “It could be from falling on the floor. But test the particles

from the floor. If this box was placed somewhere else before it came here, the dust may be different.”

Vinay smiled. “You are going to solve a murder with a betel-nut box?”

“If it turns out to be murder. For now the box tells me only that its place changed. In a person's room, objects are not words; they are grammar. Chair, cup, pen, keys—each in its own place makes a sentence. Move one object and the sentence falters. Move five and you begin to ask who rewrote it.”

To Madhavi, Vasudha's room truly began to look like a written sentence—the box on the left, the chair turned right, the blue cup recovered from the drain, ash on the floor, the clock stopped. Had someone altered the sentence, or had the event itself displaced everything? The whole truth rested upon that difference.

Jaynarayan said to her, “Can you draw yesterday evening's table on paper?” Madhavi took her notebook and drew a rectangle: the box at the upper right, a pile of files on the left, the blue cup in the middle, the keys toward the window, the bag below. Today's photograph was placed beside it. Four of the five objects were in different positions.

Vinay asked, “How much can we trust this map?”

“Not a hundred per cent,” Jaynarayan said, “but it gives us a basis for testing. Now ask other people

independently. If three memories agree at the same point, the weight increases.”

The records clerk came in. He too remembered the box on the right, but not where the keys were usually kept. Buchchan knew nothing about the blue cup. Kamli said Vasudha normally returned her cup herself; yesterday she had not. Small facts began to join one another, yet Jaynarayan kept leaving room for doubt between every match. “Agreement alone is not truth,” he said again and again. “People’s memories also begin to resemble one another after they hear the same story. Take the statements separately.”

Vinay gradually began to understand that the old officer’s method was slow, certainly, but not lax. Instead of relying on conjecture, he created small tests, then placed each conjecture against them.

Jaynarayan looked again at the photograph of the pen by the table. “Where did Vasudha put the pen after writing?” Madhavi said, “At the top of the paper, with the nib pointing right.” In the photograph the pen lay on the floor, its nib pointing left. Vinay laughed. “If there was a jolt, everything could have gone flying.”

“Correct,” Jaynarayan said. “Which is why one pen tells us nothing. But the box, chair, cup, pen, ash—all of them together are asking a question. I still will not give an answer.”

His restraint gave Madhavi a strange kind of confidence. A man who was not rushing to find a culprit might, perhaps, truly be looking for the truth. Outside, the rain had stopped, but water was still running through the drain. The blue cup had gone into an evidence bag; its empty place was still visible in the room.

“Enlarge the photograph,” he told the constable.

Vinay asked, “What do you see?”

“Nothing yet. But the box is not merely out of place; whatever is stuck to it is not present on the table.”

He read Vasudha's unfinished note. “If this paper disappears again...”

Madhavi said, “Didi would not have written the word ‘again’ for nothing. That means it had already disappeared once before.”

Jaynarayan studied her closely. “Good. Which paper?”

“Possibly the collective document from 1934. But I am not certain.”

“‘Possibly’ and ‘not certain’—remember the distinction. Mystery first corrupts language. People turn a possibility into ‘this is what happened’.”

News came from outside that Vasudha's husband had not been found in town. The family said he had been at

home during the night, but the car was missing. Vinay's expression sharpened again.

Jaynarayan shook his head. "A lie in the household does not prove murder. People lie for a hundred reasons—love, shame, obligation, another woman, fear, debt."

Faces from Vasudha's household moved through Madhavi's mind. Her husband Arun, who always spoke in polished words; her brother Prakhar, who mocked his sister's public-interest cases; her mother-in-law, who said, "No justice is greater than the family name." But Madhavi said nothing.

Jaynarayan went back to the clock. Four seventeen. "The clock did not fall. It is not broken. The glass is intact. Why did it stop?"

The clerk said, "Battery exhausted?"

"Remove the battery and test it. But do not treat the time on this clock as the time of death. For anyone staging a scene, stopping a clock is one of the oldest pieces of theatre."

Vinay laughed. "You've already decided it was murder."

"No. I have accepted the possibility that suicide was staged. Keep everything open—murder, accident, suicide under coercion."

At that moment Abhiram arrived. His wet hair clung to his head, a computer bag tucked under his arm. The moment he saw Madhavi he stopped. “I’ve been looking for you since last night. Why weren’t you answering the phone?”

Madhavi’s voice was rough with exhaustion. “Didi...”

“I heard. That’s why I came.” Abhiram’s eyes moved for a moment into the room, then dropped. “Sutra’s central computer has retained all the access logs from last night. If the police want, I can reconstruct a timeline.”

Vinay’s face brightened. “Now?”

“It will take a little while. The courthouse entrance, the records-room lock sensor, the digitisation machines, phone signals—whatever is available, I can bring it all together.”

Jaynarayan looked at him calmly. “Does the machine know where Vasudha kept her betel-nut box?”

Abhiram was taken aback. “No.”

“Whether she took sugar?”

“No.”

“Then your Sutra will see half the world.”

Abhiram's youthful pride flared at once. "And human beings don't see even half. They see what they want to see. Data, at least, do not lie."

A faint pleasure glimmered in Jaynarayan's eyes. "Data do not lie, but they remain silent. Human beings make them speak."

Madhavi looked from one to the other: on one side, the seasoned eye; on the other, faith in calculation. Vasudha Didi's body would now be lying in a cold hospital room; no one knew where Dulari was; and here the first tug-of-war over truth had begun.

Jaynarayan looked once more toward the betel-nut box. "Come, Abhiram Babu. Let us hear what your Sutra has to say. But on one condition."

"What?"

"We do not take the first answer for the final one."

Abhiram tightened the strap of his bag over his shoulder. "And you will not take your first suspicion for the final one either."

"Agreed."

The brief smile that passed between them was not friendship. But neither was it hostility. It was as though the investigation truly began in that moment.

Chapter 3 — Sutra's First Answer

The courthouse's new building stood two courtyards away from the old one. Rain seemed less melancholy there, because glass windows, white lights, and freshly painted walls did not allow drops of water to become history. On the third floor was a small digitisation room: three computers, two document-imaging machines, a heavy cupboard, a tangle of wires, and an old fan gathering dust in a corner. This was where Abhiram worked.

As soon as he entered the room, he did not lock the door from inside; he merely pulled it shut.

Jaynarayan noticed even that small action.

“You people pull the door closed; you don't fasten it?”

Drawing out a chair, Abhiram said, “During the day, yes. People keep coming in and going out. At night, it is locked.”

“The old records room?”

“That has a sensor-fitted lock, but the original wooden latch is still there too. The new device records only when the lock is opened and closed; it knows nothing about the latch.”

Jaynarayan's brows rose slightly. "So even if the latch is fastened from inside, the device will report only the lock."

"Correct."

Vinay Thakur stood beside a chair. Madhavi was near the window. Her clothes were drying now, but the fatigue in her body had deepened. She did not want to go home. If she did, her mother would ask questions, the news would spread through the village, and Vasudha's death would become real. Here, amid the work, she could still think of it as something unfinished.

Abhiram switched on the computer. A plain symbol appeared on the screen with the word "Sutra" — no face, no human voice. Only written lines.

Sutra had been created mainly to detect irregularities in records. Two maps for the same parcel of land, different dates for the same case, one person recorded in two places at the same time — contradictions that might take a human being months to uncover could be listed by Sutra in moments. Later, when the district administration began using it, facilities were added for timelines and entry logs.

Abhiram was a student assistant on the project, but in this tool he saw more than a job: he saw the future. He believed that where people were influenced by relationships, fear, status, caste, money, or their own

assumptions, data at least applied the same rules to everyone.

Madhavi often laughed at this faith. “Applying the same rule to everyone is not justice,” she would say. “In a poor household five people use one phone; in a rich household five people have five phones. If Sutra reads both in the same way, the poor will look more suspicious.”

Abhiram would answer, “That is why context is added.”

“Who adds the context?”

“A human being.”

“Then in the end the human being has returned again.”

They had laughed over this argument many times. Today, with Vasudha dead, there was no laughter in it.

Looking at the screen, Jaynarayan asked, “Does this system remember its mistakes?”

“Yes. In cases where the correct facts are discovered later, it compares them. But the local data set is small.”

“And what about people whose lives have never been written down?”

Abhiram was silent for a moment. “That is a weakness.”

Jaynarayan looked at Madhavi. “The question you asked earlier — the system itself admits it.”

A little displeased, Abhiram said, “Admitting a weakness is not a weakness. It is caution.”

“True.” Jaynarayan smiled. “We need caution too.”

“It doesn't speak?” Jaynarayan asked.

“Deliberately not. Give it a voice and people begin to think of it as a person. It is an analytical tool.”

Jaynarayan smiled faintly. “I like that.”

Abhiram entered the previous day's date. The system began assembling the available records: the time at the entrance gate, the records-room lock, use of the digitisation equipment, mobile-phone signals around the courthouse complex, the times when Vasudha's digital documents had been opened, fluctuations in the electricity supply. Lines appeared one after another.

Madhavi's eyes stopped on one time — 20:41. At that moment she had been looking at the last papers with Vasudha. Then 20:52 — she left the complex. 21:08 — Dulari's phone connected to the courthouse tower. 21:11 — the lock of the old records room opened. 21:13 — the lock closed.

“Dulari went inside,” Vinay said.

“Possibly,” Abhiram corrected him. “A phone signal identifies an area, not a person. But it agrees with Buchchan's statement.”

22:02 — a document was scanned. File name: rehabilitation_1934_part7.

Madhavi leaned forward. “Is this the file I made yesterday?”

Abhiram shook his head. “No. The copy you made was at 18:16 yesterday evening. This is another image, after ten at night.”

“Who scanned it?”

“The device user name is ‘V_Karna’. Vasudha Didi's.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Was the password known only to her?”

Abhiram hesitated. “In theory. But people in the courthouse often write passwords on slips of paper and keep them beside the keyboard. Vasudha Didi was not like that, but...”

“But?”

“She once entered the login code in front of Madhavi. Madhavi may know it.”

Madhavi said immediately, “I don't remember the password. She typed fast on the keyboard.”

Jaynarayan looked at her face, then turned back to the screen without comment.

22:07 — the machine shut down. 22:11 — one phone moved from the courthouse complex to an outside tower. The number was Dulari's.

Vinay straightened. "Then Dulari left."

"Strongly possible," Abhiram said.

"And Vasudha?"

"Her phone remained in the courthouse area until 22:16. After that the signal was stationary. The phone was probably still there."

"Time of death?"

"Not yet. Keep going."

23:48 — the lock of the old records room opened again.

Everyone fell silent.

23:49 — closed.

Vinay said, "Who?"

Abhiram's thumb stopped on the keyboard. "There is no access-card record. Only the lock sensor."

"The main outer gate?"

"No digital entry log there. Only the guard."

Jaynarayan asked quietly, “The latch?”

“Unknown.”

00:03 — a document opened on Vasudha's computer: “seven_evidence_list.” 00:09 — closed. 00:12 — an external storage device was connected. 00:15 — removed.

Madhavi's throat went dry. “I have never seen that name before.”

“Is the file still there?”

Abhiram searched. “No. Only the record showing that it was opened. The original file has been deleted.”

Jaynarayan looked at Vinay. “The unfinished line — ‘If this paper disappears again...’”

Vinay nodded. “It fits.”

After that came a long darkness in the night's record. At 01:37 there was a slight fluctuation in the electricity supply. At 02:14 an unidentified phone was active in the courthouse area for three minutes. At 03:52 an unfinished message was composed on Vasudha's phone but never sent.

Abhiram opened it. Only three words: “Madhavi, not the book...”

Madhavi caught her breath. “The book?”

“What book?” Vinay asked.

“I don't know,” Madhavi said, but before the sentence was finished a scene from the previous day came back to her: a thick object wrapped in cloth inside Vasudha's bag. She had asked about it, and Didi had laughed and said, “The sky of old people.” Madhavi had paid no attention then.

“You remembered something?” Jaynarayan caught it at once.

Madhavi said slowly, “Perhaps it was a book. Something about stars, births, things like that. I didn't see it clearly.”

Jaynarayan said nothing, but wrote it down.

04:17 — the last event recorded in the system: the small time-signal linked to the internal clock in the records room stopped.

Abhiram said, “The clock looks ordinary, but during the digitisation project a local signal unit was added to it for time synchronisation. At four seventeen, the signal broke.”

Vinay said, “So the clock stopped at that time.”

“Yes.”

“And the death too?”

“That is not established.”

The system seemed to think for a few moments, then a result appeared on the screen. Abhiram read aloud:

“Probable sequence on the basis of available data: Vasudha Karn present in the room after 21:11. Dulari Sadai likely leaves the premises around 22:11. The room lock opens briefly at 23:48. Document activity occurs between 00:03 and 00:15. Vasudha's phone is active at 03:52. Local time-signal ceases at 04:17. No digital evidence of forced external entry is available.”

Below it appeared percentages:

Self-induced death or accidental toxic exposure: 61 percent.

Homicide by an external person: 27 percent.

Insufficient data / other: 12 percent.

The fact that the room was locked from inside increases the probability of self-induced death.

Vinay drew a deep breath. “See? The police's first inference was not without foundation.”

There was no triumph on Abhiram's face, but there was a kind of satisfaction. “Sutra is pointing in the same direction.”

Madhavi was not looking at the percentages. She was reading the warning beneath them: “Available data may be incomplete.” Those seven words were printed far

smaller than the figures above. She said, “Put that warning at the top. Make it as bold as the numbers.”

Abhiram looked at her. “This is a technical page, not a poster.”

“A dead person's name is attached to it. Whoever reads it will see the numbers first.”

Jaynarayan agreed. “Layout also dispenses justice. What is printed in large type is easily taken for a larger truth.”

Reluctantly, Abhiram moved the warning upward. Vinay watched this small dispute; he understood that an investigation was not only about facts. The way facts were presented could also alter the outcome.

Sutra produced another short line: “Confidence level: medium; three primary sources unavailable.”

Abhiram opened the three sources: physical examination of the scene, the deceased's medical report, and independent witness statements. Jaynarayan said, “Then we are standing only halfway across the bridge.”

“But we can see the direction of the bridge,” Abhiram repeated.

“Yes,” Jaynarayan conceded, “provided we do not mistake the river for the road.”

For the first time amid her grief, a faint smile came to Madhavi's face. Abhiram softened a little too. But as soon

as the next line appeared, all three faces hardened again: the 23:48 opening of the lock did not match the normal pattern for that hour of night. During the previous thirty nights, the lock had never opened at that time.

“Put this anomaly at the top,” Jaynarayan said.

Abhiram complied without argument.

Jaynarayan kept looking at the screen. Then he asked quietly, “Whose knowledge produced this sixty-one percent?”

Abhiram turned his chair toward him. “Historical cases, scene patterns, the available timeline, the locked room, phone activity — all of it.”

“Vasudha's habits?”

“Not as data.”

“Betel nut?”

“No.”

“Sugar?”

“No.”

“Two cups?”

“Image analysis can be added. It hasn't been yet.”

“The blue cup in the drain?”

“Not yet entered as a fact.”

“Whether someone else used Dulari's shared phone?”

Abhiram paused. “That information is not available.”

“At 23:48 the lock opened — who was inside, who outside?”

“Unknown.”

“The latch?”

“Unknown.”

“The ventilator?”

“Unknown.”

“Then the sixty-one percent tells me this much: among the things the machine knows, the pattern matches suicide more strongly. About what it does not know, it is silent. Correct?”

Abhiram's jaw tightened slightly. “That is the limitation of every analysis. Human analysis too.”

“Exactly. That is why I am not opposing it. I simply will not bow before a percentage the moment I see it.”

Vinay intervened. “But at this point the digital evidence in our hands is solid. Dulari's phone leaves after ten. Vasudha's phone is active close to four. There is no sign of outside entry.”

Jaynarayan took the last sip of his sugarless tea, now cold. “Dulari's phone outside and Dulari outside are not

the same statement. Vasudha's phone active and Vasudha active are not the same statement. The lock opened and a person entered are not the same statement. We will preserve the distance between words.”

He leaned back in his chair. “I remember an old case from my service. On the night of a theft, the house owner's shoes were found beside a pond. Everyone concluded he had fled that way. Three days later we learned that the servant had washed the shoes and left them there to dry, and a dog had carried them off. The shoes were true; the conclusion was false. Evidence does not lie. We arrange it into the wrong sentence.”

Abhiram replied at once, “That is why Sutra gives probabilities, not verdicts.”

“That is one of its virtues. What worries me is that a human being sees a percentage and turns it into a verdict.”

Vinay tapped his fingers on the chair. “The police make that mistake too. But without a preliminary direction, how can an investigation proceed?”

“We need direction, not certainty.”

Madhavi said quietly, “The moment Dulari's name appears at the top of the screen, everyone will rush to arrest her. Where on this screen are the twenty-two rupees left in her house, the shared phone, the threats?”

Abhiram answered, "We'll add them. As more facts arrive, the result will change."

"But what if the first result escapes into the world?"

No one answered immediately. The room's lights continued their faint electrical hum.

Jaynarayan looked at Abhiram. "That is why discipline in the language of a machine is necessary. It is easy to write 'prime suspect'; harder to write 'stronger match within the limited data currently available'. But the second is closer to the truth."

After a moment Abhiram nodded. "I can change the wording of the results."

"Not someday. Now," Madhavi said.

Abhiram looked at her. Even in grief, Madhavi's old stubbornness was alive. He opened the display settings and began revising the sentences. Jaynarayan watched in silence. It seemed that this small correction had not ended the first collision between human beings and the machine; it had begun it.

Madhavi's eyes settled on Abhiram. "Do you think Didi killed herself?"

Abhiram did not answer at once. "What would my 'thinking' prove? What is available says this."

"Your Sutra says it."

“Sutra combines what is available. Emotion does not change the result.”

“Not emotion — I knew Didi.”

“Knowing someone can itself be a bias.”

Madhavi's eyes filled, but her voice hardened. “And not knowing someone is pure, impartial truth?”

A strange silence descended on the room. Abhiram's face softened, but it was already too late. He seemed about to say something, then stopped.

Jaynarayan walked to the window. From there the roof of the old building was visible. The rain had almost stopped. Water gleamed on the roof. The ventilator of the old records room could be seen clearly from here — small, square, covered with an iron grille. Jaynarayan studied it for a while.

“Abhiram Babu, do we have the ventilator's dimensions?”

“The old building plans are preserved digitally. Let me see.”

The plan opened. The ventilator was on the outer wall, roughly ten feet above the ground. The inner grille was old; an outer grille had been added later. There was a five-inch gap between the two.

“No human being could get through,” Vinay said.

“I am not looking for a human being.” Jaynarayan said. “For a latch to be fastened from inside, must a person always remain inside?”

Abhiram raised his eyes from the screen. “You mean fastening the latch from outside?”

“For now, only a question. Show me the shape of the old latch.”

An image was brought up. An iron bar in a wooden frame. Jaynarayan took a length of string from his cloth bag. Madhavi watched in surprise — why would an old man carry string in his bag? He smiled. “My granddaughter flies kites; this was left in the bag yesterday.”

In the air he demonstrated a model: a loop around the iron bar of the latch, the string running toward the ventilator, a pull from outside. “Possible in principle. Difficult in practice. Distance, angle, friction — all of it would have to be tested.”

Abhiram immediately drew a line on the plan. “The angle is about thirty-two degrees. If it were a thin wire or a strong cord...”

He stopped.

Jaynarayan smiled. “See? A human question, a machine calculation. Each is incomplete alone.”

Vinay was genuinely serious now. “Any cord at the scene?”

“None was found. It could have been thrown away outside. Or the whole idea may be wrong.”

Abhiram entered a new fact into Sutra: mechanical possibility of fastening the latch remotely through the ventilator. The system recalculated. The percentages changed:

Self-induced death or accidental toxic exposure: 48 percent.

Homicide by an external person: 39 percent.

Other / insufficient data: 13 percent.

Looking at the screen, Madhavi whispered, “One question changed thirteen percent.”

Abhiram said, “Because a new possibility entered.”

Jaynarayan said, “So a percentage is not truth; it is the shadow cast by present knowledge.”

Abhiram's eyes sharpened. “But even a shadow shows direction.”

“Certainly. And sometimes a shadow is longer than the object itself.”

Vinay raised a hand to stop them both. “Philosophy later. Work now. I want the full history of Dulari's phone. The reason the lock opened at 23:48. The

unidentified number at 02:14. The unfinished message at 03:52. And where the file 'seven_evidence_list' went."

Abhiram nodded.

Madhavi suddenly said, "One thing."

Everyone turned toward her.

"Yesterday Didi was counting pages. She reached seven, then returned to the first page. I laughed: 'Didi, have you forgotten how to count?' She said, 'Everyone looks up to the sixth; at the seventh, people's eyes grow tired.' I didn't understand what she meant then."

The room fell silent again.

For the first time there appeared on Jaynarayan's face an expression Madhavi could not identify — worry, or curiosity. "Her exact words?"

"Yes. 'Everyone looks up to the sixth; at the seventh, people's eyes grow tired.'"

Abhiram immediately searched the system for files associated with "seven." Several names appeared: part7, seven_hamlets, seven_evidence_list, seventh_mark_1934, and the name of an old image — "witness7_unclear."

"Open that," Madhavi said.

Abhiram clicked. The image was only partly legible: the corner of an old document, blue thread, and half of a

circular mark along the left edge. Below, only two letters of a handwritten word could be made out — “wit...”

“Where is the original paper?” Jaynarayan asked.

“The source location is listed as records box 47/B, old building.”

Vinay immediately summoned a constable.

When box 47/B was opened, the inventory said it should contain fifteen papers. There were fourteen. The seventh numbered page was missing.

A shiver ran through Madhavi.

Jaynarayan spoke very slowly. “Vasudha was counting papers. She was writing, ‘If this paper disappears again...’ During the night, ‘seven_evidence_list’ was opened. And now the seventh page is gone.”

Vinay's initial certainty about suicide had broken apart.

Abhiram looked at Sutra's earlier sixty-one percent, which now seemed like an irrelevant calculation from a different past.

Jaynarayan came close to his shoulder and said, “Your Sutra was not wrong.”

Abhiram answered sharply, “But the result went in the wrong direction.”

“An accurate calculation made from incomplete knowledge can lead in the wrong direction. The fault is not in the calculation but in its boundary. We must keep examining our own boundaries too.”

Madhavi looked out through the window. The wall of the old building had been washed clean by the rain, but its dark cracks stood out more clearly. Suddenly she remembered the cloth-wrapped book inside Vasudha's bag. Where was it?

The question had nearly reached her lips when her phone vibrated. A short message from an unknown number:

“Do not look for Dulari. If you want her alive, leave the seventh page alone.”

The colour drained from Madhavi's face.

“What happened?” Abhiram stood up.

She handed the phone to Jaynarayan.

Jaynarayan read the message, then checked the time — seven forty-nine.

He turned toward Vinay. “We can stop discussing suicide now.”

Outside, the sun was trying to tear through the clouds and cast a little light. But to Madhavi it seemed that the real darkness had only just begun.

Chapter 4 — Dulari Is Missing

The moment Vinay Thakur read the threat that had arrived on Madhavi's phone, his first reaction was: trace the number immediately. Jaynarayan's first reaction was: sit Madhavi down in a chair. Abhiram's first reaction was: open the message again and examine its time, its manner of writing, and the sequence of its characters. The three reactions were different, yet each was appropriate in its own place.

“Do not look for Dulari. If you want her alive, leave the seventh page alone.” Vinay read it again. “Whoever sent this may know where Dulari is.”

“Or may know only that we will be frightened,” Jaynarayan said. “A threat can be information; it can also be theatre. Do not assume at the outset that words know as much as they claim to say.”

Abhiram opened the message's underlying details. The number was new; until yesterday there had been no activity associated with it in the records. The message had not come through an ordinary mobile network but through a temporary communication service from which the sender's identity could be erased almost at once. Frowning, he said, “Whoever sent it certainly understands enough technology not to expose a direct number.”

“That much is no longer difficult,” Vinay said. “Half the boys around the courthouse could do it.”

Jaynarayan read the wording again. “Dulari ‘alive’—why that word? If the purpose were merely to frighten us, it could have said, ‘If you want Dulari back.’ The person who wrote alive has placed death on the table. I will not take that word lightly.”

Madhavi was still silent. Dulari's face moved through her mind: her thin frame; the little gap between her teeth when she laughed; the way, whenever she failed to understand something at the courthouse, she narrowed her eyes and said, “Explain it again, please. I am not stupid; I am only new to this.” Vasudha used to laugh and say, “One day this girl will read everyone's papers for them.”

“I am going to her house,” Madhavi said suddenly.

Vinay at first wanted to stop her, but Jaynarayan agreed. “The time has come to see the house. We will not repeat the questions already put to Phulo Devi. Now we will see what the house itself says.”

Seven Hamlets spread below the old embankment, beyond the last paved road of the town. The name suggested seven separate settlements, but rain and time had merged their boundaries so thoroughly that to an outsider they formed one woven world. Here a thatched roof, there a sheet of tin, elsewhere bamboo screening above a half-built brick wall; between them puddles,

pigs' hoofprints, the naked laughter of children, smoke, wet firewood, boiling rice-water, and the hands of women washing clothes.

The police jeep could not enter. Everyone had to go on foot. Vinay's constable stepped carefully, trying to save his shoes from the mud. Jaynarayan watched him and smiled. "Where there is an investigation to conduct, it is difficult to save one's shoes."

Madhavi's sandals were already soaked. Abhiram followed behind her. Once, when she nearly slipped, he reached out a hand, but Madhavi recovered her own balance. Their eyes met for a moment. The sharpness of yesterday's argument still lay between them, but this was not the time to speak of it.

People had gathered in front of Dulari's hut. Phulo Sadai sat on a low wooden stool at the doorway. Her eyes were swollen like those of someone who had stayed awake all night, though the tears had now dried. The moment she saw the police, she rose. "Babu, have you found my daughter?"

Vinay did not shake his head. He said only, "Not yet. We are looking."

For a moment Phulo's face emptied. Then she saw Madhavi. "Child, your Didi treated my Dulari like her own daughter. Now Didi is gone. Who will tell me where my girl has gone?"

Madhavi took her hand. There was no answer.

The hut was divided into two small sections. In the first were the hearth, two earthen pots, a single brass plate, a water vessel, and clothes hanging from a bamboo peg. In the second lay a thin mat, a wooden trunk, and a low cot against the wall. On the cot were four notebooks, two books, a pencil worn almost to a stub, and an introductory book on law wrapped in a cover made from newspaper.

“Vasudha Didi gave her this,” Phulo said. “She used to tell her: first learn to read your own name; then learn to read the name of your land.”

Jaynarayan touched nothing when he entered the room. His eyes went first to the doorway, then the peg, then the trunk, then the mat. Beside the door a cheap pair of black shoes had been placed neatly together. A faded blue dupatta hung from a peg inside. In one corner stood the earthen container holding twenty-two rupees.

“Did she wear these shoes when she went to the courthouse?”

Phulo said, “Yes. If it rained, she would go in slippers and put on the shoes when she got there. Yesterday she wore her worn slippers and left the shoes at home.”

Vinay bent near the doorway. “Then the shoes being here is not evidence that she ran away.”

“Not evidence,” Jaynarayan said softly, “but a useful object for building a story. People see shoes beside the door and say, ‘She left her shoes and fled.’ But for a girl who normally goes out in the rain without those shoes, this is ordinary.”

Phulo said sharply, “I told them yesterday itself that she had left the shoes at home. But who listens in this settlement? Everyone says she stole the papers and ran away.”

A woman's voice came from outside. “Then why did she not come home at night?” Phulo turned toward the doorway, but Jaynarayan raised a hand to stop her. “Do not silence people's mouths yet. We also need to hear what everyone is saying.”

He went outside. Five or seven women, two old men, and several adolescents stood there. One elderly man said, “Babu, I am not defaming anyone, but a poor person is still human. Seeing money can turn anyone's eyes.”

Phulo flared up. “She left twenty-two rupees here, and you say she was tempted to loot wealth?”

The old man fell silent.

A girl of roughly Dulari's age spoke from behind the crowd. “Yesterday evening Dulari told me that if she got late, I should tell her mother she was with Vasudha Didi. She never said anything about running away.”

“Your name?” Vinay asked.

“Sunita.”

“Did Dulari tell you she was afraid of anything?”

Sunita first looked toward Phulo. “Two days ago, while returning from the night school, she said someone had been walking behind her. I asked who, and she said, ‘I didn’t recognise him, but his shoes shone like the shoes of courthouse babus.’”

Vinay wrote it down at once.

Jaynarayan asked, “Did she see his face?”

“No. She said he had kept his umbrella low.”

“Why did you not say this yesterday?” Vinay’s voice hardened.

Fear tightened Sunita’s face. “No one asked me. When the police came, I stayed away.”

Jaynarayan gave Vinay only a glance. There was no accusation in it, merely a reminder: in a poor settlement, information does not come out of its door by itself when one knocks.

They returned to the hut and began examining the notebooks. The top one contained writing exercises from the night school. In Dulari’s rounded hand stood the sentence: “I will read the papers of my own house myself.” Below it the teacher had written in red ink:

“Good sentence. Make the handwriting clearer.” On the next page were exercises using the names of Seven Hamlets families, copied land-account numbers, and meanings of several terms: “settlement”, “possession”, “tenant cultivator”, “appeal”.

Madhavi's throat tightened. “Didi was teaching her all this.”

A page had been torn from the middle of one notebook. The tear was fresh. Vinay's gaze stopped there. “Who tore this page out?”

Phulo held her head and tried to remember. “I don't know. She never let anyone touch her notebooks.”

Abhiram cast slanting light across the next blank page. Faint pressure marks became visible. “Whatever was written on the torn page above may have left impressions here.”

Vinay's eyes lit up. “Can you read them?”

“Not by guessing now. I can photograph the page and examine it under light from different angles.”

Jaynarayan said at once, “Bag the notebook before any inference. Everyone in the house will have touched it. For now, we are trying to recover writing, not fingerprints.”

With Phulo's permission they opened the wooden trunk. Inside were two pairs of clothes, an old blanket, a

red-bordered sari that was probably Phulo's, a small mirror, a comb, dried neem leaves, and three letters wrapped in paper. The letters turned out to be school-fee notices and ration slips. No hidden money. No preparation for flight.

“Did she take clothes?”

“No,” Phulo said. “Only what she was wearing. Not even her little cloth bag.”

“Food?”

“She had wrapped two rotis for the night. Vasudha Didi often kept her late, so she would get hungry. The rotis went in her bag.”

Jaynarayan looked at Phulo's face. “Was that bag found?”

“No.”

At that small answer, everyone fell silent. Dulari had left home as though for an ordinary night's work: notebook, pen, torn umbrella, two rotis, the shared phone. Not to run away. Yet she had not returned.

When they asked about the phone, Phulo called her younger son, Niranjana. He was eleven, thin, and held a half-finished paper boat. The sight of the police frightened him, and he pressed himself against his sister's cot.

Jaynarayan crouched down and asked, “You play games on the phone?”

The boy's eyes brightened slightly. “Yes.”

“Were you upset that Didi took it yesterday?”

He nodded. “I told her to bring it back soon. She said, ‘I’ll be late tonight. You go to sleep.’”

“Whose numbers were stored in the phone?”

“I don't know. Didi had saved names—Ma, Madhavi Didi, Vasudha Didi, school, Kamli Kaki... and a few others.”

Abhiram asked, “Any lock code?”

The boy said proudly, “Four digits. I know it.” Then, seeing his mother's face, he fell silent.

“Do not say it now,” Jaynarayan said with a smile. “If the police need it, tell Vinay Babu then. Not in front of everyone.”

Perhaps for the first time, the boy understood that his small secret too had value. He nodded.

As they stepped outside, Jaynarayan noticed the bunch of dried basil hanging above the doorway, the sheet of plastic caught in the thatch, and the row of bricks laid down to hold back water. An ordinary household manages its insecurity through a thousand small devices. Dulari's life had been much the same: a

few rupees in an earthen container, notebooks beneath clothes, one phone shared by everyone, the path home at night watched over by herself. How much of such a life's habits could a town's computer ever know?

Before leaving Seven Hamlets, Jaynarayan asked to see the night school. The school was really half of an old panchayat storehouse: a tin roof, an alphabet painted on the wall, a broken weighing scale in one corner, and three long bamboo benches in the middle. During the day sacks of grain were stored there. At seven in the evening children came to learn letters, along with girls who worked in homes, young rickshaw drivers, and even two or three elderly people.

Shaila Bahin, who taught at the primary school by day and volunteered here in the evening, became silent as soon as she heard Dulari's name. "In the last six months she has not missed a single day without a reason. If work made her late, she would tell us beforehand. Yesterday she left at seven twenty. She said Vasudha Didi had called her to explain some papers."

"Her state of mind?" Jaynarayan asked.

"Restless, not frightened. She kept asking one question: 'Is testimony only something seen with the eyes, or can paper also testify?' I do not know the law, so I told her to ask Madhavi."

Madhavi's chest tightened again. Dulari had never had the chance to ask her.

Shaila Bahin opened a wooden cupboard and took out Dulari's exercise book. With the police's permission they looked through it. One lesson was on "The Changing Face of My Village." Dulari had written that when people went to the city to earn money, their old parents at home could not understand their land papers; anyone who could read ought to read the papers aloud to them. Another page told of river floods, erosion of soil, and houses having to move. The writing contained mistakes, but the thought was clear.

"This girl was not trying merely to understand her own case," Jaynarayan said.

Shaila Bahin smiled with faint pride. "She used to say, 'Now that I have found letters, I will read other people's papers too.'" Then the smile faded. "I do not believe a girl like that simply ran away. Yes, she might have hidden somewhere to save her life."

Vinay paid attention to the distinction—running away and hiding. People outside had collapsed the two into a single word.

Abhiram photographed the attendance register. Dulari's signature from the previous day was clear: "Dulari Sadai", time 7:19. Beneath it, beside the name of a new student, was a thumbprint. Abhiram stared at the page for a few moments. Sutra's world wanted everyone in an identical line, but here one person signed a name, another pressed a thumb, and someone else did not even

know a date of birth. Data builds equal boxes; life does not arrive in equal boxes.

Jaynarayan read his face. "What are you thinking?"

"That missing data is not always laziness. Sometimes it is circumstance."

"How will you teach Sutra that?"

Abhiram closed the register before answering. "First I will learn it myself."

Madhavi looked at him. That small sentence stayed inside her longer than the bitterness of yesterday's quarrel.

An earthen water pot stood beside the school door. Shaila Bahin gave everyone water. Phulo came from a distance and stood there. It seemed she had not followed the police so much as followed the road her daughter had taken. Yesterday Dulari had left from here, had touched this doorway, perhaps had drunk from this very pot. Phulo placed a hand over the mouth of the vessel and stood motionless for a long time.

"She will come back, won't she?" The question was addressed to no one in particular.

Jaynarayan did not offer false comfort. "We will not stop looking."

Phulo looked into his eyes. Perhaps she did not receive an answer to "will she return", but "we will not

stop looking” was something she could hold on to for now.

As they left Seven Hamlets, Abhiram said, “I will explicitly add the shared-phone fact to Sutra. In yesterday's timeline, the locations shown under Dulari's name were really only locations of the device.”

Jaynarayan said, “The language must change. Not ‘Dulari left the compound at 22:11.’ Say: ‘The phone associated with Dulari moved out of the compound area at 22:11.’ Between those two sentences lies an entire human life.”

Abhiram did not object. “Correct.”

Madhavi looked at him. Yesterday there had been a hard confidence in data in this young man's voice. Today he was correcting his own sentence. She felt some relief, though she said nothing.

When they reached the jeep, Vinay's phone rang. The technical team had news: at the time the threatening message was sent, the network signal came from the service area of one of three towers on the south-eastern edge of town. The area was large—the rear of the courthouse, the old pond, the bus stand, and the roads leading toward the river all fell within it.

“Nothing concrete,” Vinay said irritably.

“Not concrete,” Abhiram said, “but not nothing either.”

Jaynarayan stopped with one hand on the jeep door. “It was easy for the sender of the threat to guess that we would come to Dulari’s house. If that person is watching our movements, the next move must not be played according to their calculation.”

“Then?” Vinay asked.

“Dulari’s night school, Kamli’s shop, Vasudha’s bag, and the drain behind the courthouse—four directions. One at a time. No crowd.”

Madhavi looked once more toward the hut. Phulo still stood in the doorway. Niranjana’s paper boat had slipped into a stream of rainwater, and the boy was running after it. For a moment the scene was so ordinary that Dulari’s absence seemed impossible. As though she might come around a bend and say, “Ma, why are there so many people here?”

Madhavi’s gaze fell on an open notebook lying on the cot inside the hut. A breeze turned the page and exposed the last written sentence. She went inside and read it. It was in Dulari’s own hand:

“I will not run away. I will read the papers my ancestors could not read.”

Madhavi stared at the sentence for a long time. Outside, people were saying: Dulari ran away. Inside, her own hand was saying: I will not run away.

Where the truth lay between those two sentences, no one yet knew.

Chapter 5 — Madhavi's First Dream

By the time they returned from Seven Hamlets, the day had begun to slope toward evening. The rain had stopped, but the lanes of the town still retained its memory—green moss in one place, black water from a drain in another, an overturned bucket beside a doorway, a sack of paddy soaked through somewhere else. When Madhavi reached home, she could hear the thak-thak of the sewing machine from inside.

Her mother, Malati Devi, was joining the sleeve of a blouse, an old pair of spectacles perched on her nose. One foot worked the treadle, her hands held the cloth, and a length of thread rested between her lips. The moment she saw Madhavi, she removed the thread and said, “You’re back? Have you eaten even a single grain since morning?”

Instead of answering, Madhavi took off her bag and hung it on the peg in the wall. Her body felt so heavy it was as if all day she had been carrying not herself, but the fears of many people.

Malati stopped the machine. “I heard about Vasudha Didi. May God grant her soul—”

She did not finish the sentence. One look at her daughter’s face told her that a ready-made phrase of consolation would wound rather than soothe. “First wash your face and hands. I’ll warm the rice.”

The house was small, but everything had its place. Beside the window stood a box of thread arranged by colour, a measuring tape coiled above it, a half-stitched kurti hanging from a peg, and an old trunk in one corner. Madhavi had grown up in this house creating space for books wherever she could. Her mother cut cloth; she sat beside her with a law book open. To Madhavi the thak-thak of the machine was not noise but the heartbeat of home.

Today, even within that heartbeat, she could hear fear.

There was rice with potato-and-aubergine curry and sour mango chutney. Madhavi could not eat more than two mouthfuls. Malati kept looking at her plate, and finally asked, “Any news of Dulari?”

“No.”

“Did you see that girl's mother?”

“Yes.”

“She must be shattered.” Malati's hand paused for a moment. “When a poor family's daughter stays out late at night, people question her conduct before they question her safety. I've understood that since I was your age.”

Madhavi looked at her mother. Malati rarely said such things openly. Much of her own life had been buried beneath the sound of the sewing machine.

“Ma, if I get stuck at work late at night, are you afraid?”

“If I stopped being afraid, why would I be called a mother?” Malati smiled faintly. “But if fear became a reason to keep you tied inside the house, why were you given wings?”

Madhavi's eyes filled. She turned her face away at once.

Her phone vibrated. A message from Abhiram: “The pressure image from the notebook yielded something. Not clear. Two words are possibly ‘ghat’ and ‘blue’. Not certain. We'll look again tomorrow.” Beneath it was a second line: “I'm sorry about what I said this afternoon. I should not have said, ‘Knowing someone may itself be a bias,’ in that way.”

Madhavi began typing a reply, then erased it. She wrote another: “The reasoning wasn't wrong; the way you said it was.” She erased that too. In the end she wrote only: “All right. We'll see tomorrow.”

The reply came at once: “Eat something.”

An involuntary smile touched Madhavi's lips. Malati caught it. “Who?”

“Someone from work.”

“Work sends such sweet messages?”

“Ma!”

Malati started the machine again. “I didn't say anything.”

Madhavi went into her room. On the table lay two books Vasudha had given her: a book on the law of evidence and a small volume on land rights. On top of them was a slip of paper in Vasudha's handwriting: “Law is not merely a section in a statute; it is also the roof over someone's home.” Madhavi ran her fingers over it, then folded the paper shut at once. Grief does not always emerge as full-throated weeping; sometimes a single line catches in the throat and a person simply turns the page over.

Suddenly she remembered Vasudha's bag from the previous day—Vasudha had opened it three times and once had felt inside for a thick volume. The body had gone to the hospital; personal effects were on the police inventory. Madhavi called Vinay.

“Where is Vasudha Didi's bag?”

Vinay's voice was tired. “Sealed at the station. Why?”

“Yesterday she was looking for a thick book. It seemed to be wrapped in cloth. I didn't see it clearly.”

“We'll open the inventory tomorrow. It would not be proper to break the seal now. You rest.”

“Dulari?”

“Three teams are looking. The night school confirmed that she left at seven twenty yesterday evening. Then she went to the courthouse. After that, nothing concrete yet.”

Madhavi ended the call.

Malati still had work left. Basanti Kaki from the neighbourhood had come in the evening and said her granddaughter's school uniform was needed by morning. Death in the house, fear for Dulari, the sound of police voices—none of these could stop sewing; the income of a poor household does not take leave out of respect for grief. Malati kept cutting cloth with the measuring tape over her shoulder.

Listening to the machine, Madhavi remembered old days. When she had insisted on studying law, Vasudha had been the first person in the family circle to support her. Madhavi had then just passed Class Twelve, and an uncle had said, “Why spend so much on a girl? She'll do a B.A. and sit at home.” Vasudha had come herself to Malati's sewing room—not to have clothes stitched, but to speak to Malati. She had said, “Your daughter asks questions. If you stitch the mouth of her questions shut, even the thread in this machine will be ashamed.” Malati had burst out laughing, and from behind that laughter consent had emerged.

Now Vasudha was gone. Anger rose suddenly in Madhavi—how could someone who opened roads for others have her own road closed midway like this?

Joined to grief, anger brought a new energy into her body, but the energy had no direction.

The phone vibrated again. This time Abhiram was calling. Madhavi went to the doorway outside, where the air after the rain was a little cool.

“Yes?”

“I only wanted to know that you're all right,” Abhiram said, his voice lower than she expected. “And one thing about the pressure marks in the notebook—the word ‘ghat’ is not certain. It could also be ‘ghaat’—an ambush, an attack. So don't tell anyone yet.”

“Good. The moment an inference becomes a word, people turn it into an event. Jaynarayan Kaka has been teaching that all day.”

“You've started calling him Kaka?”

“Didi used to. It feels natural to me too.”

They were both silent for a few moments. A child cried somewhere far away. Abhiram said, “Madhavi... when I said yesterday that knowing someone could be a bias, I was really afraid of something in myself. In the work on Sutra, we are always told: remove personal relationships. But if you remove personal relationships from human life, what remains alive?”

Madhavi rubbed one foot against the wet brick beside the doorway. “Don't abandon reason. Just don't assume reason exists only on your side.”

“Accepted.”

“So quickly?”

“Shall I put it in writing?”

Madhavi laughed—the first open laugh after the entire day. Inside, Malati stopped the machine for a moment and looked toward the door, then returned to her sewing without saying anything.

Abhiram said, “Good. You laughed. Will you come to the courthouse early tomorrow? We need to examine the ventilator again.”

“I will. And I'll bring the envelope of dust too.”

“What dust?”

Madhavi paused for a moment. “Nothing. If I tell you at night, you'll laugh.”

“I won't. At most I'll look for a cause.”

“That's exactly what I'm afraid of,” Madhavi said, and ended the call. The smile was still on her face.

Night deepened. First the children's voices in the lane fell silent, then the clatter of washed utensils, then a distant radio; at last there remained only frogs and, now and then, the sound of a passing vehicle. Malati

completed the final stitches at her machine. Madhavi sat with a book open, but the letters would not enter her eyes. The sentence from Dulari's notebook—"I will not run away"—returned again and again. Alongside it came the threat: "If you want her alive..."

At half past eleven Malati told her to put out the light. "There will be no studying tonight. Close your eyes."

Madhavi lay down. The wall of the room was a pale sky-blue, painted two years earlier. No lime had flaked near the pillow. She looked once at her palm—clean. She remembered the white particles they had seen beneath Vasudha's nails at the courthouse. "Like lime," Jaynarayan had said.

Clouds growled again outside.

Madhavi did not know when sleep came.

In the dream, she heard water first. She saw it only afterward.

She was standing on the steps of a pond. The sky was neither night nor dawn, but the grey between them. The pond water was not still, though there was no wind. Seven steps descended into the water. The first five were clear. The sixth was covered in moss. The seventh was half beneath the surface.

At the far end of the steps lay a red dupatta. No person. Only the dupatta. Although the cloth was wet, it

did not sink; it slowly swelled and contracted upon the water as though breathing.

Madhavi moved toward it. Her footsteps made no sound. She could not hear even her own breathing. Only an anklet sounded somewhere within—once. Then silence. Then twice.

She looked around. Behind the ghat stood a thick wall. No door in it, no window. The anklet sounded from within that wall.

Tink.

Tink-tink.

Madhavi placed her hand against the wall. The surface was cold. The instant her palm touched it, white lime-dust began to fall. But it did not fall downward; it floated upward, as though gravity had been forgotten. She tried to pull her hand away, but her palm was stuck to the wall.

Inside the wall she could hear a woman's breathing. No sobbing. No words. Only breath.

The red dupatta was no longer on the steps. It had reached the middle of the pond. A blue thread hung from one corner of it. Seven circular ripples rose on the water—one, two, three, four, five, six... before the seventh could form, the anklet rang suddenly, violently loud.

Madhavi turned. A hair-thin crack opened in the wall. There was no darkness within the crack, but a yellow light. In that light, for a moment, she saw someone's hand—nothing on the wrist, soil on the fingers, white dust beneath the nails.

Whether it was Vasudha's hand or someone else's, Madhavi could not tell.

A voice came so softly that she could not hear the words themselves; only their meaning entered her mind: "The wall listens."

Madhavi woke with a violent start.

Her chest worked like a bellows. The room was dark. Lightning flashed beyond the window. Malati was asleep in the adjoining room. The first thing Madhavi did was feel her own hands. Her left palm was clean. Across the right lay a fine layer of white dust.

She sat absolutely still.

"No," she whispered to herself. "This is possible. Courthouse all day, walls, notebooks, mud... something must have stuck."

She tried to remember. She had washed her face and hands after coming home. She had eaten rice. Lifted utensils. Touched the books. If the dust had been there, it should have washed away. Yet there were clearly white particles in the lines beside her nails.

Madhavi switched on the light. Pillow, bedsheet, wall, cushion—nowhere was there white lime. The wall paint was intact. The ceiling carried old soot, but that dust was black.

She did not go to wash her hand. Even through fear, the mind that studied law told her one thing: when something seems strange, first preserve it. She took a small clean paper envelope from the desk drawer and lightly tapped her palm over it. The particles fell inside. She folded the envelope and wrote the time: “2:13 a.m. Immediately after waking from a dream.”

Even as she wrote, she felt like laughing at herself. “Am I losing my mind?”

She picked up the phone. She wanted to message Abhiram, but it was two thirteen in the morning. She stopped. Then she noticed on the screen that Abhiram had been active half an hour earlier. Probably working.

She wrote: “Are you awake?”

The answer came within a minute: “Yes. Looking at the notebook images. What happened?”

Madhavi wrote: “Nothing. One question. Can yesterday's lime remain under the nails even after washing the hands twice?”

The reply took longer. “It can, if fine particles are trapped beneath the nails. Why?”

Madhavi sent a photograph of her hand. She still did not have the courage to describe the dream. She wrote only: "Found it when I woke."

Abhiram: "Is lime flaking in your room?"

"No."

"Did you touch a wall at the courthouse yesterday?"

"I don't remember."

"Don't be afraid. Keep it in an envelope. We'll compare it tomorrow. Did you have some kind of dream?"

Madhavi stared at the screen for a few moments. "Yes."

"Will you tell me?"

"Tomorrow."

Abhiram's reply came: "All right. Sleep with the light on if you want. And drink some water."

Madhavi wanted to smile, but tears filled her eyes. How strange—the remedy for human fear is not always philosophy; sometimes it is only: drink some water.

She got up and drank. She did not switch off the light.

Sleep returned, but the dream did not. When she woke in the first light of morning, the envelope was still on the table. Her palm was clean. The night's event

might have seemed an extension of the dream, if there had not been white particles inside the paper.

While putting tea on the stove, Malati asked, “Why did you leave the light on last night?”

“I woke up.”

“Bad dream?”

Madhavi started. “How did you know?”

“You’ve had the habit since childhood. When you see a frightening dream, you make a fist with your right hand.” Malati crushed ginger into the tea. “At dawn your fist was so tight that your nails left marks.”

Madhavi looked at her right palm. Four red crescent-shaped marks. The wall from the dream rose again in her mind.

“Ma, do you believe in dreams?”

Malati thought for a while. “Dreams? The mind digests at night what it has swallowed all day. Sometimes an old memory, sometimes fear, sometimes desire. But there is one thing: some dreams are so vivid that in the morning the mind mistakes them for events. Then one should not rush to extract meaning from them.”

“Ambika Kaki says dreams give signs.”

“Ambika Kaki knows the stories of fifty households, so her signs often seem to come true. Someone who listens

to a great deal learns to make deep guesses. Whether that is magic or experience, I don't know.”

Madhavi kept looking at her mother. Without reading any book, Malati had said something so simple that Jaynarayan too would have approved.

When Madhavi reached the courthouse, Jaynarayan was already on the veranda. He held a narrow strip of paper in his hand and was looking at the outer wall of the old building. Madhavi handed him the envelope. “Something strange happened.”

She told him the entire dream—the pond, the seven steps, the red dupatta, the anklet inside the wall, the blue thread. Abhiram arrived midway and listened in silence. Madhavi's voice sometimes fell with embarrassment, sometimes quickened. At the end she showed them the envelope.

Jaynarayan neither laughed nor looked startled. He asked only, “Where did you encounter white dust at the courthouse yesterday?”

“Under Vasudha Didi's nails. There is lime on parts of the wall. I washed my hands at home.”

“Particles can remain even after washing. They could also have transferred later from paper, cloth, or a bag. We will check all those routes first. Do not make the dream into evidence, but a dream certainly tells us something about the material inside your mind. Why

seven steps? Why the red dupatta? Why a wall? Perhaps a joining of things you heard and saw all day. Perhaps an older memory. For now, no more than that.”

Abhiram said quietly, “We’ll compare the dust. The sample from the scene is in the laboratory.”

Madhavi looked at him. Yesterday he might have said, “A dream is not a fact.” That was still what he meant, but there was no contempt in his voice today.

Jaynarayan pointed toward the outer wall. “And in the dream, was the wall breathing?”

Madhavi started. “I heard breathing.”

“I’m not asking about the dream,” he said with a smile. “Today we’ll see whether this wall really breathes.”

Abhiram looked up at the ventilator. Vinay was approaching with two constables. In his hand was Dulari’s old torn umbrella, recovered during the night from a peg in the eastern veranda of the courthouse. Phulo had identified it.

Inside Madhavi, the anklet from the dream was still ringing. Outside, the light of day was clear. The two worlds ought to have remained separate from one another—but today she felt the wall between them had grown very thin.

Chapter 6 — The Locked Room's Second Breath

Dulari's umbrella was an utterly ordinary object: black cloth, patched in two places, one rib bent, the plastic of the handle worn smooth. Even sealed inside a police evidence bag, it seemed to contain an entire history of poverty. Instead of buying a new umbrella, it had been stitched again and again, wired where necessary, and put back into use. Phulo Sadai had said, “It can still keep the rain off. Why throw it away?”

The first question Jaynarayan asked on seeing it was, “Where was this found?”

Vinay said, “On a peg in the eastern veranda of the old building. No one paid attention to it in the first search last night; everyone assumed it belonged to someone from the courthouse. It was separated out when the inventory was made in the morning. Phulo identified it—the yellow thread around the handle was tied by her own hand.”

Madhavi remembered what Buchchan had said the previous day: Dulari had gone inside without an umbrella. So leaving it on the veranda was entirely possible. The question was not why the umbrella was there. The question was where Dulari had gone from there.

For reasons of evidentiary procedure, Vinay did not hand the actual umbrella to Jaynarayan. Instead, an old umbrella of roughly the same size was borrowed from a peon. "Use this for the experiment," Vinay said. "The evidence umbrella stays in the bag."

Jaynarayan looked pleased. "Today the police are being more careful than I am."

"I've spent two days with you," Vinay said with a smile. "Some habits are bound to rub off."

The old records room was still sealed. With permission the seal was opened, and the entry time of everyone going inside was recorded. With the body removed, the emptiness among the papers seemed more conspicuous. The table, chair, clock, and cupboard remained marked as before. The broken panel of the door was held in place temporarily with a bamboo brace.

Jaynarayan first had the positions of the two water drops marked on the floor from the photographs. The actual drops had dried, but the images and measurements were available. The first had been about two cubits inside the door; the second lay farther in, toward the ventilator. There had been no third.

"Yesterday we could have built an easy story," he said. "A wet person came inside and two drops fell. But would a rain-soaked person leave only two drops? The rain that night was heavy."

Vinay said, “Someone could have wrung out their clothes before coming in.”

“Could have. So I am not erasing that story. I am only looking for another one.”

He looked up at the ventilator. The inner grille was old iron, divided into square openings. The outer grille was a later addition, finer in mesh. Between the two lay the thick wall. The computer plan from the previous day had shown a five-inch empty gap, but the wall of the old building was in fact more than two feet thick. The question was: what occupied the rest of that thickness?

Abhiram opened an old plan on his tablet. “This is the 1978 repair plan. Here the ventilator runs directly to the outside wall. But I still haven't found the original plan.”

“A repair plan shows the present, not the history,” Jaynarayan said. “Ask the age of the wall from the building itself.”

He taped a thin strip of paper beside the calendar page. The door and window were closed as fully as possible. The strip continued to move faintly.

“There is wind outside,” Abhiram said.

“Good. Now cover the outside ventilator with the umbrella.”

A constable climbed a ladder outside. He spread the old umbrella cloth completely over the grille and

weighted the edges with bricks. Inside, everyone watched the paper strip. For a moment it stopped—then began to move again.

Abhiram frowned. “Is it completely covered?”

A voice came from outside. “Yes.”

“A gap in the window?” Vinay checked. It was shut from inside. Because the door was broken, the experiment could not yet be perfectly controlled, so thick plastic was taped over the damaged section. The strip still moved.

Jaynarayan's eyes brightened. “Air is entering by another route.”

Abhiram immediately took out a small smokeless airflow indicator—a tuft of very light paper that bent toward the slightest current. Held directly beneath the ventilator, it did not lean toward the outside grille. It tilted instead toward the wall on the left.

“That's impossible,” Abhiram murmured.

“Scientists should not use the word impossible so quickly,” Jaynarayan teased.

“All right—unexpected.”

They shone a light through the ventilator. Behind the grille there was not merely a straight darkness: on the right came the light from outside; on the left, inside the

wall itself, was a narrow black slit. Repair plaster had covered half of it.

Vinay said, “An old air duct?”

Abhiram enlarged the plan. “Not on the 1978 drawing.”

Jaynarayan tapped the wall. In one place the sound was a deep thak; elsewhere it answered with a hollow tun. “There is empty space inside here.”

The dream of the night ran through Madhavi's body again—the breathing inside the wall. She said nothing.

They summoned Ramcharit, the old peon of the building. He had spent fifty-six years around the courthouse, first working beside his father and later on his own. Jaynarayan asked, “Was there once some kind of duct inside this wall?”

Ramcharit did not answer at once. He looked at the ventilator, then the door, then the veranda roof. “Babu, this building is older even than I am. But cleaners, peons, and masons used to know more about the old building than the plans did. What was closed on paper was not always closed in practice.”

Vinay raised an eyebrow. “Meaning?”

“Meaning that once, during heavy rain, the records got wet. My father used to say there were passages inside the wall for air to circulate. Once a rat died in the mouth

of one of those passages, and the whole room filled with a foul smell, but no one could find the rat anywhere. Two days later they opened an iron plate in the rear room and pulled it out.”

“An iron plate?” Abhiram asked at once.

“Yes. But I don't remember exactly where it was.”

Jaynarayan looked toward Vinay. “Even a dead rat can teach us the plan of a building.”

Ramcharit laughed, then grew serious. “There are many things in the old courthouse that babus never write in files. Which room leaks in the rain, where snakes come out, which window latch can be shaken from outside—we learn all that by working here. But every time a new officer arrives, all that knowledge begins again from zero.”

Abhiram fell silent. Ramcharit's memory existed nowhere in Sutra's records. For the first time he understood clearly that part of an institution's knowledge lives on paper, while another part lives in the habits of human bodies. What survives on paper can be digitised; what dies with a person is far harder to reconstruct.

“Is your father alive?” Jaynarayan asked.

“No. Twenty years now.”

“Who else might remember that iron plate?”

Ramcharit listed several names—one retired mason, an old record keeper, a cleaner now living with her daughter in Nepal. Vinay wrote them all down.

“Will all this go into Sutra?” Jaynarayan asked Abhiram.

Abhiram replied, “Not merely names. We need a separate category—‘oral memory of the building’—with reliability checks.”

“Good. Human memory is neither divine revelation nor rubbish.”

Scratching his head, Ramcharit said, “I remember hearing when I was small that this building had ventilated openings to dry papers. The damp from rain was terrible. Many were closed later. There was also a narrow passage with steps, later bricked up.”

“Where?”

“Beyond the rear veranda. Where the junk room is now.”

Vinay sent two constables. The junk room was opened. Inside were broken tables, old election boxes, pieces of iron grille, torn banners. On the rear wall, amid newer plaster, ran a long raised strip. When tapped, it too produced a hollow sound.

Abhiram grew excited. “If this old passage connects with the duct beside the ventilator, then air can circulate from here even when the outside grille is covered.”

“Air,” Vinay said. “Not a human being.”

“For now, only air,” Jaynarayan repeated. “The question of entry remains exactly where it was.”

They returned to the records room. Jaynarayan looked at the positions of the two drops on the floor and at the top of the cupboard beneath the ventilator. Dust lay across the cupboard, but in one place there were two small clean circles. Along the metal strip above ran a streak of rust.

“If water came from above, it may have paused here and then dripped,” he said.

Abhiram opened local weather-station data from the previous night to check the direction of the rain. Between three and five in the morning the wind had blown from south-east toward north-west. The outer ventilator was on the northern wall of the building. Direct rain should therefore have reached it only slightly.

“But the other mouth of the old duct may face east,” Jaynarayan said. “Then water could have entered the duct with the wind and left two drops in this room.”

Vinay looked slightly disappointed. “Then the two drops are no longer evidence that a person entered.”

“Their evidentiary weight has decreased; it has not vanished. This is how investigation proceeds. Something sharp yesterday becomes blunt today. Truth is under no obligation to please us.”

Watching the umbrella experiment, Madhavi asked, “What does Dulari's umbrella tell us in all this?”

Jaynarayan pointed toward the peg outside. “Dulari left the umbrella outside when she went in—that agrees with Buchchan's statement. If she later came out again during the night, ordinarily she would have taken it, because the rain had grown heavy. The umbrella remained there. Two possibilities follow: she left in such haste that she forgot it, or she did not come out by that route at all. But then—”

“How did she disappear?” Madhavi completed the question.

“That is exactly where we are.”

Abhiram remembered his string hypothesis from the previous day. “Shall we test today whether the latch can be fastened from outside?”

Vinay gave permission. They practised on a rod of the same thickness as the old latch. A thin cord was fed through the outer grille. It passed the first straight five inches, but caught where the inner grille met the angle of the wall. The actual ventilator grille was not removed;

the route was tested using photographs and a thin probing wire.

Abhiram tried three different angles. “Reaching the latch directly from the outer grille is almost impossible. Yesterday the computer assumed a straight line; the displacement of the inner grille was not fully present in the model.”

Jaynarayan smiled faintly. “One of Sutra's assumptions has broken.”

“Mine too,” Abhiram said without trying to defend himself. “I became excited too quickly.”

“Enthusiasm is no fault, provided you can break your own inference the next day.”

Madhavi watched them both. She liked this form of investigation—being wrong was not shameful; clinging to what was wrong was.

When the thin probing wire was pushed into the slit on the left side of the old duct, it travelled much farther than expected. Abhiram measured it—about five feet—then it struck something hard. If the duct turned toward the junk room, there might be a bricked section between them.

Vinay said, “We cannot break the wall without permission.”

“And there is no need to break it yet,” Jaynarayan replied. “First the original plan, the repair records, old photographs of the building. A wall is not the final witness whose belly we immediately cut open.”

The phrase “the wall's belly” lodged in Madhavi's mind. In the dream she had placed her hand upon the wall. Without meaning to, she looked at her right palm. The red crescent marks from her nails were fading.

Abhiram noticed. “Did you give them the dust sample?”

“Yes.”

“The preliminary comparison won't come before tomorrow. Don't think anything yet.”

“You too are telling me ‘don't think anything’ about the dream?”

“No,” he said with a smile. “I'm saying don't draw a conclusion from the dust. The dream is yours. Think whatever you want about it.”

A faint smile appeared on Madhavi's face. The sharpness of yesterday had not entirely gone, but a softer space was beginning to form between them.

Just then a constable came running from the junk room. “Sir, there's something like a small iron cover in the lower part of the wall. We saw it after moving the junk.”

Everyone went there. About a cubit and a half above the floor was a square iron plate set into the plaster, almost erased beneath layers of paint and lime. Around its edge were old screwdriver marks. It was rusty now, but one corner was comparatively clean.

Vinay grew serious. "Opened recently?"

Jaynarayan bent to examine it without touching. "Hard to say. The clean corner may be recent abrasion, or something stored here may have struck it. Photograph it, take samples, then call a workman."

Abhiram matched the location against the plan. The iron plate lay along the probable line of the duct to the left of the records-room ventilator.

"If this is an inspection hatch," he said, "the duct opens here."

Vinay's eyes widened. "A person?"

"We don't yet know the width of the passage. Perhaps only a hand or a tool."

Jaynarayan measured the distance from room to room. "To say that a killer entered and left through this duct would be foolish at this stage. But the statement that the room was 'completely sealed' is now certainly false. There is another route for air, water, and possibly a slender tool or cord."

Vinay said quietly, “So half the locked-room mystery is broken?”

“No. The door is merely less mysterious. The question of how a person entered is still alive.”

Jaynarayan returned to the records room and looked again at the calendar page. The outer grille was still covered by the umbrella. The page moved. A fine current came through from inside the wall on the left.

He held his palm beneath the ventilator. “Look—the room's second breath.”

A shiver went through Madhavi.

At that very moment a very faint metallic sound came from somewhere inside the duct—tin... only once. Perhaps the probing wire had struck something; perhaps an old piece of metal had shifted in the airflow. Abhiram looked sharply to the left. Vinay sent a constable to check the junk room. Nothing was found.

In Madhavi's ears the anklet from the dream rang again. She rebuked herself: do not turn a daytime metallic sound into the anklet from a dream.

As though reading her face, Jaynarayan said softly, “Once the mind has heard a story, it writes every new sound in the words of that story. That is why, in moments of fear, the ear too is a witness—but a witness to be treated with caution.”

Madhavi asked, “Aren't you ever afraid?”

Jaynarayan was silent for a moment. “Of course I am. Anyone who says fear never touches them is recording their own mind falsely. The difference is only this: give fear a chair, not the pen.”

The umbrella was removed from outside. Morning cloud-light fell across the ventilator. Jaynarayan looked again at the thin pale line on the outer wall, where the previous day's rain streaks had seemed to divide around something. The line fell directly opposite the leftward turn of the duct.

“Find old photographs,” he told Abhiram. “From before 1978. Relief camps, earthquake records, construction photographs—whatever exists. We need to know when this air duct was made, when it was sealed, and who knew about it.”

Abhiram nodded. “There are some images from 1934 in the digitisation list. I'll search them all.”

The moment she heard “1934”, Madhavi remembered the seven steps of her dream again. And the cloth-wrapped volume in Vasudha's bag. Old records, Seven Hamlets, the blue thread, the breathing wall—separate things were now circling like shadows in the same room, but Jaynarayan's caution prevented her from stitching them too quickly into a single story.

By noon the experiments were finished. Vinay resealed the room. Abhiram added a new fact to Sutra: “External airflow connection to room: multiple pathways probable; sealed-room assumption invalid.”

The system requested permission to recalculate its earlier probabilities.

Vinay asked, “Run it?”

Abhiram looked toward Jaynarayan.

Jaynarayan smiled. “Run it. But write above the result, in bold letters: ‘Subject to change when new facts arrive.’”

Abhiram laughed. “Madhavi made me add that yesterday.”

The percentages changed on the screen, but this time Madhavi did not read the numbers. Her eyes went to the warning. Perhaps whether human beings learn or not could be measured by something as small as this.

They all went outside. The veranda of the old building had already filled with the ordinary clamour of the courthouse day—litigants, lawyers, papers, tea, shouted names. Yesterday death had been here. Today life had already resumed its pace.

Madhavi turned once to look at the sealed door. From the outside, the door was closed. Inside, air was moving.

Within the wall lay an old duct forgotten by the current plans.

The locked room was now less locked than before, yet the mystery had grown larger.

For the question was no longer merely who had been inside that night. There was another question now: who knew the paths by which this old building breathed?

Chapter 7 — Vasudha's Home

By late afternoon the rain had thinned, but the crowd in front of Vasudha's house had still not diminished. Two pairs of slippers lay half-sunk in mud near the door; wet umbrellas crowded the veranda; in one corner were tulsi leaves and the smoke of incense. Inside came the muffled weeping of women, outside the low murmur of men. Once death enters a house, people's voices lower of their own accord, while curiosity often grows sharper.

Jaynarayan stopped at the doorway. Vinay was with him; Madhavi stood a little behind. Abhiram had not come this time. He was at the courthouse sorting old photographs of the building and repair records.

“Let the family grieve first. Questions later,” Madhavi said softly.

Jaynarayan looked at her. “Yes. But often, in the first hours of grief, things emerge naturally. Later the household dresses them, arranges them, and makes them uniform. Fewer questions; more listening.”

Vinay instructed the guard at the doorway not to allow unnecessary people inside. Vasudha's husband, Arun, came out himself. He wore a white kurta; he had not shaved; blue shadows lay beneath his eyes. The moment he saw Jaynarayan, he folded his hands.

“Didi respected you greatly,” he said. His voice was exhausted, but his words were clear. “At a time like this, for you to be drawn into all this trouble...”

“Not trouble,” Jaynarayan interrupted. “Vasudha respected me, and argued back with me just as strongly. I will say nothing now on her behalf. I will only try to understand what was there.”

Arun's eyes lifted for a moment, then fell again. “What is there left to understand now? The one who is gone...”

Leaving the sentence unfinished, he led them inside.

The sitting room was not large. Three family photographs hung on the wall: one from the wedding, one from a school prize ceremony, and one showing Vasudha in a courthouse crowd that looked like a protest. In the wedding photograph she was serious in a red sari; in the prize photograph she was laughing; in the third she held papers, without a microphone, listening to someone speak. It seemed almost like three different temperaments within one face.

A rug lay spread in the centre of the room. Vasudha's mother sat with her back against the wall. Her eyes were swollen, though the weeping had stopped. Her mother-in-law sat in another corner, turning prayer beads. Her brother, Prakhar, stood by the window, repeatedly picking up and setting down his phone.

The moment Madhavi entered, Vasudha's mother saw her and stretched out a hand. "You were with her until yesterday, weren't you?"

Madhavi folded her knees and sat beside her. "Yes, Maiji."

"Did she say anything? About the house? About me? Anyone's name?"

This was not merely the curiosity of an investigation. It was a mother's last hunger: had her dead daughter thought of her in the final hours or not? Madhavi's throat tightened. She told the truth. "Didi was talking about the land papers. And she told me not to let Dulari go out alone. She did not speak in detail about anything at home."

Her mother nodded slowly. "She was like that from childhood. Her own sorrow in her stomach, everyone else's sorrow in her hands."

By the window, Prakhar's jaw tightened. "Ma, what is the need to say all this now?"

Jaynarayan listened carefully to his voice—grief? irritation? exhaustion? All three can live inside the same sentence.

"Whether there is a need or not is not for me to decide," the mother said. "My daughter is gone. Whatever I remember, I will say."

The mother-in-law stopped moving the beads and said quietly, "Everything in the heart is not spoken everywhere. A household's name matters too."

The old sentence rang in Madhavi's ears: nothing is greater than the family's name. Vasudha had once laughingly told her that her mother-in-law said such things. Madhavi had taken it then as merely a domestic barb. Today the edge of the sentence felt different.

In an official tone, Vinay said, "We have not come assuming anyone is guilty. The death is suspicious. Anything in the household that may help the investigation needs to be understood."

"Suspicious?" Prakhar turned. "Since morning we've been hearing that the police are calling it suicide."

"The police's preliminary inference is not the final truth," Vinay replied. "The door was locked from inside, but the room was not completely sealed. Some physical details do not fit."

For the first time Arun became sharp. "What does not fit?"

"Everything cannot be shared yet," Vinay said.

"I am her husband."

"Which is why we will question you too. But not every detail from the scene can be disclosed now."

For several moments the only sound in the room was the faint movement of prayer beads. Jaynarayan opened no notebook. His manner made Prakhar uneasy. When a policeman writes, answering is simpler—the question ends, the line ends. This old man merely watched.

Jaynarayan asked Vasudha's mother, “Was Vasudha stubborn from childhood?”

Prakhar almost laughed, but the sound was bitter. “The whole town could answer that question.”

His mother ignored him. “Stubborn? Yes, when she believed something was right. When she was five, she would not let us sell a calf from the cowshed. She said, ‘It was born in this house; it will stay in this house.’ At ten, a poor girl's name was struck off the school register; Vasudha sat at the headmaster's door. She was stubborn, but seldom for herself.”

Her mother-in-law cleared her throat slightly. “Stubbornness is fine if one also understands the dignity of the household. After marriage, a woman does not belong only to her own wishes.”

A response rose inside Madhavi, but she remained silent. Jaynarayan immediately turned toward the mother-in-law. “Which matters of the household did Vasudha refuse to listen to?”

“I did not say it like that.” She became cautious. “She was educated. She worked. Did I ever stop her? But court

at all hours, slums, across the river—will people at home not worry?”

“Arun?”

Arun's hand tightened on the armrest. “I never stopped her work. On the contrary, many times I gave her the car, gave her money. But yes, over the last two or three months she had begun taking more risks than necessary. Threatening calls came. I told her to report them to the police. She would say, ‘Against whose name should I file a threat that comes without a name?’”

Vinay asked immediately, “The numbers?”

“Mostly unknown. Twice she changed phones.”

“Where are the old phones?”

“One should be somewhere in the house. I'll find it.”

Prakhar spoke suddenly. “The threats were not only because of cases. Didi walked into people's houses and took on their fights. Seven Hamlets, the embankment, land, wages—wherever there were two sides, she would arrive and become a third.”

Madhavi looked at him. “So?”

“So don't place the blame for everything on the family. Since morning people have been making stories about quarrels at home.”

“I didn't blame the family,” Madhavi said.

“Your face did.”

“Prakhar!” his mother said sharply.

He fell silent, but kept tapping his fingers against the window frame. Jaynarayan memorised the rhythm—three slow taps, two quick. Nervousness finds its own metre in the human body.

Jaynarayan turned back to Arun. “When did you last speak to Vasudha yesterday evening?”

Arun thought for a moment. “After seven. Around seven forty-five. She said she would be late. I told her to come home; the rain was getting worse. She said Dulari was coming and there were some papers to reconcile.”

“Her voice normal?”

“Tired. A little irritable. But not frightened.”

“Did you quarrel?”

Arun's eyes moved toward his mother, then Prakhar. “No.”

The “no” came so quickly that Jaynarayan said nothing.

Vasudha's mother spoke. “They quarrelled two days ago.”

Arun closed his eyes. “Ma...”

“If it is true, it is true,” Vasudha's mother said plainly. “I heard them on the phone. Vasudha was saying, ‘I will not return the papers.’ Arun was saying, ‘Talk at home first.’”

Jaynarayan asked, “Which papers?”

Arun let out a breath. “I don't know. She brought many papers home. Someone's land papers, someone's application. I had only said it was not right to keep anyone's original documents with herself. Later she could be accused of theft.”

“Vasudha said, ‘I will not return them’?”

“Perhaps she was talking about copies. Ma did not hear the whole conversation.”

Her mother seemed about to object, then stopped. Perhaps she too understood that memory is sharp in grief, but not always complete.

Vinay made a note. “Where did Vasudha keep her private papers at home?”

Arun led them to a room at the back. It was a small study: a wooden desk, two cupboards, bundles of files on the floor, and on the wall a line written in Mithilakshar that Madhavi could not fully read. On the desk lay a blue-ink pen, a small brass fish used as a paperweight, and in one corner fennel and cardamom for making tea without sugar.

“This room was hers,” Arun said. “I did not touch her files without asking.”

From a distance Jaynarayan examined the papers on the desk. Each stack had a small slip on top: case, correspondence, copies, personal. The upper-left corner of the papers was folded. One, two, five, seven—almost all of them.

Madhavi leaned toward the desk without thinking. “Didi folded the left corner of papers. To remember.”

“What?” Vinay asked.

“If she had to return to a paper, she would bend the upper-left corner slightly. She said clips could not always be found when needed.”

Jaynarayan was silent for several moments. In his mind rose the unfinished page at the scene—that page had been folded at the right corner.

He said nothing about it yet. He asked only, “An old habit?”

Arun said, “Very old. She ruined books the same way. I’ve told her so many times.”

The mother-in-law had come to the doorway. “A life spent among papers and books. Who ever looked after the household papers?”

“Which household papers?” Jaynarayan asked at once.

Startled, she said, “I only mean ordinary things—bank, insurance, house tax. If a woman puts herself into everyone's outside quarrels, who will keep the accounts of the house?”

Arun said wearily, “Ma, not now.”

Jaynarayan examined the lock on the cupboard. One door was open. Inside were not clothes but records, old maps, several envelopes. The police had already made a preliminary inventory. Vinay showed the list. “The bag recovered from the scene is being kept separately as evidence. The papers at home will also be inventoried. No one is to remove anything.”

Prakhar appeared at the doorway. “Why are we being treated like criminals?”

Vinay remained calm. “Because no one has been declared a criminal, all facts are being viewed from the same distance.”

“The same distance?” Prakhar's voice rose. “Dulari is missing, people are talking about her, but the police are counting our cupboards.”

Madhavi said at once, “Dulari is missing. She has not been proved guilty.”

“To you, every poor person looks innocent?”

“No. To me, a human being remains a human being until guilt is proved.”

Before Prakhar could answer, Jaynarayan stepped in. “Did Vasudha quarrel with you about this too?”

Prakhar's mouth closed.

“How many times?”

Looking toward the window, he said, “Do people count quarrels between brother and sister?”

“When there has been a death, even very small things are counted.”

Prakhar clenched his teeth. “She did not want to leave the Seven Hamlets case. I told her our family's name was tied to old dealings with the land group; she was making enemies of everyone for nothing. That's all.”

“Which land group?” Vinay asked.

“There are many people. Partnerships keep changing. I don't know the full names.”

Jaynarayan raised an eyebrow slightly. Prakhar, who dealt in land in the town, saying he did not know the “full names” sounded rather like a fish claiming not to know where the pond was. But Jaynarayan did not seize on it yet.

Vasudha's mother said softly, “Vasudha used to say there was very old dishonesty in the papers of the Seven Hamlets land.”

“Ma, again!” Prakhar snapped.

“Why does it burn you? You say you know nothing.” For the first time his mother looked at him with hard eyes.

The old cracks buried beneath the household's grief had become visible. Death does not necessarily unite a family; sometimes it merely throws light on the fissures the living have kept hidden behind curtains.

Jaynarayan changed the subject. “Did Vasudha chew betel nut at night?”

Her mother-in-law said, “She did chew it, but not at night. It gave her acidity.”

Arun nodded. “The doctor had stopped her. Two or three times during the day, never after dinner.”

Madhavi thought of the scene—the betel-nut box open, pieces of betel nut outside it.

“Tea?” Jaynarayan asked.

“Without sugar,” her mother said. “As a child she loved sweet things. Later she gave sugar up completely.”

“Everyone at home knew?”

For the first time a faint smile appeared on Arun's face. “Anyone who put sugar in her tea once would not forget a second time. She simply would not drink it.”

Jaynarayan drew a long breath. Three habits: the left-folded corner, no betel nut at night, tea without sugar.

He stored them in his mind. They still had to be matched against the evidence.

Suddenly a woman began to cry loudly outside. Perhaps a relative had arrived from some distance. Everyone in the room looked that way for a moment. In that one moment Prakhar slipped his phone into his pocket, but Madhavi's eyes caught the line glowing on the screen: "Don't call again. The police are at the house now." The sender's name was not visible.

Madhavi's body became alert, but she said nothing. She understood that seeing a thing did not instantly create its meaning. It might be Prakhar's business associate, a journalist, a creditor, a woman, a friend. Jaynarayan's warning returned to her: once the mind has heard a story, it writes every new sound in that story's words.

Arun suddenly asked, "Have you found Dulari?"

Vinay said, "Not yet."

"Do you know why Vasudha called her?"

Before Madhavi answered, Vinay looked at her. She said, "Possibly about the land papers. Dulari attended night school; Didi was teaching her how to understand copies."

A complicated expression crossed Arun's face—pity, exhaustion, or disbelief. "She's a good girl. Vasudha brought her home many times. Ma didn't like it."

The mother-in-law spoke at once. “When did I say the girl was bad? I only said it was not right to bring everyone into the house without restriction. Workers, litigants, people from other households’ quarrels—should a home remain a home or become an office?”

“Dulari is not a servant,” Madhavi’s voice hardened of its own accord.

The mother-in-law looked at her. “I did not name her.”

The room tightened again. Jaynarayan rose slowly. “Let this be enough for now. We will not add the weight of questions to a house in mourning.”

Vinay told Arun to provide by evening the old phones, the threatening messages, the car, and a list of everyone who had been present in the house the previous day. At the word “car”, Arun’s eyelids flickered once more than necessary. Jaynarayan saw it but said nothing.

As they left, Madhavi looked back toward the study. A paper hanging on the wall did not move in the still air. Unlike the calendar at the courthouse. This room breathed ordinarily.

When they reached the lane, Vinay asked, “What did we get?”

Jaynarayan tapped the tip of his walking stick into the mud. “Four living stories about one dead woman.”

“Four?”

“Her mother says she was stubborn for others. Her mother-in-law says she did not understand the household. Her husband says she took risks, but supported her work. Her brother says she went looking for quarrels. There may be some truth in all four. None is the whole story.”

Madhavi added softly, “And Didi cannot tell her own story now.”

“Then her habits will speak,” Jaynarayan replied. “People lie. Habits lie less often.”

Vinay said, “You're thinking about the tea, the betel nut, and the folded paper?”

“Yes. Ask the laboratory tomorrow for the residue report from the cups. We'll look again at the page from the scene. Also the status of fingerprints on the box. When three small things point in one direction, we should at least walk in that direction and see.”

At that moment Vinay's phone rang. The station reported that, of the two cups recovered in the case, sugar crystals had been found at the bottom of one; none in the other. The quantity was still under examination.

Vinay ended the call and looked at Jaynarayan.

Jaynarayan remained silent for a few moments. Then he said, “Yesterday the family would have told us

Vasudha never took sugar. Today the laboratory says one cup contained sugar. The question now is not whose cup it was. The question is whether two people's everyday habits were present in that room that night—or whether someone constructed the scene.”

In Madhavi's mind flashed all the left-folded papers in Vasudha's study.

The rain began again as a fine drizzle. Inside the house there was weeping, in the lane there was mud, and three small habits were slowly beginning to attach themselves to a death.

Chapter 8 — Everyday Habits

Before the courthouse opened at dawn, Kamli Devi was sitting beside her stove. The coal fire had not yet fully caught; she kept fanning it, narrowing her eyes against the smoke. After the night's rain, the bricks of the veranda looked washed clean, though mud had gathered again in the corners.

Jaynarayan pulled a low stool in front of her stall and sat down. Madhavi sat beside him. Vinay stood some distance away, speaking to someone.

Kamli Devi asked, "Tea?"

"Two," Jaynarayan said. "One the way you always make it for me. The other the way you used to make it for Vasudha."

Kamli's hand paused for a moment. "Where will she drink it now?"

"To understand a habit."

Without asking another question, she put two glasses on to boil. Into one went a little more milk and one spoonful of sugar. Into the other, less milk, ginger, no sugar. She poured them separately.

"This was Vasudha Didi's," she said, indicating the unsweetened glass. "For years. At first she would say she had given up sugar; later she'd say, 'Kamli, your tea

tastes better without sugar.' I thought she was only trying to please me."

A faint smile touched Madhavi's face. Vasudha could have said exactly such a thing.

Jaynarayan asked, "Did you make tea for Vasudha last night?"

Kamli shook her head. "I stay only until half past eight. Yesterday, seeing the rain, I packed up at eight fifteen. Vasudha Didi came a little after seven in the evening. I gave her one glass then—without sugar. Who gave her tea later, I don't know."

"Dulari?"

"She came after nine at night. My stall was already closed."

"Who else knew Vasudha's tea habit?"

Kamli laughed. "Anyone who had tea with her twice in the courthouse knew. If sugar went into her glass, she'd send it back. Not angrily—she'd say, 'That one is yours. Make another for me.'"

Jaynarayan lifted his glass but did not drink. "Some habits are so small that everyone knows them, yet the person who constructs a crime scene often forgets precisely such small things."

Madhavi asked, "So the sugar found in one cup proves there was a second person?"

“No. Vasudha may have made tea for someone. Someone may have left their cup behind. An old cup may have already been in the room. Or the scene may have been arranged. One grain of sugar does not arrest a criminal.”

Kamli looked at both of them. “I’ve remembered something.”

Jaynarayan set his glass down.

“The evening before last, a man had tea with Vasudha Didi. I don’t know him. Clean clothes, shiny shoes. He asked for two spoons of sugar. Vasudha Didi laughed and said, ‘Will that much sweetness make your tongue tell the truth?’ He did not laugh.”

“Age?”

“Around forty. Perhaps younger. A large umbrella. His car was on the road.”

“Would you recognise his face if you saw him again?”

Kamli narrowed her eyes. “Perhaps. But show me photographs. Don’t tell me the names. Once the mind hears a name, it starts making a face.”

Jaynarayan looked pleased. “You are taking my work away from me.”

“Selling tea beside you people, I’ve learned a little,” Kamli said with a smile.

Vinay had come over by then. He noted that a formal photographic identification should be conducted later.

Jaynarayan said, “Not today. Do not fence memory in. Different time, several photographs of men of similar build.”

The courthouse opened. Clerks, lawyers, litigants, copyists, peons began flowing in their own directions. One question occupied Jaynarayan: who knew Vasudha's daily routine? If the person who staged the scene knew it, why make these mistakes? Or had the mistakes been left deliberately?

Their first stop was Vasudha's small working table, where she met people on court days. With police permission the desk was being cleared. Devkinandan, a copyist, said, “Vasudha ji used to fold the left corner of her papers. So often I'd straighten it, and she'd fold it again.”

“Why?” Madhavi asked.

“She used to say: if there is a question on a page, fold its ear. A folded left corner meant ‘look again’. A folded right corner meant someone's signature was still needed. I've just remembered that.”

Madhavi started. “The right corner had a meaning too?”

Devkinandan nodded. “Yes. But she used it less often. Mostly the left.”

Jaynarayan immediately asked for the scene photographs. The upper-right corner of the unfinished sheet lying in front of Vasudha had been folded. There was no signature line on the page, only an unfinished sentence.

“Perhaps it had become mixed with another paper that did require a signature,” Vinay said.

“Perhaps,” Jaynarayan replied. “For now note only this: a folded right corner may mean ‘signature pending’. The question is: whose signature was pending on that unfinished page?”

Madhavi enlarged the image. The handwriting looked like Vasudha's, but the last line stopped halfway through: “Without the seventh sign...” Then blank.

“This is Didi's hand,” Madhavi said, “but the letters are slightly stretched, as though she wrote in haste.”

Jaynarayan asked, “When Vasudha wrote, did she hold the paper down with her left hand?”

“Yes. And the pen in her right.”

“Then to fold the right corner she would have had to stop writing and change the position of her hands. Even that tiny act takes time.”

Vinay smiled. “You are counting seconds inside a habit?”

“A staged crime scene is often broken not by minutes, but by half a second of habit.”

By noon they had been reconstructing Vasudha's ordinary routes. Before leaving home she sent a brief message to her mother; on Monday and Wednesday nights she went to the night school; on Tuesdays and Thursdays she met people from Seven Hamlets; Friday was for old records; on court days she drank Kamli's tea; she chewed betel nut after daytime meals, but never after dinner. Each small habit survived in the memory of a different person.

Rahmat Kaka arrived too. He was past seventy, wore thick spectacles, and his fingers had grown hard from tying binding thread around old files.

“Did Vasudha beti chew a lot of betel nut?” Jaynarayan asked.

Rahmat laughed. “During the day. Not at night. Stomach trouble. Once, at eight in the evening, I offered her the box and she said, ‘Kaka, if you give me this at night, will you look after my stomach in the morning?’ From that day on, I never offered it at night.”

“Was the box always on the right?”

Rahmat thought. “Her hand was right-handed, so probably. But Vasudha beti carried her bag on the left shoulder. When she was seated, the box stayed on the

right side of the desk. When she got up, it went into the bag.”

Madhavi said, “At the scene the box was on the floor to the left.”

Vinay looked at her—this was not necessarily something to disclose to everyone yet. But Rahmat Kaka was an old courthouse man, and details of the case had already spread through half the town.

Rahmat narrowed his eyes. “On the left? One corner of that box is broken. Vasudha beti used to say, ‘Keep it on the right, otherwise the lid opens.’”

Jaynarayan's gaze sharpened. “Are you certain?”

“It broke in front of me. Two months ago it fell on the floor. I told her to throw it away and get a new one. She said, ‘Rahmat Kaka, if we throw things away when they break, what are we to do with human beings?’”

Madhavi's throat tightened. Vasudha would say sentences like that and then laugh.

Jaynarayan said quietly, “The lid of the box was open at the scene.”

Vinay immediately opened the evidence photograph. The lid was indeed half open. Two pieces of betel nut lay outside.

“If it was kept on the left, it could open,” Rahmat said. “But she herself would not have placed it that way.”

“It may have fallen from someone's hand?” Vinay asked.

“Could have.”

“During a struggle?”

“Could have.”

Jaynarayan stopped them again. “Do not turn every ‘could have’ into a story. Three habits are gathering together—sugar, betel nut at night, and the folded corner. Yet each could have been reversed for a different reason. What I want to know is whether Vasudha broke her own habits that night, or whether another hand arranged the things around her.”

After noon, the laboratory sent a more detailed report. There were no clear fingerprints on the sugared cup; it looked as though it had been wiped. On the unsweetened cup was a partial impression of Vasudha's thumb. Neither cup had lipstick on the rim. The cup containing sugar held more milk residue at the bottom.

Madhavi said, “Kamli Devi said the man from the evening before last took two spoons of sugar.”

Vinay nodded. “But that cup from the other evening is not the cup from the night of the incident. Only the habit matches.”

“We need a face identification,” Jaynarayan said.

At that moment Abhiram appeared descending the courthouse steps. His eyes looked as though he had been awake all night; he held three folders. “I found half of the 1978 repair file. Also an inspection note from 1954. It mentions the old duct—‘proposal to seal the ventilation passage’. But there is no proof that the proposal was completed.”

Jaynarayan did not simply take the file; in the presence of the police he had it entered on the list. “1934?”

“There's a separate index. Some pages were never digitised. The originals are in the record store. This evening Madhavi and I can sort them together, if she's willing.”

Madhavi looked at him. “Since when did you start needing to ask me?”

Abhiram was slightly taken aback. “Yesterday you said machines should not make every decision themselves. So I'm asking for human consent.”

Jaynarayan laughed. “Sutra's first reform has borne fruit.”

Madhavi smiled despite herself.

Before evening a small experiment was conducted. With police permission they brought five old papers from Vasudha's home, five from the office, and a high-resolution image of the unfinished page from the scene.

Without telling Madhavi and Devkinandan which was which, the papers were shown in mixed order. Both correctly identified, in most cases, Vasudha's left-corner and right-corner folds. The page from the scene had the right corner folded.

“Right corner means a signature was pending,” Devkinandan said again.

“There is no place for a signature on this page,” Vinay said.

“Then perhaps the next page?”

The order of the papers recovered from the scene was checked again. The page with the number immediately following the unfinished sheet was missing. It was not in the cupboard either.

A shiver went through Madhavi. “Didi folded the right corner because someone's signature was needed on the next page?”

Jaynarayan replied, “Possible. Or someone who knew Vasudha's system folded the page to communicate something. Or it is coincidence. All three paths remain open.”

Vinay asked, “Where do we look for the missing page?”

“First identify which document this sheet belongs to. Handwriting, paper, watermark, page number. Madhavi, did Vasudha ever use the phrase ‘seventh sign’ before?”

“No. But in the Seven Hamlets case she may have spoken of ‘seven pieces of evidence’—I’m not sure.”

Abhiram intervened. “Sutra can search document images for the same phrase.”

Jaynarayan looked at him. “Run it. This time the machine has the right job: find one phrase among a thousand pages. But don’t interpret its meaning yet.”

Satisfaction appeared on Abhiram’s face. “That’s exactly what it was built for.”

“And within that boundary, extremely useful.”

As the first darkness of evening began to fall, Madhavi made a request. “Let’s go to the night school. More people there will know Didi’s daily habits.”

The night school ran in one room of an old panchayat building half a mile from the courthouse. There were reed mats for sitting, vowels and consonants and numerals painted on the wall, and a small blackboard hanging in one corner. Vasudha came here two nights a week. Dulari studied here too.

There was no class that day, but on hearing the news five or six students had come on their own. One was seventeen, another forty. An elderly woman who had

learned to write her name began to cry when she saw Madhavi. “She used to tell me, ‘Don’t use a thumbprint—write your name.’ Who will tell me that now?”

Jaynarayan asked each of them separately the same question: “What did Vasudha Didi always do before class ended?”

The answers differed in wording, but the meaning was nearly the same: first she assigned the next day’s work; then she glanced through everyone’s notebook; she drank water from her blue cup; placed the betel-nut box in her bag; and finally told Dulari or whichever young student remained not to walk home alone in the dark.

“Did she chew betel nut?” Jaynarayan asked again.

A middle-aged woman laughed. “I saw her chew it until eight. Not after nine. She used to say her stomach rebelled at night.”

The same ache passed through Madhavi again. How precious the most ordinary sentences of a person become after death.

A young man said, “Didi taught us the paper-folding marks too. Left corner—read again. Right corner—ask someone or get a signature. We used to joke and call them the paper’s ears.”

“How many people knew this?” Vinay asked.

“Everyone in the class.”

Jaynarayan looked at Madhavi. So the habit was not a secret code. Anyone staging the scene would not have found it difficult to learn. The fact did not make the habit unimportant, but it changed its meaning.

On the wall of the room was a line in Vasudha's handwriting: “First learn to read your own name; then learn to read the name on the paper.” Madhavi remembered seeing the same thought in Phulo Sadai's house. Perhaps Dulari had turned that sentence into a path for her life. Where she was now, no one knew.

As they came out, Jaynarayan said, “A habit is personal, but once people watch it often enough, it becomes social knowledge. Half a dozen people here know all three of these things. So we can no longer say, ‘Only the family knew.’”

Vinay changed his note. “Instead of shrinking, the circle of possible suspects has grown.”

“An investigation's job is not to shrink the circle too quickly,” Jaynarayan replied. “Lock the wrong person inside and the real one will walk comfortably outside.”

The sun was setting behind the clouds. The courthouse veranda was beginning to empty. Kamli Devi was putting out her stove. Jaynarayan went back to her stall and remembered the unsweetened tea she had made in the morning for Vasudha.

“Kamli,” he asked, “if Vasudha was having tea with someone who took sugar, would she put the sugar into their cup herself?”

Kamli laughed. “No. She'd say, ‘Stir your own poison.’ Then she'd push the sugar tin toward them.”

“Meaning Vasudha's fingerprints need not have been on the sugared cup.”

“No.”

Jaynarayan nodded. Another possibility had shifted. Investigation works like that: what seems sharp a moment ago changes edge when a new habit is learned.

Before leaving for home, Vinay showed them the scene photographs once more. There were two circular cup marks on the table. A white cup had been found near the floor; the blue-rimmed cup had been recovered from the rear drain. One ring was smaller, the other larger. Both cups were private courthouse cups.

Madhavi said suddenly, “Didi recognised her blue cup. How did it get as far as the drain?”

Everyone fell silent.

The recovery list was checked again: a white porcelain cup from the scene; a blue-rimmed cup from the rear drain.

“What kind of cup did she use for Kamli's tea at seven yesterday evening?” Jaynarayan asked.

Madhavi tried to remember. “Kamli's glass tumbler. Later Didi drank water from her own blue cup. It was on the desk.”

“Not in the room now. In the drain,” Vinay said quietly.

“Then someone removed the cup,” Abhiram said.

“Or Vasudha herself carried it outside,” Jaynarayan corrected him. “A recovered object is not an accusation either. But find out how the cup travelled from the room to the drain.”

A strange unease rose in Madhavi. When people tell a story of murder, they look for knives, poison, threats. Here the mystery seemed to have contracted into tea, betel nut, folded paper, and a blue cup found in a drain. Perhaps that was why it felt even more frightening: death had happened among the ordinary objects of life.

As they walked, Jaynarayan said, “A person builds a home out of everyday habits. Someone who kills them can kill the body; but if they want to imitate the life around that body, they must know the habits too. And in imitation, one small mistake...”

“Like a stitch sewn the wrong way?” Madhavi asked, remembering her mother's work.

“Exactly. From a distance the cloth looks whole. Up close the stitch tells you what kind of hand moved.”

Abhiram tucked the folders under his arm. “Then tonight we’ll examine the stitches in Vasudha’s old records.”

Madhavi looked at him. “We?”

“Yes. Without you I won’t be able to read half the Maithili marginal notes. Without me and the index, you’ll be turning a thousand pages until dawn.”

“You mean a temporary alliance between human being and machine?”

“No,” Abhiram said with a smile, “between Madhavi and Abhiram. Sutra will serve in the middle.”

Madhavi turned her face away, but the smile did not disappear.

Jaynarayan watched them from behind. “An alliance lasts longer when it isn’t written down,” he murmured to himself.

And the old courthouse clock struck five. According to its everyday habit—one, two, three, four, five. This time each sound seemed as though time itself were counting out testimony.

Chapter 9 — Madhavi and Abhiram

By seven in the evening, the new courthouse building was almost empty. Only three lights were burning in the digitisation room—one on the ceiling, two on computer screens. Outside, the rain had thickened again; drops slid down the glass as though some unfinished line of writing were falling downward.

Madhavi sat on one side of the table with a heap of old files before her. Abhiram sat on the other. Between them glowed the screen of Sutra, its search window open with the words: “seventh sign”, “seven pieces of evidence”, “Seven Hamlets”, “constellation”, “1934”, “air passage”.

“If you feed it so many words at once, even the machine will panic,” Madhavi said.

Abhiram did not look up. “Machines do not panic.”

“Do you?”

“Me? No.”

“Then why did you open the same file four times in three minutes?”

Abhiram stopped. He had indeed reopened the folder titled “Building Repairs 1954–78”. Madhavi laughed.

“All right,” he admitted. “I’m tired.”

“Not nervous?”

“A tired person's fingers repeat mistakes.”

“And a nervous person's?”

“Theirs do too.”

“Then what's the difference?”

“A tired person admits it.”

“And a nervous one?”

This time Abhiram looked at her. “Often makes jokes.”

Madhavi's laughter stopped for a beat, then deepened.
“Then you are nervous.”

“I said no such thing.”

“Enter it into Sutra—human inference.”

For the first time since Vasudha's death, laughter sounded so natural in the room. Both of them fell silent almost immediately, as though they had simultaneously remembered the guilt of laughing. Madhavi lowered her eyes. “If Didi were here, she'd say death does not mean every laugh must be locked away.”

Abhiram said softly, “She once told me, ‘A person who can laugh in the midst of great sorrow does not make the sorrow smaller; they help the body survive it.’”

Madhavi looked at him. “When did she tell you that?”

“Last year. When my father died.”

“You never told me.”

“How many people was I supposed to tell?”

Madhavi did not answer. For the first time she clearly saw that Abhiram's life had many rooms she had never entered because she had never asked. She had assumed everything about him was open like a computer screen—lines, tables, dates. But there is no search window for the data inside a human being.

She began turning the pages of the file. The 1954 inspection note mentioned damp in the courthouse building, cracks in the roof, and ventilation ducts. In 1962: “north-side ventilation openings partly sealed.” In 1978: “records room modernisation”—but the original plan was missing.

“Look at this,” Madhavi said, sliding a page toward him. “It says ‘old passage left as existing’. Which passage?”

Abhiram enlarged the image. “A handwritten note. Probably the engineer's. Half of it was cut off in the scan.”

“The original page?”

“In the old store. Can't request it now. Let me check the index location.”

Sutra tried to isolate the faint handwriting along the margin. Three possible readings appeared on the screen: “old passage”, “old margin”, “old section”.

Madhavi said immediately, “The first. It says ‘passage’.”

Abhiram asked, “How certain?”

“Eighty percent.”

“Human confidence?”

“No. Eyes.”

“Eyes make mistakes too.”

“You've started again.”

“I'm only—”

“Your machine read ‘margin’. Does a margin walk through a building?”

Abhiram laughed. “All right. ‘Passage’ is probable. But we'll check the original.”

Madhavi pushed her chair back with an air of victory. “Write it down—human one, machine zero.”

“You didn't break the machine's assumption in yesterday's latch experiment. Jaynarayan Kaka did.”

“I'm on the human team.”

“Can teams be changed?”

“Why?”

“Nothing.”

The nothing was so flat that Madhavi felt her ears grow warm. She bent over the page at once. Lightning flashed outside; for a moment their two reflections appeared together in the glass—Madhavi leaning forward, Abhiram looking at her. The lightning passed; so did the reflections.

A little later the door opened. A young advocate, Shashank Jha, came in carrying a file. Madhavi knew him; he had attended several meetings with Vasudha in connection with the Seven Hamlets case.

“You're here?” Shashank said, looking at Madhavi. “Haven't gone home?”

“Sorting records.”

“Alone?”

Madhavi looked toward Abhiram. “No. He's here.”

Even if Shashank had seen Abhiram before, he seemed to notice him properly for the first time now. “Oh, the one who works on the computer—Abhiram?”

Abhiram did not rise from his chair. “Just Abhiram.”

Shashank laughed. “All right. Madhavi, we'll write something for Vasudha Didi's memorial meeting

tomorrow. If you have a photograph of her, send it to me.”

“I’ll see.”

“And if it gets late, I’ll drop you home. I have a car.”

“No need.”

“It’s raining.”

“I also have an umbrella.”

Shashank looked slightly disappointed, though his smile remained courteous. He deposited the file and left.

When the door closed, Abhiram said, still looking at the screen, “He has a car.”

Madhavi raised an eyebrow. “What?”

“Nothing. Merely repeating a fact.”

“Enter it into Sutra: has a car.”

“It is also raining.”

“And there is also an umbrella.”

For a moment they looked straight at one another, then Madhavi laughed. “Were you jealous?”

“Me?” Abhiram’s ears actually turned red. “Of whom?”

“The car.”

“There's nothing wrong with my motorcycle.”

“Then the advocate?”

“Am I supposed to work, or answer these useless questions?”

Madhavi said nothing more. Her mind had become irrationally light. Abhiram had not answered the question she asked; yet many answers arrive without words.

At that moment Madhavi's phone rang. Her mother.

“Where are you?”

“At the courthouse.”

“Still?”

“There's work. I'll be a little late.”

On the other end came the churr-churr of the sewing machine. Madhavi's mother was still stitching at night. Household expenses, Madhavi's education, medicines—all came out of the turning of that machine. Vasudha often said, “Your mother threads time itself through a needle.”

Her mother asked, “Have you eaten?”

“Not yet.”

“Is your work to find the truth, or to lose your own body?”

Madhavi smiled. "I'll eat."

"Don't return alone."

"Abhiram is here."

There was a moment's silence at the other end. Then her mother said, "Then all right. But don't come flying through the rain on his motorcycle."

Madhavi's cheeks grew hot. "Ma!"

After the call ended, Abhiram pretended to keep staring at the screen, but his smile would not hide.

"What?" Madhavi tried to sound stern.

"Nothing. I merely heard 'don't come flying on the motorcycle'."

"Were you supposed to listen?"

"The room is small."

"Your ears are large."

"New fact."

Madhavi made as if to throw a page at him, then laughed instead.

After a while she asked, "Who's at your home?"

Abhiram's fingers stopped over the keyboard. "My mother. My younger sister studies in Bengaluru. Father is gone. My uncles are in the village."

“Your mother alone?”

“Yes. Though she refuses the word ‘alone’. She says: there are trees, neighbour women, two goats, and a radio—so how am I alone?”

“Does she call when you're late at night?”

“No. She sends a message: ‘Alive?’ I write, ‘Yes.’ That's all.”

“So short?”

“In my house, sentences of love are short.”

Madhavi fell silent at that line. In her home love arrived as instructions—eat, don't be late, keep your medicine with you. In Abhiram's home it came as one word: alive? Perhaps the language of love changes from house to house, not its meaning.

“Did you change a lot after your father died?” she asked softly.

“How much?”

“You used to laugh more.”

Keeping his eyes on the screen, Abhiram said, “When someone goes, we lose one version of ourselves along with them. With Father I was a son. After he died I suddenly became the grown-up in the house. I didn't like becoming grown-up that way.”

Vasudha rose in Madhavi's mind—beside Didi she had been student, friend, sometimes younger sister. Now Vasudha was gone; Madhavi too would have to carry certain versions of herself alone.

She said, “I always thought you managed everything through logic.”

“Logic doesn't manage it. It only keeps the names of things correct. It calls grief grief, searches for causes. But the empty chair you see at night has no equation.”

For the first time Madhavi saw him not merely as Abhiram immersed in data, but as a young man who had endured grief. Instead of saying anything, she divided the heap of papers into two equal parts. “This part is yours. This is mine.”

Abhiram smiled faintly. “Taking turns?”

“No. Equal.”

After eight at night, Sutra produced its first substantial search result. “Seven Hamlets” appeared forty-seven times; “seven pieces of evidence” nine times; the exact phrase “seventh sign” not once. But “seventh” and “sign” occurred within five pages of one another in three old records.

One was a 1935 relief dispute list, one a 1941 land-boundary record, and one an undated handwritten index sheet.

“Open the undated page,” Madhavi said.

The image was poor. The paper was yellow, its edges eaten away. The title was incomplete. In the middle were seven numbered entries—1 to 7. Words appeared beside the first six; beside the seventh was a stain. Below was writing in a mixture of Mithilakshar and Devanagari.

Abhiram enlarged it. “Can you read this?”

Madhavi brought her face closer. “Not completely. Something like the word ‘witness’... or perhaps ‘sakhi’.”

“Sakhi?”

“In older writing it could also carry the sense of testimony or proof. I’m not certain.”

“Date?”

“None.”

“The index says: ‘private donation, 1989; original estimated 1930–40.’ Donor’s name illegible.”

Vasudha’s unfinished line flashed through Madhavi’s mind—“Without the seventh sign...”

“Did Didi see this?”

Abhiram opened the access log for the record. “The digital image was opened four times in the last three months. Twice from the office’s general account, once from Vasudha’s authorised account... and once...”

He stopped.

“What?”

“A guest account. No name recorded, because the old system stored only the machine number.”

“When?”

“Two days after Vasudha opened it.”

Madhavi's body tensed. “Which machine?”

“A public terminal in the courthouse library.”

“Camera?”

“Probably at the entrance. I don't know whether footage from three months ago has been retained.”

Abhiram immediately messaged Vinay. He did not call Jaynarayan; it was already growing late. But five minutes later Jaynarayan called them himself.

“You've found something?”

Abhiram was startled. “How did you know?”

“At 8:20 tonight I saw your message to Vinay Babu: ‘Call immediately.’ Vinay is with me.”

Abhiram explained briefly.

Jaynarayan was silent for a few moments at the other end. “Three things. One: a guest account does not mean a criminal. Two: the old image may be connected with

Vasudha's search, but we do not yet know why. Three: do not decide the reading without the original page. Tomorrow: library entry records, repair register of the public terminal, and the original file.”

“All right.”

“And a fourth thing.”

“What?”

“Don't work too late. Tired eyes turn ‘witness’ into ‘sakhi’, and ‘sakhi’ into ‘witness’.”

Madhavi laughed. “Kaka, Abhiram says machines don't get tired.”

Jaynarayan's smile could be heard through the phone. “The machine doesn't. But the person operating it grows tired from love, jealousy, hunger, sleep—all of them.”

Abhiram said at once, “I'm hungry. Everything else is inference.”

“Good. Eat first.” The call ended.

Madhavi stared at him. “Why did Kaka say ‘love’?”

“He teases everyone.”

“Everyone?”

“Probably.”

“And jealousy?”

“Hunger is certain.”

Laughing, Madhavi stood. “Come on. Let’s get something downstairs.”

Almost all the shops outside the courthouse were closed. One cart still sold hot muri, gram, onions, and green chillies. The two of them sat on the veranda steps eating from paper packets while the rain slanted before them.

Abhiram said, “Do you like Shashank?”

Madhavi stopped a chickpea halfway to her mouth and looked at him. “Is this question necessary for the research?”

“No.”

“Then why do you need the answer?”

“I don’t.”

“You asked.”

“Mistake.”

“Correction in Sutra?”

“Yes.”

Madhavi wanted to tease him a little longer, but suddenly remembered Vasudha. She had once said, “Don’t keep merely testing the person who looks at you.

Sometimes you have to let yourself be seen too.” Madhavi had laughed it away then.

She said quietly, “Shashank may be a good person. But I feel nothing like that for him.”

Abhiram looked down at the chickpeas in his packet as though counting them. “I didn't ask anything.”

“Now that's a lie.”

He smiled. “All right.”

“And you?”

“Me what?”

“Anyone...?”

Abhiram looked directly into her eyes. Suddenly the sound of the rain seemed louder. “Madhavi, should I give a data-based answer or intuition?”

There was a joke in the question, but behind the joke was something that silenced them both. Madhavi's fingers twisted the edge of the paper packet.

Just then Vinay called. The moment broke.

“Abhiram, the detailed inventory of the bag from the scene has just been completed. One object inside had initially been taken for an ordinary religious volume and sealed separately. It is wrapped in cloth. Vasudha's family says it is not hers. Tomorrow morning we'll open

it in front of witnesses. Call Madhavi too—her help may be needed to identify the writing.”

“What kind of book?”

“The cover isn't visible. On top there seems to be a circular diagram of stars or constellations.”

Abhiram ended the call and looked at Madhavi.

Ambika Kaki's face flashed through Madhavi's mind—birth hour, constellations, old ledgers, stories of household after household.

“It was in Didi's bag yesterday,” she whispered. “I saw the cloth, but I never opened it.”

“Then tomorrow...”

“Yes.”

The rain grew heavier. They went back up to the digitisation room, but only to gather their work. On the screen the undated page was still open—seven numbered entries, a stain beside the seventh.

As Abhiram shut down the system, he said, “Today: human one, machine one.”

Madhavi asked, “Where did the machine get its point?”

“It found the three old pages.”

“And the human?”

“You read ‘passage’.”

“Equal?”

“For now.”

Closing the door, Madhavi said, “Listen, I’m not competing with you.”

“Neither am I.”

“Then why keep score?”

Abhiram paused. “Because losing to you does not feel very bad.”

Madhavi did not answer. As she went down the stairs her steps felt light, although inside her mind Vasudha, Dulari, the seventh sign, and the constellation-book all revolved together.

Outside, it was night. In the rain the city lights looked like blurred stars. Madhavi opened her umbrella. Abhiram began to open his own, but the wind flipped one of its ribs inside out.

Madhavi laughed. “Data-based umbrella?”

“Old model.”

“Come here.”

They walked beneath one umbrella, trying at first to maintain an awkward distance. Again and again the

wind tilted the umbrella to one side, and the distance diminished by itself. Neither said anything.

Madhavi understood that even in the midst of mystery, life goes on making its own small, secret beginnings.

Chapter 10 — The Constellation Ledger

By ten in the morning, a small sitting had been arranged beside the evidence room at the rear of the police building. An iron cupboard, a sealed bag, a ledger on the table, and a glass window on which drops from the night's rain still clung. Vinay Thakur first displayed the seal, read out its number, and had the names of everyone present entered. Jaynarayan sat silently at one side of the table. Madhavi's eyes never left the bag. Abhiram had opened his equipment, but before anything else Jaynarayan warned him, "Do not tell the machine a story before you have seen the paper. First listen to what the paper itself says."

Abhiram smiled. "A machine does not listen to stories."

"It looks where the human question directs it. A question can also make a story."

Vinay cut the sealing cord. Vasudha's brown bag was taken out. Its contents were placed on the table one by one: a pen, a small bunch of keys, a half-eaten packet of fennel seeds, two receipts, a spectacle case, a blue file, and finally a thick volume wrapped in an old turmeric-coloured cloth. The cloth had not been knotted tightly, only wound around twice. When it was opened, the smell of old paper rose from it, and Madhavi

remembered one of Vasudha's sayings: "Anything kept buried long enough eventually gives off its own smell."

The cover of the volume was not leather but thick handmade paper. The corners were eaten away; the binding thread hung loose at the centre. On the front, in soot-dark ink, someone had drawn a circle with twelve small compartments around it and constellation marks inside. There was no title. At the top of the first page was written: "Birth Constellations and Household Ledger." Beneath that were entries in different hands, from different years—some in red ink, some black, some blue.

Madhavi said softly, "It looks like an astrology book."

Jaynarayan replied, "Looks like. Keep the words 'looks like' safe for now."

Madhavi had suggested Ambika Kaki's name. Before two hours had passed, she arrived, leaning on her old bamboo umbrella. Her white hair was tied back, thick-lensed spectacles covered her eyes, and she carried a small cloth bag in one hand. Seeing all the police formalities as she entered, she laughed. "Will I have to sign as though I were a criminal?"

Vinay smiled too. "You are examining evidence, Kaki. The rule is the same for everyone."

"Good. A rule is a good rule when it is the same for everyone."

She washed her hands, dried them with a cloth, and only then sat beside the volume. After looking at the first two pages, the smile faded from her face. "This is not an ordinary horoscope book."

Madhavi asked at once, "Then what is it?"

Ambika Kaki moved not a finger over the page, only the shadow of her nail. "Look. There is the time of birth, there is the constellation, there are planetary calculations. But alongside them someone has written: 'the pond dried this year', 'five maunds of paddy borrowed from the moneylender in Phagun', 'younger son went to Calcutta', 'daughter-in-law did not return from her mother's home', 'dispute over the boundary'. Whoever wrote this cared more for preserving the life of the household than for predicting the future."

She turned a page. "This book binds up more of the past than the future."

For a moment the room fell silent at that sentence. Abhiram looked toward his equipment. On the screen Sutra's preliminary classification was running: "astrological table", "genealogical information", "chronology", "uncertain handwriting".

Ambika looked at the screen. "What does this say?"

"It separates types of paper, words, dates, names," Abhiram said. "Wherever it can read them."

"And where it cannot?"

“It says uncertain.”

“That is good. Human beings are often uncertain and yet become certain anyway.”

Jaynarayan laughed softly. “Kaki, are you taking my work from me today?”

“You read human faces. I’ll read the old age of paper.”

They began examining the pages in order. Some sections were astonishingly ordinary—who was born, who married, which year brought flood, which year brought disease. Between them were tiny sentences capable of opening an entire household history: “eldest daughter-in-law’s jewellery pawned”, “second son’s name removed from the partition”, “southern field boundary shifted in the night”. Madhavi was beginning to understand why Ambika Kaki called it a ledger of memory.

Ambika Kaki stopped at one page. Beneath a planetary table was the entry: “Daughter of Jamuna the washerwoman; birth unknown; third day of the great Sawan flood.” The next line: “Boatman Ramcharit’s house destroyed; five persons went to North Hamlet.” Kaki said, “Look. Even the one whose birth hour was never written in a pandit’s house has not been thrown out of this ledger. If no date was available, time was tied to an event—the third day of the flood, the morning of such-and-such a wedding, two nights before such-and-such a death. Poor people’s lives appear less often in

government papers, but in ledgers like this the dust from their feet remains.”

Madhavi looked at that page for a long time. Dulari's face came to mind. In Sutra's data, her shared phone, cash wages, and life without formal receipts so often became empty spaces. Yet in this old ledger, even without a recorded birth time, someone's existence had not been erased.

Abhiram understood it too. “If Sutra reads a ledger like this, event-based time will need to be handled as a separate type.”

Jaynarayan said, “First understand that data is not merely numbers. The manner in which a life is written down is also data. If a society does not even write someone's name properly, and a machine later identifies that person incorrectly, the fault is not the machine's alone.”

Abhiram fell silent. On the screen he looked at the entry for “Jamuna the washerwoman's daughter”. Text recognition was reading “Jamuna” as “Yamuna” and “dhobin” as “dhobi”. He corrected both by hand, then entered the correction source as: “human reading; with original image.”

“Now is it right?” he asked Ambika Kaki.

Kaki said, “The letters are right. The story is still incomplete. But saying ‘incomplete’ is also honesty.”

Abhiram continued taking high-resolution images of each page. Sutra matched names and connected dates. For the first half hour, nothing appeared that linked directly to Vasudha's death. But when they reached the pages around 1934, the body of the volume changed. Two pages had swollen from water, one was half brown, and after it an entire page had been torn out from the root. The torn edge was not new; the fibres had aged yellow.

“There was a page here,” Madhavi said.

“Yes,” Ambika Kaki said. “Removed long ago. Not yesterday.”

Vinay recorded: page missing from the 1934 section.

The page before the missing one bore the date: “Magh, Samvat...” Beside it, in English numerals: 1934. Underneath, in a trembling hand: “the earth split, houses fell, people camped by the pond.” One line was drowned in a stain. Beneath it, clearly: “the youth recording names at the relief camp—Ras...” The remaining ink had rubbed away.

Holding her breath, Madhavi tried to read it. “Ras...?”

Ambika Kaki removed her spectacles and wiped them. “Could be Rasbihari. Could be Rasmohan. Do not turn an inference into a name.”

The next line read: “Kusuma, daughter-in-law, red...” Then a stain on the paper.

A slight shiver went through Madhavi. Red. The dupatta from her dream flashed in her mind. She said nothing.

Abhiram enlarged the image on the screen. “After ‘red’, does that look like ‘odh...’?”

“It could,” Madhavi whispered.

Jaynarayan stopped them immediately. “Write what is visible. What you think it means, write separately. Mix the two and the paper will start speaking what is already in our minds.”

Sutra's text-recognition score on that line was only eighteen percent. Abhiram read the number aloud. Ambika Kaki said, “If a human being were only eighteen percent certain, would he stay silent?”

“Probably not,” Jaynarayan replied.

After the torn page came a strange table. On the left were seven small circles. Inside the first six were different marks—dots, lines, triangles, a nail-like mark. The seventh circle was not blank; the ink there had been rubbed away. Under the circles was written: “seven proofs...” The remaining words were eaten away.

Abhiram immediately opened the undated digital page from the previous night. It too contained seven numbered entries. “Look. The structure matches.”

Vinay had the two images placed side by side. There was similarity, but not identity. In the ledger there were circles; on the digital page, numbers. Jaynarayan said, “A connection is possible. It is not proof.”

Ambika Kaki leaned close beneath the seventh circle. “Something like ‘sakhi’ is written here.”

Madhavi started. “I thought I saw the same word on the digital page yesterday.”

“Sakhi, sakshi, sakh—in old writing their bodies can lie very close together. The sentence must tell us the meaning.”

“The sentence is incomplete,” Abhiram said.

“Then let the meaning remain incomplete too.” Ambika Kaki's answer was simple.

Caught in the stitching between those same pages was a fine blue thread. The rest of the ledger had been bound with dull white cotton. The blue thread appeared only between two pages, like a knot. Vinay was about to lift it with tweezers, but Ambika stopped him. “Photograph first.”

Abhiram took the image. When the thread was removed, they saw that it was not part of the book's binding but had probably been used to tie some small object separately; on one end clung a grain of old wax.

“And what does it mean now?” Vinay asked.

“Thread,” Jaynarayan said. “Meaning later.”

For no rational reason, the red dupatta and the blue thread drew together in Madhavi's mind. She looked at her palm—the white dust was gone now, but its memory remained.

The later section of the ledger was comparatively recent. Some pages were forty or fifty years old; the final four or five had probably been written within the last twenty years. At the corner of one page Ambika Kaki suddenly laughed. “I know this hand.”

Everyone looked at her.

“Not mine. My maternal uncle-in-law, Nakshatranand Jha. He used to travel from village to village recording times of birth, but he also wrote down what happened in people's households. This ledger must once have passed through his hands.”

Vinay's question sharpened. “Then have you seen this ledger before?”

Ambika Kaki shook her head. “Not this ledger. The handwriting. Nakshatranand had many such books. People asked him for birth dates, and alongside them he would write—whose field had been mortgaged, whose son had run away, which house had undergone partition. He used to say, ‘Constellations and human beings do not move alone. If you do not write the

condition of the household, the condition at birth remains incomplete.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Where are his ledgers?”

“Some are with me. Some were lost in floods. Some were taken away by people and never returned. I’ll look through the old chest at home.”

Madhavi spoke immediately. “Kaki, did Vasudha Didi ever bring this ledger to you?”

Ambika thought for a while. “Not the ledger. Two weeks ago she showed me an image—something like these seven circles. She asked, ‘What does the seventh sign mean?’ I told her I would say nothing without seeing the whole page. Then she asked: why do old houses call a room ‘the bride’s room’? I laughed and told her that in many houses the room where a new bride’s trunk, bedding, jewellery, and things from her mother’s home are kept comes to be known by that name.”

“Whose house was she talking about?” Jaynarayan asked.

“She didn’t say.”

Madhavi’s mind flew like an arrow toward Vasudha’s house. The previous day, behind the study, she had seen a closed door with an old brass lock. She had paid it no attention then.

From between the pages of the ledger, a small slip of paper also emerged. The paper was new. Madhavi recognised Vasudha's handwriting at once. Only three lines:

“Find photograph—relief camp.

Bride's room?

Ventilator—the same construction?”

Abhiram's eyes lit up. “Ventilator.”

Jaynarayan did not touch the slip. “What Vasudha was searching for before she died was not merely a copy of a land record. She was looking for old photographs.”

Vinay said, “To search the locked room in the house we need the family's consent or a lawful order. First, the simple route.”

Madhavi kept looking at the slip. “Did Didi reach that room or not?”

“That question is still open,” Jaynarayan said. “And it is too early to dress an open question in the clothes of an answer.”

Abhiram began adding the ledger images to Sutra and building a relationship map. Lines appeared across the screen—1934, relief, seven proofs, Kusuma?, Ras...?, ventilator, Seven Hamlets. In the middle Sutra displayed a red warning: “name identification low confidence; historical text incomplete.”

Madhavi read it and smiled. “Today the machine has said something good—incomplete.”

Abhiram leaned slightly toward her. “I told you yesterday, didn't I? A machine can say uncertain.”

“And a human?”

“A human makes the story first and then goes looking for proof. Kaka says so.”

Jaynarayan heard from a distance. “I did not say the machine was innocent. Whoever lies outside the world shown to the machine remains invisible to it.”

Closing the ledger, Ambika Kaki said, “A constellation too is visible only through as much sky as is open. If there are clouds, the stars do not die; they are merely hidden from the eye.”

Vinay had the ledger sealed again. The blue thread went into a separate evidence packet. Vasudha's slip was sealed separately. Everyone signed.

When they stepped outside, sunlight had broken through the clouds for the first time and fallen across the wet courthouse yard. Small puddles held fragments of sky. Madhavi descended the steps beside Ambika Kaki.

Without looking at her, Kaki asked, “Did you dream again last night?”

Madhavi stopped. “How did you—”

“Your eyes say you haven't slept enough.”

Madhavi breathed in relief. “No. But the red dupatta... I read the word ‘red’ in the ledger.”

Ambika Kaki looked at her now. “Do not make a dream into evidence. But do not throw it away either. What the mind cannot understand during the day, it gives a form at night. The form may contain truth; it may contain fear.”

“You read destiny, and yet you doubt so much?”

Kaki laughed. “One who does not doubt is not reading destiny; he is selling it in the marketplace.”

Madhavi laughed too, but inside her the three lines on the slip kept turning: relief camp. Bride's room. Ventilator.

And there, inside the police building, Sutra was linking the ledger pages and producing a new connection: in the old property records of Vasudha's family there was an expenditure receipt from a 1934 relief camp. The name was illegible, but the place was the very locality where the old courthouse stood today.

Chapter 11 — A Lie in the House

After noon, Abhiram ran Sutra's travel-related cross-checks. The written timeline Vasudha's family had given the police was being tested separately against road cameras, fuel payments, mobile-phone signals, and vehicle-entry records. Jaynarayan approved of Sutra for this kind of work: where a human being, reading a thousand lines, might miss one point in time, the machine could show the knot. But he repeated one warning: "Seeing a knot and untying it are two different tasks."

At 3:32 in the afternoon Abhiram called Vinay. "Arun Karn's car was not at home that night."

Vinay came from the police station to the courthouse. Jaynarayan was already there. Madhavi was comparing Vasudha's slip with images from the constellation ledger. Abhiram turned the screen toward them.

Arun's written statement said that after eight in the evening he had remained at home, gone to sleep at about half past ten, and woken at dawn when the police called. But an automatic number-plate camera on the western outskirts of town showed his car leaving at 10:47 p.m. A second camera recorded the same vehicle entering the town from the opposite direction at 12:31 a.m. Between those two times was an electronic receipt from a fuel station—11:20 p.m.

“The mobile?” Vinay asked.

“Arun's main phone remained on the home tower,” Abhiram said. “Meaning: the car was outside; the phone was at home.”

Vinay's face tightened. “He deliberately left the phone behind?”

On Sutra's screen appeared the line: “Person-location cannot be inferred. Available evidence establishes vehicle location only.”

Jaynarayan read it. “Remember that answer. The car was outside. We have not yet proved Arun was in it.”

Abhiram opened another page—Sutra's “inconsistency list”. Against Arun's statement it showed three flags: “location conflict”, “phone stationary / vehicle moving”, and “undeclared night journey”. Beneath them, the investigation-priority measure had risen.

Jaynarayan frowned. “What is this ‘risk’?”

“Investigation priority,” Abhiram said. “Not a declaration that he is guilty. A statement that clashes more strongly with outside data gets checked first.”

“Fine. But why is it red?”

“To draw attention.”

“The human mind reads red as danger. If this screen is ever shown in court, the meaning of the words must be explained before the colour is seen. Otherwise the number will remain neutral while the colour delivers the verdict.”

Abhiram switched off the colour layer. “That should be tested.”

Madhavi did not laugh. She understood that Jaynarayan's objection was not hostility to machines; it was hostility to illusions that work against human judgment. People often take what appears clear for what is true; the sheen of a machine can magnify that weakness.

“But the written statement is a lie,” Vinay said.

“Yes. It is a lie. Whether the reason for the lie is murder is another question.”

Madhavi said nothing. The face of Arun at home appeared before her eyes—tired, guarded, hiding something even after his wife was gone. Her mind wanted at once to build a story. She stopped herself. In two days with Jaynarayan, she had encountered the same lesson repeatedly: the first story is often the easiest; truth often is not.

Vinay decided not to summon Arun publicly to the station, but to question him again at home. “It would not

be proper to take him away in public while the family is in mourning. But we need an answer.”

Jaynarayan said, “Check the car first. Mud inside, seats, receipts—whatever is there. And preserve the original camera-time records. Sutra's screen will not stand up in court and testify by itself.”

Abhiram nodded. He immediately began securing the raw data. Madhavi watched him. Here the machine's usefulness was not magic but patience—preserve each line of each source so that, if someone later asked, the answer would not merely be ‘Sutra said so’, but ‘this camera, this receipt, this time’.

When they reached Vasudha's house, Arun was sitting alone on a chair in the veranda. The number of mourners had thinned, but the silence had grown denser. Prakhar was somewhere outside. The mother-in-law was inside. Vasudha's mother was sorting her daughter's clothes—folding each sari, opening it again, folding it once more.

Vinay showed Arun his written statement. “You said you did not leave the house after eight that night.”

“Yes.”

“Your car went out on the western road at 10:47.”

At first Arun's face seemed not to understand. Then his right hand gripped the arm of the chair. “The car?”

“Your car. The number is clear. It returned at 12:31.”

“Can you see who was driving?”

Vinay caught the question. “Then you accept that the car went out?”

Arun stood. “I—”

He left the sentence unfinished. Vasudha's mother came out from inside. “What happened?”

Arun said at once, “Nothing, Maiji. Routine police questions.”

Jaynarayan noticed the word routine. Arun's eyes kept moving toward the inside of the house, particularly toward his mother's room. Fear of someone hiding a murder? Or something else?

Vinay said, “We would like to speak separately.”

Arun led them into the study and half-closed the door. Madhavi wanted to remain outside, but Arun himself said, “Let Madhavi stay. Vasudha considered her one of her own.”

For several moments Arun stood beside the window. Then he said quietly, “I drove the car myself.”

Vinay's voice remained level. “Where?”

“On the Madhupur road there is a women's health centre called Sahajini. About twenty-five kilometres from town.”

“For whom?”

Arun fell silent. The answer seemed difficult for him. Jaynarayan said, “If the matter is unrelated to the death, its privacy can be protected. But if you conceal a period of time, the investigation will be forced to treat it as potentially related to the death.”

Arun closed his eyes. “My younger sister Rupa was admitted there.”

“Why?” Vinay asked.

“I have not taken her permission to tell anyone in this house.”

“Was her life in danger?”

“No. But it concerns her marriage. For three months she has been living apart from her husband. Everyone at home believes she is at her in-laws' house. The night before last she miscarried. She called me. I left my main phone at home and drove there.”

Madhavi lowered her eyes. Inside one lie of the household lay another woman's sorrow—a sorrow over which a family might draw the curtain of prestige.

Vinay asked, “Did Vasudha know?”

“Yes.” Arun's voice broke. “She was the one who told me to go. Rupa was alone. I had returned home after eight. Vasudha was at the courthouse. At 9:45 Rupa's

attendant called. Ma was still awake, so I left my main phone at home. I took a smaller second phone.”

“The number?”

Arun gave it. Vinay wrote it down.

“Why did you lie in the written statement?”

Arun laughed, but the laughter was bitter. “At dawn my wife was dead. The house was full of people. The police were asking questions. If I said I had spent half the night at a women's health centre, by the next day the whole town would have made a story out of it. Rupa's marriage has already broken. Her body too would become marketplace gossip. I thought that night had nothing to do with Vasudha's death, so why speak of it?”

Jaynarayan said softly, “In an investigation, no one can know beforehand when something you believe ‘unrelated’ may become connected. But I understand the reason.”

“Do you believe me?” Arun asked him directly.

“Belief is not a substitute for checking. The centre's records, cameras, the attendant, the car—we will match everything. If they match, the meaning of this lie changes. If they do not, we ask again.”

Arun lowered his head. “All right.”

Vinay asked, “What time did you return home?”

Vasudha's mother had reached the doorway and heard the end of the conversation. She looked at Arun as if grief had acquired another wound. "Why didn't you tell me?"

Arun said softly, "Rupa didn't want me to."

"I am not Rupa's mother, but I am an elder in this house. I could have heard her sorrow without turning it into a market."

Arun's eyes remained lowered. "Maiji, not everyone in a family thinks as you do."

Vasudha's mother was silent for a few moments. Then she said, "It is right to choose who is worthy of hearing the truth. But if a person goes on speaking lies, sooner or later even he no longer knows whom he is protecting from what."

Jaynarayan looked at her. The old woman's sentence was more exact than any rule in a training manual.

"Around twelve forty-five," Arun said.

"Did you speak to Vasudha?"

"At 11:05 p.m., from the smaller phone. Only two minutes. She asked whether Rupa was stable. I said yes. She said, 'When you return, don't tell Ma anything. Let Rupa say it herself when she wants to.'"

"Vasudha's voice?"

Arun's face changed suddenly. "Tired. But... she said to someone behind her, 'Sit down, let me finish reading this page.' I asked who was there. She said, 'Dulari has come.'"

Madhavi's heart struck hard. Dulari was with Vasudha at 11:05 p.m.? Then Dulari had come after nine and remained for quite some time.

"Anything else?" Vinay asked.

"Before the call ended, something metallic clinked. Vasudha said, 'This lock is going to jam again.' That's all."

Jaynarayan asked immediately, "Which lock?"

"I didn't ask."

In Madhavi's mind rose the slip from the constellation ledger: "Bride's room?"

Vinay asked for the smaller phone for examination. Arun took it from the cupboard and handed it over. The call record initially supported his account: Rupa's number, Vasudha's number. The times matched.

Jaynarayan stepped out through the study door. His gaze went to the closed door at the back, the one Madhavi had noticed on the previous visit: brass padlock, old vermilion marks on the wood, dust above it.

"That room?" he asked casually.

Arun's face tightened again. "Old things. Grandmother used to call it 'the bride's room'. No one uses it now."

Madhavi and Jaynarayan looked at each other at the same moment.

"Did Vasudha go inside?" Jaynarayan asked.

"Two weeks ago she asked for the key. Ma did not want to give it—old trunks, jewellery, papers, termites. Later I gave her the key. She stayed inside about an hour."

"What did she take out?"

"I didn't see. She said she was looking for old photographs."

Vinay said at once, "We will open it again today."

The moment this reached the household, Arun's mother—Vasudha's mother-in-law—came out angrily. "Now all that remains is to dig through the ancestors' room? The daughter of this house is dead, the house is in mourning, and the police will count the trunks?"

In a calm voice Vinay showed her Vasudha's slip without handing it over. "Vasudha ji herself wrote 'bride's room'. Old photographs may be connected with the inquiry. We will examine it in your presence, make an inventory, and remove nothing without a record."

The mother-in-law read the slip from a distance. Alongside the anger, a faint shadow of fear crossed her face. "That old madness again..."

Jaynarayan caught the words. "What madness?"

She fell silent.

Arun said, "Ma, there is no use hiding it now."

"What do you know?"

"As much as Vasudha told me. The old story of the family's land."

The mother-in-law tightened the prayer beads in her hand. "Old houses contain old stories. Not every story is meant for a courtroom."

Madhavi said quietly, "Perhaps Didi was not searching for the courtroom. Perhaps she was searching for the truth."

The mother-in-law gave her a long look. "Vasudha was very fond of you. Have you inherited her stubbornness too?"

Madhavi did not answer. In a house of grief, there was no question of winning.

The lock was not opened that day. Vinay decided to obtain proper written permission so that no later challenge could be raised over the evidence. The mother-in-law finally agreed to give written consent, on one

small condition: one member of the family would remain present.

As they came out, a message arrived from Abhiram: “Sahajini centre entry log: Arun 11:03 p.m.; exit 12:02. Vehicle-camera times match. No medical details requested without Rupa's consent. Travel account preliminarily corroborated.”

Vinay showed the message to Jaynarayan.

Jaynarayan said, “See? There was a lie, but it did not become murder.”

Madhavi asked, “So suspicion of Arun decreases?”

“The reason for one lie has been explained. His entire life has not been certified innocent. Investigation proceeds like this—one door closes, another opens.”

Arun stood on the veranda. Inside the house, his mother was again moving the prayer beads. From Vasudha's mother's room came the rustle of clothes being folded. Everyone in this house was trying to protect something—someone's reputation, a sister's private sorrow, an ancestral story, a dead woman's name.

Madhavi suddenly understood: truth hides not only from criminals, but also from those who love. Often people lie not because they wish to harm anyone, but because they fear that the light of truth will strip

someone bare. Yet when light is stopped, the shadow grows larger.

As he descended the steps, Jaynarayan said, "Tomorrow, the bride's room. Tonight, nobody is to build a story in their head about what is inside."

Abhiram, who had arrived by then, walked beside Madhavi and whispered, "You've already built one, haven't you?"

Madhavi looked at him. "Ten."

"Sutra will generate five possibilities."

"The human wins."

"More possibilities do not mean victory."

"Do you believe that in love too?"

Abhiram looked at her for a moment, then straight ahead. "Open the room tomorrow. No philosophy now."

Madhavi laughed. But beneath the laughter was unease. Two weeks earlier Vasudha had spent an hour alone in that locked room. What had she seen? What had she taken? And if she had found the photograph, why had she later written herself a note to look for it again?

The bride's room remained locked through the night. But now the lock guarded not merely the old things of a household; it had become the investigation's next question.

Chapter 12 — The Bride's Room

The next morning the rain had stopped. The sky was not entirely clear, but there was enough light for drops of water to glitter on the leaves of the mango tree behind Vasudha's house. Vinay arrived with written consent, two witnesses, and an inventory sheet. Arun would remain present for the family; his mother did not wish to come herself, but the bunch of keys came from her hand. Madhavi, Jaynarayan, and Abhiram were also there. Abhiram's role was limited to making images and digital copies of any papers they found; Sutra would remain outside for now. The room would be seen first by human eyes.

The locked door stood apart from the main part of the house, in a narrow rear veranda. The wood had darkened with age; green rust spread over the lock. Above it was an old red smear of vermilion under a layer of dust. Arun tried a key. The first would not turn. The second turned halfway and jammed. With the third, the lock grated from within and opened.

Jaynarayan looked at Arun. "Vasudha may have meant this lock when she said, 'It will jam again.'"

Arun's face grew sad. "Yes. That day too she spent half an hour turning the key."

When the door opened, a smell came out—dust, dried neem leaves, old cloth shut away too long, and

something like the very old memory of camphor. The window inside was small, half-covered with a wooden shutter. Light fell upon the floor in one thin strip. Abhiram switched on his torch, but Jaynarayan said, "Photograph it first exactly as it is."

The photographs were taken. Only then did they enter slowly.

The reason the room was called the bride's room became clear the moment one stepped inside. Along one wall stood three wooden trunks, one painted long ago with faded leaves and flowers. On the wall hung an old mirror whose glass had blackened over half its surface. There was a fan woven from bamboo fibre, a small brass hand-chest, a rotting red-bordered chunari, bundles of cloth, a broken vermilion box, and an old silver bangle for a child. This was not the room of one woman. It held the half-light and half-darkness of things left behind by generations of daughters-in-law.

Madhavi said quietly, "A house preserves so many things belonging to women, but not their names."

Arun heard her and remained silent. After a while he said, "Grandmother used to say that whatever a new bride brought would, once it became old, slowly be moved into this room—trunks, bedding, letters, signs of her mother's home. Then another bride would come."

"People too?" Madhavi asked without intending to.

Arun looked at her. “In some houses, perhaps.”

Vinay began the inventory. “We will look only at things related to Vasudha's search. Before any trunk is opened: photograph, number, entry.”

The first trunk held clothes and old bedding. The second held metal utensils, wedding saris, and an empty box that had once held a broken necklace. The third trunk was heavy. None of the keys on the bunch fitted it. Its lock was very old, but the lower edge of one panel stood slightly open. Jaynarayan crouched to examine the floor. The dust was not even—there was a thin clean line in front of the trunk, as though it had been dragged a few weeks earlier.

“Did Vasudha move this?” Vinay asked Arun.

“I did not see her do it.”

Madhavi's eyes went to a corner. On the floor lay an old splinter from a broom, and behind it a tiny scrap of paper. Vinay lifted it with tweezers. In blue ink, only the word fragment “...camp” could be read.

Abhiram became alert. “Relief camp?”

Jaynarayan said at once, “The scrap says ‘camp’. We are adding ‘relief’.”

“Right.” Abhiram smiled. “Kaka, I'm learning.”

Vinay hesitated over whether it was proper to break the lock on the trunk. The family's written consent

allowed necessary old containers to be opened. Arun said, “Open it. Ma will blame me later, but if this is what Vasudha was searching for, open it.”

They did not cut the lock. A local locksmith was called. While they waited, Madhavi examined a wall cupboard. Its panel had swollen inward and termites had eaten one side. Across the dust at the top were what looked like two old finger-lines. She showed Vinay. When the cupboard was opened, it contained wedding photographs, invitation cards, yellowed letters, and a large bundle of pictures wrapped in cloth.

Madhavi's breathing quickened. “Her note said, ‘Find photograph.’”

The bundle was placed on a low stool that had been cleaned like a table. The photographs were separated one by one. Most were family pictures—old people seated on a veranda, weddings, sacred-thread ceremonies, pond steps, field boundaries. Some had dates; some had names. One photograph was stuck between two sheets of paper, as though someone had hidden it deliberately.

Wearing gloves, Abhiram separated the papers. “This is extremely fragile.”

When the photograph came free, Madhavi's fingers went cold.

It showed an open ground. Behind it stood a partly collapsed brick building; in front were temporary bamboo-and-thatch shelters. Cooking vessels lay on the ground, there were medicine boxes, and a crowd of people. In the centre stood two women—one elderly, the other very young. Over the young woman's head and shoulders was a red dupatta. But the photograph was black and white, so how was it red? Someone had coloured the image later; a faded ochre-red still clung to the dupatta.

Madhavi sat down.

“What happened?” Abhiram looked at her.

Before answering, she pointed toward the building in the background. High on the wall was a small rectangular ventilator—four slanting iron blades with a tiny circle in the middle. Exactly the same design as the one in the old courthouse records room.

Abhiram brought the photograph closer. “This... looks the same.”

Jaynarayan was looking not at the photograph but at Madhavi's face. “You're seeing something else too.”

Madhavi's mouth had gone dry. “In my dream...”

Arun, Vinay, Abhiram—all turned toward her.

“The steps of a pond. A red dupatta. A wall. I had never seen this photograph before.”

Abhiram began to speak, then stopped. Perhaps he remembered the promise from the previous day—not to build a story at once. He asked only, “Did Vasudha Didi ever show you a photograph like this, or tell you a story about 1934?”

“She mentioned a land dispute from the earthquake period. Not the red dupatta. Not this picture.”

“Have you seen a picture like this in anyone's house?”

“No.”

Jaynarayan said, “Keep the dream in a separate packet for now—the mind's packet. Keep the photograph in another—the evidence packet. Make them one, and you damage both.”

Madhavi nodded, but the shiver inside her did not leave.

On the back of the photograph, in blue ink, was written: “Relief camp, Magh 1990 Sal / January 1934.” Beneath it were two names. The first was clear: “Kusuma.” The second had rubbed away, but “Rasbi...” remained visible. The final line read: “copying names.”

Abhiram read slowly, “Kusuma... Rasbi... copying names.”

Jaynarayan said, “Not ‘Rasbihari’ yet. The next letters have not survived.”

The lines from Ambika Kaki's ledger joined themselves in Madhavi's mind: "the youth recording names at the relief camp—Ras..." "Kusuma, daughter-in-law, red..."

There was a hole in one corner of the photograph, and in it remained a minute fibre of blue thread. Abhiram photographed it. Vinay had it separated with tweezers. Remembering the thread from the constellation ledger, Jaynarayan said, "The colour looks similar, but a visual match is not proof. Fibre comparison separately."

Arun stared at the photograph in silence. "Who is this Kusuma?"

At that moment Vasudha's mother-in-law appeared in the doorway. No one had called her. Perhaps she had been unable to stay away from the sounds of the room being opened. The instant she saw the photograph, her face changed.

"Where did you find that?"

Arun said, "In the cupboard."

She did not enter the room. She remained on the threshold. "Leave that photograph."

Vinay said calmly, "A copy will be made for the investigation. The original will be preserved and recorded."

“This is an old matter of the house.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Do you recognise the name Kusuma?”

She tried to move the prayer beads, but one bead kept catching in the same place. “I heard the name as a child. Someone among the ancestors.”

“Whose?”

“Not exactly. The grandmothers told stories. One young woman did not obey the household. In the year of the earthquake... later her name was not liked in the house.”

Madhavi asked softly, “Red dupatta?”

The mother-in-law's eyes snapped toward her. “Who told you?”

The air in the room thickened.

Madhavi told the truth. “It was written incompletely in the ledger.” She did not mention the dream. Not yet.

The mother-in-law looked at the photograph for several moments. “I was a child. What I heard was only half. Kusuma may not have been a bride of this house; perhaps she was a daughter. Some said sister. The old people themselves changed the story. They said that after the earthquake she disgraced the family's name at the relief camp—gave testimony on papers belonging to low-caste people. Then...”

“Then?” Jaynarayan asked.

“Then there was a quarrel in the house. That's all.”

“And after that, Kusuma?”

“I don't know.”

Jaynarayan kept reading her face. This “I don't know” was not sharp like Arun's earlier lie. Here memory, fear, and learned silence were mixed together. Some family stories are reduced by half in each generation, like old cloth trimmed at the edges again and again until the original shape becomes difficult to recognise.

The locksmith arrived. The third trunk was opened. It contained fewer papers than women's belongings—an unfinished piece of embroidery, a dried perfume bottle, a comb, two bundles of letters, and a small tin box. The letters were very old and fragile. Vinay said immediately, “Do not open anything before it is entered in the inventory.”

Inside the tin box were photographic negatives, old tickets, and a dried flower mounted on a strip of glass. At the bottom lay a folded sheet. The top carried writing in Mithilakshar; beneath it, in a later hand, were several words in Devanagari. It would be difficult to read without Rahmat Kaka or another specialist.

Abhiram said excitedly, “If we scan it and run pattern
—”

Jaynarayan laughed. “Rahmat Kaka first. The machine may offer a second opinion.”

Madhavi looked at the bundle of letters. The tying thread was dull-coloured, not blue. They did not open it; it was packaged separately for conservation.

Behind the cupboard lay an old picture frame turned face down. Its glass was broken. There was no photograph inside, only a piece of backing board. When the board was removed, pencil writing appeared on the back: “Kusuma—relief camp, 1934. Rasbihari writing names.” This time the full name was clear.

Everyone fell silent.

Abhiram looked at Jaynarayan as though asking: can we say it now?

Jaynarayan said quietly, “Now: Rasbihari.”

Something opened inside Madhavi. The incomplete name from the constellation ledger was complete, yet the mystery did not shrink. Instead, the name became a person standing before them. Kusuma. Rasbihari. 1934. Relief camp.

Beneath the writing on the frame-board was another line, the ink extremely faint: “Seven Hamlets names entered. Seventh...” The final part had been erased by moisture beneath the broken glass.

Vinay said, "The connection between this photograph and the land case may be direct."

"May be," Jaynarayan said. "For now we have only found words."

Arun held his head and sat down on the low stool. "Vasudha was searching through all this and told me nothing fully."

Madhavi looked at him. "Perhaps she wanted evidence before speaking."

There was hurt in Arun's voice. "Was I her husband or a court?"

Jaynarayan did not answer directly. "When a house and a lawsuit stand upon the same land, it becomes difficult to decide what to tell whom."

The mother-in-law slowly sat down on the threshold. For the first time, her hardness loosened. "I did not want to give Vasudha the key. I was afraid the old matter would bring quarrels back into the house. She said, 'Ma, hiding a thing does not change what happened.' I told her, 'The past does not survive; the house survives.' She laughed: 'What if the house survives on a lie?'"

Her eyes filled. "That day I said something very harsh to her."

Madhavi went closer but did not touch her. There are moments in grief when even touch should be given only

after asking. The mother-in-law herself reached out and caught Madhavi's wrist. "Did she tell you anything?"

"Not everything."

"I thought she was fighting against the family. Perhaps she was doing it for someone else..."

The sentence broke.

By the time the search of the room was finished, it was afternoon. The inventory included the photograph, the frame, the bundles of letters, the Mithilakshar sheet, the blue-thread fragment, and several old records. All originals went into the required legal custody; the family was given receipts.

Outside in the veranda, Abhiram examined the photograph at high resolution and compared it with the image of the present courthouse ventilator. Shape, slanting blades, central circle—the match was extremely close. Sutra showed a high structural similarity, but also displayed a warning: similar designs may have been common in old buildings.

"Is it the same courthouse?" Madhavi asked.

"Possible," Abhiram said. "Not certain. We need the construction records."

Jaynarayan looked satisfied. "Your language is improving."

Abhiram laughed. "Mine, or Sutra's?"

“Both.”

Madhavi kept looking at the red colouring laid over the young woman's dupatta in the photograph. The pond from her dream was not in the image. There was no anklet. But there was the red dupatta, and the grille in the wall. Coincidence? Some old story heard by day, coloured by the mind at night? Had she perhaps once passed this photograph on Vasudha's table without consciously noticing it? Possible. Human beings do not remember everything their eyes have seen, but the eyes preserve things all the same. That answer seemed rational to her. Even so, the shiver in her body did not entirely fade.

Abhiram understood her silence. “Afraid?”

“A little.”

“Of the photograph?”

“Less of the photograph. More of thinking that Didi saw all this before we did, and understood that something very old was alive in today's case.”

“Old papers are not alive.”

Madhavi looked at him.

Abhiram immediately added, “All right. Kaka will say habits remain alive. Papers produce consequences.”

“And memory?”

“Memory...” He paused. “Memory is not data, but it affects data.”

“That is as incomplete as your answer about love.”

Abhiram smiled. “You are developing a habit of bringing every subject back to love.”

“Habits are evidence, aren't they?”

“Ask Kaka.”

Jaynarayan, standing some distance away, had heard them and was laughing.

By evening, the first confirmation arrived from the building records. One wing of the present old courthouse had served as a district-office storehouse in the 1920s; after the 1934 earthquake it was used for several months as a relief-account office and temporary camp office. The original iron grille of the ventilator had never been replaced; repairs had altered only the outer frame.

Madhavi looked at the photograph again. The building in the background was no longer merely “similar”. It was becoming almost certainly the very place where Vasudha had been found dead.

Jaynarayan placed a finger on the table and made a timeline. “1934—earthquake. Relief camp. Kusuma. Rasbihari. A suggestion that Seven Hamlets names were entered. 2026—Vasudha, the same land dispute, searching old copies in the same old building. Ninety

years between them. I do not want a story yet. I want records.”

Vinay said, “Can Rahmat Kaka read the old letters?”

Madhavi replied, “Binding papers all these years, he recognises half the town's handwriting.”

“Call him tomorrow.”

Madhavi's gaze remained fixed on the name “Kusuma” on the back of the photograph. For no clear reason, merely reading the name made the young woman's face in the picture seem a little more distinct. Illusion or attention—it was difficult to say.

Before leaving for home, the mother-in-law called Madhavi aside. She held a small cloth packet. “This was in a corner of the cupboard. See whether it went into the police inventory or not.”

Madhavi did not open the packet. She handed it to Vinay. Inside was an old key and an extremely small strip of paper. On the strip were only two words: “the belly of the wall.”

Every face changed.

Jaynarayan examined the paper from a distance. “Handwriting?”

Holding her breath, Madhavi said, “Not Didi's.”

“Old?”

“Looks old.”

Abhiram enlarged the image. The ink was faded; the paper fibrous. Sutra could say nothing immediately.

Jaynarayan did not smile. He said only, “For now, leave those two words exactly where they are. There are many walls. Whose belly, later.”

Madhavi stepped outside. Clouds were gathering again in the evening sky. Kusuma in her red dupatta, Rasbihari writing names, the old courthouse ventilator, Seven Hamlets, the blue thread, and “the belly of the wall” all crowded together in her mind.

And that night, for the first time in several days, she had no dream. But when she woke at dawn, the first name in her mind was not Vasudha. It was Kusuma.

Chapter 13 — The Year of the Earthquake

Magh, 1990 Sal. The earth had shuddered and fallen still, but the trembling inside people's bodies did not stop for many days. Village after village lay reduced to heaps of earth, thatch, and brick. Pond water had climbed beyond its banks, well water had turned muddy, and roads that only yesterday could carry bullock carts were split by wide cracks or sunken into the ground. People feared the breaking inside themselves more than the broken walls of their homes.

The old storehouse behind the district courthouse was opened for relief accounts and as a temporary camp office. Wooden cupboards were dragged outside, sacks spread on the floor, bamboo screens hung up, and two tables placed on the veranda for recording names. High on the building was a small rectangular ventilator—four slanting iron blades with a circular joint in the middle. There had been no rain, yet the interior smelled of damp. Hairline cracks spread across several parts of the walls like threads left by snakes.

Kusuma came there with her mother on the first day. As she was leaving home, her grandmother had said, "If the work is to distribute relief, then help. But there is no need to get into papers about people's names and identities." Kusuma had not answered. The elders of the house believed that an educated daughter helping in

charity increased the family's honour; but the moment educated eyes began asking questions, suspicion fell upon that very education.

Kusuma was twenty. Her handwriting was good, her arithmetic quick, and she spoke with such restraint that people before her often could not tell whether she agreed or was merely preserving a question for later. Her family belonged to an old branch of a zamindari house. Not enough land remained to match the ancestral stories, but the family name still carried weight in people's speech.

Her first task at the relief camp was to record the names of families receiving grain, their village, hamlet, and number of persons. The young man preparing the lists sat on the other side of the table. Thin, dark-complexioned, hair neatly set, a permanent ink stain on the middle finger of his right hand. His name was Rasbihari. He was learning copying work at the courthouse; after the earthquake, when extra hands were needed, he had been assigned to the relief records.

At their first meeting, neither even heard the other's name properly. The veranda was full of voices—a child crying, someone arguing over the measure of grain, someone repeating the name of a village again and again. An elderly woman came forward. She was asked, “Hamlet?”

She said, “West of Barki Musahari, beneath the pipal tree.”

One of the clerks writing the entries snapped irritably, "How are we supposed to write that? Tell us the mauza."

The old woman fell silent. She did not know the name of the mauza. She knew the way to her house by the pipal tree, the pond, the monastery, a mound of earth, and other people's houses; the mauza of official paper existed nowhere in her life.

Rasbihari raised his head. "Which pond is near your hamlet?"

"Saraunja."

"West of Saraunja?"

"Yes."

Kusuma looked at a name already entered in the list. "Would that fall under 'Haripur North'?"

Rasbihari looked at her. "Yes. But these people do not call their hamlet Haripur."

"Then write both."

Rasbihari's pen stopped for a moment. "There isn't much space on the paper."

Kusuma smiled for the first time. "Has the space on paper become greater than people's homes?"

Rasbihari laughed too. "Ask the people who designed the form. I only have to fit people into the space I've been given."

From that day onward, two names began to be written in the lists—the official mauza and the hamlet name people actually used. It was a small change, but Kusuma noticed how many elderly people, seeing their own hamlet on paper, asked for it to be read aloud again. As if the act of writing the name made a ruined house stand again for a moment.

After noon, a boy carrying flattened rice for his mother tripped. The bamboo measure overturned. Kusuma rose and began gathering the grain. The maid who had come with her from home whispered urgently, "Why are you touching it? I am here."

Kusuma looked at her. "The grain has fallen in the mud, not the family name."

Rasbihari heard her but said nothing. In the evening, while gathering the lists, he asked only, "Will you come here every day?"

"Until the people at home stop me."

"Why would they stop you?"

"The elders at home are very good at finding reasons."

Rasbihari suppressed a laugh. "Then do as much work as possible before they find one."

Kusuma turned to look at him. His tone was light, but there was more understanding than amusement in his eyes. That evening, on the way home, she remembered for the first time the ink stain on the finger of the young man who copied names.

Over the next several days, the relief camp became a temporary world for people. Someone found a missing family member after three days; someone else fell silent while giving the name of a person who would never answer again. As Kusuma filled list after list, she understood that disaster did not give everyone the same colour of suffering. When a masonry house collapsed, the wealthy too lost a roof; but land, cash, kinship, and support elsewhere gave them a different strength with which to rise again. When the hut of a landless family fell, the evidence that they had ever occupied that place could be swept away with it.

In one corner of the camp sat Bhola the potter with his two children. The wheel at his home was buried under rubble. Turning a brass bowl received in relief between his hands, he said, "This bowl is good for eating, but what will my hands do without the wheel?" Kusuma did not understand at first. Later Rasbihari said, "People need more than grain. They need the tools of their work. To say the stomach is saved, therefore life is saved, is an incomplete account."

The next day Kusuma had an old round wooden board brought from home and iron fittings from a

blacksmith. It did not become a complete potter's wheel, but Bhola was so pleased that he kept running his palm around the edge of the board. "It will work," he said. "First I'll make small lamps. People's houses are broken, but evening will still come, and when it does they will need lamps."

Rasbihari watched from a distance. "You have opened a new department in the relief camp—the Department for Saving the Heart."

Kusuma said, "Why do you give everything a name?"

"Nothing survives in a courthouse without a name."

Then what is the name of love? The question reached Kusuma's lips, but she swallowed it. For now, the question itself was still nameless within her.

A woman from another family, Janakbatti, had lost her husband in the earthquake. When his name was about to be struck from the relief list, she began to tremble. "Do not cut out his name," she said. "He was the head of the house." The clerk grew irritated. "The dead are recorded separately." Janakbatti did not cry; she merely seized the page. Kusuma understood that crossing a name out of an official line could sometimes feel like removing someone from life a second time. Rasbihari did not tear up the page. In a new note he wrote: "Deceased; former head of household," and entered Janakbatti's name on the next line.

“Why wasn’t the woman’s name there from the beginning?” Kusuma asked.

Rinsing his pen, Rasbihari said, “Because the people who make the papers identify a household by a man’s name.”

“And the person who keeps the household running?”

“Paper seldom asks that question.”

That day Kusuma wrote in her own notes: “The questions paper does not ask also remain in history.” Later, the sentence would seem to her like a form of her own courage.

One day people arrived from seven different hamlets. Their accounts were much the same: after the earthquake the old settlements were no longer fit to live in, so they had erected temporary shelters on slightly higher ground away from the river. But two landed families claimed that ground. The moment relief bamboo was raised, objections began.

“We were told this land belongs to an owner,” said one boatman.

Another elderly man said, “My grandfather used to say that during heavy rain and floods, all the hamlets tethered their cattle there. It was common high ground.”

Kusuma heard the names—Domahi, Navatoli, Kamar Patti, Musahari, Dhobiyahi, Kahartoli, and Chhota Mallah Tola. Seven names.

Rasbihari asked for a copy of an old map. The lines on the paper were faint. One boundary marker—“old pipal”—had been half uprooted by the earthquake. Another—“unlined pond”—had filled with earth and changed its shape.

“Whose land is it?” Kusuma asked.

Rasbihari looked around before answering. “The paper says one thing; use says another. And the old copy is incomplete.”

“Where is the complete copy?”

“In an old bundle inside the courthouse. A cupboard fell in the earthquake. Some papers got wet. They’re still searching.”

“Can I see it?”

Rasbihari looked at her as though he had certainly heard the question, but answering it might be dangerous. “You are a relief volunteer. The records room is not a place for volunteers.”

“And the question of land—is that part of relief, or not?”

He remained silent. Then he said softly, “Why do you ask every question so directly?”

“People give crooked answers to crooked questions.”

“And they answer direct questions by becoming silent.”

For a moment they looked into each other’s eyes. A child laughed on the veranda. Dust rose outside. In a way she did not yet recognise, Kusuma felt that this conversation had moved a little beyond the work of making lists.

That evening Rasbihari showed her an old copy—not outside, but at the last table on the veranda, in full view of everyone. The edges of the paper were water-damaged and some letters had vanished. No old phrase resembling “community grazing use” was clearly legible, but the words “for public use” could be read, along with the older names of three of the seven settlements.

Kusuma asked, “Is that enough for them to remain there?”

“No.”

“Then what?”

“Testimony. Old land-revenue receipts. Boundary evidence. Witnesses to long use. And the copy that is missing. Paper alone does not give people a home. Paper needs people beside it.”

“And people without paper?”

Rasbihari did not fold the document; he placed it straight between two sheets. "People live for generations without paper. But when someone decides to remove them, the first thing demanded is paper."

The sentence remained inside Kusuma.

That night at dinner, her father asked about the relief camp. Kusuma wanted to tell them about the Seven Hamlets, but stopped when she saw the face of her uncle sitting near the doorway. Her uncle was looking after the family's claim to part of that same high ground.

"Write names at the camp, distribute medicine," her uncle said. "Surveying and measuring land is government work. If poor people put up shelters somewhere during a disaster, the land does not become theirs."

Kusuma quietly mixed the rice on her plate. Her father noticed her silence. "What are you thinking?"

"Nothing."

Her grandmother called from a distance, "When this girl says 'nothing', that is when the most is going on inside her."

Everyone laughed. Kusuma did too. But when she went to her room that night, she wrote the names of the Seven Hamlets again on a sheet of paper. Beside each one, she remembered the face of a person she had met at the relief camp.

Then, at the very bottom, she wrote one more name—
Rasbihari.

The moment she wrote it, she felt shy. She folded the paper and brought it near the flame of the lamp, but did not burn it. She placed it inside her trunk, behind a ledger.

The earthquake had split the walls of houses; inside Kusuma, a hairline crack had already opened whose sound, for now, only she herself could hear.

Chapter 14 — Forbidden Love

Even a month after the earthquake, the earth would from time to time tremble faintly. Sometimes it truly moved; sometimes people's bodies began trembling first, and only afterward did they realise the ground was still. The crowds at the relief camp had thinned, but the lists of names kept growing. Roofs rose where houses had collapsed, the fear of disease receded, and people began remembering their old quarrels. Disaster does not erase every division; often it merely covers them with dust for a few days.

At Kusuma's house, questions about her going to the camp had now increased. Her uncle said plainly, "It is not proper to sit at the courthouse day after day. The first emergency of the relief work has passed. The propriety expected of daughters and daughters-in-law of a household is different."

Kusuma said, "I am not a daughter-in-law. I am a daughter."

"A daughter will become a daughter-in-law tomorrow."

"Then why should tomorrow's propriety begin today?"

Her uncle flared. Her father intervened. "Enough argument. You may go two days a week."

Kusuma lowered her head. Two days were permitted; that also left her time to think of what to do with the other five.

In the old book room of the house lay her grandmother's constellation ledger. Her grandmother recorded dates of birth, marriages, journeys, illnesses, and important household events alongside the names of constellations. Since childhood Kusuma had opened the ledger and gazed at its letters as though they were pictures. Her grandmother made no boast of foretelling the future; she would say, "The names in the sky are knots for memory. Events are made by human beings."

One evening her grandmother caught Kusuma searching through the ledger. "What are you looking for?"

"When is Rohini?"

Her grandmother looked over the rims of her spectacles. "A sudden interest in the sky?"

Kusuma's ears grew warm. "A woman at the camp asked for her daughter."

"When you lie, your left eyebrow rises a little."

Kusuma was silent.

Her grandmother closed the ledger. "If you do not wish to name someone, do not name them. But do not lie to your own heart."

“You will not stop me?”

“I do not yet know anything, so what should I stop?” There was laughter in her grandmother's eyes. “But a road that must be walked in secret from one's own household has more thorns. Watch where you put your feet.”

Kusuma copied the sequence of constellations from the ledger onto a sheet of paper. From that, a game was born.

It was difficult to hand Rasbihari a letter directly. At the relief camp, eyes were everywhere. Kusuma hid her first note inside a copy of an old relief list: “The day after Revati, behind the pipal tree, List Three.” Rasbihari did not understand at first. The next day an answer appeared inside List Three: “Mrigashira. Third quarter of the day. Not the copy—the original question.”

From that day, the constellations became their secret code. More than names, they indicated times and places. “Rohini” meant the old well near the book room; “Magha” meant the pipal behind the courthouse; “Revati” meant the letter had arrived; “Ardra” meant beware—the family is near. It was not knowledge of the heavens but the secret language of two young minds.

For the first time Kusuma met Rasbihari outside the camp, beneath the pipal behind the courthouse. It was daylight and people were coming and going, so the

meeting carried less sense of wrongdoing. Rasbihari had three papers in his hand.

“About Seven Hamlets?” Kusuma asked.

“Yes. But first, one thing. Your family's name appears in an old claim.”

Kusuma stopped. “I know.”

“All of it?”

“My uncle makes the claim. How old it is, on what basis—I don't know.”

Rasbihari showed her the first paper. “This is a copy of a survey map from before the earthquake. The second mentions an old land-revenue receipt. The third records the temporary settlement of Seven Hamlets families in the relief accounts. But the principal bundle has not been found.”

“Who would have it?”

“It may be in the old courthouse records. Or a copy may be in someone's house.”

“In my house?”

“It is possible.”

Kusuma looked at his face. “Are you meeting me because you need papers from my house?”

Rasbihari's colour changed. “Is that what you think?”

“It is a question.”

“Then hear the answer. For the Seven Hamlets papers, I do need your help. But if papers were the only reason I met you, I would not have gone to the trouble of learning the names of constellations.”

Kusuma could not keep herself from laughing. “Where have you learned them? Twice you read the signals backwards.”

“That is why I call it trouble.”

The lightness of that moment melted some of the fear between them. But the fear did not disappear.

Rasbihari's life took on another shape away from the courthouse table. On the edge of town he lived in a rented room with his mother and younger sister. His father, ill, was staying in the village with an uncle. Before going to the courthouse each morning Rasbihari taught his sister, and at night he returned from the market with cheap greens for his mother. Kusuma learned all this much later, but one day at the camp she happened to see his food tin open: two dry rotis, a little jaggery, and a green chilli.

“Only this much?” Kusuma asked without thinking.

Rasbihari closed the tin. “The stomach agrees to this much.”

“I have food from home.”

“I am not a beggar.” For the first time his voice hardened.

Kusuma was hurt. “I did not say that.”

Rasbihari regretted it at once. “Forgive me. In poverty, a person sometimes hears insult the moment pity appears, even if the person in front of him has said no such thing.”

Kusuma opened her bundle. “Then not pity. Exchange. My vegetables for your jaggery.”

Rasbihari smiled. “Accounts balanced?”

“No. Jaggery is sweeter.”

That day they ate beneath the same pipal tree, from separate leaf plates. No vow, no declaration of love. Yet after returning home Kusuma kept remembering for a long time the sweetness of jaggery on her fingers. Affection is not always made from grand sentences; sometimes it grows from such small exchanges. At the time, she did not yet know how to put that into words.

Rasbihari came from a family of copyists. His father had once been an assistant to a petition writer at the courthouse. There was little money in the house, but great emphasis on education. By caste, Kusuma's family would not even imagine him as an equal match in marriage. The difference in wealth stood apart from that. Family standing, lineage, land, ancestral honour—Kusuma had heard these words since childhood. That

day, for the first time, the words appeared to her as walls.

“You understand, don't you,” Kusuma said softly, “what happens if this reaches my family?”

“I understand.”

“You could lose your work.”

“And your home?”

Kusuma took time to answer. “The house will remain. Whether I will remain inside it is harder to say.”

Rasbihari spoke at once. “I am not asking you to leave your home.”

“You are never asking anything. Only lists, papers, constellations.”

“Then today I will say it.”

The pipal leaves rattled in the wind. Far away a cart driver urged his bullocks onward. Rasbihari's voice was very low. “The day you had that old woman's hamlet name written on the paper, I felt that you listened to people. Later I realised that you listened to me too. I wait for you. It is more than the work.”

Kusuma's heart began to beat hard. She looked at the ground. “That sentence would have been better in writing.”

“Why?”

“If I hear it from your mouth, I have to answer with mine.”

“Then shall I give you a paper?”

“No.”

Rasbihari's face fell completely.

Kusuma smiled a little. “I do not want to answer yet. This ‘no’ belongs to time, not to the letter.”

Rasbihari let out his breath. “You should have become a lawyer.”

“Say that at home and they will marry me off within two months.”

“Then I will not say it.”

After that day their letters became more frequent, though the words were carefully measured. Even in notes of love, land, relief, and people's names found their way in. Once Kusuma wrote: “The ink remains on your hand, but why does its stain fall more deeply on the heart than on paper?” Rasbihari replied: “Paper can be washed. Where is a copy of the heart to be made?”

In another letter he wrote: “Rohini is not safe. Ardra.” Kusuma understood that someone at home was watching.

Indeed, her uncle had become suspicious. One day when Kusuma returned from the camp, he was standing

at the doorway. "Is there a young man named Rasbihari at the courthouse?"

A shiver went through Kusuma's body, but her face remained steady. "Yes. He records names."

"Does he speak to you?"

"If two people work at the same table, will they not speak?"

"About work?"

"Mostly."

Her uncle caught the word mostly. "And the rest?"

Kusuma remembered her grandmother's words—do not lie to your own heart. "The land of poor families. Studies. Books."

Her uncle did not laugh. "Know your limits. People who write names are not all equal to this household."

For the first time Kusuma asked him directly, "Who decides equality?"

"Society."

"Am I not part of society?"

Her uncle's voice hardened. "Too much education makes a girl forget the ways of her own house."

Her father entered just then. He had not heard the whole argument, but he understood the air in the room.

That night he called Kusuma and said, “I educated you so that you would become wise, not so that you would turn against the house.”

“What if the house is wrong?”

Her father closed his eyes and sat for a while. “A house can be wrong. But if you leave it, where will you find the place that is right? You may spend a lifetime searching.”

Kusuma's anger softened a little. “I do not want to leave home.”

“Then do not become the fire that burns it.”

“And what if the fire is already there?”

Her father gave no answer.

That night, for the first time, Kusuma held Rasbihari's letter against her chest and cried. Love is not only sweetness; it becomes fear when a person understands that giving the beloved a place within one's own world will not be easy.

Two days later she found a note. It contained only one constellation name—“Anuradha”—and beneath it one line: “Three elderly witnesses have been found for the Seven Hamlets papers. Without your testimony, the chain remains incomplete.”

Kusuma read the note several times. The question of love and the question of land had once again come to stand upon the same piece of paper.

She wrote back: “Revati. I will come. But this time, no talk of love. People's homes first.”

Rasbihari's reply arrived the next day: “People's homes first. Perhaps that is why there is love.”

Kusuma folded the note and tied it with a thin piece of blue thread. Red thread was easy to find in the household's prayer box; blue thread was in her embroidery case. She made blue her private sign—the constellation would indicate the time, and the blue knot would say that the letter was personal.

That day her grandmother, looking at Kusuma's embroidery, asked, “Are you using a great deal of blue thread?”

Kusuma started.

Her grandmother smiled. “I am old, not blind.”

“Will you tell anyone?”

“Until your foot steps on a thorn and begins to bleed, I will not block the road. But remember—love demands its own truth. It does not live long upon half a lie.”

Kusuma sat down near her grandmother's feet. Evening was descending outside. Kusuma did not know which constellation was truly in the sky that night. To

her, two things were clearer than the heavens:
Rasbihari's handwriting, and the question of the homes
of the people of Seven Hamlets.

The two paths were now moving toward the same
place.

Chapter 15 — Seven Hamlets

At the beginning of Phagun, people from the Seven Hamlets gathered in the field behind the relief camp. The terror that had followed immediately after the earthquake had now become the anxiety of ordinary days. Their shelters were standing, but the question was how long they would be allowed to stand. The agents of the family claiming the land had already pulled out the bamboo poles twice. The third time, the women had seized the poles and stood holding them. A beating was narrowly avoided, but one thing had become clear: without papers, the people could be uprooted again before the rains returned.

Rasbihari called two representatives from each of the Seven Hamlets. Kusuma did not come openly; she arrived with her mother under the pretext of distributing relief. Sitting some distance away, she listened to the meeting. A mat lay on the ground; in the centre were an old map, two receipts, the relief list, and statements from elderly villagers.

“Why put everyone's case on one paper?” an elderly washerman asked. “Our hamlet is separate; theirs is separate.”

Rasbihari said, “Because the raised strip of land was used in common. If you make separate claims, you will

have seven weak documents. If you make one together, the old pattern of use becomes one coherent account.”

Sita Devi, a boatwoman, said, “Not an account. The truth.”

“Yes, the truth. But the court will ask for the truth in the form of paper.”

Kusuma listened from a distance. She remembered: people can live for generations without papers; it is when someone wants to remove them that papers are demanded.

The work of preparing the document continued for three days. The first day: names of families and their earlier settlements. The second: boundary markers. The third: evidence of historic use. There was disagreement over everything. Was the peepal tree the boundary, or had there been two peepal trees? Which way had the old line of the pond run? Where had herders tethered cattle? Where had the common cooking hearth been lit during weddings? Where had the river cut its channel in earlier years? Rasbihari wrote everything down, then read it back again and again.

Each representative of the Seven Hamlets had a different fear. Ramsakhi of Domahi feared that even after the papers were prepared, upper-caste people would push her hamlet to the far edge. Jagarnath of Navtoli said, “We are people of the river, but our children need a dry path to school.” Phuleshwar the

blacksmith of Kamar Patti had another question: if a forge was built at the new place, would space be allowed for the smoke, or would complaints begin again? Fekni Devi of the Musahari said, "First show me that my name will remain on the list. We can talk about the land afterward."

Rasbihari wrote each demand on a separate page. Kusuma asked, "Will all this go into the main document?"

"Not all of it. But the minutes of the meeting will remain. If someone later says that only land was demanded, these pages will say that people were asking for a place to live a life."

In the middle of this, Sita Devi laughed and said, "Babu, put my goat's name in the papers too. It needs grass as well."

The meeting burst into laughter. The tension eased a little. Rasbihari replied, "The goat's name will go into a separate annexure."

Kusuma watched and understood that making a document was not merely a legal act; it was also a way of teaching people to state their own case clearly. The woman who had trembled while saying her name on the first day was questioning the boundary on the third. The old man who had once said, 'Whatever Babu writes,' now stopped the reading if even one word sounded

wrong. The document was becoming a copy of their voices, not a gift bestowed upon them.

One thing startled Kusuma. Mahendra Jha, an old steward from her own household, had also come to testify. He was nearly seventy. He said, “When I was a boy, I saw cattle of every caste tethered on that strip during floods. The owners never stopped them.”

“Whom do you mean by the owners?” Rasbihari asked.

Mahendra Jha looked toward Kusuma and recognised her. Then he said, “On paper the land was linked to the old Thakurbari accounts, but the use was shared.”

If Kusuma's Kaka heard this, he would burst into flames.

Rasbihari asked, “Will you give this in writing and sign it?”

The old man's hand trembled. “I cannot write my name.”

“A thumb impression.”

He fell silent. “People in the household will hear.”

Sita Devi said sharply, “And when our homes are destroyed, people won't hear that?”

Shame passed over Mahendra Jha's face. Kusuma rose and went to him. "Kaka, say what you saw. Everyone is afraid of something."

The old man looked at her. "Bitiya, this concerns your own house."

"That is why I am listening."

At that moment every eye turned toward Kusuma. She understood that once a word had been spoken, it would not quietly slip back across the threshold of her house; it would carry questions with it.

Mahendra Jha finally gave his thumb impression.

A draft was prepared. At the top, the language of government was hard and formal; below it stood the names of the Seven Hamlets. In between came the details of temporary resettlement after the earthquake and testimony about older common use. Alongside the document, Rasbihari prepared a separate list of evidence.

First — a copy of the old survey map.

Second — a mention of the shared path in a land-revenue receipt.

Third — names of families from the Seven Hamlets in the relief list.

Fourth — statements from three elderly witnesses.

Fifth — a reference to the site of a communal hearth in a pre-earthquake wedding record, found in an old ledger preserved by the father of a bookbinder named Rahmat.

Sixth — the thumb impression of Mahendra Jha, the steward who had seen the common cattle-tethering ground.

Rasbihari left the seventh line blank.

Kusuma asked, “Why is this blank?”

“We need a written acknowledgement from someone on the landholding family's side that the use was shared.”

“Who will give it?”

Rasbihari did not look at her. “Perhaps no one.”

Kusuma understood.

That evening Kaka was unnaturally quiet at home. There was a seed of anger in that quiet. After dinner he summoned Kusuma to the sitting room. Her father, grandmother, and mother were there too. On the table lay a copy of the draft Rasbihari had prepared.

Kusuma's heart struck hard.

Kaka asked, “Do you recognise this paper?”

“Yes.”

“How did it come to you?”

“It was prepared at the camp.”

“That young man is preparing it. Rasbihari.”

Kusuma remained silent.

“He is trapping you. He will take testimony against the family from the daughter of the family, and then the people of the Seven Hamlets will strengthen their hold over the land.”

“What if the use truly was shared?”

“On paper the ownership belongs to this house.”

“Are ownership and people's old rights of use the same thing?”

Kaka struck the table with his hand. “Have you studied law?”

“No. That is why I am asking.”

Her father said sternly, “Kusuma.”

She fell silent.

Kaka lifted the draft. “No name from this house will go on this paper. Not yours either. From tomorrow you will stop going to the camp.”

Her mother said in a tearful voice, “Bhaiya, the girl is only helping with relief.”

“Not relief—politics!”

Grandmother had remained silent until then. She asked slowly, “Did those people tether cattle on that land earlier or not?”

Kaka snapped, “Ma, old custom does not decide ownership.”

“I did not ask about ownership. I asked what happened.”

Kaka did not answer.

Grandmother looked at Kusuma. The glance was brief, but its meaning was large: do not lie to your own heart.

Kusuma did not sleep all night. On one side was home: this house where she had been born, her mother, father, grandmother, the mango tree in the courtyard, the book room, childhood. On the other side were the Seven Hamlets, whose people's eyes had lit simply because their names had appeared on paper. And between the two stood Rasbihari, whose place in her heart was making the decision harder rather than easier.

She asked herself: if Rasbihari did not exist, would I still want to testify?

After a long time the answer came: yes.

Once she had that answer, her mind became steadier.

At dawn Grandmother came to her room. In her hand was not the constellation ledger but a small tin box. "These are your great-grandmother's papers."

Inside, wrapped in old cloth, were two receipts and a letter. In the letter, an ancestor of the household had written to a local officer that during floods the raised strip should be kept open "for the temporary safety of the people of the village". It said nothing about surrendering ownership, but the acknowledgement of shared use was clear.

Kusuma looked at Grandmother in astonishment. "Does Kaka know about this?"

"I cannot say whether he does or not. It was in an old trunk."

"Why are you giving it to me?"

Grandmother's voice was calm. "Paper does not create truth, but neither should it become a tool for hiding truth."

"May I take this outside?"

"Not the original. Make a copy. The original stays with me."

Kusuma caught Grandmother's feet. The old woman placed a hand on her head. "Don't cry yet. Do the difficult work first."

Kusuma did not go straight from home to the courthouse. First she went to a teacher she knew and had copies made of the receipts and the letter. Then she wrapped the copies in cloth and went to the relief camp. The moment Rasbihari saw her, he stood up.

“You were forbidden to come.”

“I have been forbidden.”

“Then?”

“I did not stop.”

She placed the copies on the table. Rasbihari read them, then lifted his face. “Where did you find these?”

“At home.”

“Do you understand what this may mean?”

“Can it fill the seventh line?”

Rasbihari's eyes brightened, but he mastered himself immediately. “It is an old written basis for acknowledgement from the household. It must be verified; we will need to see the original, compare the handwriting and seal. But yes—it is very important.”

Kusuma said, “The original will not come outside yet.”

“All right. I will not ask for it without the owner's permission.”

“Owner?” Kusuma laughed softly. “Grandmother.”

Rasbihari smiled too. “Then the strongest owner of all.”

The seventh evidence line in the document was filled: acknowledgement, in an old household letter, of community use during times of disaster. Beneath it Rasbihari made a small mark, only to keep the sequence matched. Kusuma asked, “Why seven dots inside this circle?”

“Seven pieces of evidence. If the bundle gets separated, the identifying mark remains.”

“A name?”

“What need for a name?”

Kusuma teased him. “Seven Hamlets, seven pieces of evidence—write ‘the seventh witness’.”

Rasbihari stopped his pen and looked at her. “A paper as witness?”

“Human beings lie. Paper at least does not change what has been written on it.”

Rasbihari's face grew serious. “Paper can be altered too, Kusuma. Pages disappear, ink is scraped away, copies are remade. That is why one witness is not enough. That is why there are seven marks.”

“Then write it—the seventh witness.”

He smiled. Not on the official document, but on his working slip, in small letters, he wrote: “Seventh witness — household letter.”

From her embroidery box Kusuma took an extremely small piece of blue thread and tied it to the corner of the slip. “This is my mark.”

“Thread on a government paper?”

“Not on government paper. On your working slip.”

“And if someone asks?”

“I’ll say the thread got caught there.”

“You lie rather well.”

“Watch my left eyebrow.”

They both laughed.

But the next task was no matter for laughter. The document required Kusuma’s written statement: that she had seen the old letter in her house, had produced a copy, and had heard from her grandmother the family memory of shared use. Rasbihari said, “There will be pressure on you. If you do not want this, we can look for another way.”

Kusuma took the pen. “Will another way change the truth?”

“No.”

“Then.”

She wrote her name—“Kusuma.” At the place where the full family surname had to be written, she paused for one moment, then wrote it in full.

After she signed, a strange silence fell. No one from the Seven Hamlets applauded. Everyone understood that a paper had been made, not that victory had been won. Victory was still far away. But Sita Devi stepped forward and touched Kusuma's head. “Bitiya, your family will be angry with you.”

Kusuma said, “They may be.”

“Aren't you afraid?”

“I am.”

“Then why did you write it?”

Kusuma searched for an answer. At last she said, “If there were no fear, this would not be testimony. It would merely be convenience.”

Rasbihari watched her from a distance. There was love in that gaze, pride, and fear as well.

As evening descended, the document was prepared in three copies—one for the relief records, one for submission to the court, and one secure copy. The evidence list was separate. The serial numbers of all copies were matched. Rasbihari counted every page again and again.

Kusuma asked, “Why so much care?”

“A paper whose disappearance benefits someone grows legs.”

“Paper can walk?”

“People make it walk.”

Darkness was gathering outside. The last light of day entered through the ventilator of the old storehouse. Kusuma looked once at the grille with the small circle at its centre. She could not know that ninety years later the same design would appear behind the room of a dead woman. All she knew was that a document had been made that day, and upon it rested the hope of homes for the people of the Seven Hamlets.

As Rasbihari tied the document bundle, he handed Kusuma a small slip. There was no constellation name on it. Only one line: “I said nothing about love today, but what I felt on seeing your signature was no less than love.”

Kusuma read the slip and lowered her eyes. Then she asked for the pen and wrote on the back: “Today I did not write against my family. I wrote against a lie. If you love me, remember the difference.”

Rasbihari read the slip. He bowed his head. “I will remember.”

When Kusuma returned home that night, the main door was open, but the courtyard was unnaturally silent. Kaka sat in the sitting room. Before him was a man dressed like a courthouse clerk. News of the document bearing Kusuma's signature had reached the house before she had.

Kaka said only, "From tomorrow, you will not go outside."

Kusuma remained standing on the threshold. The lamp in Grandmother's room was burning inside. Somewhere far outside, a dog barked.

She understood: the Seven Hamlets had now entered the record; inside her own house, preparations were beginning to strike out her name.

Chapter 16 — The Missing Document

At daybreak, the main door of Kusuma's house was secured from inside with a heavy iron bar. The door had always been shut at night, but today the sound was different. When the iron rod dropped into its socket, Kusuma understood that the bar had not been drawn for the safety of the house, but to stop her from moving beyond it.

In the courtyard, beside the tulsi altar, her mother was lighting a lamp. Instead of rising straight upward, the smoke kept bending in the heavy wind before the rain. When Kusuma came onto the veranda, her mother looked up and then immediately lowered her eyes. After the meeting of the previous night, everyone in the house was speaking, but speaking less to Kusuma. Silence too has its own grammar—some fall silent in anger, some in fear, some in love.

Before breakfast, Kaka had called her father and said clearly, “The girl will not go outside. Not to the relief camp, not to the courthouse, not to the pond—nowhere.” Her father had not objected. At night her mother had come into Kusuma's room, stroked her head, and said only, “Remain quiet for a few days. Let the fire in the house settle first.”

Kusuma had asked, “Will a lie settle down too?”

Her mother had not answered.

Now Kusuma went toward Grandmother's room. Grandmother sat on the cot, folding the edge of an old cloth. The place where the tin box of old receipts and the letter had been kept was empty. The moment Kusuma's eyes went there, Grandmother said, "The originals are safe. Don't worry about them."

"Did Kaka search?"

"Let him search. This house has many ancestors, many trunks, and an old woman's stubbornness greater than both."

A smile came to Kusuma's face for a moment, but did not remain. "Rasbihari will take the papers to court today."

Grandmother stopped twisting the thread in her fingers. "So that is why your mind is flying outside."

"The people of the Seven Hamlets will all be waiting."

"Is it necessary for you to go?"

Kusuma was about to answer, then fell silent. What exactly was necessary—the protection of the papers, responsibility for her own signature, or seeing Rasbihari? The three had become so mixed together that it was difficult to separate one from another.

Grandmother read her face. "A thing does not cease to exist because you do not give it a name. But for now, be patient."

At that same time, in the old copying room of the courthouse, Rasbihari was counting pages. The filing bundle was tied in red cloth. Inside it were the signed original copy of the main petition, the thumb impressions of the Seven Hamlets representatives, the evidence list, the certified copy of the old map, a copy of the relief register, Mahendra Jha's statement, and Kusuma's written testimony. The second copy prepared for the relief camp and the secure duplicate were stored separately, but the original thumb impressions and certifications needed for immediate court filing were in this bundle.

Rasbihari said to his colleague Nandlal, "Count them again."

Nandlal laughed. "We counted three times yesterday and you counted twice at night. Papers do not multiply."

"They can diminish."

"That much fear?"

Rasbihari's face was serious. "For someone who stands to lose because of these papers, one missing page may be worth the profit of a thousand bighas."

Nandlal stopped laughing. They counted again. Everything was in order. Rasbihari placed his small seal on the knot of the red cloth. The bundle had to be taken to the court filing window, but first a verification from the tehsil record had to be written. For that reason, the

bundle was placed for half an hour in the iron cupboard of the copying room.

The cupboard had two keys. Rasbihari held one; the head copyist held the other. The arrangement was old. Everyone knew it. And perhaps precisely because everyone knew it, it was considered safe.

Rasbihari went to the rear building for the verification. There was a queue. After the earthquake, land, relief, death, inheritance—all kinds of papers had surged forward at once. One person was proving his father alive, another proving his father dead; one was claiming that his house had collapsed, another that no house had ever stood there. At a government desk, a human life became a statement of two or three lines.

An hour later Rasbihari returned. The outer lock of the cupboard was exactly as before. He inserted his key. The door opened. The red bundle was gone.

In the first moment he thought Nandlal must have taken it out. In the second, his mind said no. In the third, his body understood before thought did: a sudden hollowness inside his stomach, sweat on his palms, distant sounds turning blurred in his ears.

“Nandlal!”

Nandlal came running from the next room. “What happened?”

“The bundle?”

“You put it there.”

“Did you take it out?”

“No.”

Together they searched every compartment of the cupboard. Old survey sheets, revenue registers, the box of seals, torn cloth—everything was there. The red bundle was not.

The head copyist was summoned. His second key hung on the ring at his waist. He swore that he had not taken it out since morning. But possessing a key and not using it are not the same thing. Rasbihari did not bring that question to his lips.

“Was the lock broken?”

“No.”

“The window?”

“Iron bars.”

“The ventilator?”

Everyone's eyes lifted. A small square ventilator, its grille thick with dust. It would be difficult for anyone's hand to reach inside through it.

Nandlal said quietly, “It was opened with a key.”

The head copyist's face flushed with anger. “You have the courage to say that?”

Rasbihari stepped between them. “No accusation yet. First make a written report.”

The report was made. With the writing of that report, the incident became official; and once it became official, the questions left human hands and passed into the hands of paper. Who had placed the bundle there, who had seen it, who had last been near the cupboard—names were written down again and again.

By noon five people from the Seven Hamlets had reached the courthouse. Sita Devi was in front. “Has it been filed?”

Rasbihari took her aside. “The bundle is missing.”

Sita Devi stood motionless for several moments. Then she said, “Missing? The paper walked away on its own feet?”

Rasbihari remembered what he had said the previous evening: a paper whose disappearance benefits someone grows legs. The sentence was no longer a joke.

“They are searching for it.”

“The copies?”

“We have them. But the original thumb impressions and several certifications were in the bundle. The fight can continue with copies, but the filing will be held up for now.”

Ramsakhi clenched her teeth. “I told you—put my name on the paper. The name went up, and the paper came down.”

Meeting her eyes, Rasbihari said, “The name will go up again. This time in a place where it will be harder to remove.”

But his own confidence was not as strong as the sentence he had spoken.

Before evening, a second story had spread through the courthouse: Rasbihari himself had removed the bundle. Why? He had demanded money from the Seven Hamlets; when they refused, he withheld the papers. A third version said he had a private grudge against Kusuma's family; he created the document to disgrace the household, then, realising the evidence was weak, made it disappear himself. A fourth version: he was in love with Kusuma; the papers were merely an excuse. Rumour proved to have faster legs than paper.

Late in the evening, two constables came from the police station. A complaint had been filed alleging theft and destruction of government records. The complainant's name was written on the paper, but Rasbihari did not need to read it. He was an agent aligned with the landholding household, claiming that “forged papers” had been made and that their traces were now being erased.

“I am the one who reported the missing bundle,” Rasbihari said.

The constable replied, “Then come for questioning. You were the last responsible hand.”

Rasbihari looked at the small piece of blue thread tied to the corner of his desk. Kusuma had tied it to the working slip the previous evening. The main slip had gone into the bundle, but the remaining end of the thread had caught in his mind like a strand of embroidery.

“I’ll come,” he said.

At the police station, the questions kept circling back to the same points. Who had the keys? Where was the bundle? What was his relationship with Kusuma? Had he taken money from the people of the Seven Hamlets? Where was the original household letter? Rasbihari answered every question. When Kusuma’s name came up, he paused.

“She gave testimony. That is all.”

The officer laughed. “Only that?”

Rasbihari looked at him steadily. “Examine the papers through the papers. Do not make a spectacle out of a woman’s name.”

The answer hardened the officer’s tone. Rasbihari’s bag, desk, and rented room were searched. Nothing was

found. Yet the accusation did not disappear. Sometimes the absence of evidence, instead of reducing suspicion, increases it—especially when society has already chosen its story.

At home, Kusuma knew nothing of any of this. In the evening a servant boy came to the rear gate on the pretext of delivering milk. Grandmother took the brass pot from his hand. A thin folded slip of paper had been pasted to its bottom. Without a word, Grandmother gave it to Kusuma.

The note was in Nandlal's hand: "Bundle meant for court missing from cupboard. Rasbihari Babu accused of theft. Police questioning. Do not leave the house; someone is watching outside."

Kusuma's hands began to tremble. For a moment she felt that by signing she had trapped Rasbihari. If she had not testified, if she had not brought out the old letter, if she had allowed the seventh line to remain blank—would none of this have happened?

Grandmother asked, "What does it say?"

Kusuma handed her the slip. Grandmother could not read it, so Kusuma read it aloud.

Grandmother was silent for a long time. Then she said, "You think this is your fault?"

"If I had not gone..."

“Then the Seven Hamlets would still have had no paper. Whoever stole the paper bears the blame. Why should the person who spoke the truth put the thief’s guilt on her own face?”

“But Rasbihari...”

“He did his work knowing what he was doing. Love or no love, he is not a child.”

Kusuma started at hearing the word “love” from Grandmother for the first time. The old woman did not smile. “I am old, not blind.”

That night Kaka returned home late. He spoke with Kusuma’s father in a low voice in the sitting room. Kusuma did not press her ear to the door of her room; instead she sat beside the window, listening to the first heavy drops of rain. But one sentence came clearly: “The papers will not reach the court now.”

A shiver went through Kusuma. It was not clear whether Kaka had spoken the sentence or the agent who had come with him. She tried to hear again, but the voices dropped lower.

At dawn something unexpected happened. A government inspector arrived carrying the relief-camp account ledger, and Nandlal came with him. The men of the house were in the sitting room. Kusuma remained inside. On the pretext of touching Grandmother’s feet, Nandlal came as far as the place where Kusuma stood

behind a curtain. He could not speak. As he folded his hands, he let a small piece of paper fall into her palm.

The note was in Rasbihari's handwriting: "The papers are gone, but the serial numbers remain. The record of the three copies, the witnesses' names, and all seven marks are in memory. Do not change your statement out of fear. I have been accused; the truth has not changed."

Below it was another line: "The blue thread was your mark; one end of it is still on my desk."

Kusuma closed the note in her fist. Outside, in the sitting room, the men were talking about land, honour, family prestige, and law. Inside, her mind was not completely calm, but neither was it scattered as before.

The document was missing. The accusation was against Rasbihari. She herself was confined inside the house. The three facts stood before her like three separate walls.

On the back of the slip, Kusuma wrote only two words: "Statement unchanged." Meaning: she would not alter her testimony.

She sent the slip back through Nandlal.

After noon, Kaka stood outside Kusuma's room and said, "There is only one way to save this family's name. Write that you were misled into signing."

From inside, Kusuma asked, "And if that is a lie?"

“The family is greater than the truth.”

Kusuma kept looking at the door. Beyond that wood stood people of her own blood. On this side she stood alone. Then Grandmother's sentence returned to her: paper does not create truth, but neither should it become a tool for hiding truth.

She answered quietly, “I will not write it.”

For several moments there was silence outside. Then Kaka's footsteps receded. The iron bar clanged again.

Kusuma understood that the search for the missing document would now continue not only in the courthouse, but inside this house as well. And her body, her name, and her love had all become evidence in that search.

Chapter 17 — The Night of the Red Dupatta

The first heavy rain of Ashadh that year came with such force that the difference between day and night seemed to disappear. The sky was grey, the courtyard flooded, water poured steadily from the eaves. The village's dirt paths turned to mud. The river was far away, yet its roar could be heard in the wind. People said the earthquake had torn the earth open; now the clouds were washing its wounds.

Kusuma had been confined inside the house for four days. “Confined” did not mean only the bolt on the door. Her meals were brought to her room; someone watched when she crossed the courtyard; even when she sat with Grandmother, a household woman waited outside. Her mother wanted to protect her, but her mother too was bound by the discipline of the household. Her father spoke little. Kaka spoke more.

The accusation against Rasbihari had spread through the village. He had not been imprisoned, but he was repeatedly required to present himself between the police station and the courthouse. He had been kept somewhat away from work in the copying room. There was talk of filing a new application for the Seven Hamlets on the basis of duplicate documents, but the case had been weakened by the disappearance of the

original thumb impressions and the sequence of evidence.

Kaka regarded that weakness as victory. One night at dinner he said, "See? That is the strength of paper. Old household customs are not changed by paper."

Grandmother asked, "Then why did the paper disappear?"

Kaka stopped. "Did I make it disappear?"

"I did not say that."

The sound of spoons on the table ceased. Kusuma's mother did not look toward her. Her father began drinking water. Kusuma understood that in this house questions had become more dangerous than answers.

That night her mother came into her room carrying a red dupatta—Kusuma's old one, which Grandmother had given her in Phagun.

"Why this?" Kusuma asked.

Her mother placed the dupatta on the cot. "At dawn tomorrow you will be sent to your maternal uncle's house. Stay there for a few months, until things become quiet."

"Was I asked?"

Her mother was silent.

“Rasbihari is accused of theft. The papers of the Seven Hamlets are missing. I refused to change my statement. And now sending me away is called peace?”

Her mother's eyes filled. “What can I do? I cannot bear hearing the things people say in this house while taking your name. You two...” She stopped. “People will turn love into a crime. If you remain here, the talk will only grow.”

For the first time Kusuma took her mother's hand. “Ma, if I leave, what becomes smaller—the talk, or my voice?”

Her mother could not find an answer. At last she said only, “First stay alive. Truth can come later.”

The sentence lodged inside Kusuma: first stay alive. Was her life truly in danger? Until now she had thought of humiliation, confinement, pressure to marry—not fear for her life.

Grandmother came at night. Her mother had gone. The rain was fierce. When lightning flashed, Grandmother's face appeared white for an instant, then vanished again into darkness.

“You heard about your uncle's house?”

“Yes.”

“Will you go?”

Kusuma looked into Grandmother's eyes. "What do you want?"

"I want you to make your own decision. But first understand the price of that decision."

Grandmother untied the ring of keys at her waist and separated one slender key. "The back door of the book room. From there a path leads into the garden."

Kusuma stared at her. "Are you telling me to run away?"

"No. I am showing you the road. Whether you take it or not is yours."

"And if I do?"

"Then I will not ask where you are going. The fewer people who know, the fewer lies anyone will have to speak."

Grandmother set the key down and rose, then turned back. "Do not wear the red dupatta. It can be seen from far away."

Kusuma looked at the dupatta lying on the cot. The red colour suddenly looked like a warning.

Until midnight she could not decide. Rain outside, pounding inside. Rasbihari's slip lay beneath her pillow—"The truth has not changed." She remembered that Rasbihari had told only two people where the secure copy was kept: Nandlal and Kusuma. In an iron chest in

the old storehouse behind the relief camp. The principal bundle was gone, but if the secure copy was still there, the people of the Seven Hamlets were not completely empty-handed.

For several days Kusuma had suppressed one fear: if the people who made the courthouse bundle disappear were connected with the landholding household, news of the secure copy might reach them too. Nandlal was being watched. Rasbihari was under police scrutiny. She herself was confined. If anyone learned where the chest was, the second set of papers could vanish as well.

Should she wait until dawn? At dawn she would be sent to her uncle's house. Then she would be able to do nothing.

She rose. Instead of wearing the red dupatta, she took an ordinary dark shawl made from dhoti cloth. Then she stopped. Her mother's red dupatta lay on the cot. It held the smell of the house, her mother's hands, Grandmother's gift—everything. Kusuma could not leave it behind. She did not put the red dupatta on her body; she folded it inside her bundle of clothes.

The back door of the book room opened with the key. As soon as it opened, the smell of wet earth filled the room. Water in the garden was not knee-deep, but it rose above her ankles. Rain struck the mango leaves. Kusuma looked back once. No lamp was burning anywhere inside the house. Whether Grandmother was awake, she did not know.

She went out.

Up to this moment, Kusuma's story can still be held by paper. A later note in Grandmother's hand reads: "Ashadh, dark fortnight, heavy rain; Kusuma not in room at night." In the morning the lock of the book room was found open. Small footprints on the rear path had been half-erased by the rain. Up to this point, these are facts. Beyond them, the story runs in many directions.

One story says Kusuma went directly to the relief camp. A watchman there later said that after midnight he saw a woman near the veranda asking for the key to the storehouse. But the watchman's statement was written ten years afterward; there is no proof that the woman was Kusuma.

A second story: Haripat the oilman of the village said that a young woman in a red dupatta took the road toward the old pond. The contradiction is that Kusuma had not been wearing the red dupatta; she had kept it in her bundle—and only Grandmother knew that. So how did Haripat see red? Perhaps the bundle opened in a flash of lightning. Perhaps he saw someone else. Perhaps later folklore added the red dupatta from the beginning.

A third story belonged to the boatmen by the river. They said that a young woman asked for a boat that night. The river was swollen, so no boat was given. She went south along the bank. But the boatman's name changes from telling to telling—sometimes Jagarnath,

sometimes his brother, sometimes merely “an old boatman.”

The fourth story became the favourite: Kusuma had run away with Rasbihari. There was one problem with it. That night, after reporting to the police, Rasbihari was under watch at the district officer's rest house; the entry register carried his name, the signatures of two employees, and a record of his presence at dawn. Folklore, however, is not embarrassed by records. If lovers are in two different places, the story simply brings them together.

The fifth story was frightening. People of the household had caught Kusuma and locked her in the old mansion; she died there; her name was scratched into the wall; at night her anklet could be heard. No one knows when this story first appeared. The old mansion had been the family's earlier residence. One section had cracked in the earthquake and was later abandoned. Children did not go there after evening. Whatever sound someone heard—bats, a loose beam, the whistle of wind—became an anklet.

But the account of the immediate search that night is clearer. When it was time at dawn to send Kusuma to her uncle's house, she was not found. There was no public outcry at first; the family searched in secret. Kaka sent four men—to the pond, the relief camp, the courthouse road, and Rasbihari's lodging. By noon there was no result. Only then was the police station informed.

The report described Kusuma's age, height, and clothing, but did not mention a red dupatta. It said "dark-coloured shawl."

When questioned by the police, Grandmother said only one thing: "She went on her own feet."

"Where?"

"I do not know."

"To meet whom?"

"I do not know."

"Who gave her the key?"

Grandmother answered, "In an old house, keys keep changing their places."

Whether that was her whole truth or a half-truth meant to protect her granddaughter was never established.

Rasbihari learned that Kusuma was missing only after noon. The police officer watched his face, perhaps hoping to read a reaction. At first Rasbihari did not believe it. Then he asked only one question: "Was the back door of the house open?"

"How do you know there is a back door?"

Rasbihari fell silent. A correct answer given at the wrong time can also become guilt.

He was questioned again. His correspondence with Kusuma, the relief camp, the documents, the missing bundle—everything was tied into one knot. Rasbihari offered to hand over all his slips except Kusuma's private notes. "Those are private," he said. The officer laughed. "The private affairs of a missing young woman are no longer private."

Rasbihari replied, "Prove a crime. Do not confiscate love."

Later the sentence spread among people in many altered forms. Some said Rasbihari had admitted the love affair. Some said he had helped Kusuma run away. The actual interrogation register recorded only this: "Unwilling to produce personal correspondence."

The rain did not stop by evening. At the pond steps there was no body of Kusuma, no shoe, no anklet. There is a later story that two or three strands of red thread were found in the mud; the contemporary inventory does not mention them. The fibres appear only in memories recorded much later.

On the third day, the iron chest in the old storehouse was opened. Inside were relief lists, dry papers, old receipts—but not the secure copy of the Seven Hamlets document. The lock of the chest was not broken. Who had the keys? Nandlal continued to say that he had one and Rasbihari had the other, but Rasbihari's key had already been deposited during the police inquiry.

With this second disappearance, the disappearance of Kusuma and the disappearance of the papers became one story. Some said Kusuma had taken the copy. Some said she had gone to save it and fallen into someone's hands. Some said greed for the papers had cost her life.

Grandmother declared belief in none of these stories. Every evening she continued lighting the lamp in Kusuma's room. Kusuma's mother put another red dupatta away in a trunk. Her father gradually became a silent man. Kaka continued to flare up whenever the Seven Hamlets were mentioned, but at Kusuma's name his voice changed—anger, guilt, or grief, no one could tell.

A month later, for lack of evidence, the charge that Rasbihari had stolen the papers went no further, but his place of work was changed. Before leaving the village he wanted to meet Grandmother. The men of the house refused permission. Grandmother herself came out on the pretext of going to the temple. There is no written account of what passed between them. It was only said later that Grandmother gave him a piece of blue thread and said, "The paper we trusted is gone. Do not let the person we trusted die as well."

Whether Rasbihari took the thread is also uncertain.

In Kusuma's constellation ledger, the pages for that year suddenly become blank at this point. Before then there had been a small note every week—rain, relief, birth, death, moon, household matters. After that night

in Ashadh, three pages are empty. On the fourth page, in Grandmother's hand, there is only one sentence: "Do not ask the constellations for the direction of one whose path cannot be found."

Years passed. The people of the Seven Hamlets scattered again, settled again, and litigated again. Inside the household, Kusuma's story became a forbidden name; outside, it became folklore. The red dupatta gradually ceased to be an actual garment and became a sign—of leaving home, of love, of rebellion, of death, or of escape, according to the meaning the storyteller desired.

And the old mansion? One of its walls had been repaired after the earthquake. No record says when someone scratched a name into the new layer of lime plaster. The mansion slowly emptied. When the wind moved through it, a metallic chime could sometimes be heard inside. People said it was Kusuma's anklet.

The papers say: Kusuma left the house that night and was never officially found again.

People say: she still returns.

The truth, somewhere between those two sentences, remained in darkness as dense as that night of rain.

Chapter 18 — The Belly of the Wall

Madhavi woke to the sound of an anklet.

Jhan... jhan... then two moments of silence, then a small chime.

She opened her eyes and stared at the ceiling in the darkness. The window of the room was closed. Outside, the first bird of dawn had not yet called. Her mother's breathing could be heard softly from the next room. Madhavi moved her feet—she did not wear anklets. The sound did not come again.

The dream was still caught in her body. Water from a pond was climbing the steps. The red dupatta was wet. On one wall of the old mansion, the lime plaster had broken away, and from inside it emerged not anyone's hand, but only one end of a blue thread. An anklet sounded behind the wall. She wanted to pull the thread, but white dust once again settled on her palm.

At dawn Madhavi opened the constellation ledger. The previous night she had read the 1934 pages—three blank pages after Ashadh, then the sentence: “Do not ask the constellations for the direction of one whose path cannot be found.” Before sleeping she had already known the story of the red dupatta, but blue thread inside a wall? There was no such description in the ledger.

She became irritated with herself. The mind takes what it has seen, stories it has heard, fear and desire, and joins them into new scenes. Jaynarayan had said it: dreams are not evidence. Abhiram would certainly call it “the brain's pattern-joining.”

Then she remembered not the dream, but the photograph—the image of the 1934 relief camp found in the locked Bride's Room at Vasudha's house. In the background was the grille-like form resembling a ventilator. Along one side of the photograph was a wall with cracked lime plaster. Abhiram had enlarged that photograph. At the time Madhavi had been fixed on the young woman in the red dupatta; she had not noticed the wall.

At seven she sent Abhiram a message: “Bring the photograph and the plans of the old mansion. Meet me in the records room at ten.”

The reply came at once: “Why?”

Madhavi wrote: “We need to look at a wall.”

“Which wall?”

“The one we haven't looked at yet.”

After a while Abhiram replied: “Are you learning sentences like this from spending too much time with Jaynarayan Babu?”

Madhavi could not help smiling.

At ten Abhiram arrived with two plans, a copy of the photograph, and a ruler. "I thought you were going to tell me another dream."

"I will."

"The wall first?"

"Facts first."

Abhiram raised an eyebrow. "Progress."

Together they opened the records of the old mansion. The building was now semi-abandoned; ownership was disputed between a distant branch of Vasudha's maternal family and a trust, while the outer portion had been declared unsafe by the municipality. It would not be proper to enter without permission. Madhavi telephoned Vasudha's mother. She did not give the whole reason, only said they needed to compare an old photograph with the records. Permission was granted on one condition: Gopal, an old servant of the household, would accompany them.

Jaynarayan was informed. He said clearly, "Do not break any wall. Photograph whatever you see. If you find anything unusual, call me. Vasudha's death investigation is still open; if old papers turn out to be connected with her case, do not damage the chain of evidence."

Abhiram ended the call and looked at Madhavi. "This is why I like him. Procedure before curiosity."

Madhavi said, "And I thought you disliked him precisely because he trusts Sutra so little."

"He trusts Sutra little. He trusts me only halfway too."

"Half is a lot."

The old mansion stood at the edge of the town, where a new road had cut through the old settlement. The outer gate leaned crookedly; wild grass filled the courtyard. The lime over the section repaired after the earthquake was a different colour. Gopal was nearly seventy, thin but quick on his feet. He said, "There is nothing here even for thieves now. If you're looking for papers, the termites will have read them before you."

Madhavi asked, "Do anklets sound here?"

Gopal stopped and looked at her. "Who told you?"

Abhiram immediately looked at Madhavi—a glance containing both 'See?' and 'Now it begins.'

Gopal laughed. "It is an old house. When the wind comes from the west, the beams and iron fittings jingle. Children call it an anklet."

"Near which wall?" Madhavi asked.

"The Bride's Room at the back. But that part is closed."

The hair along Madhavi's back rose. Abhiram's face was serious now. "Show him the photograph," he said.

The 1934 photograph was placed before Gopal. He narrowed his eyes at it. "This is the courtyard from the time relief meals were being served. The wall in the back is the outer wall of the Bride's Room."

"And now?"

"Now it is thicker from the inside. The old people used to say a second wall was raised after the earthquake."

Abhiram immediately opened the plans. He compared the old measurements with the later municipal measurements. The interior length of one room was about a hand and a quarter shorter than the exterior dimensions suggested. He wrote the figures on the ruler pad. "There is no reason for the wall to be this thick. There may be a hollow space inside it."

Madhavi said, "The dream said that."

"The plan says it too. Credit the plan first."

"All right, Mr Data."

"Thank you, Goddess Dream."

Gopal laughed at both of them. "Fight later. Come inside."

The door of the Bride's Room had jammed. It opened only after much effort. Inside was the smell of dampness, spider webs, an old cot, and an empty trunk. Many layers of lime covered the walls. The inner frame of the ventilator visible in the old photograph was now half

blocked. Madhavi slowly looked around the room. The scene was not exactly like the dream. Reality is always smaller than a dream and more full of dust.

Abhiram angled the light from his phone across the wall. Under the slanting light, the relief became clearer. At one place the lime surface formed a square. “This was sealed later.”

Madhavi did not place her palm against the wall. She remembered Jaynarayan's instruction. She took photographs. Gopal said, “My father used to say there was once a little niche here. At some point it was bricked up.”

“When?”

“It was already closed when I was born.”

Abhiram measured outside and then inside. “The empty space is roughly nine inches deep, two feet wide, around three feet high. An old niche, or a recess for keeping documents.”

Madhavi's hearing suddenly sharpened. “Quiet.”

All three fell silent. Wind rose outside. The ventilator grille trembled. Then—jhan. Very faint.

Gopal smiled. “The anklet.”

Abhiram examined the grille. “Loose iron. The wind catches it.”

Madhavi kept looking toward the wall. “The sound was coming from there.”

“Echo. If there is a hollow, sound can travel around inside it.”

“Why did I see this place in my dream?”

“You saw the photograph, read the story, and your brain joined them.”

“The blue thread?”

Abhiram paused before answering. “Where have we actually found that yet?”

Madhavi fell silent too. He was right—nowhere, so far.

By the time Jaynarayan arrived, afternoon was declining. With him came a photographer and an officer from the local police station. They were shown every detail. Keeping his eyes on the square section of wall, Jaynarayan said, “This is not the place where Vasudha was killed. But Vasudha was searching for papers connected with this history. Whatever we find must be properly recorded.”

A local mason was called, but before work began the wall was photographed from every side, measurements were written down, along with the time and the names of everyone present. Madhavi's impatience was growing. Abhiram said quietly to her, “Five minutes of

documentation now can prevent five years of dispute later.”

“I understand.”

“Then why are you shaking your foot?”

Madhavi looked down. Her right foot really was moving again and again. “Habit.”

Abhiram smiled faintly. “Jaynarayan Babu would say habits are evidence.”

The square layer of lime was cut from the edges. Behind it came brick, and behind the brick, a hollow sound. The bricks were removed one by one. A dark recess opened. No air came from it, only stale dampness. Light was directed inside.

The hollow was almost exactly the size Abhiram had estimated. Inside lay a small tin box, a piece of cloth half-stuck with damp, and two or three dried leaves. There was no bundle of documents.

Madhavi's heart struck hard. “Empty?”

Jaynarayan said, “Say only what you see.”

The box was photographed before it was removed. Then a gloved officer lifted it out. The lid was rusted but opened. Inside were half of a folded sheet of paper and a thin knot of blue thread.

Madhavi could not speak. At the memory of the dream, her palm went cold. Abhiram looked first not at the thread but at the paper. “The blue colour may be old, but colour alone cannot date it.” His voice was deliberately flat.

Jaynarayan looked at Madhavi's face. “The dream?”

Madhavi nodded.

“Keep it in mind. In the written statement, dream separately; recovered object separately.”

The paper was not opened immediately; first its exterior was photographed. Its edge was not freshly torn, but broken from age. On one side, inked letters were visible—old writing mixed with Maithili, some words unclear. Once it had been placed in a protective sleeve, they tried to read from the photographs.

From the visible section they could make out only this much: “...if the paper does not reach the court...” Two lines after that were blurred. Then: “...as necessary as the first six signs...” and the page broke at that point. The following portion was missing.

Holding her breath, Madhavi read, “The first six signs.”

Abhiram said, “Then the seventh may be whatever came next. But that is inference.”

Jaynarayan's eyes brightened, yet instead of agreeing he said, "Do not write the inference. We have half a letter. Filling in the missing half with our own intelligence is the most dangerous thing we can do."

The sentence struck Madhavi as if it had been directed at her. Dreams were filling empty spaces. Sutra filled empty spaces in data with probabilities. Human beings filled them with stories. Both needed boundaries.

"The thread?" she asked.

Jaynarayan said, "Pack it separately. Fibre, dye, age—as much testing as is possible. But do not assume it is from 1934 merely because that is the story we are investigating."

Abhiram looked at Madhavi. This time there was no victorious logic in his gaze, only caution. "Sutra's database has very few samples of old document-binding materials. If it looks at this thing and speaks with too much confidence, the first thing I will question is its confidence."

Madhavi laughed. "Today you sounded like a human being."

"And today you sounded like data."

"A draw?"

"For now."

Gopal was staring into the hollow. “My father used to say the women of this house hid letters in this wall. I thought it was a joke.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Your father's name? Approximate dates, if you remember?”

Gopal laughed. “See? The moment I tell a story, he asks for paper.”

“Not to insult the story. I am only looking for where its feet touch the ground.”

Outside, evening light was falling upon the leaves. Though the hollow had been opened, much inside it remained closed. No document. No definite fate for Kusuma. Only half a letter and a blue thread—two objects that enlarged the questions instead of answering them.

Madhavi came out into the courtyard. Abhiram followed. For a few moments both were silent. The wind carried the smell that comes before rain.

“Did you truly see blue thread in the dream?” Abhiram asked.

“Yes.”

“Could you have seen it somewhere before?”

“Perhaps. In the binding of the ledger, on someone's clothes, in childhood. The mind stores everything.”

“I wasn't expecting that answer from you.”

“Neither was I.”

Abhiram seemed about to say something, then stopped. His hand came almost close enough to touch Madhavi's, but did not. Madhavi felt that unfinished distance. The mystery was drawing them closer and making them cautious at the same time.

Suddenly Jaynarayan called from inside, “Abhiram! Search Sutra for the repair records of the old building. If we can find which year this recess was sealed, it will narrow the possible date of the letter.”

Abhiram answered, “Right away.” Then he said quietly to Madhavi, “See? Whenever there is time for romance, a record always arrives for him.”

Madhavi's cheeks grew warm. “What romance?”

“All right. Records.”

He ran inside. Madhavi followed, smiling.

That night Sutra returned its first match: repairs to the mansion's western wall were recorded between 1935 and 1937, but the contractor's complete ledger was unavailable. The system offered three possible dates, with medium confidence. Above the result, Abhiram wrote in bold: “This is a date range, not a verified date.”

Jaynarayan read it and nodded with satisfaction. “The machine is becoming polite.”

Abhiram said, “Not the machine. The operator is becoming afraid.”

“Fear is sometimes the first step toward wisdom.”

Madhavi kept looking at the digital image of the half-letter. “As necessary as the first six signs...” The sentence broke at precisely the place where perhaps the most important word would have begun. The blue thread lay in a separate transparent evidence pouch—small, ordinary, almost trivial. Yet to her it looked like a piece of that night's dream.

She stopped herself: dream separately, object separately.

Then an automatic note appeared in one corner of Sutra's screen: “Reliability of any conclusion concerning ‘seventh’ on the basis of incomplete text: extremely low.”

Madhavi read it and laughed. “This time I agree.”

From a distance Jaynarayan asked, “With whom?”

“With Sutra.”

“So this day had to come too.”

All three laughed. But when the laughter ended, the image of the half-letter remained in the room. Half a sentence, half a history, half a love, half the evidence.

And inside the opened wall of the old mansion, where the tin box may have remained in darkness for ninety

years, air touched it directly for the first time. From a distance the loose iron of the ventilator chimed once more.

Abhiram said, “Wind.”

This time Madhavi did not argue.

But her palm closed by itself—as though she were still holding the invisible end of a blue thread.

Chapter 19 — Two Lines on the Palm

The blue thread recovered from the hollow in the wall was sent to the laboratory, the half-letter was placed in a protective sleeve, and the room in the old mansion was sealed again. But Madhavi's mind could not be sealed. She slept that night and had no dream; even so, when she woke at dawn, the first thing she looked at was her own palm.

There was no white dust. Only the old lines—crossing one another, curving, then disappearing somewhere. She laughed to herself. “Now even my hand has questions?”

Her mother was sitting beside the sewing machine. Threading a needle, she said, “If your hand is asking something, go to Ambika Kaki. Mine is being asked by three blouses and two petticoats when they are going to be finished.”

Madhavi looked at her. “Do you believe in it too?”

“In what?”

“Palms, constellations, signs.”

Her mother pushed her spectacles up onto her forehead. “I believe Ambika Kaki can understand half a matter just by looking at a person's face. Whether the other half is written on the hand or the person tells it herself—I don't know.”

Madhavi liked the answer. Neither complete faith nor complete ridicule. Just then the phone rang. It was Abhiram.

“Nothing has come from the laboratory yet,” he said, “but Jaynarayan Babu has said we should not extend any inference from what was found yesterday. Where are you now?”

“At home.”

“Aren't you coming to the records room today?” Abhiram asked.

“I'll go to Ambika Kaki first.”

There was a moment's silence at the other end. “Why?”

“To have my palm read.”

Abhiram suppressed his laughter, but Madhavi heard it. “Did you laugh?”

“No. I coughed.”

“Since when is coughing so joyful?”

“Take me with you. I'll cough scientifically.”

Madhavi ended the call, but a smile had reached her face. Half an hour later, Abhiram was indeed standing in the lane outside her house—not astride his motorcycle, but pushing an old bicycle. After the rain, the road was so muddy that feet were more reliable than wheels.

Ambika Kaki's house stood east of the pond, behind a clump of bamboo. At the doorway was a tulsi altar, an old wooden stool, and on the veranda, makhana shells drying in the sun. Ambika Kaki was rubbing oil into a teenage girl's hair. The moment she saw Madhavi she said, "You've made your eyes red reading that ledger, and now you've come to have your palm read?"

Abhiram whispered, "The intelligence network got here first."

Madhavi elbowed him. Ambika Kaki saw it but said nothing. When the girl had gone, she seated the two of them on the low wooden stool.

"First tell me," Kaki said, looking at Madhavi's face instead of taking her hand, "why do you want your palm read?"

"Just... to know."

"Know what?"

"These dreams... and everything that's happening..."

"If dreams were written on the hand, the poor pillow would become useless." Ambika Kaki laughed. Abhiram turned his face away. Madhavi glared at him.

Now Kaki took her hand. Her fingers were not cold; they were warm. She did not trace the lines with her nail, only opened the palm and tilted it toward the light. "Are you looking for death in this hand?"

Madhavi started. "Did I say that?"

"No. But when a girl looks three times at the veins in her wrist and then at me, her question is not usually about the date of her marriage."

This time Abhiram's laughter truly escaped him. "Kaki, that's data-based—"

"Be quiet," Madhavi said sharply.

Ambika Kaki looked at Abhiram. "Your palm later. First straighten the lines on your face."

Abhiram fell silent.

Kaki stopped her finger near two lines on Madhavi's palm. "Look here. People would say: one life, one fate. I don't say that. To me these are two paths. They come close at one point, then separate, then farther ahead cross one another. Your present condition looks something like this to me—love caught between two truths."

"Love?" Madhavi almost pulled her hand away.

Abhiram cleared his throat again.

"Go outside and cough," Madhavi said.

Ambika Kaki did not release her hand. "Why so much anger the moment you hear the word love? Love is not only between a boy and a girl. Love for a teacher, for the dead, for justice, for one's own beliefs. Sometimes we

love the truth we have already accepted more than truth itself.”

Madhavi's anger loosened slightly. Her mind went to Vasudha—the conviction that Vasudha could not have taken her own life. Was that conviction love or evidence? Then to Abhiram—the belief that he would always side with data. Was that too merely a story she had made about him?

“Two truths?” she asked softly.

“One is what the eyes see. The other is what the mind has already decided to believe. When love is trapped between the two, a person is not reading the hand; she is reading her own judgment.”

Abhiram was no longer laughing. “Kaki, did you understand that from the palm or from talking to Madhavi?”

Ambika Kaki looked at him directly. “If you give a computer the behaviour of ten thousand people, it will estimate the next behaviour. For seventy years I have watched people's faces, households, births, deaths, quarrels, reconciliations. I make mistakes too. But to mock experience as magic and worship data as science—both are foolishness.”

Abhiram's face grew serious. “I could write that down.”

“Don't write it. Understand it first.”

For a moment silence spread across the veranda. Bamboo leaves rubbed against one another.

Madhavi asked, “Can you remember anything about blue thread? Was there an old custom of tying letters with it in households?”

For a moment Ambika Kaki's eyes went far away. “Blue thread was used for many things—binding ledgers, tying it on a child's wrist, marking cattle, tying bundles of cloth. Do not build a story from colour alone. Ask Rahmat; his hands know old bindings better.”

“Kusuma?”

Kaki did not answer immediately. “I have heard the name. I have heard many stories. But keep story and record separate. When the right time comes, I will tell you what I remember.”

Abhiram whispered, “The right time again.”

“Must you have everything immediately?” Ambika Kaki asked. “Have you forgotten how to wait from living with machines?”

Abhiram smiled. “Possibly.”

Madhavi turned her own hand and looked at it. She could see nothing extraordinary now in those two lines. Yet Kaki's phrase—love caught between two truths—remained caught in her ear.

As soon as they stepped outside, Abhiram said, “All I’ll say is that there are many lines on a palm. You can make as many stories from them as you want.”

Madhavi stopped. “Why did you fall silent inside?”

“When?”

“When Kaki spoke about experience as data.”

“Because she wasn’t wrong.”

“Then why were you laughing?”

Abhiram stood with one hand on the bicycle handle. “When you said you were going to have your palm read, I thought you were looking for a way to prove yesterday’s blue thread supernatural. I... perhaps—”

Madhavi cut him off. “Perhaps you had already made up your mind.”

Abhiram laughed. “Fine. Perhaps I had already made up my mind.”

“Like Sutra?”

“So far Sutra hasn’t learned that fault from me.”

“Don’t worry. It will.”

They started walking. At one place beside the pond there was more mud than elsewhere. Madhavi’s foot slipped; Abhiram caught her wrist. The moment was very short, but before their hands separated they looked

into each other's eyes. Ambika Kaki's words came unwanted into Madhavi's mind. She immediately pulled her hand away.

“I can walk by myself.”

“I only kept you from falling.”

“I wasn't falling.”

“The data says—”

“Throw the data into the pond.”

Abhiram burst out laughing. This time Madhavi laughed too, though somewhere inside a faint unease remained.

When they reached the records room, Jaynarayan was already there. On the table lay the laboratory slip for the blue thread, a high-resolution image of the half-letter, and the Seven Hamlets list from Vasudha's case. The moment he saw them, he asked, “What did the palm say?”

Madhavi stopped short. “Who told you?”

“Ambika called me earlier asking for Rahmat's number. When I asked why, she said, ‘The youngsters have left history behind and reached the palm.’”

Abhiram laughed loudly. Madhavi pulled out a chair and sat down. “Everyone is conspiring against me.”

Jaynarayan smiled, then grew serious and pushed a paper toward them. “You’ve arrived at the right time. Sutra has produced a new connection. Cash withdrawals linked to Dulari’s name, the movements of a shared phone, and two locations across the river. The system has moved her upward into the category of principal suspect.”

Madhavi’s laughter stopped at once. “Dulari?”

Abhiram moved toward the screen. “I haven’t seen the whole result yet.”

Jaynarayan stopped him. “First remember this: whether a line is on the palm or on a screen, its meaning does not emerge by itself. Without context, both can deceive.”

Ambika Kaki’s veranda, the two lines, Abhiram’s laughter—all of it receded in an instant. A red indicator was flashing on the screen.

‘PRIMARY SUSPECT: DULARI SADAI.’

Madhavi’s palm closed involuntarily. This time she did not remember the blue thread. She remembered Dulari’s frightened face.

Chapter 20 — Sutra's First Error

Abhiram sat before the screen, but did not immediately open and read the result. His habit was to examine the raw data first and the system's conclusion afterward. Jaynarayan liked that habit. Today's result was serious. The words “primary suspect” could change the course of a person's life.

Sutra's summary had four points. In the two days before Vasudha's death, three cash withdrawals had been made from Dulari's bank account. A telephone number that had been active near Vasudha's records room was the same number entered as the contact number on Dulari's legal-aid form. At half past ten that night, the number appeared on a tower in the southern part of the town; toward dawn, on a tower on the western bank of the river; and the following day, in a cluster across the river. Third: shortly before Vasudha's death, a small amount had entered Dulari's wage account from an unknown account. Fourth: Dulari had disappeared.

The system had combined these facts and raised its probability score.

Looking at the screen, Madhavi said, “Is withdrawing cash three times a crime?”

Abhiram said, “No. But unusual transactions before a disappearance increase risk in the model.”

“Unusual for whom?” Jaynarayan asked.

Abhiram paused before answering. “Against Dulari's pattern over the previous six months.”

“Are those six months the normal pattern of her life?”

“That is all the available data.”

“Then say ‘available’. Not ‘normal’.”

Abhiram nodded. On the system panel he added a note: ‘Baseline period limited.’

Jaynarayan placed a finger on the first withdrawal. “Location?”

“A customer-service point near the bus stand.”

“Did Dulari herself go there?”

“The transaction was from her account.”

“That was not my question.”

Abhiram fell silent.

Jaynarayan telephoned Vinay Thakur. “Has the operator at the centre where Dulari's bank withdrawals were made been questioned?”

Vinay said, “It's on the list. Today—”

“Today.” Jaynarayan corrected him gently. “I am going myself. Send a police officer as well, but this time

do not tell the operator the machine's conclusion first. Let us hear his memory before we give it a story.”

The three of them went to the bus stand. The tiny room called the customer-service centre was squeezed between a paan shop and a pharmacy. Inside, Harinarayan Mahato sat with a laptop, a biometric device, and a small box of cash. Jaynarayan casually mentioned the date.

Harinarayan frowned. “Dulari? Yes, her account is handled here. But hearing that there were three withdrawals makes it sound more suspicious than it was. One day her mother came.”

“Her mother, withdrawing from her daughter's account?” Madhavi asked.

“Dulari was with her the first time. She withdrew five thousand. Two hours later they came back—the mother said the chemist wanted the full amount in cash, and what remained was not enough. Was Dulari here that second time or not...” He scratched his head. “She may have come with a neighbour. The machine requires the account-holder's thumbprint. Yes, Dulari must have come, but the money was for her mother.”

“The third?”

“The third withdrawal was small—eight hundred. Payments for several people had been delayed that day. Perhaps Dulari's wages arrived and she withdrew them.”

Abhiram asked, “Do you keep receipts?”

“There are digital records. We also have a camera, but the footage deletes itself after thirty days. Is the date old?”

When he heard the date, he shook his head in disappointment. The visual record was gone. But the assumption that the withdrawals were ‘unusual’ had weakened. In a poor household, a bank entry does not say whose medicine, whose food, or whose debt the money eventually paid for.

Outside, Jaynarayan said, “Now the telephone.”

The number on the legal-aid form was registered in the name of Rahima Khatoon, who lived two houses away from Dulari in the same settlement. When they reached Rahima's home, they realised the phone did not belong to one household so much as to the lane itself—a small shared utility. Rahima's husband worked away from home, her son was in school, her daughter-in-law did sewing work, and four neighbouring families used the number in emergencies.

Rahima said, “Where would Dulari get a phone of her own? Sometimes she borrowed mine to call Vasudha Didi. She had also written my number on the night-school form.”

“Who had the phone on the night of the murder?” Jaynarayan asked.

Rahima called her son Shamsheer. The seventeen-year-old came in. "That night I went across the ghat to my cousin's place to watch football," he said. "The phone was in my pocket. It got late, so I slept there."

Abhiram's face changed. "The tower across the river..."

Shamsheer said, "The boats weren't running in the morning because of the rain. I went westward and came back by the bridge."

The tower sequence rebuilt itself in Abhiram's mind like the red line on the screen—town, western bank, across the river. The system had treated this movement as Dulari's journey because the number appeared on Dulari's form. The reality: the phone had been in Shamsheer's pocket.

There was anger in Madhavi's voice. "So Sutra lied?"

Abhiram answered at once, "It didn't lie. It made the wrong association. The identity rule it was given binds a number too strongly to a person."

Jaynarayan said, "A machine has no intention to lie. But a false assumption can do as much harm in its result as a human lie."

"I'll have to change that rule," Abhiram murmured.

"First write down why confidence in this result has fallen. Do not hide the error."

Abhiram nodded. He was proud of his system; for the first time that pride had been bruised. Madhavi watched his face. Yesterday at Ambika Kaki's house he had laughed at the lines on a palm; today a line on his own screen had silenced him. Madhavi could have mocked him, but did not.

The third point—the small payment from an unknown account—also took on a different meaning when checked. The amount was twelve hundred rupees. The sender's name had been abbreviated, so the model had classified it as unfamiliar. The bank branch confirmed that the money was a small allowance paid by the Seven Hamlets Legal Aid Committee for witnesses' travel and the cost of copying documents. Dulari was not alone; nine people had received the same amount that week.

Back at the office, Abhiram opened Sutra's panel. "One flaw in my system is clear. It assumes 'one person—one phone—one financial pattern'. Shared devices, cash-based lives, pooled family expenses—these are underrepresented."

Jaynarayan leaned back in his chair. "Poverty leaves more blank spaces on paper. A machine can read easily the life in which every act leaves a receipt. But a person who shares one phone among five households, takes wages in cash, or buys a ticket through a neighbour's account can look suspicious to a machine if the rules are not careful."

Madhavi said, “Human beings do the same thing. Dulari is missing, poor, and went to Vasudha at night—people immediately decided she must be guilty.”

“Exactly,” Jaynarayan said. “So when we discover a machine's error, human beings must not declare themselves innocent. Bias can live in two places—in code and in the head.”

Abhiram added a new note: ‘Suspicion score reassessed. Telephone ownership unstable. Cash withdrawals for family purposes. Assistance payment legitimate.’ The red indicator turned yellow, and Dulari moved down from the primary-suspect list.

“Will the history of this change be preserved?” Jaynarayan asked.

“Completely. The old result will not be deleted. The reason for the change will remain too.”

“Then it is useful.”

Abhiram let out a small breath of relief. “Sutra can admit an error.”

Madhavi said, “Sutra, or you?”

“Both.”

Madhavi laughed. “Good. If Ambika Kaki hears, she'll say your palm is improving.”

Abhiram pulled a face. “The palm again!”

At that moment Kamli Devi came in carrying tea. Jaynarayan's without sugar, Madhavi's with half a spoon, Abhiram's with two. Without asking, Kamli placed each cup in the correct hand.

Looking at his cup, Jaynarayan smiled. "See? Kamli's database."

Kamli asked, "What?"

"Nothing. You remember all our habits."

"What's remarkable about that? I see you every day."

Abhiram stopped with the cup in his hand. "I see you every day"—Ambika Kaki had said almost the same thing.

After Kamli left, Abhiram asked, "Jaynarayan Babu, if habits matter so much, does Dulari have a habit that matters?"

"I have been working on that question since yesterday. When Dulari returned home from night school, she never took the main road, because two boys in the market harassed her. She went around behind the pond. When she visited Vasudha at night, she usually returned with someone. On the night of the murder she went alone. That is a break in habit. But fear could explain it. Compulsion could explain it too."

Madhavi asked, "Did she return?"

"That is still the question."

Abhiram opened the possible routes for that night on the screen. “If Rahima's phone was not with Dulari, then we have zero movement for her.”

“Not zero,” Jaynarayan said. “Unknown.”

Abhiram changed the note again: ‘Location: unknown.’

Jaynarayan said with satisfaction, “Writing ‘unknown’ is also part of knowledge.”

The afternoon was declining. Madhavi gathered the copy of the constellation ledger. “Then what do we actually know about Dulari now?”

Jaynarayan weighed each word. “She came to meet Vasudha. After that, she disappeared. She had no phone of her own. She was afraid. And so far there is no solid evidence that she killed Vasudha.”

“And no evidence that she is alive,” Madhavi said quietly.

The room fell silent.

New results were appearing on the screen before Abhiram—Dulari's old aid form, night-school attendance, the courthouse entry register, the witness list in the Seven Hamlets case. Suddenly the system surfaced an old handwritten note. Beside Dulari's name, Vasudha had written in her own hand: “Contact not secure. Speak only face to face.”

A shiver ran through Madhavi. “Didi knew already.”

Jaynarayan looked at the note. “At least this much she knew: Dulari's means of contact could not be trusted.”

Abhiram said in frustration, “If this note had been in the structured data from the beginning...”

“Then the error would have been smaller,” Jaynarayan said. “But life does not arrive pre-structured. Investigation means understanding it, not forcing it into a frame.”

A little before evening, Madhavi rose to go home. Just then her phone vibrated. Unknown number. First, a blank message. Immediately after it, an audio clip. Duration—seven seconds.

Madhavi's hand stopped. “Someone has sent a voice recording.”

Abhiram came to her side. Jaynarayan stood up.

Madhavi played the clip. First came wind, then the faint slap of distant water, then someone's suppressed breathing. After that, the trembling voice of a young woman—

“I haven't run away...”

The recording cut off.

Madhavi's face went pale. “That's Dulari.”

Chapter 21 — Dulari's Voice

The seven-second recording was played again.

Wind. The faint slap of water. Suppressed breathing. Then—"I haven't run away..."

Madhavi had not the slightest doubt that the voice was Dulari's. She had heard it many times in Vasudha's office—soft, slightly nasal, dropping lower at the end of a sentence. But Jaynarayan said immediately, "Recognising it is one thing. Verifying it is another."

Madhavi grew restless. "I know Dulari."

"I do not doubt you. I am protecting the chain. Preserve the device on which the original message arrived, the time, the number, the audio clip—everything."

Abhiram told Madhavi not to switch off the phone. "Don't forward the message. I'm taking screenshots and timestamps. The police will need to inspect the original device."

Vinay Thakur arrived within fifteen minutes. They immediately called the unknown number—it was switched off. The message had not come through ordinary telecom messaging but through an internet-based messaging service. Vinay arranged, through the proper legal process, to send requests to the service provider and the telecom operator.

“For now, assume only that an unknown person has sent an audio clip that sounds like Dulari,” he said. “We should neither rush across the river at once nor assume it is a prank.”

Madhavi was agitated. “What if she's in danger?”

Jaynarayan put a hand on her shoulder. “That is why we will not delay. But if we run to the wrong place, we lose time reaching the right one.”

Abhiram worked only on a copy of the audio, leaving the original untouched. He carried out a basic attempt to separate the background sounds. “Strong wind. Close to a water surface. There's also a metallic tap-tap—it could be a boat chain, but that's inference.”

Jaynarayan said, “Write it as inference. Not conclusion.”

“Yes.”

Madhavi closed her eyes and listened again. “Is there someone else's voice in the background?”

Abhiram slowed the audio. In the final half-second there really was an indistinct sound—human or bird, impossible to say. Sutra's voice-matching was run, but the result was weak.

‘SPEAKER IDENTIFICATION: INSUFFICIENT SAMPLE.’

Reading the screen, Madhavi said, “At least this time it isn't pretending to be certain.”

Abhiram smiled faintly. "I've lowered its confidence threshold."

"A benefit of making a mistake," Jaynarayan said.

At nine that night the first network information arrived. The unknown number was attached to a newly activated prepaid identity, only two days old. Whether the registration papers were genuine or stolen was still being checked. At the time the message was sent, the device had been active within a cluster of towers across the river. The coverage area was large, including several villages, river islands, ghats, and fields.

Abhiram opened the map. The river ran like a blue strip through the middle. The town lay to the west; to the east-southeast, three towers formed a triangle. The possible area was shown not in red, but as a pale yellow ring.

"This is not a precise location," he said before anyone else could. "Only a broad area."

Jaynarayan nodded with satisfaction. "You're learning."

Vinay said, "The boats stop at night. Going around by the bridge will take three hours. One police team is leaving by road. A second will go from the ghat at dawn."

Madhavi said at once, "I'll go."

"No," Vinay said.

“Dulari knows me. She may hide if she sees the police.”

“You are a student, not an investigation team.”

Madhavi's voice hardened. “She used to see me with Vasudha Didi. If she's frightened, she may need a familiar face.”

Jaynarayan intervened. “Not tonight. We'll see the situation at dawn. If the river route is safe, we'll consider it.”

Madhavi wanted to protest, but Jaynarayan's “we'll consider it” was not an absolute refusal. She fell silent.

That night, back at home, Madhavi could not sleep. The seven seconds kept sounding in her ears. “I haven't run away.” How much accusation lay inside that sentence—against everyone who had decided, without listening, that Dulari had run away. Against Madhavi too. How many times had she herself thought, ‘Where did she run to?’ rather than ‘Where did she go?’ Words carry prejudice too.

Her mother asked, “Did you find anything?”

Madhavi said only, “Dulari may be alive.”

Her mother stopped folding the sewing cloth in her hands. “Then has her mother been told?”

“The police will tell her. Nothing is certain yet.”

“Until it becomes certain, how is a mother supposed to pass the night?”

Madhavi had no answer. Investigative caution and a household's anguish run on different clocks. One asks for proof; the other asks for one word.

At four in the morning Vinay sent a message: the unknown number had become active again for an instant, this time near the southern tower across the river. No new message had been sent. The road team had checked one village and found nothing. The current at the ghat was strong, but boats might begin running once daylight grew.

At five Madhavi reached the courthouse tea stall. Kamli Devi was lighting the stove. “So early?”

“I couldn't sleep.”

Without asking, Kamli put tea on the boil. “If you can't sleep, staying hungry is worse. Here.”

Jaynarayan arrived a little later. In his hand was a paper map, not a mobile phone. “A screen cannot tell you the smell of a river,” he said, opening the map.

Abhiram came running, dark circles under his eyes. “Sutra has given three possible routes—the main ghat, the old sand ghat, and the small herders' boat path to the south. But if we add last night's wind and current...”

“Where did you get the current data?” Jaynarayan asked.

“From the water-resources gauge and yesterday's information from a local boatman.”

“Good. Show the boatman's account separately and the official gauge separately. Don't merge both into one number.”

Abhiram laughed. “Will you ever let me build the model?”

“If it makes fewer mistakes, I'll consider it.”

As Kamli set down the tea, she asked, “Are you going across the river?”

Madhavi started. “How did you—”

“Two policemen were drinking tea here at dawn and talking about it. In a courthouse, secrecy is not a wall. It's a sieve.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Do you remember anyone Dulari knows across the river?”

Kamli thought for a moment. “Wasn't her mother's sister somewhere toward the boatmen's settlement? No, not an aunt... Her mother once said that during a flood, when Dulari was little, she stayed across the river for a few months. I've heard the name of an old woman—Phulmati.”

Madhavi asked immediately, “Which village?”

“I don't remember the name. Dulari sometimes said while drinking tea, ‘Nowhere is fish as tasty as Phulmati Dadi's.’”

Abhiram wrote it down. “This data existed nowhere.”

Kamli laughed. “Does the taste of fish count as data too?”

Jaynarayan said, “From today, it does.”

They decided to meet Dulari's mother along with the police. She had cried through the night. When Madhavi arrived, the woman first caught her hand and asked only, “Was the voice hers?”

Madhavi did not cross the boundary of truth. “It sounded like her to me. The verification is still going on.”

“She said she hadn't run away?”

Madhavi stared. “Who told you?”

“The settlement has heard.”

Again the same sieve. Privacy is difficult in poor settlements in a different way—ears are close, walls are thin, fear is shared.

At the name Phulmati, Dulari's mother nodded. “Yes. Phulmati is a distant relation from my maternal side. In the flood year Dulari was little and stayed there. The

village—Baraila Diara. But whether Phulmati is still alive, I haven't heard in many years.”

Abhiram looked at the map. Baraila Diara lay within the same tower triangle.

Jaynarayan warned them immediately. “We have found a match, but that does not mean Dulari is there. The tower area is large.”

Madhavi said, “But at least we have one path to search.”

“Yes.”

By noon, the police road team was trying to reach Baraila, but the dirt road had been cut by the night's rain. Boats were running from the main ghat, though the wind was strong. A local boatman said they could cross before evening, but there was a risk of a storm later. Vinay did not want to permit Madhavi to go, but Dulari's mother herself said, “If Madhavi goes, Dulari may come out. If she sees the police, she may hide again.”

Finally the arrangement was made: one female police constable, a local boatman, Jaynarayan, Madhavi, and Abhiram. Vinay would coordinate from the road. Jaynarayan laid down one clear condition: “No private heroics. Whatever I say, you follow.”

Madhavi said “yes” immediately. Abhiram did so after a short pause.

“Why were you thinking?” Madhavi asked.

“Because when he said ‘private heroics’, you looked at me.”

“Because you’ll start calculating the river current by staring at a screen.”

“And you’ll jump into the river because of a dream.”

Jaynarayan glared at both of them. “Already?”

Both fell silent.

When they reached the ghat before evening, the river was grey. Dark clouds had gathered far across the sky. The boatman, Bhola Sahni, tightened a rope and said, “We can cross now. In an hour or an hour and a half the wind may turn.”

Abhiram checked the map on his phone. The unknown number had last been active two hours earlier—in the tower sector north of Baraila. Then it had gone silent again.

Before stepping into the boat, Madhavi looked at the river. The pond of her dreams was nothing like this vast water, yet the red dupatta, the anklet, and the blue thread stirred together in one corner of her mind. She told herself: dream separately, fact separately.

Then Abhiram’s hand came forward. “The plank is slippery.”

Madhavi looked at his hand for one moment, then took it and stepped into the boat.

Abhiram did not smile. He only let go of her hand.

The boat left the bank. The sounds of the town began to fall away behind them. Ahead lay the river islands, tall grass, grey water, and black clouds. Dulari's seven-second voice sounded again inside Madhavi: "I haven't run away."

Jaynarayan watched the current. Abhiram closed the map and put the phone in his pocket.

Bhola Sahni looked up at the sky and said quietly, "The sooner we reach, the better. The clouds are moving badly."

The boat moved toward midstream.

Chapter 22 — Night on the Boat

The moment the boat reached midstream, the wind changed its course. Bhola Sahni looked first at the sky, then at the water. Abhiram began to open his phone, but Bhola stopped him with a hand. “Look at the river first, Babu. The map can come later.”

Abhiram put the phone back in his pocket. An unwilling smile came to Madhavi's face. Jaynarayan noticed. “Today every teacher seems to have found Abhiram.”

“I register my protest,” Abhiram said.

“Put it in writing,” Jaynarayan replied.

The brief moment of joking ended at once. To the east, black clouds had stooped low. First small ripples ran over the surface of the river, then long dark bands. Bhola reduced the engine speed. The woman constable pulled the rope lying in the middle of the boat closer to herself.

“Will we go straight to Baraila?” Madhavi asked.

Bhola shook his head. “Straight ahead is worse now. The current is cutting to the right. First we'll take shelter behind the sandbar.”

Madhavi grew impatient. “Dulari may be there.”

Jaynarayan looked at her. "If we get trapped in the water, who will reach Dulari?"

Madhavi fell silent. She knew he was right, but a correct answer does not always quiet the mind at once. The seven-second voice sounded inside her again—"I haven't run away."

The first heavy drop struck Abhiram's cheek. The second landed on Madhavi's hand. Within a minute a curtain of water had fallen. Instead of keeping the rain out, the boat's small canopy seemed to gather its sound into one place. Bent over at the bow, Bhola Sahni worked the oar to hold their direction. The engine coughed.

Abhiram leaned back at once. "What happened?"

"A root of kans grass, perhaps, or water hyacinth caught in it." Bhola switched off the engine. "Don't worry. The current is carrying us toward the sandbar for now. We only have to keep the boat from turning broadside."

Even after hearing 'don't worry', Madhavi's fingers gripped the sideboard of the boat. Water suddenly seems vast when one's movement is no longer in one's own hands. The town ghat was now blurred behind them; ahead, the diara was dark.

Abhiram looked at her hand. "Afraid?"

"No."

“Your fingers are digging into the plank.”

Madhavi loosened her grip. “You look at your data.”

“The data is getting wet too.”

A fierce gust lifted the boat's canopy. Abhiram reached up and caught a bamboo pole. Madhavi's dupatta blew across her face. As she tried to control it, the boat tilted once to the left and her body struck Abhiram's shoulder. Instinctively, he caught her arm. This time Madhavi did not immediately pull away.

Bhola shouted, “Everyone sit low!”

They all crouched into the bottom of the boat. Rain, the engine's coughing, the slap of water—together they made a noise so dense that one person's breathing could not be heard by another. Yet Madhavi could clearly feel Abhiram's grip on her wrist. It was not hard, only steady. Once the boat righted itself, his hand slowly withdrew.

“I wasn't falling,” Madhavi said.

Abhiram smiled. “I've heard that sentence before.”

“It was true this time too.”

“Between two truths?”

Madhavi glared at him, but even in the rain her face grew warm. Ambika Kaki's sentence had followed them onto the river.

About twenty minutes later the boat seemed to catch in shallower water beside the sandbar and came to a stop. Bhola climbed down into water up to his knees and pulled the kans grass from the engine propeller. The sky had grown so dark that night appeared to have descended before evening.

“It isn't wise to push on to Baraila now,” Bhola said. “There is an old fisherman's shelter ahead. Cross the sandbar and wait there for an hour or two. If the wind settles, we'll go on.”

The woman constable tried to telephone Vinay. The signal kept breaking. At last a short message went through: team safe, halted on sandbar.

Everyone got out of the boat and walked through sand, mud, and kans grass. The shelter was really only four bamboo posts, a crooked tin roof, and a thatch wall on one side. Inside lay old nets, two earthen water pots, and a broken cot. But as protection from the rain, it was no less than a palace.

As soon as they entered, Jaynarayan looked around. “Does it seem anyone has stayed here recently?”

Bhola looked at a half-charred piece of wood lying in one corner. “Boatmen stop here during the day. Rarely at night.”

Madhavi's eyes went at once to a small heap of ash. “Burned paper?”

Jaynarayan crouched to look. “Don't touch it yet.”

Abhiram lowered the light from his phone. In the ash were fish bones, a bidi stub, and the blackened edge of paper. The moment Jaynarayan saw it he said, “We have no reason to assume this came from the courthouse. It could just as easily be newspaper used to wrap fish.”

Madhavi did not laugh. Since Vasudha's death, her mind had begun searching for a story in every burned scrap of paper. Jaynarayan had read that in her.

“Not everything is a sign,” he said gently. “Sometimes ash is only ash.”

The rain remained fierce. The wind kept trying to lift the tin roof. Bhola went outside to lash the bamboo tighter with rope. Jaynarayan and the woman constable sat near the entrance, watching the way outside. Madhavi and Abhiram stayed near the back wall, with a heap of fishing nets between them.

To save the phone batteries, all devices were switched off. The darkness was not complete—whenever lightning flashed, every bamboo pole, net, and face in the shelter turned white for a moment and then disappeared again.

Madhavi asked quietly, “Are you truly not afraid of water?”

Abhiram was silent for a while. “I am.”

Madhavi turned toward him. “But all this time you—”

“Looking at data and not feeling fear are not the same thing. I don't know how to swim well in deep water.”

“Then why did you get into the boat?”

“You were getting into it.”

The sentence was short. The rain outside was so loud that Madhavi could have pretended she had not heard it properly. But she had.

Abhiram immediately added, “And there was investigative work to do.”

Madhavi said softly, “Did the second sentence come to rescue the first?”

“Possibly.”

“That Hindi-flavoured word again.”

“Fine—it may be.”

Both laughed. Jaynarayan turned and looked back. “Is class in session even in a storm?”

“Language class,” Madhavi said.

Jaynarayan smiled and turned back toward the rain.

After a while, in the darkness, Abhiram spoke on his own. “I'm sorry I laughed at what Ambika Kaki said.”

Madhavi did not answer.

“Uncertainty makes me uncomfortable,” he continued. “If something can't be measured, I dismiss it with a joke. That isn't right.”

Madhavi listened to the rain striking the tin. “I do the opposite. When I can't find meaning, I give something a meaning in my own mind. Dreams, thread, anklets. It may be—” She stopped herself. “It may be because I cannot bear Didi's death to feel meaningless.”

“Meaning and cause are different things,” Abhiram said.

“I know.”

“But...” He paused. “If you believe in dreams, I do not have the right to laugh at you. I do have the right to question them.”

Madhavi said quietly, “And even when I get angry at your screen, I shouldn't stop looking at what the screen says.”

“A compromise?”

“No. A condition.”

“What?”

“You will not think me a fool. I will not think you a stone.”

Lightning flashed. For one instant both faces were clear. There was no laughter in Abhiram's eyes. "Agreed."

Madhavi held out her hand. Abhiram laughed and shook it. But the handshake lasted one breath longer than expected. They let go at the same moment.

At that instant the phone gave a faint sound. Abhiram opened it at once. The unknown number had become active three minutes earlier—in the tower sector north of Baraila. No message had been sent.

"Send it to Vinay," Jaynarayan said. "And no chasing from here. Night, storm, an unfamiliar sandbar—against those three, heroics become stupidity."

Madhavi did not object. She was beginning to understand that searching for Dulari was not only about running toward her; one also had to arrive alive.

The night grew long. At times the rain weakened, then became fierce again. Bhola went outside from time to time to check the ropes. The woman constable dozed near the entrance with a torch in her hand, but opened her eyes at every sound. Jaynarayan sat silent on half the cot, his back against the wall. No one could tell whether he slept.

Madhavi closed her eyes, but sleep stayed far away. Every metallic knock on the tin roof sounded to her like the anklet in her dream. Once she truly started awake.

“What happened?” Abhiram whispered.

“Nothing.”

“The anklet?”

Madhavi looked at him. “Are you making fun of me?”

“No. Your face told me.”

“It was the tin.”

“Yes.”

“I know.”

“Yes.”

There was no ridicule in that ‘yes’. Some of the tension inside Madhavi loosened.

The first light of dawn came before the rain had fully stopped. The sky was still grey, but the wind had weakened. Bhola opened the engine and cleaned it again. At seven the party set out toward Baraila Diara. This time the boat kept to the shallower belt near the bank.

Baraila was not a permanent village so much as a settlement that expanded and shrank with the seasons. Houses raised on bamboo posts, nets, mats on which fish were drying, children's bare feet on the sand. At the sight of the police, people first stood at a distance. Madhavi asked for Phulmati.

An old boatman said, “Phulmati? The old woman stays now with her daughter on the North Char. When the rains rise, she doesn't stay here.”

“Where is the North Char?”

He pointed toward a pale stretch of sand far away between two channels of the river. “You can't get there without a boat. And the water is rising now.”

Madhavi described Dulari. The old man thought for a moment. “Two days ago a thin young woman came here. A gamchha over her head. She asked for Phulmati. I told her North Char. She was alone.”

“Which way did she go?” Jaynarayan asked.

“That I didn't see. It was evening. A woman from a boatman's family gave her water. Then I went off with my nets.”

Madhavi's heart began beating fast. The description was not enough, but the path had narrowed.

Abhiram took out his phone and began asking questions—time, place, whose house, the name of the boat. Jaynarayan looked at him once but did not stop him. This time local memory was moving alongside the questions.

Phulmati's exact location on the North Char was uncertain. The river was rising. Vinay's instruction arrived: the team should return for now; the local police

boat unit would separately check the houses on the North Char. Madhavi's face fell.

“We've come this close and now we're going back?”

Jaynarayan said, “An estimate of closeness can kill. The police boat is here. If Dulari is in that belt, the search area is now much smaller. We will come again.”

On the return journey, Madhavi and Abhiram sat facing one another. The darkness of the night had lifted, but what had become clear between them in the night was nameless again in daylight.

Abhiram said softly, “Last night you said you wouldn't think of me as a stone.”

“Yes.”

“And I wouldn't think of you as a fool.”

“Yes.”

“Does that condition still apply?”

Looking at the river, Madhavi said, “More than ever.”

Bhola Sahni turned the boat's bow toward the town. Behind them lay Baraila; beyond it, the North Char. Dulari had still not been found, but for the first time there was a concrete geography around her disappearance.

And inside Madhavi, around the fear, another shape had begun to form as well—not yet something she was ready to name, but now difficult to deny.

Chapter 23 — Not an Astrologer, a Chronicler

As soon as they returned to the town, Jaynarayan spoke of rest. But before noon, a message arrived from Ambika Kaki: “If you want to see not the almanac but the ledgers, come today. Tomorrow I am going to my granddaughter's house.”

Madhavi was exhausted. There was unfinished sleep in her eyes and the damp smell of the river still clung to her clothes. Even so, the moment she read the message, she sat up. Abhiram's reply had arrived before hers: “I'm on my way.”

Madhavi wrote, “Who invited you?”

The answer: “Data.”

Madhavi put down the phone and laughed. Her mother asked, “Did you find Dulari across the river?”

“No. But the road has narrowed.”

“If the road has narrowed, why is your heart heavier?”

Madhavi could not find an answer. Her worry about Dulari was one thing; Abhiram's words in the shelter the previous night were another. Both lived in the same mind, yet did not merge with one another.

Ambika Kaki's veranda was empty that day. The makhana shells had been gathered away. In the middle stood an old iron chest. As Kaki opened its lock, she said, "You all laughed a great deal when I read the palm. Now see what truly earned me my bad reputation."

Inside the chest were five thick ledgers, several thin notebooks, old almanacs, envelopes, and slips tied with thread. The ledger edges were worn, the pages yellow, the ink spread in many places.

Abhiram's eyes lit up. "How old are all these?"

"In the thickest ledger, the first page is in my father's hand. Later my mother wrote in it. I have been writing since I was a girl. They are not all kept in exactly the same way."

"What is written in them?" Madhavi asked.

Ambika Kaki opened the first ledger. "People used to come to have their birth horoscopes cast. I had to write the day, hour, and place of birth. Then they would return another time—someone married, a child was born, someone died, someone went away to another place. I thought, if everyone is going to tell me all this anyway, why not write it down?"

Across the pages were dates, names, villages, relationships, brief notes. In one place: "First son; heavy rain at the time of birth." Elsewhere: "Husband in Calcutta; not home for three years." Elsewhere: "Field

mortgaged; promise to repay debt in Kartik.” Elsewhere: “Two brothers, separate hearths.”

Madhavi stopped while turning a page. “You recorded quarrels too?”

“If a quarrel changes the course of a family, why not? To write the planets but not the fire in the house—what kind of incomplete astrology would that be?”

Abhiram did not laugh. He took out his phone, but asked permission before taking photographs. “May I make a digital copy while preserving the order of the pages?”

“Understand first. A photograph of paper makes the words easier to read, not their meaning.”

Jaynarayan arrived as well. Seeing him, Kaki said, “I have been waiting for you since yesterday.”

“For me?”

“These young people think I am only an astrologer and ask me questions that way. You spend your time looking for criminals and end up reading people’s habits. You will understand.”

Jaynarayan lifted one page of the ledger. To the left of each entry there was sometimes a round dot, sometimes a triangle, sometimes a small square. “These marks?”

Ambika Kaki brightened. “That is why I called you. Round dot—I saw it myself or was present. Triangle—

two or more people from the household told the same thing. Square—I saw a document. Only a straight line—one person's account, unconfirmed. If something is not certain, why should I write it as certain?”

Abhiram stared. “You've created source categories.”

“Give them whatever name you like. I only made a way to keep truth and falsehood apart.”

Jaynarayan smiled. “This ledger seems more honest to me than many government registers.”

“A government register doesn't make faces at me,” Abhiram said.

Kaki glared at him. “A ledger can make faces too, if you read it badly.”

The second ledger had more pages on migration. Through the seventies and eighties: from villages to towns, Calcutta, Assam, Punjab, the Nepal border, Delhi. Beside each name was a brief reason—work, flood, marriage, debt, quarrel. Madhavi suddenly understood that maps are made not only of rivers and roads; people's sorrow and hope also make routes.

Ambika Kaki said, “People came asking about constellations, but these notes became more useful for learning which household came from where, and who went where. One year the flood shifted an entire hamlet. Twenty years later a child asks, ‘Where was my maternal

grandfather originally from?" If there is no paper, we open the ledger."

Abhiram said quietly, "People's history."

"Does history belong only to important people?"

"No," Madhavi said at once. "To everyone."

Kaki opened the third ledger. There were fewer names crowding the pages, but the notes were longer. "These are the flood years. Look here—Baraila."

Madhavi and Abhiram leaned forward at the same moment.

The entry read: "Phulmati Sahni, maternal-side relation from the western tract; after the flood, Baraila Diara. In later years, seasonal house on North Char." The mark was a triangle. To the left two names were linked; beside one was the note: "Child Dulari stayed several months; had fish-fever."

Madhavi's breath seemed to catch. "Dulari?"

Kaki narrowed her eyes and read again. "This is very old. Dulari must have been five or six, by my estimate. Her mother came to ask me about the day of the fever. The child was staying across the river with Phulmati. That is why I wrote it."

Abhiram immediately noted the date, but Jaynarayan stopped him. "The source mark for this entry is a triangle—two people's accounts, correct?"

“Yes. Her mother and her mother's sister.”

“And the note that Phulmati now lives on North Char—when is that from?”

Kaki looked at a later note in the margin. “Updated six years ago. It may have changed since then.”

“Good,” Jaynarayan said. “An old ledger can show us a road. The present still has to be verified separately.”

In Madhavi's mind, this joined the old boatman's words from the previous day. Two independent memories pointing in one direction. A safe place from Dulari's childhood—Phulmati.

Abhiram said, “Sutra has no record of this relationship. In the official family list, Phulmati is a separate household and Dulari's name is not there.”

Kaki asked, “Does staying in someone's house for five months make you part of their official family?”

“No.”

“Then many relationships in a life will remain outside government paper.”

Jaynarayan looked at Abhiram. “Remember how to write ‘unknown’?”

Abhiram smiled. “Now we'll need a new field called ‘unrecorded relationship’.”

The ledgers offered another unexpected benefit. Entries relating to the Seven Hamlets were not gathered under one heading; they were scattered through marriages and debts. Kaki traced the old settlements of one family after another. “These people were first in the western tract. After the earthquake, south. Then the flood. This family's daughter married into that hamlet. A son-in-law from this house testified in court.”

Abhiram wanted to begin drawing a map, but Jaynarayan said, “Preserve the original sequence first. The map comes later.”

Madhavi stopped when she saw Vasudha's name on one page. The entry was only three years old: “Vasudha Karn—asked for oral list of old resettlement families; land case.” Beside it was a round dot.

“Didi came here?”

Ambika Kaki nodded. “Twice. The first time to ask where the Seven Hamlets families had originally lived. The second time, about Kusuma's story.”

Madhavi's body tightened. “What did she ask about Kusuma?”

“When the folk story first began. The red dupatta, the anklet, the mansion. I told her it is difficult to date a story, but the accounts of the old people who survived are written separately.”

Kaki took out a thin notebook. On the cover were only the words: "Heard Accounts—Unverified."

"In this?"

"Not rumour—memory. There is a difference. Rumour wants to move forward; memory looks backward."

On one page were three separate accounts. First: "Kusuma went toward the camp at night." Second: "Red dupatta on the pond road." Third: "Left a name in the old mansion." Beside the third was a straight line—one person's account, unconfirmed.

Madhavi stopped her finger there. "Left a name?"

"My mother was the source of that, but she had not seen it herself either. One of her aunts had told her that Kusuma's name had been scratched into the lime plaster of the mansion. Later, another layer of lime was put over it."

"Her full name?"

Ambika Kaki shook her head. "I don't remember. I never saw it myself. Vasudha asked the same question."

"Did Didi go to the mansion?"

"She told me she intended to. She never told me afterward what she found."

Abhiram seemed about to say something, but seeing Madhavi's face, remained silent.

Jaynarayan did not close the thin notebook. "Kaki, did you record the date of Vasudha's second visit?"

"Yes."

The date was one month before Vasudha's death. Jaynarayan wrote it down. "We need a certified copy of this page. The original stays with you. It will be added to the police's formal evidence list."

Kaki said easily, "Take the copy. But don't call me an astrologer in court and have everyone laugh at me."

Jaynarayan laughed. "Whether you are an astrologer is not the court's concern. This ledger has source marks, dates, and a continuous record. That has a value of its own."

For the first time Ambika Kaki sat a little straighter, almost with pride. "It would be a lie to say I do not look at planets. But people think that is all I am. Half the history of our villages is inside this chest, and no one asks about it."

Madhavi said softly, "We will now."

Until evening they photographed the pages. With each image Abhiram recorded the ledger number, page number, source mark, and date. Not one word was allowed to become an immediate conclusion inside

Sutra. Everything first went into a separate store as ‘unverified community record’.

As soon as they stepped outside, Abhiram said, “Ambika Kaki understood data quality before any of us did.”

Madhavi said, “Data again?”

“Fine. Memory quality.”

“That's better.”

From behind them Jaynarayan said, “Respect does not come from changing the word. Change your behaviour.”

Abhiram laughed.

Madhavi's mind, however, remained fixed on the mansion—“left a name in the old mansion.” She remembered the old photograph. Kusuma in the red dupatta, the ventilator-like shape behind her, the lime-plastered wall. Had there been some scratch mark in the photograph? She had looked at it many times, but could not remember any name.

When she reached home, she opened the copy of the photograph at once and enlarged it. One part of the wall was blurred, the light falling across it obliquely. No clear letters were visible.

A message from Abhiram arrived: “If you're going to the mansion tomorrow, not without police permission.”

Madhavi stared. "When did I ever say I was going?"

The answer came immediately: "Your face."

Madhavi wrote, "You've spent too much time with Ambika Kaki."

"Learning."

Madhavi switched off the phone. In the photograph, the wall was silent. But Ambika Kaki's ledger had opened a new question: if people's memory had carried the story of a name for so many years, where had the name gone?

And why had Vasudha come asking the very same question one month before her death?

Chapter 24 — The Anklet at Midnight

Permission to visit the mansion the next day was not easy to obtain. The half-letter and blue thread recovered from the hollow in the wall had already entered the evidence register; that section of the room had been sealed. Madhavi said she wanted only to compare photographs. Vinay Thakur refused at first, then, at Jaynarayan's request, granted limited permission—the outer veranda and the wall that had already been inspected, in the presence of police. Nothing was to be touched, nothing scraped.

“And not at night,” Vinay said with particular emphasis.

Madhavi agreed at once.

Jaynarayan stared at her. “Hearing such an immediate ‘yes’ only increases my suspicion.”

“I don't break rules.”

Beside her, Abhiram said, “And if a dream summons you at midnight?”

Madhavi moved to elbow him, but Jaynarayan stood between them. “Neither of you behave like children.”

The team reached the mansion after noon. This time they were accompanied by a police constable, a local records officer, and a photographer. Measurements

around the wall hollow, photographs, layers of old lime plaster, signs of later repair—everything was systematically recorded. Madhavi held her copy of the old photograph separately.

“Where's the name?” Abhiram asked softly.

“Not visible yet.”

“The folk story may be wrong.”

“It may be,” Madhavi replied without anger.

Abhiram looked at her. “Effect of the night on the boat?”

“Effect of Ambika Kaki's ledgers.”

In the photograph, the light fell on the wall from the left. In the present room, the direction of the window seemed to have changed. During repairs after the 1934 earthquake, one section had been filled in; later the ventilator had been made smaller. The photographer cast light obliquely across the wall to reveal the relief of the surface. There were many scratches, names added later by children, dates, the initials of some lovers. But no clear Kusuma.

At five in the evening the records officer said, “Enough for today. The outside light is fading.”

Madhavi was disappointed but did not protest. Everything was packed away. Jaynarayan had to go to the district office; Abhiram had to submit the digital

copies. Madhavi too was preparing to leave when the photographer said, “One image taken under oblique light may become clearer on a laptop. Not here.”

They all returned to town.

At eight that night a message came from Abhiram: “In the oblique-light image there are three strokes like letters near the lower part of the wall. Not complete. We’ll look again tomorrow.”

Madhavi opened the photograph. Indeed—among the raised patches of lime, something like ‘Ku’? Or only an illusion of the eye? She looked at the image five times, then switched off the phone.

At ten it began to rain—small, regular drops. Her mother went to sleep. On Madhavi’s table lay Vasudha’s notes, copies from Ambika Kaki’s ledgers, and the old photograph. While comparing them she stopped at one discrepancy. The portion of wall behind Kusuma in the old photograph corresponded, in the present inspection, to a thin strip of newer lime directly in front of it, about a hand and a half to the right of the hollow. During the day everyone’s attention had been on the hollow, not on this strip.

She sent Abhiram a message: “Look at the photograph. The strip on the right is different.”

No reply. Perhaps he had gone to sleep.

Madhavi too lay down, but sleep did not come. Anklet? Name? Vasudha's plan to visit the mansion one month before her death? The questions circled again and again. At eleven twenty, Abhiram replied: "Seen it. Could be later plaster. We'll examine it tomorrow. Don't go anywhere now."

Madhavi laughed. "I'm at home."

"Proof?"

She sent him a photograph of her mother's sewing machine.

"Accepted."

At eleven forty her mother suddenly woke and said, "The veranda roof is leaking. Put a bucket there." Madhavi set down the bucket. At that moment a motorcycle stopped in the lane outside. It was a police constable carrying a short note from Vinay: water had entered the outer veranda of the mansion; a box containing photographic measuring sheets left there during the day was still inside. Madhavi did not have the records officer's key, but the photographer had accidentally left a digital memory card in Madhavi's file. The police needed the card immediately because copies from the inspection had to be sent at dawn.

Madhavi checked the file. The card was indeed there. The constable said, "I'm going to the guard at the mansion. Give me the card."

Madhavi was about to hand it over, then asked, “Water has entered the veranda?”

“Yes. The guard is moving things alone. More men are coming from the station.”

The strip of lime on the right flashed in Madhavi's mind. So did Vinay's order: ‘not at night.’ She handed the card to the constable. “I won't go.”

The constable left.

Five minutes later Abhiram called. “Vinay Babu has called me too. A plugboard in the outer veranda of the mansion got wet; they're having the electricity switched off. Stay at home.”

“I'm at home.”

“Good.”

The call ended.

Madhavi stood by the window watching the rain. She became annoyed with herself—why this much restlessness? The wall would still be there in the morning. If a name existed, it would not run away.

Five minutes before midnight, the phone rang again. Abhiram this time. His voice was urgent. “Madhavi, do you have the original high-resolution image of the old photograph you were carrying today?”

“On my laptop.”

“We're comparing it under light here at the mansion. Not you—we only need the image. Can you send it?”

“You're at the mansion?”

“Yes. The police are here. Jaynarayan Babu is coming too. The water has not reached the hollow wall, but things are being moved from the veranda.”

Madhavi sent the image. Ten minutes later Abhiram sent another message: “The older layer under the strip on the right really is different. But we won't touch it now. Specialist in the morning.”

Madhavi was beginning to type a reply when the electricity went out. The house fell dark. The rain outside had weakened. In the silence, a faint metallic chime sounded somewhere in the distance. One, two, then three little sounds—chhan... chhan... chhan.

Madhavi froze. The sound was not inside the house, but from the lane. Then she understood: the bell around the neighbour's goat's neck. She laughed at herself.

At that moment Abhiram called. “There's a problem.”

“What?”

“Jaynarayan Babu's vehicle is stuck on the way. A police team is outside on the veranda. I'm in the inner veranda comparing the photographs. The lines that were visible in the daytime image in front of the strip on the

right seem to vanish now when the direction of light changes.”

“Vanish?”

“Meaning it may be an illusion caused by light. Without your original image, the direction is hard to match. What I have on the phone is compressed.”

Madhavi said nothing.

Abhiram immediately added, “You are not coming. We’ll do it tomorrow.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“I recognise your silence.”

Madhavi ended the call.

Fifteen minutes later Jaynarayan called. “You’re at home?”

“Yes.”

“Stay there. I’m on my way to the mansion. Abhiram is inside, the police are outside. There is no emergency.”

Madhavi said, “Yes.”

Twelve fifteen. The rain had stopped. There was still no electricity. Her mother had gone back to sleep. Madhavi sat at the table, but her mind was at the mansion. Jaynarayan himself had said there was no

emergency. Then why did something inside keep prodding her?

At twelve twenty, what arrived from Abhiram was not a message but a photograph. A torch cast oblique light across the strip of lime on the right. Three strokes stood out clearly—something like ‘Ku...’. Something else below.

Madhavi brought the screen closer. She opened the old high-resolution photograph beside it. In that photograph Kusuma stood before the wall. One portion of what they now believed to be the strip was hidden behind her dupatta. On the exposed portion—was there a faint scratch? It had not been visible in the compressed image.

Madhavi called Jaynarayan. No signal. Abhiram's phone rang but he did not answer.

Her mind began to race again. Five minutes later Abhiram himself called. “I've come outside. The police are sealing the inner section again. Examination in the morning. That's all.”

“There are letters in the photograph.”

“There may be. No conclusion yet.”

“Kusuma?”

“Madhavi—”

“All right. Tomorrow.”

The call ended.

Madhavi went to sleep.

At half past four in the morning a message arrived from Jaynarayan: “Mansion at seven. Permission obtained. We will examine the strip on the right.”

At seven the team returned to the mansion. A specialist examined the lime surface using non-contact oblique light, shadow photography, and measurement. The strip on the right was indeed composed of lime from two different periods. The thin upper layer was relatively new; beneath it were older scratches. No layer was removed. As the angle of light changed, the letters gradually began to emerge.

First—“Ku.” Then “su.” Then “ma.”

Madhavi's heart struck hard.

Below, in smaller letters: “Devi.” After that a partial sequence—“Ra...lo... Chau...” The specialist said, “It would not be appropriate to read the whole thing yet. We'll use digital light-compositing.”

Abhiram said softly, “Kusuma Devi... daughter of Ramlochan Chaudhary—possibly.”

Jaynarayan stopped him at once. “Possibly. Do not declare it yet.”

By noon the image processing was complete. The inscription emerged fully: “Kusuma Devi — daughter of

Ramlochan Chaudhary.” Beneath it, extremely faint, as if scratched by a nail or the point of metal: “I was here.”

A shiver passed through Madhavi. This was not a death message. It was presence. ‘I was here.’

Abhiram remained silent.

“Ambika Kaki's memory wasn't wrong,” Madhavi said.

“At least not about the name,” Abhiram replied. “But when it was scratched, whether Kusuma herself scratched it or someone else did—still unknown.”

“The photograph?” Madhavi asked. “Why isn't it visible in the old photograph?”

Abhiram put the old high-resolution image on the screen. Kusuma's body covered half the name; over the remaining portion the light was flat, throwing no shadow from the scratches. “It may have been scratched after the photograph was taken. Or there may have been a thin layer of lime over it that later wore away. Or the lighting may simply have failed to reveal it.”

Madhavi said slowly, “Then this is not proof that she came to this mansion on the night she disappeared.”

Jaynarayan looked at her with satisfaction. “Correct.”

It was not easy for Madhavi to say that. One half of her mind insisted: the name is there, so the story is true. The other half answered: a name does not tell us when it

was made. She remembered the condition from the night on the boat: you will not think me a fool; I will not think you a stone. She repeated the same condition to her own mind.

When the day's work ended, Jaynarayan went to the police station. Abhiram went to the records room with the photographs. Madhavi remained for a while in the mansion's outer courtyard, with a police constable at the door. The sun had not yet set. She looked back toward the wall—the name still could not be seen by ordinary sight, only from a particular angle of light.

That night she slept at home. Around midnight she woke to the vibration of her phone. A message from Abhiram: “The name is not visible in the old photograph. Pixel examination shows no clear shadow from the scratches. It may have been made later.”

Before Madhavi could reply, she heard a sound that was not the goat's bell.

Chhan... chhan...

Very soft. Like an anklet on a distant veranda.

She sat up. The door of the house was closed. Her mother was in the next room. Again—chhan...

Madhavi took a torch and came outside. The sound seemed to come from the far end of the lane. There was no rain. The wind was very light. She took two steps forward, then stopped. To chase a sound alone in the

middle of the night would be foolish. She did not step beyond the doorway of the house.

Then the phone rang. Abhiram.

“Awake?”

“Yes.”

“I need to tell you something. During the day, when I was setting up the oblique light inside the mansion, I heard something like an anklet once.”

Madhavi's hand stopped. “You?”

“Yes. I thought it was the keys of the constable outside. I asked him—the constable said no one had moved at that moment.”

Madhavi was silent.

Abhiram said, “It isn't evidence.”

“I know.”

“But I didn't want to hide it from you either.”

“Why?”

“Because I accepted our condition on the boat yesterday.”

A smile came to Madhavi's face in the darkness.
“Good.”

“Did you hear something?”

Madhavi looked toward the lane. It was silent now.
“Maybe.”

“What?”

“Like an anklet.”

At the other end of the call, Abhiram's breathing stopped for a moment. Then he said, “Stay inside the house.”

“I am.”

“We'll look in the morning.”

“Yes.”

The call ended.

Madhavi went back inside. On the table today's image remained open: ‘Kusuma Devi — daughter of Ramlochan Chaudhary. I was here.’ The scratches were not visible in the old photograph. The name exists now. The time between is unknown.

That was all logic could say.

But the three chimes at midnight were written nowhere on logic's page. Madhavi did not treat them as evidence. Nor did she forget them.

Chapter 25 — Dulari Found

As the day brightened, the matter of the anklet-like chime at dawn receded again into the background. At seven forty-five, Vinay Thakur called. The local boat team sent to North Char had seen, with one family, a young woman matching Dulari's description. When asked her name, she had first remained silent, then said, "Let Madhavi Didi come. Then I'll speak."

The cup of tea almost slipped from Madhavi's hand. Her mother, Malati, was sitting beside the sewing machine. The moment she saw her daughter's face, she stopped the machine.

"Found her?"

"Maybe."

Malati closed her eyes. "First see her alive. Ask the questions afterward."

Madhavi nodded. Since Vasudha's death, ordinary sentences spoken at home sometimes seemed heavier to her than orders from a court.

Jaynarayan was already at the ghat. Abhiram carried a waterproof bag; with Vinay was the woman constable, Saroj Devi. Bhola Sahni was untying the boat. The night's storm had passed, but the river was swollen. The water was thick and earth-coloured, the current strong underneath.

“No heroics today,” Jaynarayan said as they boarded.

Abhiram looked at Madhavi. “Is that order for both of us?”

“Whoever thinks it applies may write down their own name.”

Bhola laughed. After the fear of the night, the laughter felt slightly unnatural, but good all the same.

It took an hour to reach North Char. From time to time the boat touched shallow sand and Bhola pushed it free with a long bamboo pole. The mobile signal came and went. When Abhiram started opening the map again, Bhola called from behind, “Read the river at this bend, Babu. The map is from last year.”

Without protesting, Abhiram switched off the phone. Madhavi smiled.

On the char there were not houses so much as temporary shapes of houses—bamboo platforms, reed mats, straw roofs, poles for drying nets, the smell of fish, smoke, and barefoot children running across the sand. At the sight of the police boat, several people stood at a distance. Saroj Devi first went to an elderly woman wearing a white gamchha over her head. Bhola whispered, “Phulmati.”

Phulmati narrowed her eyes at Madhavi. “You’re Madhavi?”

“Yes.”

“Then come. Let the police stay behind.”

Vinay was about to object, but Saroj Devi raised a hand. “I’ll go with her.”

Phulmati led them behind her house. Beneath a small shelter, two women were mending a torn fishing net. One was Phulmati's daughter, Chunki; the other's face was half-covered by a gamchha. Madhavi stopped in her tracks.

“Dulari.”

The gamchha slowly came down. Dulari's eyes were sunken, as though she had been awake for nights. Her cheeks were hollow. But she was alive. The stone lodged inside Madhavi for two days suddenly loosened. Madhavi wanted to run forward and embrace her, but Dulari herself rose, came toward her, and held her tightly.

“Didi...”

Only that one word. Then Dulari's body began to tremble. She did not cry; her breath merely came out brokenly. Madhavi kept a hand at her back.

“I knew you would look for me,” Dulari said after a while.

Madhavi's eyes filled. “You sent me a message. Why didn't you tell me where you were?”

Dulari looked at Saroj Devi, then toward Vinay and Jaynarayan standing farther away near the boat. “If I had told the place, who would have reached me first?”

There was no easy answer. Madhavi remained silent.

Phulmati took tea from the earthen stove and served everyone. Dulari held the cup but did not drink. Blue net-thread was caught beneath her fingernails. Madhavi froze for a moment—blue thread. Then she stopped herself. On this river island, fishing nets were full of blue thread. Not every blue thing was a sign from Kusuma.

Jaynarayan came closer slowly. “I will ask questions here, but only as much as you want. First this—are you injured?”

“No.”

“Did anyone follow you?”

“The first night I felt someone did. I am not certain.”

“Why did you come here?”

Dulari set the cup down. “Because after what I saw, going home did not feel safe. And at dawn, when I heard Didi had died, I understood that everyone would take my name first.”

Jaynarayan's face did not change. “What did you see?”

Dulari looked around. The air on the char was open, yet her voice dropped by itself. "Papers burning on the rear veranda of the courthouse."

Madhavi's body tightened. Abhiram stepped closer. Vinay immediately opened his notebook.

"When?"

"After ten at night. I don't remember the exact time. I had left Didi. Buchchan Kaka was not at the gate; it was raining heavily. I thought I would go out beneath the rear awning because the main path was flooded. There I saw a small flame near an old iron drum."

"Who?" Vinay's question was sharp.

Dulari pressed her lips together. "I did not see the face clearly."

"What kind of person?"

"A man. Medium build. Clothes like someone who worked at the courthouse. Torn pages from a file in his hand. He was folding the pages and feeding them into the fire."

"Did you recognise him?"

Dulari looked at Jaynarayan. "He seemed like someone I knew. But I will not name someone falsely."

Jaynarayan said at once, "Good. Say only what you saw. If something is an inference, call it an inference."

Dulari's face relaxed slightly. "I remember the way his left foot moved. When he stepped, it turned a little outward. And in his right hand was a ring of keys—a large round brass-coloured ring. It shone in the firelight."

Vinay wrote it down. "His voice?"

"He coughed once. A dry cough. Then he looked back. I pressed myself behind the corner of the wall. I saw half his face, but I cannot say here that it was this person or that person."

"Did he see you?"

"I don't know. I felt that he did. After that I ran."

Madhavi asked, "Was Didi still inside then?"

Dulari's eyes turned to her at once. "Yes. As I was leaving, I heard her speaking. On the phone she was telling someone, 'The copy will not remain with me.' A few minutes later I was outside."

Abhiram's eyes met Jaynarayan's. This mattered to the timeline.

Jaynarayan asked, "Did Vasudha give you anything?"

Dulari fell silent again. Phulmati looked toward her daughter Chunki. Chunki rose and brought an old cloth bundle from the corner of the shelter. Dulari opened it. Inside were clothes, a notebook, two dried rotis, and a folded sheet wrapped in oiled paper.

Vinay immediately raised a hand. “Don’t touch it now.”

Saroj Devi had a clean plastic evidence bag brought over. Holding only the outside of the oiled paper, Dulari herself placed it on an overturned basket used like a table.

“Didi gave me this,” she said. “She said, ‘It isn’t the original. It’s a photocopy. Don’t keep it openly at home. If anything happens to me, get it to Madhavi.’ I laughed—‘What will happen to you?’ She became angry and said, ‘Do what I’m telling you.’”

Madhavi’s eyes filled again.

“What’s on the paper?” Vinay asked.

“I didn’t read all of it. At the top: Seven Hamlets, old names, several circle-like seals. In one corner it says ‘Part 7’. That’s all I saw.”

Abhiram stared at the page, holding his breath. The missing seventh sheet from Box 47/B? Or a photocopy of it? It was too early to say.

“You didn’t go home—you came straight to the river?” Jaynarayan asked.

“First I hid for about half an hour behind the shed at the night school. Then a milk-seller’s cart was going toward the ghat and I went with him. Before dawn I found a small boat. I knew Phulmati Dadi’s name. My

Babu used to trade fish with these people. I thought if I stayed across the water, I could think for two days.”

“When did you hear of Vasudha's death?”

“At dawn. One boatman said, ‘The woman lawyer at the courthouse has died.’ Then another said, ‘The girl who went there that night has disappeared.’ I understood that my name was already being spoken.”

Madhavi said softly, “You could have gone to the police.”

Dulari looked at her in a way that made an entire society visible inside the sentence. “Didi, last year a silver bowl disappeared from the moneylender's house in our village. Do you remember whose hut the police went to first? Ours. The moneylender's grandson had sold the bowl to gamble. By the time that was known, Ma had spent three nights going back and forth to the police station. If a poor person's word were believed first, I too would have gone straight to the police.”

Madhavi had no answer.

Jaynarayan said quietly, “Your fear was not irrational. But now your statement is necessary. And so is your safety.”

Dulari's face hardened. “Will you confine me in the name of safety?”

Vinay answered at once, “No. Right now you are a witness. You will stay at a safe place with a woman police officer and your statement will be recorded. You will not sign any paper against your will. Read it first, then sign.”

Dulari looked at Saroj Devi. “You’ll stay with me?”

“Yes,” Saroj said. “As long as the process is going on.”

Dulari looked toward the oiled paper. “I will hand over this paper myself. Write that I gave it. Later no one should say the police ‘found’ it in my bundle.”

Jaynarayan's eyes brightened. “Good that you said that yourself.”

Vinay prepared an acknowledgement. Dulari began to read it. At two places she stopped and changed the wording. “Here it says ‘recovered’. Write: ‘Dulari Sadai voluntarily presented it.’”

Vinay looked at her for a moment, then changed the words.

Vasudha's words rose in Madhavi's mind—“First she will read this; then she will read all your papers.” Dulari really was reading the document. Not only for herself, but to protect herself from a sentence that might later be turned against her.

Phulmati stroked Dulari's head. "Go. Do not cross the river again merely out of fear. If you are afraid, write down names; preserve your voice."

Dulari could not smile, but she nodded.

On the return boat she sat beside Madhavi. Abhiram sat opposite. Jaynarayan's eyes were on the river, but his ears were on everything.

"How did you send me that message?" Madhavi asked.

Dulari said, "Chunki's brother-in-law's old phone. Changed number. The voice clip couldn't be longer than seven seconds—he said if it was longer the file became too heavy."

Abhiram laughed involuntarily. "Seven seconds. Seven again."

Dulari raised an eyebrow. "That seven has nothing to do with me. The phone was bad."

Madhavi laughed too. Amid the mystery, the ordinary explanation felt good. Not every 'seven' was mysterious.

As the ghat came near, Dulari's body grew rigid again. On the bank were a police vehicle, two local reporters, and many curious faces at a distance. The moment Jaynarayan saw the crowd he said to Vinay, "Do not turn a witness's face into a spectacle."

Saroj Devi adjusted the gamchha over Dulari's head. The vehicle was brought close.

Before stepping ashore, Dulari looked into Vinay's eyes. "Tell me one thing clearly. Am I going to give testimony, or am I becoming an accused?"

Vinay paused briefly. "Right now, you are a witness."

Dulari heard the answer. Then she said softly, "I will remember the words 'right now'."

For a moment a shadow of concern crossed Jaynarayan's face. The river kept flowing behind them. The ground at the bank looked firm, but Dulari had learned that even firm ground can suddenly shift.

Chapter 26 — Arrest

On reaching the police station, Dulari's first demand was not tea but paper. "Whatever I say, let me read it after it is written." Saroj Devi seated her in the women's assistance room. She was given a clean sheet to replace her wet gamchha, and food was brought. Dulari ate two mouthfuls and stopped.

"Not hungry?" Saroj asked.

"I am hungry. My stomach is refusing."

Without pressing her, Saroj covered the plate and set it aside.

On the outer veranda sat Madhavi, Abhiram, and Jaynarayan. Vinay was taking preliminary images of the sheet wrapped in oiled paper. The sheet itself was not old paper but a comparatively recent photocopy; yet the layout of the document pictured on it matched the list from Box 47/B. Along the left margin were portions of six circular evidence marks; the seventh position lay under a fold. The writing was blurred.

Abhiram enlarged it on the screen. "This is not the original. The paper fibres are recent. The image is probably a photograph or photocopy of the original."

Vinay said, "But the original sheet is missing. And this copy was with Dulari."

Madhavi said at once, "Vasudha Didi gave it to her—that is what Dulari said."

"That is a statement," Vinay said calmly. "It still needs corroboration."

Jaynarayan said nothing in between. He kept looking at the folds of the sheet. "Whose oiled paper?"

"From her house?" Madhavi guessed.

Jaynarayan looked at her. Madhavi corrected herself. "I don't know. Inference."

"Good."

Dulari's statement took three hours. Saroj remained inside. Vinay asked questions, a clerk wrote, and again and again Dulari stopped him and had words changed.

"Here you have written 'ran away'," she said. "I said 'I did not return home.' Remove the word 'ran away'."

The clerk made an irritated face. "The meaning is—"

"I will give the meaning. You do the writing."

A faint smile came to Saroj's lips. Vinay looked at the clerk. The word was changed.

"Did you recognise the person burning the papers?"

"He seemed familiar. I am not certain."

"Name?"

“No.”

“A courthouse employee?”

“Possibly.”

“A lawyer?”

“I don't know.”

“Someone connected with the land group?”

“I did not see the face clearly.”

Vinay changed the question. “Why did Vasudha Karn give you the copy?”

“She said, ‘In case the papers disappear again.’”

Hearing the sentence from the veranda, Madhavi shivered. Vasudha's half-written line—“If this paper disappears again...”

By noon Dulari's mother, Phulo Sadai, arrived. Someone had informed her. She began crying the moment she reached the station gate, but when she saw Dulari the situation reversed.

“Ma, stop crying,” Dulari said. “I'm alive. Eat something first.”

Phulo pulled her daughter to her chest. “You crossed the river without telling me—”

“If I had told you, you would have stopped me.”

“Of course I would!”

“That is why I didn't tell you.”

For a moment the quarrel between them contained more love than fear. Jaynarayan watched from a distance. Courage in an ordinary household is not always a speech; sometimes it is a mother scolding her daughter because she has been found alive.

At two in the afternoon a special message arrived from the district office. An immediate progress report was required. A dead advocate, a collective land case, public pressure—the attention of senior officers had turned toward the matter. Vinay's face hardened as he read the message.

“What?” Jaynarayan asked.

Before answering, Vinay looked toward Abhiram's laptop. “The first Sutra report has already been attached to the case diary.”

Abhiram straightened. “Which report?”

“The preliminary report that raised Dulari's suspicion score.”

“That report was corrected. The phone was not hers, the cash withdrawals were for family use, and the twelve hundred rupees were legal-aid money.”

“The correction is there too. But the first copy is also in the file.”

Abhiram's voice hardened. "The old result is clearly marked 'invalid/reassessed'."

Vinay rubbed his eyes with fatigue. "Once something is printed on paper, it acquires a life of its own, Abhiram Babu."

Jaynarayan said quietly, "The machine changed its result. The office's memory did not."

Madhavi found the sentence terrifying.

At three, a senior police officer arrived. His name was Naresh Chaube. He looked through all the papers, read Dulari's statement, and examined the image of the copied page. His questions were short; his tone impatient.

"Last person seen with the deceased?"

"Dulari."

"Disappeared after the death?"

"Yes, but—" Vinay began.

"Original document missing, and she had its copy?"

"She produced the copy herself and says Vasudha gave it to her."

"Says. Bank withdrawals?"

Abhiram spoke. "The explanations have been verified
—"

Chaube raised a hand and stopped him. “I am speaking to the police, not to the machine.”

Abhiram's face tightened. Jaynarayan placed a light hand on his arm. Anger would be of no use now.

Chaube read the portion of Dulari's statement in which she described seeing someone burn papers. “No name. No clear face. This could also be a story constructed afterward.”

Fire rose inside Madhavi. “Why? Because she is poor?”

Chaube looked at her. “Who are you?”

“Vasudha's assistant.”

“Then keep emotion separate.”

Jaynarayan stepped in. “Keeping emotion separate is fair. Do not keep the correction to the old report separate either.”

Chaube knew him. His tone steadied somewhat. “Jaynarayan Babu, I don't need pressure. I need facts. The facts are that Dulari disappeared, was the last person seen with the deceased, had a copy of the missing original, and the preliminary analysis called her activity suspicious.”

“And the corrected analysis?”

“We'll examine it.”

“When?”

“The investigation is continuing.”

Jaynarayan did not like the answer, but he remained silent.

Before five in the evening Dulari was told that the arrangement for her protection was changing; for now she could not leave the police station. Saroj Devi herself told her. Dulari stared steadily at her face.

“Witness?”

Saroj paused before answering. “There has been no formal decision yet.”

A bitter smile appeared on Dulari's face. “I remembered the word ‘yet’.”

Madhavi wanted to go inside, but permission was refused. Jaynarayan said to Vinay, “Call a lawyer now.”

Advocate Rachna Mandal arrived from the district legal-aid office. She was about thirty-eight, short, with a low voice and a thin file of papers in her hand. Before speaking to the police, she met Dulari. Fifteen minutes later she came out and asked Vinay her first question: “Is this young woman here voluntarily, or is she in custody?”

Vinay said, “There has been no formal arrest yet.”

“Then she may leave?”

Silence.

Rachna asked again, "May she leave?"

Senior officer Chaube said, "She has been held for the purposes of investigation."

"Then make the legal language clear. Indefinite restraint cannot be imposed in the name of protection."

A faint shadow of satisfaction passed through Jaynarayan's eyes.

At around six, the decision was made: Dulari would be formally arrested. The grounds written down included suspicion of a conspiracy connected with Vasudha's death, theft/concealment of the original page of a public record, and the possibility of destruction of evidence. Vinay looked uncomfortable as he read the wording.

"Destruction of evidence?" he asked Chaube. "She herself is saying she saw someone burning the papers."

"She is saying it."

"She has not named that person."

"Correct. The investigation will clarify it."

Abhiram whispered, "So because she spoke, the same thing is now being used against her?"

Jaynarayan replied, "Sometimes a system looks at the place of the person giving an answer before it looks at the answer to the question."

The arrest was recorded before nightfall in the presence of a woman constable. The grounds were read out to Dulari in writing; Rachna Mandal took a copy. Phulo was informed as family. A medical examination was arranged. Before signing the paper, Dulari read it again.

"Here it says, 'grounds of arrest explained at the time of arrest.' I understood them, but I did not accept them. Add that."

The clerk looked irritated again. Rachna said calmly, "Add it."

It was added.

Standing by the doorway, Madhavi watched Dulari's face. She did not cry. Phulo was crying. Turning toward her mother, Dulari said, "Go home. Shaila Bahin has my night-school notebook; keep it safe. Chhotka's school must not stop."

Phulo said, "You're going to jail and you're worried about school?"

"Then what should I do? Will the school come to me in jail?"

At that sentence even Saroj Devi's eyes seemed to moisten, but she turned her face away.

Abhiram wanted to show Rachna Mandal his system's revision log. "The first result was based on a wrong association. The complete history of the changes is preserved."

Rachna immediately asked, "The old result wasn't deleted?"

"No. Every version is preserved for transparency."

"Then now we'll have to defend that transparency. In court they will show the old page; we will show why it changed."

Abhiram looked unhappy. "I thought preserving history was a safeguard."

"It is," Rachna said, "but half a page of history can become a weapon. Carry the whole page."

Dulari was not subjected that night to prolonged police questioning without a court order. The next morning she was produced before a judicial magistrate. The prosecution sought custody for a short period; Rachna opposed it. Rather than hearing the full factual dispute, the court examined the immediate procedure, confirmed Dulari's health, the presence of a woman police officer, and access to counsel, and placed her in judicial custody for a short period while permitting an early bail application before the sessions court.

When Dulari came out of the court building, there were no handcuffs on her wrists; woman police officers walked on both sides. Even so, the crowd looked at her as though judgment had already been delivered. A whisper rose from somewhere—"That girl." Another—"The lady lawyer's papers..."

Madhavi stopped in her tracks. She wanted to turn and speak. From a distance Dulari met her eyes and shook her head—no.

The vehicle drove away.

Jaynarayan sat down on the veranda steps. Abhiram stood nearby.

"Sutra's first error," Abhiram said quietly, "I had corrected it. Yet it came back."

Jaynarayan said, "An error is not only a result. It is also timing. If a false sentence settles in people's minds before the true one arrives, the later correction can remain outside knocking at the door."

Madhavi clenched her fist. "Then we'll break the door down."

Jaynarayan looked at her. "In court, doors are not broken down, Madhavi. They are opened latch by latch."

Far away, the courthouse clock struck five. For the first time, in that sound, the 'breath of the court' could truly be heard—slow, heavy, capable of drawing into

itself the paper moving through the middle of a human life.

Chapter 27 — The Bail Hearing

From outside, the sessions courtroom looked ordinary—faded yellow walls, old iron windows, the steady turning of a fan, a list of dates on the wall. But for every family sitting inside, the air of that room carried a different weight. Someone's land, someone's body, someone's liberty, someone's reputation hung in that air. Today, Dulari's liberty.

Rachna Mandal had been preparing since dawn. Her file was thin, but filled with small coloured slips. One slip—the copy voluntarily produced by Dulari. Another—the verification that Rahima's phone was shared. A third—the reason for the bank withdrawals. A fourth—the twelve-hundred-rupee legal-aid payment. A fifth—the version history of Sutra.

“A bail argument is not a story,” she told Madhavi. “We do not have to solve the whole murder today. We only have to ask whether there is a solid reason to keep her in jail.”

Madhavi asked, “And what Dulari saw—the man burning papers?”

“We'll use it. Carefully. If we press it too hard now, the prosecution will say she invented a story to save herself. We'll show that her statement is capable of verification, and that the police have not completed that verification.”

Abhiram had his laptop open. “The complete version history is ready. Initial result: the 20th at 11:12. Correction: the 20th at 16:48. The reasons are marked separately.”

Rachna asked, “If the court asks—whose conclusion is Sutra's? Yours?”

Abhiram paused. “The system's calculation.”

“Can the system take an oath in court?”

“No.”

“Then where did the raw data come from?”

“Bank records, telephone towers, aid forms, courthouse entry records—different sources.”

“Who made the rules?”

“The project team. Some external models, some local adjustments.”

“Whose was the wrong association?”

Abhiram lowered his face. “The rule's. And ours, for not giving it enough local context.”

Rachna nodded. “Good. Do not defend the error in court. Admit it. Then the correction will become credible.”

Jaynarayan, who had been silent near the window, said, “To defend the truth, you first have to stop defending your own mistake.”

Abhiram smiled faintly. “Everyone has gathered today to educate me.”

Madhavi said, “It began with Bhola Kaka on the boat.”

A small ripple of laughter passed through the tension, then stopped at once. It was time for Dulari to be brought in.

She came with the woman police officer. She had not slept properly; dark circles lay beneath her eyes. But there was a notebook in her hand—Rachna had arranged, during the jail visit, for her night-school notebook to be brought to her.

“Why bring a notebook here?” Madhavi asked softly.

Dulari said, “What else should I do while waiting? Yesterday's lesson was ‘How to Write an Application.’”

Madhavi's throat tightened, but she laughed. “You're sitting in court learning how to write applications?”

“When your life gets stuck on paper, you have to learn how to write paper.”

The court was called to order. Everyone went inside. The judge was a middle-aged woman, Sessions Judge Ira Sinha. Her voice was neither very loud nor soft. She opened the file and first looked at the grounds of arrest.

The prosecutor rose. “The accused was the last person seen with the deceased. She disappeared immediately after the incident. A photocopy of the missing record that the deceased had been searching for was found in the accused's possession. Preliminary technical analysis recorded unusual bank withdrawals, telephone movement, and financial receipts. The accused claims to have seen an unidentified person burning papers but gives no name. The investigation is at an early stage; if released, there is a risk that she may influence evidence or abscond.”

At the words ‘found in the accused's possession’, Dulari's eyes sharpened. Rachna made a note.

The judge asked, “Was the page found in a search, or did the accused herself hand it over?”

The prosecution paused for a moment. “It was produced in the presence of police—”

“The question is direct.”

Vinay, present as the investigating officer, stood. “Dulari Sadai herself produced the page. The acknowledgement uses that language.”

The judge located the page in the file. “Very well.”

Rachna rose. Her argument was not shouting; it was the untying of one knot after another.

“Your Honour, the prosecution is joining four things into one sentence—the last meeting, absence, the copy, and the technical conclusion. I request that all four be looked at separately.”

She placed the first slip before the court. “The accused does not deny being the last person to meet the deceased. On the contrary, she herself supplied the time, the conversation, and the last audible indication that Vasudha Karn was alive. That statement is capable of verification.”

The second. “Missing—the prosecution's word. The accused says that after seeing a person burning papers, she was afraid to return home. She stayed with a boatman's family across the river. She did not leave the country, did not begin work under another name, did not run away with money. She contacted Madhavi herself by sending her voice—‘I haven't run away.’ She did not resist when the police reached her.”

The prosecution rose in the middle. “The message concealed her location.”

Rachna answered immediately, “Out of fear, which can be tested. But for bail, it matters that before arrest she herself communicated that she was alive and present.”

The third slip. “The record page. It is not the original; it is a photocopy on recent paper. The preliminary forensic inspection itself says only that much. The

accused did not keep this copy hidden; she voluntarily produced it at the first formal police encounter. The prosecution says the original was stolen—where is the original? Not with the accused.”

The judge looked toward the prosecution. “Original recovered?”

“No.”

“Direct evidence of theft?”

“The investigation is continuing.”

Rachna lifted the fourth slip. “Now the technical analysis. The prosecution used the word ‘preliminary’, but did not explain why it was preliminary. I am placing the system's version history before the court.”

Abhiram's heart began to beat faster. The tool he had built now lay as paper on a courtroom table.

Rachna read: “In the first result, the telephone number was treated as belonging to the accused. Verification showed the number belonged to Rahima Khatoon and was being used by Shamsher. The first result called three cash withdrawals ‘unusual’. Verification showed medicine for her mother, wages, and household expenses. The twelve-hundred-rupee ‘unknown’ receipt—equal travel assistance paid to nine people by the Seven Hamlets Legal Aid Committee.”

The judge asked, “When was this correction made?”

“Before the arrest,” Rachna said.

There was movement in the courtroom.

The prosecution rose. “But the preliminary report was one input in the investigation—”

The judge stopped him. “Was the corrected report in the case diary?”

Vinay stood. “Yes, Your Honour. Both versions were there.”

“Then why did the arrest proposal prominently mention only the first version?”

Vinay was silent. Senior officer Chaube was not present that day. After a few moments he said, “The decision was taken after higher review. I can only say that the correction was attached.”

The judge made a note.

Regaining his tone, the prosecutor said, “The technical issue may be separate, but the accused was the last witness, absconded, and was found with a copy of a missing document. In a serious offence, bail is not appropriate.”

Rachna said, “A serious allegation does not make a weak link automatically strong. The prosecution's duty is investigation, not punishment in advance.”

The judge stopped her. “Facts, not instruction.”

Rachna bowed her head at once. “Yes. Facts—nineteen years old; permanent family residence; student at a night school; no previous criminal record; voluntary production of the document before police; primary suspicion reduced in the revised technical analysis; original record not recovered; no direct evidence of violence; possible risk to her because she is a witness. Bail with strict conditions is sufficient.”

The judge looked at Dulari. “Did you see the person burning the papers?”

Dulari stood. “Yes, but not the whole face.”

“Do you know the name?”

“I have a suspicion. I am not certain. I will not give a false name.”

“You did not return home and did not immediately inform the police. Why?”

Dulari's throat went dry. Rachna looked at her but did not teach her an answer.

“Because I did not trust that my words would be heard first. I thought they would catch me first.”

The air in the courtroom seemed to grow heavier. Dulari added, “And that is what happened.”

The prosecution rose to object, but the judge raised a hand. “Answer recorded.”

Then the judge's gaze fell on Abhiram. “Who operates this Sutra?”

Abhiram stood. “I am part of the local operating team.”

“Do you call the system's conclusion evidence?”

For a moment Abhiram looked toward Jaynarayan. The older man's face was still.

“No, Your Honour. I call it analysis—based on source data and rules. The raw sources must be verified separately.”

“Did the system make an error?”

“It made a wrong association because local context about shared telephones and pooled family cash behaviour was not available.”

“Then what is the court to make of the first percentage or suspicion score?”

Abhiram's lips went dry. “In this case—it is an old result produced from incomplete context. The corrected version should be considered.”

The prosecution said, “This is not the formal stage for expert evidence.”

The judge said, “Correct. I am not giving a final ruling today on admissibility. But when the State relies on this

analysis to justify restricting someone's liberty, its limitations must be visible.”

She paused. “And one question is reserved for a later stage—who bears responsibility for a conclusion of this kind? The institutions that supplied the data, those who made the rules, the operator, or does everyone become free merely by saying ‘the machine’? That question will not be decided in today's bail order. But preservation of the records is necessary.”

A shiver passed through Abhiram. The court's question lodged inside him—but at this moment, Dulari's breathing mattered more.

The judge began writing the order. The fan kept turning. Papers rustled. Names were being called on the veranda outside. Time seemed unnaturally slow to Madhavi.

At last Ira Sinha raised her head. “The allegations are serious. However, at the bail stage, the material presently placed before the court does not appear sufficiently strong to justify continued incarceration of the accused. In particular, a significant part of the preliminary technical conclusion had already been reassessed before arrest; the original document was not recovered from the accused; the copy produced was voluntarily surrendered; the accused's local roots and age will also be taken into consideration.”

Madhavi let out the breath she had been holding.

“Dulari Sadai is granted bail subject to conditions—she shall appear for the investigation when required; shall obtain permission before leaving the district; shall not destroy evidence or influence witnesses; shall keep available contact information truthful. The State shall separately assess the accused's safety concerns. All versions of Sutra, the raw source references, and the change logs shall be preserved.”

The prosecution started to say something, but the order had been made.

Dulari gripped the chair and sat down. There were tears in her eyes, but she did not cry. Rachna bent toward her. “It will take a little time before you can leave. The paperwork has to be completed.”

Dulari asked, “Can I go home?”

“Once the conditions are completed, yes.”

“Night school?”

For the first time Rachna smiled openly. “The court has not forbidden it. Take care about your safety.”

When she came near Madhavi, Dulari's first sentence was, “Open my notebook and see—have I written the application correctly?”

Madhavi began to cry while laughing. “First come outside.”

Abhiram stood at a distance. Dulari looked at him. “Did your machine send me to jail?”

Abhiram lowered his face. “Incomplete data pointed in the wrong direction. My team bears responsibility too.”

Dulari watched him for a while and said, “Then next time tell the machine that in poor people's lives, one phone passes through five hands.”

“I have. The rule is being changed.”

“What about the day I spent in jail before the rule changed?”

Abhiram had no answer.

From behind them Jaynarayan said, “The system will not answer that question. Human beings will have to.”

In the afternoon Dulari came out of the court. Again there were people at the gate, cameras, whispers. This time Rachna walked on one side of her, Saroj Devi on the other. Phulo was in front.

A reporter called out, “Dulari, are you innocent?”

Dulari stopped. Rachna tried to restrain her, but Dulari raised a hand.

“The court will say whether I am innocent or guilty,” she said clearly. “I will say only this: I will tell what I saw. I will not invent the name of what I did not see.”

Then she walked on.

Jaynarayan watched the sentence go with her. It seemed to him that the first condition of being a witness might not be courage but knowing one's limits—say what you saw; leave blank what you did not.

On the courthouse veranda Abhiram was closing his laptop. Rachna stopped him. “Close it, but save copies in three places. At the next hearing the court will ask—whose voice is this conclusion, finally?”

Abhiram asked, “What is your answer?”

Rachna closed her file. “I don't have my answer yet. First we will hear the whole question.”

Outside, the sun was breaking through the clouds. Dulari was free on bail, but the case, the murder, the missing original document, the pages burned in fire, and responsibility for Sutra—all remained open.

Liberty had returned for a day. Truth was still on the road to court.

Chapter 28 — Who Owns the Evidence?

Three days after the bail order, the same question that Ira Sinha had left unfinished at the previous hearing returned to the sessions court: “Who bears responsibility for a conclusion like this?” This time Dulari was not in the dock. She sat on the bench behind Rachna Mandal, with Phulo beside her. Bail had brought her body outside, but two nights in custody had left dark circles beneath her eyes.

The issue before the court today was not Dulari's guilt or innocence, but the nature of the technical report produced by Sutra. The prosecution called it material assisting the investigation; Rachna wanted that if the State used even one line of it against anyone, the raw data, change logs, calculation rules, and all human intervention should remain preserved before the court.

Abhiram was quieter today than he had ever been. His laptop was closed. On the table lay only three printed bundles—the first conclusion, the corrected conclusion, and the list of sources that had changed between them. Madhavi sat behind him. She asked softly, “Nervous?”

Abhiram tried to smile. “Not while operating the machine. While explaining what the machine says to human beings.”

“Good. Today it won't be the machine being tested. It will be your honesty.”

Abhiram looked at her. Amid three days of exhaustion, that one sentence felt like support.

Judge Ira Sinha opened the file. “The previous order directed preservation of the technical material. Have copies been filed?”

The prosecutor stood. “Yes, Your Honour. Copies of the original sources from the district records digitisation project, the system's change history, and details of the local operator have been filed. The State submits that this material is only an investigative aid, not an independent witness.”

Rachna rose at once. “Then why was its percentage read out at the previous hearing to show the accused's alleged risk?”

“To explain the circumstances of the investigation.”

“Who created those circumstances—the human being or the system?”

The prosecutor began to answer, but the judge intervened. “Answer that through the structure of the report. First tell me—whose signature is on the report?”

The file was turned over. “The local project coordinator's.”

“Did the coordinator personally derive the conclusion?”

“No. The system did.”

“Can the system appear in court and take an oath?”

A very light laugh moved through the room and died at once. Even the prosecutor could not help smiling. “No, Your Honour.”

“Then a human being is needed who can explain the meaning of every line in the report. Call the operator.”

Abhiram stood and went forward. The formalities of the oath were completed. Rachna looked at him as though, for the first time, he were not a familiar young man but a technical witness.

“Your work?”

“Digital copies of old records, source tagging, and supervision of Sutra's local use.”

“What does Sutra do?”

“It searches for relationships among time, place, names, document sequence, telephone signals, entry times, and financial activity across different records. It shows probabilities; it does not see events.”

“Who makes the probability?”

“Calculation rules, available data, and the questions chosen by human beings.”

Rachna paused. “So the questions are chosen by human beings?”

“Yes.”

“And human beings add the sources?”

“Yes. Many sources arrive automatically, but deciding which sources are relevant to a particular case is also influenced by human judgment.”

“Who made the rules?”

“The project team; some were predefined, some locally modified.”

“In the first result, Dulari's shared telephone was treated as her personal telephone?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“There was not enough local information about the social difference between SIM registration and actual use.”

“So the system took an object shared by a poor household and interpreted it as the private behaviour of one individual?”

Abhiram's voice was low but clear. “Yes. That was an error.”

“Whose error?”

The room fell silent at the question. Abhiram thought for a moment. “It would not be correct to call it only the machine's error. The structure of the sources, incompleteness in the rules, and the failure to add local context—all three contributed. So the operating team bears responsibility too.”

Rachna stepped back. “Your Honour, that is our central point. If a machine's conclusion affects someone's liberty, responsibility cannot be left floating in the air merely by saying ‘the machine said it’.”

The prosecution rose. “But, Your Honour, human witnesses are also fallible. That does not mean all technical tools must be rejected.”

Jaynarayan was sitting on the rear bench. Hearing this, a slight smile came to his lips. Vinay Thakur looked at him. Jaynarayan whispered, “Quite right. Human beings lie; memory fails. That is why human testimony is cross-examined. Data should be cross-examined too.”

The judge asked Abhiram, “Was the system's first conclusion concerning suicide later changed?”

“Yes.”

“On what new facts?”

“Architectural facts showing that the locked room was not fully sealed; independent statements about Vasudha ji's habits; the social use of the shared phone;

confirmation of Dulari's presence across the river; and timing errors in some sources.”

“Timing errors?”

Abhiram opened a bundle. “The old building's wall clock stopped at 4:17, but that was not independent proof of the time of death. A local timing signal was linked to that clock, so the first calculation gave it excessive weight. Later it became clear that the loss of signal could also have been caused by the clock's mechanical stoppage.”

“Meaning that one object's error can spread into many data points at once?”

“Yes.”

The judge made a note. “That is important.”

Rachna lifted the second bundle. “This change log shows some sources unavailable from 4:09 to 4:22. Why?”

Abhiram looked at the page. “There were power fluctuations in the lower part of the old building. The local network of the entry sensors went down. Some data was later recovered.”

“What did the system assume during those thirteen minutes?”

“What was unavailable was not treated as an event.”

Rachna turned immediately. “That is precisely the problem. ‘Not recorded’ and ‘did not happen’ are not the same thing.”

Jaynarayan's eyes went to Abhiram. Many chapters earlier he had said—the machine recognises a number, not a hand; a lock being recorded as open does not tell the whole human story. Abhiram was now speaking that lesson in court in his own voice.

In cross-examination, the prosecutor asked, “You say the system is useful?”

“Yes.”

“It detects contradictions?”

“Yes.”

“It assists human investigation?”

“Yes.”

“Then it is not the unreliable toy the defence is portraying it as?”

Abhiram answered, “No. But being useful and being the final truth are two different things.”

Ira Sinha raised her head. “That is exactly where the court's interest lies.”

After that, a technical officer from the project office gave a short statement. He explained that raw sources came from different institutions; some were original

records, some digital copies, some automated timestamps. The reliability of every source was not identical. Every stage of change could be preserved, but if an operator printed only the final result, the uncertainty in between could disappear from the reader's view.

At that sentence the judge stopped her pen. “The final result shines while uncertainty is left behind—this is not merely a technical problem; it is a judicial problem too.”

Madhavi sat listening from the back. It seemed to her that what was being tested in court today was not artificial intelligence but human laziness. People like a clean number—sixty-eight percent, fifty-two percent, ‘high probability’. A clean number reduces confusion in the mind. But few people have the patience to read how much fog lies inside that clean number.

Dulari leaned toward Rachna's ear and said softly, “They turned my life into a percentage?”

Rachna turned back and squeezed her hand. “Today they are reading what was written underneath the percentage too.”

After midday the court pronounced its order. “At this stage, material from technical analysis will not be treated as independent direct evidence. If a party seeks to rely upon it, the authenticity of the original sources, chain of preservation, method of calculation, change logs, and a competent human witness capable of

explaining the result must be produced. Cross-examination cannot be avoided by calling something ‘the machine's statement’. A system's conclusion will carry only as much weight as its verified sources and transparent method can bear.”

Paper rustled through the room. Abhiram's shoulders loosened. He had neither lost nor won. It felt to him as though Sutra had, for the first time, been placed where it properly belonged—not on the judge's chair, but on the table as a tool.

The judge added, “All versions shall remain preserved. No old result is to be erased or altered by anyone. The cause of the source interruption from 4:09 to 4:22 shall be addressed in a separate technical report.”

The hearing ended. There was no rain on the veranda outside, but the air smelled of wet earth. Descending the steps with Abhiram, Madhavi asked, “Are you angry with your machine now?”

“No. I'm a little ashamed of what I used to believe.”

“Why be ashamed because a belief changed?”

“Because I used to think data was impartial.”

“And now?”

“Data is silent. How it is selected, how it is read, which empty spaces are filled—that is where human beings return.”

From behind them Jaynarayan said, “And with human beings come habits.”

They had reached Kamli Devi's tea stall. Kamli had put the kettle on the stove. Jaynarayan asked for tea without sugar. As she filled the cup, Kamli suddenly stopped and studied his face.

“Babu,” she said softly, “I have just remembered one thing from that night exactly. Earlier I had fitted the time together wrongly.”

Jaynarayan put the cup down on the table. “What thing?”

Kamli's eyes went toward the clock in the old building. “Four ten. Someone familiar took tea. Two spoons of sugar.”

Jaynarayan's hand moved away from the cup. Vasudha did not take sugar.

And the wall clock had stopped seven minutes later.

Chapter 29 — Kamli Devi's Four-O'Clock Tea

Kamli Devi did not remember time by looking at a clock; she remembered it through habit. When the stove was lit, when the milkman set down the brass can, when the first bus whistle was heard, when the cleaner's broom scraped across the veranda—between these things her morning clock was formed. So when she said “four ten,” Vinay Thakur's first question was, “Did you look at a clock?”

Without becoming flustered, Kamli answered, “No. I have something more certain than a clock.”

Vinay's eyebrows rose. “How?”

“I put the milk on at four. Ramavatar usually delivers it around five past four. After he leaves, I pound ginger for the first kettle. That day Ramavatar was five minutes late because of the rain—he himself said the mosque clock had already struck five past four. The person came immediately after he left. Tea takes three or four minutes to make. So it could not have been far from four ten.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Why didn't you tell us earlier?”

Kamli's face tightened. “Earlier you asked me about the two cups at ten at night. My mind got stuck there. Then police, crowds, death... I treated whoever took tea

after dawn as a separate matter. Later, when I heard the clock had stopped at 4:17, the thought came back to me; but I told myself—it was courthouse tea, it could have been anyone. Today, when everyone came out of court talking about ‘4:09 to 4:22’, it all fitted together.”

Vinay said, “Name?”

Kamli lowered the flame beneath the stove. Two clients were standing nearby. She served them tea and sent them away, then pulled the reed screen a little farther across. “I will not say the name openly. I will say it in my statement. People follow you all the way home.”

Jaynarayan nodded. “Fine. For now, tell us the limits of your identification. Someone who is at the courthouse every day?”

“Not every day. A familiar face. I have seen the person near Vasudha beti two or three times. Once not quarrelling with her, exactly, but speaking sharply.”

Madhavi's body tightened. “Someone from the family?”

Kamli looked at Madhavi but did not answer. “I will give my statement to Vinay Babu. If you all hear a name, each of you will make your own story. Let the police ask first.”

Jaynarayan smiled. “Kamli Devi, you are teaching me my work.”

“You people sometimes forget that selling tea also involves cross-examination.”

Rachna arrived there too. Dulari had gone home; Phulo had pressed her to rest for one day. After hearing Kamli, Rachna first told Vinay, “Take an independent statement. We will remain outside. Share later only what is lawful to share.”

Kamli went into a small room with woman constable Saroj Devi. Half an hour later the statement was complete. Vinay came out and said only this: “The name has been recorded. It is not public yet. Identification procedure will be conducted separately.”

Madhavi asked, “The tea?”

“Two spoons of sugar. For the person themselves.”

“The cup?” Abhiram asked.

“A thick glass from Kamli's stall. The person drank it there and returned it.”

Jaynarayan said slowly, “So this was not the tea in the white cup.”

Vinay nodded. “At ten that night, Buchchan's son took two cups to the old building—blue without sugar, white with two spoons. The tea at four ten in the morning was separate.”

The two sweet teas in the same case created a strange parallel. Madhavi asked, “Who drank the sweet tea at ten that night?”

“Still not certain,” Vinay said. “The prints on the white cup are indistinct. There was too much rain and too much later handling. But the residue inside the cup shows a sugar level consistent with Kamli's account.”

Jaynarayan walked onto the veranda of the old building. Kamli's stall could be seen from there. The distance was not great. A person who drank tea at four ten could easily have reached the records room within seven minutes. But ‘could have reached’ was that old phrase again—possibility, not event.

“The 4:17 clock,” Madhavi said. “If that wasn't the time of death, why would someone stop it at that time?”

Jaynarayan answered, “To make it the centre of the story. People see the clock, seize the time, then arrange everything else around it. Put one shining object in a staged scene and the eye gets caught there.”

Abhiram said, “The first Sutra got caught there too.”

“Human beings get caught first. Sutra repeats their structure afterward.”

They reopened the scene-examination report. The clock's battery cell was sound, but one fine tooth inside was bent. The clock could have stopped if struck hard; if someone held the hands by force and then released

them, the mechanical tooth could jam. There was no clear external impact mark on the clock.

Vinay took out a new paper. "The supplementary medical opinion has also come. What was unclear in the preliminary examination became clearer after tissue analysis."

Madhavi's face went pale. Hearing discussion of Vasudha's body was still unbearable to her. Rachna came to stand beside her.

Vinay read, "The injury on the right side of the head was sustained during life. It could have been caused by a hard edge or by a fall. At present, the injury alone cannot be declared the certain cause of death; however, no concentration of poison was found in the body sufficient to establish a voluntary death. There is a minute trace of sleep medication, within therapeutic range."

Jaynarayan asked, "Did Vasudha take that medicine?"

Madhavi said, "Sometimes, when she couldn't sleep, a doctor had prescribed it, but she took it very rarely."

"The prescription at home?"

"It may be found."

Rachna said, "This supplementary opinion does not by itself prove murder."

"No," Jaynarayan agreed. "But it weakens the simple suicide story."

Vinay opened another page of the file. “White particles under the fingernails—a mixture of old plaster and lime. They match material from two points on the wall at the scene, but are not distinctive enough to say which point. The black streak on the betel-nut box—a general chemical match with ash from burned paper.”

Madhavi's eyes widened. “The box was near the fire?”

“We cannot say when. But the black particles are of the same general type.”

Jaynarayan slowly wrote five points on a sheet—sweet tea; four ten; clock at four seventeen; head injury; soot on the betel-nut box. Then a sixth—the blue cup in the drain.

“And the seventh?” Abhiram asked naturally, then fell silent himself. The word ‘seventh’ was no longer an ordinary number in this house and town.

Jaynarayan looked at him. “Six are enough for now. The urge to complete a number can ruin an investigation.”

At the far end of the veranda, Ramcharit the peon was quietly directing a cleaner. Jaynarayan called him over. “Who would be in the old building around four in the morning?”

Ramcharit scratched his head. “On a rainy night? Buchchan on watch. Cleaners come after four forty-five in the morning. No records staff member is on night

duty. But from the rear veranda of the old building, one can reach the new building without passing the main gate.”

“Who knows about the inspection panel in the storeroom?”

Ramcharit thought for a while. “Me, the old records clerk, two masons... and those who were around during the repairs. Very few from the younger lot.”

Vinay asked, “Did Vasudha know?”

“I cannot say.”

Abhiram opened the small plan. An air duct ran from the storeroom toward the ventilator of the records room. It was not large enough for a person to pass through, but some sections were open enough to feed through thin cord or a tool. The old latch was on the outer door; the duct could perhaps have been used to complete the appearance of a room locked from inside—still only a hypothesis.

Jaynarayan said, “We’ll repeat the latch experiment, this time from the inspection-panel side of the duct.”

Vinay began preparing the permission paper. “Not at the original site first. On a replica.”

“Fine.”

That afternoon, in one corner of the police workshop, a door and latch were built to matching measurements.

The bends of the old duct were reproduced with bamboo pipes according to the plan. Thin strong cord, a small hook-like wire, and a long sliding rod were used. The first attempt failed. On the second the cord jammed. On the third the latch lifted halfway, then fell. On the fifth attempt, the small wire caught the ring of the latch; a person outside could pull, close the door, and then seat the latch.

Abhiram became excited, but Jaynarayan said at once, "The replica shows that it is possible. It does not show that it happened at the scene."

Vinay added, "And to know this method, one would have to know the structure of the duct."

A question rose in Madhavi's mind—who knew it? Ramcharit? The records clerk? The old masons? Someone searching for Vasudha's papers? Someone in the family who understood her work?

By evening, Rachna was given a short extract from Kamli's formal statement. The name had been blacked out on the copy because identification procedure was still pending. But one line remained visible: "The person had previously been seen as a family acquaintance of Vasudha Karn."

Madhavi held her breath as she read it. She remembered the first day at Vasudha's house—Arun's measured words, Prakhar's clenched jaw, the separate

lies of different members of the family. But Jaynarayan gently took the paper back from her hand.

“Do not create a name in your mind,” he said. “Kamli’s identification still has to be tested.”

“But someone known to the family—”

“Being known to the family is not a crime.”

“Tea at four ten?”

“Unusual. But being unusual is not a crime.”

Madhavi grew irritated. “You blunt the point of every sharp thing.”

“I do not blunt it in an investigation. A weak point will snap in court, so I test it first.”

On the way home that night, four ten and four seventeen kept circling in Madhavi’s mind. Seven minutes—in so little time a person could drink tea, cross the veranda, reach the door, stop the clock, burn papers? Or had all of that happened earlier, with 4:17 merely the final point in a staged scene?

Abhiram sent her a message: “New time point added to Sutra. Run the result?”

Madhavi wrote, “Write the question first. Result afterward.”

The reply came: "Question: is there a relationship between the 4:10 tea and the 4:17 clock, or only proximity?"

A smile came to Madhavi's lips. "Now run it."

A little later the answer arrived: "Relationship not established. Worth investigating."

She wrote, "Today your Sutra has become sensible."

Abhiram replied, "No. The operator has become slightly less foolish."

For the first time in many days Madhavi laughed freely. But when the laughter stopped, Vasudha's half-written line returned to her mind: "If this paper disappears again..."

The paper was missing. There was ash from paper. There was sweet tea. The clock had been stopped.

And at four ten, a person known to Vasudha was awake, moving, and drinking tea.

Chapter 30 — A Staged Suicide

By the following week, the question before the court had moved beyond Dulari's bail. Vasudha's death, first recorded as a "possible suicide in a room locked from within," was now the subject of a police application seeking reconsideration of that initial description. The application, signed by Vinay Thakur, did not yet use the word murder conclusively, but it stated clearly: "There are sufficient indications that the circumstances of death were deliberately altered."

Ira Sinha read the application and asked Vinay, "How did you arrive at this conclusion?"

Vinay said, "Not from a single item of evidence. Physical evidence, the supplementary medical opinion, the timeline, witness statements, and the deceased's established habits are converging."

"Give them in sequence. Keep inference separate."

Rachna sat beside Dulari. This time the prosecution itself supported the police's new application, yet the charges against Dulari had not been withdrawn. The weight of that contradiction was plain in the courtroom—the murder investigation was reopening, but the name of the poor young woman accused of that murder still remained on paper.

Vinay placed the first item before the court—the clock. “The wall clock stopped at 4:17. At first, that time was treated as an indicator of death. Mechanical examination shows that an internal tooth can jam and stop the clock after external interference or a strong jolt. The independent medical estimate of time of death is not required to correspond with 4:17.”

Second—the tea. “At around ten at night, two cups were delivered—a blue cup without sugar for the deceased, and a sweet white cup for the person with her. The blue cup was later found in the drain; the white cup at the scene. At around 4:10 in the morning, a familiar person separately drank sweet tea at Kamli Devi's stall. Identification procedure is underway.”

Third—the deceased's habits. “Independent statements say Vasudha Karn did not take betel nut after evening; the box always remained at the right corner of the table; she drank tea without sugar; while writing, she kept her chair straight and the pen pointing to the right. At the scene, the betel-nut box was on the floor to the left, the chair turned rightward, a cup of sweet tea was present, the pen reversed, and her personal blue cup was in the drain.”

The judge interrupted. “Habit evidence has limited value. A person does not behave identically every day.”

Jaynarayan, present with the court's permission as an investigative assistant rather than a formal expert witness, bowed his head in agreement. Vinay said,

“Correct. That is why the police are not drawing a conclusion from any single habit. Five independent inconsistencies are being considered together with physical facts.”

Fourth—the ash. “Minute ash from burned paper was found beneath the table; black particles of a similar nature were found on the rim of the betel-nut box. Dulari says she saw a man burning papers. The original document remains missing.”

Fifth—the locked room. “An inspection panel in the old air duct was found. A person cannot pass through the duct, but replica testing showed that a thin cord and a small tool could possibly be used to seat the latch. Definite traces of such use at the actual scene are still under examination. Therefore ‘locked from inside’ can no longer be treated as decisive proof of suicide.”

Sixth—the medical opinion. “The head injury was sustained while she was alive; no poison sufficient to establish suicide was found; sleep medication was within therapeutic range. Accidental injury, a fall after being pushed, or some other act—all three possibilities require full examination.”

Ira Sinha was silent for a few moments. “Does all this prove murder?”

“No,” Vinay said. “But the suicide scene does not appear natural. There is sufficient basis to believe the scene may have been altered. We therefore seek formal

expansion of the investigation toward suspected homicide.”

Rachna stood. “We do not oppose this application. But I would add one thing—if the police themselves now accept that the scene may have been staged, then the allegations built on Dulari's initial absence and Sutra's erroneous result must be reassessed at the same time.”

The prosecutor said, “The investigation is open; the accused's role will also remain under investigation.”

“Let her role remain under investigation,” Rachna replied, “but do not close the investigation by turning a poor witness into a convenient culprit.”

Dulari's face was expressionless, but her fingers gripped the edge of her notebook. Madhavi watched from behind. If Vasudha were alive, she thought, she would probably be standing beside Rachna at this moment. The thought filled Madhavi's chest with grief and strength at once.

The court accepted the police application. The order was brief but decisive—the initial presumption of suicide would not bind the death investigation; on the available material, there would be a full investigation into possible violent death and evidence tampering; raw technical data would be preserved; witnesses protected; the missing original document searched for; and scene reconstruction conducted under lawful supervision.

The moment they came outside, reporters surrounded them again. Questions came sharply—“Murder proved?” “Dulari cleared?” “Family under suspicion?” Vinay gave only one sentence: “The investigation has reopened; no one has been declared guilty.”

Jaynarayan escaped the crowd and took the narrow path behind Kamli's stall, with Madhavi and Abhiram beside him. For them, the order was not a victory but the opening of the next difficult stage. The simple suicide story had broken apart; now every lie, every absence, every old document had to be read again.

That day the old records room was reopened for another limited examination. Vinay personally checked the seal. As Madhavi entered, the same smell of dampness, old paper, and metal reached her. Vasudha's body was no longer there, yet the room was still filled by her absence.

Jaynarayan arranged the old scene photographs on the wall in sequence—the first morning; the cups; the betel-nut box; the clock; the table; the blue cup in the drain; the iron panel in the storeroom. “I have not come here to construct a story,” he said. “I want to see how many separate facts can endure the same story.”

Abhiram opened Sutra, but this time there were no percentages on the screen. Only a timeline.

8:30 p.m. — Madhavi leaves.

After 9:00 p.m. — Dulari enters.

Around 10:00 p.m. — two cups of tea in the old building.

10:30–10:45 p.m. — electrical flicker.

After midnight — heavy rain; reliability of gate watch reduced.

Around 4:10 a.m. — familiar person drinks sweet tea at Kamli's stall.

4:17 a.m. — wall clock stops; local timing signal breaks.

4:09–4:22 a.m. — some entry sources unavailable.

After dawn — room found locked from inside.

Jaynarayan placed a finger on the sheet. “We will not assume, yet, that the person who drank sweet tea at ten at night and the person who drank sweet tea at four ten were the same.”

Abhiram nodded. “Sutra also keeps them as separate events.”

Madhavi asked, “When did Dulari leave?”

“According to her statement,” Vinay said, “after speaking to Vasudha she saw the shadow of a person burning papers; frightened, she moved toward the rear veranda; then she left through the old corridor and took

the river road. Some stretches of that route have no cameras.”

“Was Vasudha alive then?”

Vinay opened the page containing Dulari's statement. “Dulari says that when she left she did not hear Vasudha's voice and did not go back into the room. So she does not confirm it.”

Jaynarayan said, “A proper boundary. What she did not see, she did not claim.”

He stood before the old photograph of the table. “Why stage a suicide?”

Madhavi said, “To conceal a murder.”

“The general answer. But what story did the person staging the scene want?”

Abhiram said, “Vasudha was under stress, working alone at night, wrote something—and then chose death herself.”

“And Dulari?”

“The last person to meet her, then missing—so a shadow of theft or wrongdoing falls on her.”

“Exactly. The scene was shaping not only the story of death, but also the direction of blame.”

Madhavi's eyes went to the half-written line—“If this paper disappears again...” It was not self-narration; it

was a warning. If whatever followed had been burned away, the line could resemble the unfinished thought of a despairing person.

“That note,” Madhavi said suddenly. “What if the full sentence had been something like, ‘If this paper disappears again, then I will do such-and-such’? Remove what follows and the meaning changes.”

Jaynarayan's eyes brightened. “That is why the ash matters.”

Vinay said, “The laboratory is trying to recover writing from the burned fragments. No clear letters yet.”

Abhiram opened a high-resolution image. On one fragment of ash there was a curve of ink, but no word. “If any letters emerge, we can compare them with old writing samples—but we will not infer the original meaning.”

“Good,” Jaynarayan said. “Do not fill empty space with a story.”

Madhavi thought of her own dreams. The red dupatta, the wall, the blue thread. The mind too fills empty spaces. Perhaps the difference between investigation and dream was only this: investigation must have the courage to empty again what it has filled.

Outside, in the storeroom, the second stage of replica examination was conducted. Three photographs had already been taken of newer scratches in the fine dust

inside the old inspection panel. The specialist could say only that the scratches were later than the very old rust; no date could be assigned. A fine blue fibre was found inside the duct, but it was merely blue; there was no basis to connect it with Kusuma's thread.

Abhiram became excited at the sight of the blue fibre, then stopped himself. "Blue is the colour of a thousand things."

Jaynarayan smiled. "Progress."

"What?"

"You stopped your own inference before I did."

Madhavi laughed. "Effect of the court."

At that moment Vinay's phone rang. Kamli Devi's identification procedure had been completed. She had identified one face among three independent photographs. Vinay kept his expression neutral as he listened. When he ended the call, he looked at Jaynarayan.

"Name?" Madhavi blurted.

Vinay did not answer immediately. "An identification has been made. But one witness's identification is not enough for arrest. We will recheck the timeline, vehicle, telephone, and household statements."

"Someone familiar?"

“Someone within Vasudha's family circle.”

Madhavi's heart beat hard. She wanted to guess the name, but Jaynarayan's earlier warning returned—do not construct a name in your mind.

Vinay added, “And one more thing. The person had previously said that at four in the morning they were asleep at home.”

Now Jaynarayan's face changed. Only slightly, but Madhavi saw it. “So—a new lie.”

“Yes.”

“A lie is not murder,” Abhiram said.

Jaynarayan looked at him with satisfaction. “Now you are saying my line before I do.”

Evening light fell obliquely through the ventilator. The same thin current of air stirred the calendar page that had caught Jaynarayan's eye on the first day. The locked room had once been a mystery; now a staged narrative was beginning to show inside it. But the face of the person who composed that narrative still required proof fit for court.

Madhavi stood beside the table and looked at Vasudha's empty chair. For the first time it seemed to her that perhaps the death had been turned into a suicide, but Vasudha's work had not. The ash of paper, Dulari's voice, Kamli's tea, Abhiram's corrected data,

Jaynarayan's doubt—all of it was becoming the words that followed Vasudha's unfinished sentence.

As they left, Jaynarayan said, “The investigation is harder now.”

Madhavi stared. “The simple story has broken. Why harder?”

“Because now we know the scene was lying. But the author of that lie may not have been only one person.”

Abhiram looked toward the dark corridor behind the old building. “Meaning someone helped stage the scene?”

Jaynarayan did not answer. He only said, “The person who knew the habits of the room did not fully know Vasudha's habits; that is why mistakes were left behind. And the person who knew the air duct knew the old body of the building. Those two kinds of knowledge do not have to belong to the same person.”

A shiver ran through Madhavi. The suspicion of murder had now grown larger than a single face.

The gate of the old building closed. Outside, the courthouse emptied into evening. Inside, the seal was affixed again.

And for the first time, in bold letters, the suicide file was marked: “SUSPECTED VIOLENT DEATH;

INVESTIGATION INTO SCENE ALTERATION
CONTINUING.”

Chapter 31 — Jaynarayan's Bias

On the second morning after the murder investigation was reopened, Jaynarayan reached the courthouse very early. The night's rain had stopped, but the bricks of the old veranda were still wet and dark red. Kamli Devi had lit the stove. A pot of milk was on the fire, ginger on the grinding stone, and beyond the reed screen the first clients of the morning had not yet arrived.

Vinay Thakur was already there. In his hand was a copy of the identification sheet prepared from three photographs. The face Kamli had selected the previous day had been named by Vinay within the investigation team that very night—Arun Karn.

At the name, Jaynarayan said nothing for a long while. He merely asked for tea without sugar. Kamli pushed the cup toward him. “I said what I saw. But that dawn had rain, half-light, an umbrella—everything. I did not see the face as clearly as I see yours now.”

Vinay said, “In the identification sheet you picked Arun from three independent photographs.”

“Yes. The walk, the shoulder, the cut of the face—it seemed like him.” Kamli added again, “Seemed like him. I will not swear before God that it was he.”

Jaynarayan rested a finger on the cup. His mind, however, was moving faster than Kamli's caution.

Husband. A lie at home. An argument with his wife two days earlier. Disagreement with Vasudha's work. The car out at night. Then tea at dawn. So many points seemed to lean toward one another.

“Do not call Arun again yet,” he told Vinay. “First reconstruct all his time that night again. After he returned home from Rupa's health centre, then up to dawn. Neighbours, the second phone, activity inside the house—everything.”

Vinay watched him for a moment. “Have you already made up your mind?”

“Not made up. A direction is visible.”

“Keep some distance between a direction and a decision in the mind.”

Jaynarayan did not answer. Vinay had learned the right to say that sentence from him; that made it harder to hear.

In the digitisation room Abhiram had reopened the time-correlation work that had run through the night. On Sutra's screen Arun's two phones, his vehicle, the Sahajini health centre, the entrance door of his house, a neighbourhood pharmacy, and the distance to the courthouse appeared on separate lines. The moment he saw Jaynarayan, Abhiram said, “There is a discrepancy.”

“One?”

“Two now.”

Madhavi was there as well. She was reading the laboratory report on letters recovered from the ash of Vasudha's papers. Hearing Jaynarayan's voice, she closed the page.

Abhiram opened the first line. “At 3:56 in the morning, there was a video call on Arun's smaller phone from Rupa Devi's health centre. Duration: eighteen minutes and seven seconds.”

Jaynarayan frowned. “A video-call log tells us only the time. Was Arun actually in front of the screen?”

“The centre has one short still image preserved in its secure service record with the patient's consent—because a nurse connected the doctor during the call. Arun's face is clear in the image. Behind him is his study at home. Time: 3:56 to 4:14.”

Vinay asked, “Preserved from the original service record?”

“Yes. I am showing only a verification copy for now. A lawful request for the original has been sent.”

Jaynarayan was silent. How far was Kamli's stall from Arun's house? Abhiram opened the map. On that rainy dawn, at least twelve minutes by motorcycle; far more on foot. But the video call lasted until 4:14. Kamli said approximately 4:10. The same person could not have been in both places.

“Kamli's time could be off by five or seven minutes,” Jaynarayan said.

Abhiram nodded. “That is why there is a second point.”

At 4:18, neighbourhood doctor Dr Neelima Jha arrived at Arun's house. Arun's mother had been suffering increased difficulty breathing since the night. The doctor's assistant got out at the gate carrying the medicine case; on the outside camera of a neighbouring house, Arun himself could be seen opening the gate. 4:18. The doctor's written prescription was timed 4:23.

Madhavi said quietly, “The person who drank tea at 4:10 was not Arun.”

Something hardened in Jaynarayan's face. “If Kamli's time is right.”

Abhiram placed the two points on the screen—3:56–4:14 video call; 4:18 at the house gate. Then Kamli's tea-stall point: 4:10 ± five minutes. Sutra did not turn red; it gave a grey warning: “LOCATION-TIME MATCH FOR SAME PERSON: HIGHLY IMPROBABLE.”

Jaynarayan's eyes remained fixed on the words. “Highly improbable” was the machine's phrase, but the blow landed inside a human being.

Vinay asked calmly, “And now, the direction?”

Jaynarayan pulled out a chair and sat. After a long time he said, "The direction changes."

Madhavi watched him carefully. Jaynarayan being proved wrong was not new; he himself repeatedly said that an inference should be changed when facts changed. But today his face held not merely the failure of an investigation, but the shadow of something old.

"Kaka," Abhiram said softly, "Sutra is not declaring Arun innocent. It only says the time does not fit Kamli's dawn identification."

"I understand."

"Then—"

"I understand," Jaynarayan repeated, this time a little sharply. Then he softened at once. "Forgive me. I am not angry with you."

He rose and went to the window. Outside, the courthouse yard was slowly filling: a rickshaw, two bicycles, a clerk carrying a bundle of files. An ordinary morning. Inside him, however, a night twenty-seven years old had opened.

The Chandrakala case of Belahi, twenty-seven years earlier. A newly married woman disappeared one night. Her husband said she had gone to her maternal home. The family said the husband was a very decent man. Jaynarayan was then a young officer. He suspected the husband, but between family influence and incomplete

evidence the investigation slackened. Months later, Chandrakala's skeleton was found where the river had cut deep into the bank; identification was made from her bangles and dental treatment. By then the husband had gone abroad. The case was never completed.

From then on Jaynarayan never treated a domestic lie lightly. To him, “the husband is lying” was not merely one fact; it was the bell of an old crime. He could still remember Chandrakala's mother's face—“Why didn't you arrest him earlier?”

Madhavi came and stood behind him. “That old case?”

Jaynarayan started. “How do you know?”

“Didi told me once. There is one case from your life that you remember in every new domestic-violence file.”

“Vasudha used to say many things.”

“She also said that an unfinished crime makes a person's eyes sharper—and crooked as well.”

A small line of pain appeared on Jaynarayan's face. “She said that to my face.”

“And you were angry?”

“For three days.”

Abhiram smiled in spite of himself. “Then Vasudha Didi won.”

“In an argument she had more patience than facts when it came to winning.”

After a brief silence Jaynarayan returned to the table. “I was reading Arun's lie as though it were the same kind of lie Chandrakala's husband told. But Arun's first lie was about protecting Rupa's private pain. Then, as soon as Kamli's identification appeared, my mind took the old road. That is confirmation bias. Write it down.”

Abhiram actually began making a note.

Madhavi laughed. “A report on yourself?”

“If the investigative tool is a human being, the tool's errors should be part of the record too.”

On Sutra's screen Abhiram added a new note: “HUMAN INFERENCE REVISED: ARUN-KAMLI IDENTIFICATION CONFLICTS WITH TIME. RE-IDENTIFICATION REQUIRED.”

Jaynarayan said, “Remove the name. In Kamli's next identification, do not show Arun's photograph again in a distinctive way. Same age range, same build, people holding umbrellas in rain—as neutral as possible. And do not remind Kamli, ‘You selected Arun earlier.’”

Vinay agreed. “Right.”

When they returned to Kamli's stall, Jaynarayan asked nothing this time. Vinay explained the procedure. Kamli looked at five new images. After a while her finger

paused over one, then withdrew. It paused over another. “The walk looks like this. But the face? I cannot say.”

“Certain identification?”

“No.”

“Then it will be recorded: not certain.”

Kamli seemed to breathe more easily. “Good. Earlier everyone was looking at me as though I had to give them a name. What I saw was half a face in the rain.”

Jaynarayan listened silently. It occurred to him that respect for a human witness did not mean making the witness ‘certain’; it meant preserving the witness's uncertainty.

Back in the records room, he stood before Sutra's screen. “Today you saved me.”

Abhiram looked startled. “Me?”

“Your machine.”

Abhiram smiled. “Yesterday you were scolding it.”

“A tool can be scolded. It can also teach.”

Madhavi said, “And can a tool teach a human being?”

Jaynarayan looked at the two impossible time points on the screen. “If the human being is willing to listen—yes.”

At that moment a new Sutra search notification appeared at the top. A blurred line in an old name-list had matched against a modern family record. The name was incomplete, but its beginning was clear —“Rasbihari...”

Abhiram's fingers froze over the keyboard.

Madhavi looked at him. “What happened?”

“Nothing,” Abhiram said immediately. “It's an old match.”

Jaynarayan was still passing through the sting of his own bias; he did not notice the colour change in Abhiram's face. Madhavi noticed—but did not understand what it meant.

The incomplete name Rasbihari flashed on the screen and then disappeared back into the source list.

And in Abhiram's mind an old chest in his own house opened—one he had not touched for years.

Chapter 32 — The Papers in Abhiram's House

That evening Abhiram went straight home from the courthouse. On ordinary days, before even parking his motorcycle in the courtyard, he would call to his mother, “Still alive?” and a voice from inside would answer, “So far.” Today he said nothing. He switched off the motorcycle and stood for a long time in the darkness of the veranda.

His mother was grinding spices on the stone. She looked up. “Quarrelled with someone?”

“No.”

“Then why that face, as if Sutra has thrown you out of your job?”

Abhiram could not laugh even though he wanted to. “Ma, where is Baba's old chest?”

His mother's hand stopped. “Which one? The wooden one that belonged to Dada?”

“Yes.”

“On the loft in the back room. Why?”

“I need to look at some old papers.”

His mother watched him for a moment. “Before dinner or after?”

“Now.”

“Then if a snake comes out, it is your responsibility.”

“There is no snake.”

“Old family papers can contain things worse than snakes.” She laughed, but Abhiram did not. She noticed and let the questions go. “Take the ladder. There is a lot of dust.”

The back room was the least-used part of the house. On the loft were an iron bucket, Dada's old radio, a tin box containing Baba's school certificates, and a wooden chest. A brass strip ran across the lid, half rusted. The key was kept beneath his mother's sewing box—everyone in the house knew that, but no one opened the chest.

Abhiram brought the chest down. The smell of dust made him sneeze. Inside were two bundles of clothes, yellowed letters, land-revenue receipts, an old Maithili almanac, Baba's college photograph, and a packet of papers tied in red cloth.

As he opened the packet, his mother came to the doorway. “Dadaji kept those very carefully. He used to say—my father worked in the copying office. Throwing away old papers is a sin.”

Abhiram's hands stopped. “My great-grandfather worked in the copying office?”

“You didn't know?”

“No.”

“Your Baba knew. You were a child then. What importance did anyone give the matter at home afterward? An ordinary job, ordinary pay. Later Dadaji taught at a school.”

“What was my great-grandfather's name?”

“Madhaveswar. Madhaveswar Jha. But in copied records you may also find ‘Madho Jha’.”

Something seemed to sink inside Abhiram's chest. Sutra's incomplete match had stopped only at “Rasbihari...”, yet Vasudha's land case, the 1934 relief camp, the old copying office—all of it had suddenly reached the loft of his own house.

He opened the first bundle. Mostly revenue records, partitions, releases from debt. Dates from the 1950s. The second bundle held older papers, some stuck to cloth. His training told him not to touch every page directly. He immediately fetched nitrile gloves, cleared the table, and used his phone only to record the condition of the documents.

His mother laughed. “Have the papers in our house become court evidence too?”

“Possibly.”

Her laughter stopped. “Vasudha Didi's case?”

Abhiram took time to answer. “Possibly.”

This time his mother pulled up a chair and sat down. “Then I will first tell you what I know. Dada gave this packet to your Baba two years before he died. I do not know whether Baba opened it. After Baba died, I gathered everything together and kept it. No one came to the house asking for these papers. No one ever demanded them.”

“Did Dada ever mention Seven Hamlets, Kusuma, or the name Rasbihari?”

His mother thought for a long time. “Rasbihari... the name sounds familiar. Dada used to tell a story about an old copyist—‘His written name was erased from paper, but not from people's mouths.’ Whether that was this name or another, I cannot say.”

Abhiram's heartbeat quickened. “And Kusuma?”

“No.”

He examined the pages one after another under the light. Something was caught inside the fold of a thick old sheet. When he opened it, a half-size certified copy emerged. At the top was a faded impression of an old colonial seal; below it, a handwritten note in a mixture of Maithili and Kaithi/Devanagari. The main sheet was a later copy, probably made in 1956 or 1957. The date of the original application—1935.

Name: “Rasbihari Das”—temporary worker copying relief records.

Abhiram's breath caught.

The application stated that for post-earthquake resettlement a list had been prepared of the names, boundaries, and shared-use land of families from seven settlements; before the original list could reach the court it had become “unavailable”; the applicant requested a fresh copy based on the draft retained with him.

One line below had been half cut away—“In the original copy, seven separate certification...” The rest of the paper's edge was damaged.

Abhiram stopped there. “Seven certifications”—Vasudha's notes, the constellation ledger, the half-letter. Everything had moved a little closer together, but the meaning had still not opened.

On the reverse of the paper was a later note in red pencil: “Copy not to be issued without comparison with boundary map.” Beneath it, in very faint ink, was a signature: “Madhaveswar Jha, Copying Assistant.”

Abhiram went still in the chair.

His mother asked, “Your great-grandfather's name?”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

“Then this paper has to be given to the investigation.”

“Give it,” his mother said simply.

Abhiram looked at her. “You're not afraid?”

“Of what?”

“What if Great-grandfather... what if in changing the boundary...”

His mother stopped him. “What kind of justice is it to make your own ancestor a thief before reading the paper? And if he did make a mistake, will hiding it make the mistake right?”

Abhiram's throat went dry. The answer was clear. His mind was not. Madhavi's face came to him—how she carried the blue thread, Kusuma, and Seven Hamlets as though they were the unfinished work of her teacher Vasudha. If Abhiram told her that a Rasbihari application and his own great-grandfather's signature had been found in a chest in his house, what would Madhavi think? That he had known all along? That his family belonged to the circle in which documents had disappeared? That the operator of Sutra had himself been hiding a source?

He felt ashamed of his own thought. Until now he had hidden nothing. He had only found something. But what he did in the next moment would change that truth.

His mother set down his dinner plate. “Eat first, then call the police.”

“It's night already.”

“Vinay Babu doesn't answer the phone at night?”

“He does.”

“Then?”

Abhiram looked at the paper again. Red pencil. His great-grandfather's signature. On one edge, a small pencilled number—“7/A”. How old the number was, who wrote it, none of that was clear. His trained mind said—secure the source, gloves, images, inventory, immediate notice. His fear said—understand the whole thing first.

He picked up the phone, opened Vinay's name, then closed it again.

His mother saw. “What happened?”

“I'll make images first. Tomorrow I'll hand over the original with them. It isn't wise to go out carrying old paper at night.”

That was half true. Perhaps his mother understood, perhaps not. “Fine. But tomorrow.”

Abhiram made high-resolution images and recorded the paper's measurements, colour, folds, and damage. He placed the original packet in a separate clean envelope

and did not return it to the chest; he put it in a locked desk drawer.

Then he opened the local copy of Sutra. Under the rules, a private source could not be added to the main case without formal approval. He stored the image only in a separate folder on his own laptop. He named the file: “old_copy_to_check.”

Then he disliked the name. He changed it to: “Rasbihari_1935_Madhaveshwar.”

Seeing the names clearly on the screen made the fear greater.

He read the application's words: “seven settlements.” “Original list unavailable.” “boundary map.” “fresh copy.” The root of the land case Vasudha had been fighting might lie in this very page. If his great-grandfather's signature merely marked official work, the fear was pointless. But if the red-pencil boundary note was in his hand and the later map had shifted—then what?

At half past eleven that night, a message arrived from Madhavi: “In the ash letters, something like ‘return...’ has been found. Not certain. We'll look tomorrow.”

Abhiram read the message and typed: “All right.”

He could have written: “Something has been found in my house too.” Three times his fingers moved toward the

keyboard, three times they withdrew. In the end he sent only “All right.”

And that one word became his first conscious concealment.

The next morning he rose resolved to call Vinay, but as he was leaving the house his mother said, “Don't forget the paper.”

“I won't.”

He opened the drawer. The original sheet lay safe in its envelope. His hand reached toward it for a moment; then he took only the storage device containing the digital copy. He left the original at home.

“The original?” his mother asked.

“I'll show the copy first. If it belongs in the investigation, we'll take the original formally.”

The reasoning was not wrong. But the whole truth was that Abhiram still wanted to buy himself an hour.

At the courthouse he went directly to the digitisation room. Madhavi had not arrived yet. Jaynarayan was outside with Vinay. The opportunity was simple. He opened the copy, put Rasbihari's name into the main search, but did not add the private paper as a source. Sutra returned three new matches from public records—the 1935 application list, the 1941 land demarcation, and a 1957 copy application.

A copy of the 1957 application was listed in the district index, but the image was unavailable. The applicant's name had worn away. Of “Madhaveswar”, only “Madh...” remained.

The paper in Abhiram's house completed that blank.

“You're here this early?” Madhavi's voice came from behind.

Abhiram startled and closed the file.

Madhavi laughed. “What? A secret romance with Sutra?”

“No. I was looking at an old match.”

“Rasbihari?”

Abhiram's face changed again. This time Madhavi saw it clearly.

“Yes,” he said. “Some new lists have turned up.”

“Show me.”

“It's still raw. We'll look together when Jaynarayan Babu comes.”

Madhavi paused. “All right.”

She sat down, trusting him. Inside Abhiram that trust pricked like a thorn. He could still tell her. Only one sentence—there is a copy in a chest in my house. But he remembered Jaynarayan's bias from the previous day:

once a wrong name settles in the mind, facts begin arranging themselves around it. He told himself—verify first, then speak.

The reasoning was beautiful.

And beautiful reasoning is often fear's finest covering.

Chapter 33 — A Rift in Affection

Until noon Abhiram said nothing about the paper found in his house. Jaynarayan had gone to the police station; Vinay was having Kamli's re-identification report prepared. Madhavi was matching letters in the images of the ash. The two of them sat at the same table, Sutra's screen between them—as before. But Abhiram's silence today was a different silence.

Twice Madhavi asked, "Has something happened?"

Twice the answer was, "No."

The third time she did not ask.

Toward evening Abhiram's mother came to the courthouse. In her hand was a small steel tiffin, covered with a gamchha. Standing at the door of the digitisation room, she said, "My son ran off at dawn without eating. While you people investigate, make sure he eats too."

Madhavi rose at once and took the tiffin. "Please come inside."

The colour left Abhiram's face. "Ma, why have you come?"

"What do you mean, why? Are rice and dal criminal evidence?"

Madhavi burst out laughing. "Please sit."

His mother sat on the chair and looked carefully at Madhavi. “You are Madhavi?”

“Yes.”

“I hear your name at home.”

Abhiram coughed. “Ma.”

“What did I say? I hear her name. Is hearing a name a crime?” She opened the tiffin. “You eat this fried vegetable too. He’ll finish everything alone.”

A faint smile touched Madhavi’s cheeks. Abhiram lowered his eyes. For one moment the investigation, death, and documents receded from the room; there was only a mother, her son, and a young woman whose name was heard in their home.

As she served the food, his mother asked casually, “What happened to those old papers from last night?”

Abhiram’s hand stopped.

Madhavi’s smile stopped too. “Which papers?”

His mother looked at Abhiram. “The ones from Dada’s chest. There was a name—Rasbihari, wasn’t there? He said they had to be given to the investigation.”

The room suddenly became very quiet. Outside on the veranda someone slapped down a file, a bell rang in the distance, but inside, three people kept hearing three different meanings in the same sentence.

Abhiram said softly, “Ma, I—”

Madhavi stopped him. “Rasbihari?”

“Yes.”

“In your house?”

“Found last night.”

“And you have been sitting with me since morning.”

“I was verifying it first.”

“You could have said to me, ‘A paper has been found; I’m verifying it.’”

His mother looked from one face to the other. She understood at once that this was not only about an archive. She rose slowly. “Perhaps I said something at the wrong time.”

Madhavi softened immediately. “No, Kaki. You did the right thing. The paper must come into the investigation.”

His mother looked at Abhiram. “I told you that yesterday.”

Abhiram lowered his face.

“The tiffin can stay here. I’ll take it in the evening.” As she left, she said, “If you are doing the work of truth, don’t first be afraid of the truth in your own house.”

The door closed.

For a few moments Madhavi did not look at Abhiram. She covered the tiffin, wiped her hands, then said in a very even voice, "Show me."

Abhiram connected the storage device. The image opened: the 1935 application, Rasbihari Das, seven settlements, the original list unavailable, the boundary map, and on the reverse Madhaveswar Jha's signature.

Madhavi read each line. Her eyes grew sharper, but her voice did not rise. At last she asked, "Madhaveswar?"

"My great-grandfather."

"You learned that last night?"

"Yes."

"The original paper?"

"Safe at home."

"Vinay Babu?"

"Not yet."

"Jaynarayan Babu?"

"No."

"Me?"

Abhiram did not answer. The question already contained its answer.

Madhavi rose from the chair. “Why?”

“Because I did not know what the paper meant. My great-grandfather’s signature is on it. There is a boundary note in red pencil. If the family name gets connected in the wrong way—”

“If it might be connected in the wrong way, you hide the fact?”

“I did not hide it. One night for verification—”

“One night?” Madhavi’s voice rose for the first time. “This morning when I asked about Rasbihari, you said ‘a raw match’. The paper was already on your laptop then. This was not one night. It was a conscious lie.”

Abhiram’s face tightened. “I never said ‘no’.”

“Oh!” Madhavi laughed bitterly. “Are you convening a court of words now? Because you ‘didn’t say no’, it wasn’t a lie?”

“I was afraid.”

“Of me?”

Abhiram was silent.

“Say it.”

“Yes. A little.”

At that answer the hurt beneath Madhavi's anger opened. "What would I have done? Accused your great-grandfather?"

"For you this land story is not just a file. Vasudha Didi —"

"And for you?"

"My family."

"So?"

"So I wanted to understand it first."

Madhavi gripped the edge of the table. "Do you remember what you said on the boat that night? You will not think me a fool; I will not think you a stone. You decided in advance that if I heard your family's name, I would treat you as guilty. Meaning—you did not trust me."

"This is not about trust—"

"That is exactly what it is."

Abhiram stepped back. "Madhavi, yesterday Jaynarayan Babu got stuck on Arun because of his old case. Once a name settles in the mind, the facts begin arranging themselves around it. I did not want my great-grandfather's name to become another—"

"Jaynarayan Babu admitted his bias. You hid your fear."

The line struck. Abhiram did not answer for several moments.

“Yes,” he said at last. “I hid it.”

Madhavi’s eyes filled, but she did not cry. “Thank you. That is the first clear sentence.”

Abhiram said softly, “Forgive me.”

“Forgiveness and trust do not return to the same place in a single day.”

She started to leave the room. Abhiram asked, “Where are you going?”

“To Vinay Babu. To report the paper.”

“I’ll come with you.”

Madhavi turned. “Come for the investigation. Don’t say you are coming with me.”

They walked along the veranda at an equal distance from each other. Once, on this very path, Abhiram would tilt an umbrella toward her and Madhavi would quarrel about the speed of his motorcycle. There was no rain today, yet a distance like an invisible umbrella stood between them.

The moment Vinay saw the copy, his first question was, “Where is the original?”

“At my house,” Abhiram said.

“What time did you find it?”

“Around nine last night.”

“Why are you informing us now?”

For a moment Abhiram looked toward Madhavi, then did not. “I made a wrong decision. I wanted to verify it first. I became afraid when I saw my family’s name.”

Vinay’s face hardened, but his voice remained level. “Who had access to the original paper in the meantime?”

“My mother and me. The drawer was locked. My mother is at home.”

“Did anyone touch it?”

“I did, wearing gloves. My mother touched the outer bundle, not the page.”

“All right. Two police personnel will go with you now. The original will not be seized immediately—first a voluntary handover inventory, photographs, condition record, and the family’s statement. If its connection with the case is confirmed, it will be placed under legal preservation.”

Abhiram bowed his head. “All right.”

When Jaynarayan arrived, everything was repeated to him. He studied the copy for a long time. He did not linger on the great-grandfather’s name; he examined the date, seal, torn edge, red pencil, and application number.

“Madhaveswar Jha was your ancestor?”

“Yes.”

“You hid the paper?”

“For one night.”

“Why?”

“Fear.”

Jaynarayan looked at him. Having admitted his own bias the previous day, perhaps he was in no mood to punish quickly. “Fear belongs to the human being. Withholding a source is an investigative fault. Write the two separately. I will not insult your fear, but the paper’s path will remain clear.”

Madhavi remained silent.

Jaynarayan added, “And one more thing. A family connection is not a criminal connection. Only as much as the paper says.”

Abhiram said, “Yes.” It was precisely what he had needed to hear the previous day, but he had never asked.

The paper from the house was brought in through proper procedure. Abhiram’s mother gave a full written account—how long the chest had been there, whose it was, and who opened it the previous night. She even

served tea to the police personnel. “Take the paper, but don’t fold the envelope. It is old.”

One officer smiled. “We won’t fold it.”

Madhavi had gone with them too, but standing on the veranda of Abhiram’s house caused her a strange pain. Had she come here for the first time yesterday, she might have laughed with his mother, looked at the radio, the goat, the small garden. Today she saw the house as though it were part of an evidence inventory. A rift in affection does not open only between two people; its shadow falls upon places too.

Abhiram’s mother gave Madhavi a separate glass of water. “My son did something foolish.”

Madhavi felt awkward. “Kaki—”

“I am his mother, so you do not have to defend him to me. He was afraid. When he is afraid, he becomes silent. It is an old habit. When his father was ill, he did not tell me for three days what the doctor had said. He thought he would manage it himself first.”

Madhavi asked softly, “Will he ever learn?”

His mother smiled. “If the fear of losing someone makes him silent, perhaps the fear of losing someone will also teach him to speak.”

Madhavi did not answer.

Back at the courthouse, the original paper was scanned at high resolution. For the first time, a clear entry was added to Sutra's source list: "Private family record; original voluntarily handed over; authenticity under examination." No mysterious name, no hidden source.

Abhiram made the entry himself. His hand did not tremble.

"Run it?" Vinay asked.

"Run it," Jaynarayan said.

Sutra began connecting Rasbihari's 1935 application, the 1941 land demarcation, the 1957 copy request, the present Seven Hamlets land records, and the old relief-camp map. Lines repeatedly appeared and vanished across the screen. A few minutes later a new warning came up: "LONG-TERM DISPLACEMENT CONSISTENCY IN BOUNDARY-POINT SEQUENCE; DETAILED MAP CORRELATION REQUIRED."

Jaynarayan leaned forward. "What does that mean?"

Abhiram answered, "For now, only that on maps from different years the boundary appears to shift in the same direction. How much, when, and under whose order—we cannot say without the next comparison."

For the first time Madhavi looked at him. The answer was careful, correct. But a crack in personal trust does not close at once through technical caution.

Abhiram caught her gaze. “Madhavi—”

She said quietly, “For now, work.”

That was all.

On Sutra’s screen the old maps continued to overlay one another. Blue, grey, black lines. One boundary seemed slowly to move eastward.

And the line drawn between the two of them that day belonged to no map that could measure it.

Chapter 34 — Sutra's New Map

The first light of dawn had reached the window, yet the records-room screen still glowed as though it were night. The blue, grey, and black lines from the previous evening still lay over one another. Only Abhiram's chair was empty.

When Madhavi came in, she first looked at the screen, then at the empty chair. Yesterday's words returned to her at once—"For now, work." After those four words, the two of them had gone home by different roads. All night Madhavi had kept wondering whether the anger was greater or the hurt. The answer was still not clear.

Jaynarayan stood by the window, a verified image of an old map in his hand. "Did you sleep?"

"A little."

"Too much work and too little sleep together make the mind manufacture more inferences."

Madhavi tried to smile. "Is that advice for me or for yourself?"

"For whoever feels it applies."

Vinay Thakur entered carrying two thick files. "Verified images of the 1941 boundary register and the 1957 copy request have arrived from the district archives. We already have the 1934 relief-camp map.

The measurement schedule from the present land records has also been obtained.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Abhiram?”

“He called early this morning. He is checking the original handover inventory for the paper from his house again. He should be on his way.”

Madhavi said nothing.

Ten minutes later Abhiram arrived. There were faint dark circles beneath his eyes. He carried no tea, only his laptop and a sheet rolled inside a round tube. His eyes went to Madhavi, but he could not quite summon the courage to say, “Good morning.”

“This is a full-size print of the 1934 map,” he said, handing it to Vinay. “Sutra cannot place the old map precisely over present-day coordinates by itself. The paper has shrunk, the edges are torn, and the measurement system was different. Human beings first have to choose stable reference points.”

Jaynarayan said at once, “Then write that down first. Later no one should be able to say the machine placed everything on its own.”

Abhiram nodded. He added a new line to the source register: “Initial selection of stable reference points: human; each point subject to independent archival verification.”

Madhavi kept watching his hand. The same hand that had withheld a source yesterday was today writing the source's limitations before anything else. Trust had not returned, but change was visible.

Four stable points were selected—the western ghat of the old pond, the platform of the Shiva temple, the old bend of the river marked by an erosion symbol on the 1934 map, and the north-western corner of the courthouse. The road was deliberately not used as a reference point; the road had been built later.

“Vasudha Didi was stuck on this very point,” Madhavi said softly. “The old boundary said ‘north pond’; the newer copy says ‘north road’. The road came later.”

Vinay turned the page. “Look at the dates. The first construction permission for the road is from 1968. Yet the 1941 demarcation says ‘road’.”

Jaynarayan's brows tightened. “So an object from 1968 appears in a 1941 copy?”

“Possibly the wording changed in a later copy,” Abhiram said. “We need an image of the original 1941 register. What we have now is a certified copy made in 1972.”

“Good,” Jaynarayan said. “It is a discrepancy. Too early to call it deceit.”

Sutra's work began. One by one, the lines of the old map were laid over the present map. At first the shape

warped. When the pond aligned, the temple shifted; when the temple aligned, the river bend moved. Abhiram kept adjusting the estimated percentage of paper shrinkage. Every change was recorded in a corner of the screen.

Madhavi watched closely. “This looks like a game. But if one percent is wrong, how much land moves?”

“At this scale, roughly thirty to fifty cubits,” Abhiram said. “That is why Sutra should not produce one single boundary line, but a probable boundary band.”

“A band?”

“A razor-thin line gives false certainty. If the boundary could reasonably lie a few cubits this way or that, show it as a band.”

Jaynarayan smiled faintly. “Until yesterday the machine spoke in certainties. Today it has learned ‘possibly’.”

Abhiram said, “Until yesterday the operator was foolish too.”

Madhavi looked at him involuntarily. Abhiram did not look away, but he did not take the conversation any farther.

Two hours later the first clear image emerged. The old boundary of the Seven Hamlets area appeared as seven thin bands in different colours; the present boundary as

a thick black line. Every difference leaned in the same direction—east-south-east. The distances were not equal, but the sequence was the same. Much of the land lost from the Seven Hamlets boundary appeared to have been added to nearby old family holdings.

Sutra displayed a note: “Boundary-point changes less consistent with random measurement error; directional consistency high. Cause or responsible actor not determined.”

Jaynarayan asked, “In plain Maithili?”

Abhiram answered, “If this were only measurement error, sometimes the shift would be east, sometimes west, sometimes larger, sometimes smaller. Here, in all seven areas, the boundary has moved roughly in the same direction. It could be coincidence, but that is less likely.”

“Deliberately?” Madhavi asked.

“Sutra cannot say that much.”

“And you?”

Abhiram paused. “I would say a decision made by someone is much more plausible than simple measurement error. But to say ‘deliberately’, we need to see the sequence of records.”

Vinay opened the 1941 boundary register. All seven Seven Hamlets entries had been amended within the

same week. On three pages, the same short note in red pencil: “Boundary corrected.” The field-inspection date boxes were blank on two pages; on the remaining five, the same date appeared. There were no signatures from village representatives who were present.

“Was this normal procedure?” Madhavi asked.

Vinay said, “We will have to examine the rules in force at that time in full. But five area inspections on the same day, without representatives’ signatures—yes, that raises questions.”

Jaynarayan took out Rasbihari’s 1935 application. “What does this say?”

Abhiram read: “The community boundary for earthquake resettlement shall be fixed by comparing the old pond, the communal hearth-site, and the relief-camp list; because the original is unavailable, the boundary shall not be altered in future copies.”

The room was silent for a few moments.

A shiver ran through Madhavi. “He already understood that if the original disappeared, the boundary could be changed.”

“Understood—or feared,” Jaynarayan corrected her. “There is a difference.”

Sutra calculated again. This time the 1957 copy request was added. In that application, a complaint from

the Seven Hamlets side stated: “The old communal hearth-site has been shown in the record within a family holding.” The disposal note read: “Old original unavailable; present demarcation accepted.”

Madhavi said quietly, “So it was not a one-time mistake. The later complaint was suppressed too.”

Vinay raised a hand. “Not ‘suppressed’ yet. Say ‘not accepted’. We do not know the reason.”

“The law measures the feet of every word,” Madhavi muttered.

Jaynarayan heard her. “And criminals walk in the spaces between those feet.”

After noon they all left for the Seven Hamlets area. It was necessary to see what the lines on paper looked like on the ground. Measuring instruments, a print of the old map, the present land register—everything went with them.

At the edge of Domahi, the first point fell near the old pond. According to the map, a community path ran straight from the pond to Kamarpatti; in the present day, a high wall and a private warehouse stood in between. The warehouse owner was absent. The guard outside said, “This land was bought a very long time ago.”

“How long ago?” Vinay asked.

“How would I know, Babu? I only stand guard.”

Jaynarayan wrote down the guard's name, not the claim of purchase.

Farther on, beside the Musahari settlement, an elderly woman named Phulo Devi was plastering the ground with mud. The moment she saw the map she laughed. "Searching for a road on paper? My mother used to say wedding processions passed through here. Now there is a wall."

Madhavi bent her knees and sat beside her. "Who did your mother hear that from?"

"From her mother. I only heard a story. You people find the proof."

Jaynarayan's face brightened. "That is a good answer."

Phulo Devi laughed. "Write down an old person's story and it will be half false, half true. But this wall is new—that much these eyes have seen."

Abhiram kept recording the present coordinates. Madhavi did not go near him, but from a distance she saw that he was tagging each person's statement as "community memory—independent verification required."

By evening, three points in each of the seven areas had been checked. The result was not complete, but the direction was again the same. Where an old stable marker survived, the present boundary had moved

away from it in a way that increased land on the side of the old family holdings. Where a marker had been destroyed, Sutra recorded “uncertain.”

Back at the courthouse, Jaynarayan had the new map printed. The old boundary was a blue band, the present boundary black, and the land lost between them shaded red.

“Not for court yet,” Vinay said. “First the archivist, the surveyor, and authentication of the original pages.”

“But in Vasudha's land case, this is very significant,” Madhavi said.

“Yes,” Jaynarayan replied. “And perhaps this is why Vasudha was so disturbed. But remember—proving land fraud will not by itself identify her killer.”

Madhavi nodded.

Abhiram held out a copy of the map to her. “You keep this. The source list is on the back.”

Madhavi took it. “Thank you.”

Two ordinary words. Yesterday's rift had not closed, but for the first time a hand had been placed on its edge.

Abhiram said softly, “There is one more thing on this map.”

“What?”

“In the original correlation of all seven old boundaries, one symbol appears repeatedly—a circle with seven dots inside it. The scans are poor, but it appears in three independent sources.”

Madhavi's gaze sharpened. “The Seventh Witness?”

“Don't give it a name yet. It is only a symbol.”

Hearing them from a distance, Jaynarayan said, “Good. Tomorrow we will see whether Rahmat Kaka gives it a name—or the papers do.”

Madhavi did not fold the map. She placed it flat against a board. Darkness was deepening outside. A boundary had shifted across the paper; by whose hand, that still remained in darkness.

Chapter 35 — Rahmat Kaka's Knot

Rahmat Kaka's shop stood in the lane behind the courthouse, in a place where new books were not sold; old books were kept from dying. The door stood half open. Inside mingled the smells of glue, paper, cloth, dust, and old leather. From the ceiling hung small bunches of thread—white, black, yellow, green, blue.

The moment Madhavi stepped inside, she looked up. “So many colours?”

Without raising his head, Rahmat Kaka said, “Don't build a story out of colour, beti. Ambika already called yesterday and told me you people are chasing blue thread.”

For a moment Abhiram looked at Madhavi. A faint smile came to her face.

“Ambika Kaki sent the news ahead of us?”

“She doesn't send news. She sends orders.” Rahmat Kaka pushed his spectacles up onto his forehead. “Sit.”

There were three chairs in the shop and four people. Jaynarayan pulled in a small stool from outside. Vinay opened the cardboard folder of documents. First came the examination image of the blue thread, then an enlarged photograph of the knot found in the hollow of the wall, then an image of thread caught in the stitching of the constellation ledger.

Rahmat Kaka did not touch anything at once. "Where are the originals?"

"In the laboratory," Vinay said.

"Good. From photographs I can look at colour and knot. I will not tell you age."

Jaynarayan laughed. "Everyone has begun stating their limits now."

Rahmat Kaka brought the photograph close to his eyes. "This knot is not a bookbinder's knot."

Abhiram asked, "Why?"

"In binding, the thread is tightened inside and the knot is hidden behind the spine. Look here—two turns, a small tightening in the middle, then one end deliberately left long. This is a knot meant for marking."

"Marking what?" Madhavi's question came at once.

Rahmat Kaka removed his spectacles and looked at her. "Again, too fast. There was no single official language of colour. In one household blue could mean a daughter; in another, a prayer-book; in a third, nothing more than that the white thread had run out. If you write 'blue equals such-and-such family', I will withdraw my statement."

Vinay smiled slightly. "We'll put that in the first line."

Rahmat Kaka rose and went to the back of the shop. Beneath a wooden cupboard stood a flat chest. The key hung on a cord inside his kurta. When he opened it, there were dozens of thin ledgers wrapped in cloth. "This is my wealth," he said. "The shop is rented, the house is small, my son works outside as a daily labourer. But if I sell these ledgers, the work of three generations disappears. That is why, even in poverty, I never treated them as useless things."

Madhavi's mind went suddenly to Dulari. Things belonging to ordinary people looked useless in other people's eyes, yet in those very things the footprints of history survived.

Rahmat Kaka opened one ledger. The pages carried dates, customers' names, binding cloth, thread colour, repair work. The older entries were in many hands—some round, some thin, some in Urdu, some in Maithili, some nothing but marks.

"Did you write all this?" Abhiram asked.

"Do I look ninety years old?" Rahmat Kaka laughed. "The shop first belonged to my grandfather's teacher. Then it passed to his hands, then to my father's, then to mine. The name changed. The smell of glue did not."

Jaynarayan asked, "Anything from around 1934?"

"We won't search by date. We'll search by work."

He kept turning pages. Now and then he stopped a finger to feel the thickness of the paper. Abhiram grew impatient; Madhavi remained silent. After nearly fifteen minutes, Rahmat Kaka stopped at one page.

“Here.”

The entry was old. Black ink ran along the margin, with a later note in blue pencil through the middle. Rahmat Kaka read slowly: “Copy of household paper... edge torn... do not remove blue thread... girl's personal mark...”

Madhavi's breath caught. “Girl?”

Rahmat Kaka tightened his spectacles over his eyes at the next word. “The name is half worn away. I can see ‘Kusu...’”

Abhiram immediately started to take out his phone, but Vinay stopped him. “First a proper photograph of the whole page under procedure.”

Rahmat Kaka looked pleased. “Good. I did not bring out an old ledger so people could make playful photographs of it.”

The page was photographed; its measurements, the ledger cover, and the page number were all recorded.

Madhavi asked, “So this isn't Rasbihari's blue thread?”

Rahmat Kaka shook his head. “Not according to this entry. Blue thread was tied to Rasbihari's work slip, but

the thread is described as ‘the girl's personal mark’. The man's name is separate on the next line—‘copyist Rasbihari’. If this is the same Kusuma whose story you are tracing, then the blue thread was her mark, not Rasbihari's.”

Madhavi's dream flashed through her mind—the red dupatta, the blue thread. She checked herself at once. “The dream is separate.”

Jaynarayan heard her and smiled. “And the ledger is separate.”

Abhiram asked permission to add the ledger entry to Sutra. Rahmat Kaka asked, “What will Sutra do?”

“Compare the letters, date, name, mention of thread, and other sources.”

“And afterward it will say—if you see blue thread, it means Kusuma?”

Abhiram looked slightly embarrassed. “Earlier, it might have. Not now. I'll add a rule—‘local/personal marker; no universal meaning.’”

Rahmat Kaka studied him. “Does the machine learn?”

“If a human being admits a mistake and teaches it.”

“And the human being?”

For a moment Abhiram looked at Madhavi. “Sometimes, that too.”

Madhavi kept her eyes on the ledger.

Rahmat Kaka opened another page. “Understand something about colour. In the old courthouse, thread was sometimes used to distinguish different bundles, but the rules differed from place to place. Red cloth might be a court bundle, black thread an account book, yellow a marriage register—but none of that was universal truth. A binder knew the habits of his customers. History survives not only in official seals, but also in the habits of hands.”

Madhavi asked, “How do you remember the stories of so many papers?”

Rahmat Kaka gave a dry laugh. “The person who writes a name leaves his own name on the page. The person who saves the page leaves no name anywhere. So I remember the stories—for myself.”

He lifted a torn volume. “Look at this. A widow-pension register. Five years ago it got soaked in a drain. Everyone said throw it away. I dried it, separated the pages, and bound it again. Inside were thumbprints of twenty women. If I had thrown it away, to someone else it would have been only old paper. To those women it meant five months of grain each.”

A bicycle bell rang outside the shop. For a few moments there was no sound inside.

Jaynarayan said softly, “That is why you matter to this investigation.”

“I do not matter,” Rahmat Kaka replied. “The work matters.”

They read the old entry again. Beneath the line about the blue thread was a small symbol—a circle with seven dots inside.

Madhavi stopped her finger in the air; she did not touch it. “The same symbol is on the map too.”

Vinay opened the map image. The blurred symbols from three sources and the clear mark in the ledger were placed side by side. The shapes were not perfectly identical, but the arrangement was the same—one dot in the centre, six around it.

Abhiram said, “Sutra can give visual similarity, but not meaning.”

“One foot of meaning is here,” Rahmat Kaka said. “Look at the back of this page.”

On the reverse, in faint writing: “Slip with seven marks; torn portion preserved inside binding.”

Vinay's expression changed. “Which binding?”

Rahmat Kaka read the next line. “Filing register, Samvat... the number is worn away. Below, in English numerals: 1935. ‘Volume 27.’”

Jaynarayan asked at once, “Is that register here?”

“No. In the court archives. It must have come here for repair many years ago. Instead of throwing away a torn private paper, an old binder would sometimes make a thin pocket inside the binding and keep it there, thinking the owner might ask for it again.”

Madhavi's heart began to race. “Then the other half of the letter—”

Jaynarayan stopped her immediately. “For now, only a possibility.”

“Yes,” Madhavi steadied herself. “A possibility.”

Abhiram opened the archive list. The 1935 filing register, Volume 27, was listed, with the note: “Fragile; restricted use.”

Vinay picked up the phone. “We will not open it today. The archivist, videography, conservation staff—everyone will be present. It may contain a private fragment, or nothing but blank paper.”

Rahmat Kaka closed the ledger. “Have patience. Pull a knot too hard and the thread breaks.”

Madhavi looked again at the photograph of the blue thread. For so many days it had seemed to point toward one man—Rasbihari. Now it had become Kusuma's own small declaration: ‘This is my mark.’

As they stepped outside, Abhiram said softly, "I have something to say."

Madhavi stopped, but did not look at him.

"If I had told you first yesterday, today's work would not have changed. But the way you looked at me would have. I am beginning to understand that."

After a few moments Madhavi replied, "Beginning to understand and earning back trust are two different things."

"I know."

"Good."

She walked on. Abhiram followed a little behind. This time the distance between them was not as hard as yesterday, but it had not vanished either.

Behind them in the shop, Rahmat Kaka bent once more over his torn book. The great names of history were moving outside through courts and files; an old binder quietly tied a knot in thread so that someone's small name would not fall out of a page again.

Chapter 36 — The True Meaning of the Seventh Witness

The next morning the air in the conservation room of the district archives was colder than in an ordinary room. A white cloth covered the table, with thin gloves, glass weights, and two flat lamps. The 1935 filing register, Volume 27, was laid down as carefully as though an ailing old man were being turned onto his side.

Archivist Shashibhushan Mishra made one thing clear at the outset. “If something is found inside the volume, that does not automatically make it evidence in this case. First we examine provenance, paper, ink, torn edges, handwriting—everything.”

Jaynarayan said, “That is exactly the sentence I wanted.”

Madhavi's palms were cold. The dream, the mansion, the half-letter, the blue thread—all rose together in her mind. She told herself: only as much as I actually see.

Rahmat Kaka was present too, but stood two arm's lengths from the table. “I will not open the volume. I only need to show you where the binding should be examined.”

The video recording began. Images were taken around the entire outside of the register. The cloth over

the spine had lifted slightly, though the original stitching remained stable. With a thin tool, the conservator separated a loose inner covering. The first layer held dust; the second, fibres of old paper. Behind the third layer was a thin fold like a pocket.

From a distance Rahmat Kaka said, “That is the method. Old craftsmen did not throw away a torn fragment.”

The pocket was opened. Inside lay a small brown fragment of paper. One edge was straight, the other irregularly torn. Four lines of ink were visible.

Madhavi held her breath.

Vinay signalled with his hand—no one move closer. First photographs. Measurements. Board number. Condition of the paper. Only then was the fragment placed separately on a transparent tray.

On his screen Abhiram opened a high-resolution image of the half-letter recovered from the mansion. The two images were placed side by side. The fibres along the torn edges looked like teeth—at one point a small triangle, at another a long fibre, and between them half of an inked letter.

“Do not join them automatically,” Jaynarayan said.

“No,” Abhiram replied. “First, edge similarity only.”

Sutra compared the torn lines using three different measuring methods. Result: “HIGH VISUAL CONSISTENCY; PHYSICAL ORIGINAL-TO-ORIGINAL MATCH REQUIRED.”

Jaynarayan looked at Madhavi. “See? We still have not called it ‘the other half’.”

Madhavi nodded.

Images were immediately sent to a paper-examination specialist. The procedure for bringing the two original fragments together was set in motion. A full physical comparison was not possible that day, but the half-letters seemed to meet so cleanly that the patience of everyone in the room was being severely tested.

The final visible line on the fragment found at the mansion read: “...as necessary as the first six marks...”

The first line on the newly found fragment read: “...the seventh household-paper mark is equally necessary...”

The word escaped Madhavi before she could stop it. “Seventh.”

Shashibhushan Mishra asked, “Are the letters certain?”

Rahmat Kaka leaned forward without touching anything. “It looks like ‘seventh’ to me, but old forms of

‘t’ and ‘s’ can blur into each other. A handwriting specialist should read it.”

By noon a preliminary reading was ready. The probable form of the joined text was:

“...if the paper does not reach the court, compare the seven marks on the copy. As necessary as the first six marks, the seventh household-paper mark is equally necessary. Seven dots have been placed inside a circle, so that if the copy is altered the mark will break. On the work slip Kusuma laughed and called it the Seventh Witness...”

The text became slightly blurred there, then clear again:

“...the blue thread is her private mark, not a mark of the record...”

Madhavi closed her eyes. The blue thread, which for so long had seemed like the centre of a mystery, suddenly became intensely human—a young woman's own small mark.

Abhiram said softly, “So the ‘Seventh Witness’ is not a person.”

Jaynarayan corrected him at once. “Not in this letter. The phrase may carry another meaning elsewhere.”

“Yes.” Abhiram's voice was modest. “In this letter—the seventh authentication mark.”

Vinay opened the list of authentication sources from the old 1934 document. The first six were already known—the relief list, the old map, tax receipts, the marriage register tied to the communal hearth-site, the pond-use account, and local testimony about the boundary. The seventh line—the old acknowledgement on the household paper.

“And the circle with seven dots is its identifier,” Madhavi said.

“Correct,” Vinay replied. “If the paper disappears but a copy survives, the seven marks can be compared. A kind of old authentication system.”

Abhiram's eyes brightened. “And all this time Sutra kept assigning a possibility that ‘Seventh Witness’ was a person's name because words such as ‘what was seen’, ‘testimony’, and ‘name’ appeared nearby.”

Madhavi looked at him. “Did the machine understand language, or merely the neighbourhood of words?”

“The neighbourhood of words.”

“And human beings?”

Abhiram gave a slight smile. “Human beings made a story.”

Jaynarayan said, “The two can be wrong together. That is why we need the paper.”

Sutra's knowledge list was corrected. The old classification—"Seventh Witness: possible person/alias"—was struck out and replaced with: "Informal name for a seventh authentication mark in a historical work slip; does not support identification of a person." The reason for the change, the source, and the time were all recorded.

Before saving the entry, Abhiram showed it to Madhavi. "Anything to add?"

Madhavi read it. "One thing—write separately: 'Kusuma's private blue thread was not an official authentication mark.' Otherwise someone will see the colour later and build another story."

"Right."

From behind them Rahmat Kaka said, "Now I can breathe."

Everyone laughed.

But the final two lines of the letter had still not been read. After digital processing reduced the stain across the fold, letters emerged. The first line was half in Maithili and half in the office language of the period:

"The seven marks protect the paper, but..."

The next line was clear:

"Where in the record do we place the one who sees but does not name?"

The room fell silent again.

A shiver ran up Madhavi's back. "Who is this?"

Jaynarayan did not answer.

On Abhiram's screen Sutra immediately displayed three possibilities—"unnamed eyewitness", "metaphor", "authorial note". Confidence was low in all three.

Madhavi laughed. "At least now it isn't insisting this is 'one definite man'."

Abhiram smiled too. "Progress."

Rahmat Kaka looked at the image of the letter from a distance. "Sometimes the person making a document leaves one line for himself. Not every line has the meaning of a lawsuit."

Jaynarayan asked, "What do you think?"

"I am a binder. I am not paid wages for guessing."

"Excellent," Jaynarayan said.

The preliminary physical-comparison report arrived in the evening. Paper fibres, thickness, part of the watermark, visible qualities of the ink, and the torn edges all strongly supported the two fragments having come from the same original sheet. Final chemical testing remained. The report stated clearly: "High probability of common origin; final conclusion after detailed testing."

For the first time Madhavi saw the whole letter digitally reconstructed. A name Kusuma had given in jest ninety years earlier had spent all this time wandering through local stories, dreams, and the machine's inferences as though it were a human being; in reality, it was a paper security mark.

Yet the final line opened another door—"the one who sees but does not name..."

"Is that line useful in the land case?" Madhavi asked.

Vinay answered, "Not its figurative meaning. But the first part of the letter, the sequence of the seven authentication sources, and the description of the mark—if authenticity is established—may help verify copies of old documents. It is not direct evidence in the murder case."

"Had Vasudha Didi understood this?"

"We'll look at her notes," Jaynarayan said. "No inference."

At that moment Abhiram quietly took the new map from the previous day out of his bag. The Seven Hamlets boundary, the seven sources, the seven-dot mark. "One thing is matching. In the amended 1941 demarcations, the circle-with-seven-dots mark that ought to be present is missing from five copies. It survives very faintly in two older images."

Jaynarayan's gaze sharpened. "Meaning?"

“Meaning that the amended copies do not preserve the complete original seven-mark chain. That does not by itself prove they are forged, but the old authentication system is broken.”

Vinay said, “We need expert opinion on that. Nothing public yet.”

Madhavi rested a hand on the board. “A name Kusuma gave in one laugh may still be able to protect land ninety years later.”

Rahmat Kaka shook his head. “Not the name, beti. The mark. People change names.”

The sentence settled inside Madhavi.

When they came out of the archives, the evening air was warm. Abhiram stopped on the steps. “Madhavi.”

She stopped.

“I will not repeat yesterday’s apology. Repeating words will not restore trust. But whatever source reaches my hands, I will share it first. You may be angry, you may question me—but I will not hold it back.”

Madhavi looked at him for a long time. “Give that promise to the investigation, not to me.”

“To both.”

A faint smile came to Madhavi’s face, but she grew serious again at once. “Trust is repaired the way Rahmat

Kaka repairs an old book—you do not throw out the old paper and put on a new binding. What was torn remains visible.”

Abhiram said quietly, “I will not hide the torn edge.”

They walked down the steps together. The distance between them still existed, but it was no longer nameless as before. Its names were fear, silence, and trust being learned again.

Back in the conservation room, the two halves of the complete letter were placed in separate protective sleeves. The small circle of seven dots remained steady on the paper. But the final line, bound by no seal, seemed to remain in the air even after the room had emptied—

“Where in the record do we place the one who sees but does not name?”

Chapter 37 — The Broken Family Circle

On the second morning after they left the conservation room, three new files lay on Vinay Thakur's table. One was from a bank, one from a telecommunications company, and the third from the accounts of Prakhar's own business partnership. Seen from above, they were all ordinary papers—dates, accounts, numbers, seals. But Jaynarayan used to say that a family's lies are often caught not in words, but in the empty spaces between accounts.

Before opening the file, Abhiram looked toward Madhavi. “You first. I remember the promise I made yesterday.”

Madhavi took the papers. “The promise was not made to me. It was made to the investigation.”

“To both.”

She did not reply, but pulled the file toward herself. The torn edge of trust was still visible, yet for the first time it seemed as though a thin layer of fresh glue had been laid along it.

On paper, Prakhar's business was described as a small brokerage partnership in buying and selling land. In reality, three of his deals had collapsed over the previous two years, an advance on a warehouse had

been lost, and his private debt had grown beyond eighteen lakh rupees. Part of that debt had not come from an ordinary bank but from two partners in the land group trying to acquire Seven Hamlets land. On paper it was not called a loan—it was recorded as an ‘advance consultancy fee.’

Madhavi turned the page. “Consultancy for what?”

Vinay said, “No written work. No contract. Just three instalments. The first two before Vasudha's case intensified; the third four days before her death.”

Jaynarayan asked, “After the third instalment, did pressure from Prakhar's creditors decrease?”

“Not the bank debt. But two old notes for private debts were torn up on the same day. The lenders say Prakhar paid them in cash. The source of the cash is unclear.”

Abhiram opened Sutra's money trail. “The system shows only one thing—whenever Prakhar's account kept emptying, money arrived in his firm from accounts of people connected with the land group. It does not say why.”

“Human beings will find the reason,” Jaynarayan said. “First see this—where was he that night?”

Vinay opened the second file. Prakhar's main phone remained in the signal area of his house until 11:22 p.m. Then it went off. It came back on at 4:42 in the morning.

Those facts were already known, but the family had said Prakhar had remained at home and the phone battery had died.

The new element was a second number. A cheap, unregistered small device that was recorded as being used in Prakhar's firm's office. It became active in the office signal area at 3:36 a.m., in the central part of the town at 3:49, at the courthouse's western tower at 4:04, and at 4:27 again near the tower behind the new building.

Madhavi's finger stopped on the paper. "What proves this device was in Prakhar's hand?"

"Nothing direct yet," Abhiram said at once. "It belongs to the firm. It could have been in anyone's hand."

Jaynarayan looked at Abhiram. "Good. Read Sutra's line, but don't turn it into a man."

Abhiram did not smile. He was beginning to understand the weight of that caution.

Vinay placed a small image before them. It was from the exterior camera of Prakhar's office building. 3:31 a.m. The rain obscured the face, but a person could be seen leaving from inside, carrying a small bag, a helmet in the left hand. The last four digits of the vehicle number matched Prakhar's motorcycle.

"And home?" Madhavi asked.

“The office is two lanes from the house. The family said he had not gone out after ten at night.”

Jaynarayan leaned back in his chair. “Read the family statements again.”

Vinay separated four pages. In her initial statement, Vasudha's mother had said, ‘Prakhar was on the veranda late into the night; I saw him around midnight.’ Vasudha's mother-in-law had said, ‘I got up to drink water at two; the light in his room was on.’ Arun had said, ‘Prakhar did not go out; the motorcycle was in the courtyard.’ Prakhar himself had said, ‘After ten I switched off the phone and went to sleep.’

All four statements pushed toward the same conclusion—he was at home. But each gave a different time of direct observation, and none placed him there around four in the morning.

Jaynarayan said slowly, “Four people built four walls to protect the same fact. The room in the middle was left empty.”

The first day at Vasudha's house rose again in Madhavi's mind—the mother-in-law turning her beads, Prakhar by the window, Arun's measured words, the mother's crying. At the time, everyone had seemed to be protecting themselves from one another. Now it appeared they had also been protecting one another from someone else.

“Ask Maiji again?” Madhavi's voice was low.

“Separately,” Vinay said. “No confrontation. Whoever breaks easily first should not be turned into a weapon against the others.”

When they reached Prakhar's house, there was no crowd on the veranda today. A crowd after death gathers as quickly as it returns to its own homes. The flower garlands had dried brown, the incense holder lay overturned in a corner, and a fresh marigold had been placed on Vasudha's photograph.

Her mother sat alone. In her hands was a torn seam from one of Vasudha's old salwars. As she tried to thread the needle her vision blurred, and she would lower the needle again. Madhavi sat beside her. Vinay sat not directly opposite but slightly to one side.

“Maiji,” Vinay asked very gently, “did you see Prakhar at midnight that night?”

The mother kept her eyes on the tip of the needle. “That is what I said.”

“What do you remember now?”

“I saw his slippers.”

Madhavi's chest tightened.

“Prakhar himself?”

The mother shook her head. “No. His slippers on the veranda. The door to his room was closed. I assumed he was inside.”

“Then why did you say in your statement that you ‘saw’ him?”

For a long time there was no answer. A crow called outside. Stroking the torn seam with her finger, the mother said, “My daughter was dead. The police were beginning to look at my son. I... I changed the words.”

Madhavi wanted to take her hand, then stopped. Grief asked for compassion; a lie demanded accountability. Both sat in the same body.

The mother began speaking on her own. “Vasudha and Prakhar fought since childhood. Yet neither could live without the other. Prakhar was not born bad, beti. He got trapped in business. We at home thought—there is debt, it will pass. Vasudha said, ‘Will you sell Seven Hamlets to pay off debt?’ They fought badly that day.”

“When?”

“Two days before the death.”

“What did Prakhar say?”

The mother's eyes went to Vasudha's photograph. “He said, ‘Stop your papers and all of us will be saved.’ Vasudha said, ‘Destroy Seven Hamlets to save my house? No.’”

Inside Madhavi, Vasudha's voice came alive again.

“Did you know Prakhar went out that night?” Vinay asked.

The mother closed her eyes. “I heard the motorcycle toward dawn. It woke me. I did not look at the clock. He came inside, his clothes wet. I asked where he had gone. He said, ‘The office.’ The moment I saw his face I knew something had happened. But he said not to bring Didi's name into it. After dawn the news came—Vasudha...”

The sentence broke. Then the crying came—slowly, from deep inside the body.

Madhavi placed a hand on her shoulder. There was no forgiveness in the touch; only acknowledgement of human grief.

The mother-in-law's statement was taken in a separate room. At first she said she remembered nothing. Then Vinay asked only one thing: “Did you see the light on at two?”

She was silent. Then she said, “I turned the light on.”

“Why?”

“Prakhar's mother said that if the police came again, they would think he was asleep inside.”

Sitting outside, Madhavi felt cold descend through her body as she heard this. The phrase about protecting the family's name had now revealed its full shape—

sometimes, to protect a name, a house keeps truth in darkness.

When Arun's turn came, he resisted at first. "I did not sit in any meeting to manufacture a lie."

For the first time Jaynarayan asked, "You said the motorcycle was in the courtyard."

"I saw it at ten at night."

"At four in the morning?"

Arun looked away. "No."

"Then how did 'he did not go out' become your statement?"

"Everyone at home was saying it. I believed them."

"And you had it written as though you had seen it yourself."

Arun clenched his teeth. "At that time... Vasudha was dead. Ma was shattered. Prakhar was frightened. I thought first let the police leave the house, then—"

"Then tell the truth?"

Arun did not answer.

Jaynarayan said, "The most convenient tense of a lie is always 'not now, later.'"

Prakhar was not at home. Vinay already knew he was at his office. The police called him in, but did not arrest

him. Jaynarayan had insisted: “If there is evidence, place it in front of him. Do not manufacture a statement by frightening him.”

In the office's small meeting room, Prakhar looked different from the last time. His beard had grown, his eyes were red, but his voice was still sharp. “Why is my family being harassed again?”

Vinay placed three bank pages before him. “This money?”

Prakhar glanced at them. “Business advance.”

“For what work?”

“Land consultancy.”

“Seven Hamlets?”

Prakhar's eyelids stopped. “Not directly.”

“How indirectly?” Jaynarayan asked.

“Are you a lawyer?”

“No. If you do not want to answer, don't. But the question will remain.”

Vinay placed a second paper—the phone signals. A third—the office camera image. A fourth—the message on Prakhar's main phone that Madhavi had glimpsed on the first day: ‘Do not call again. The police are at the house now.’ At the time the sender's name had not been

visible; the service copy now showed the number belonged to Vijay Mallik, a broker for the land group.

For the first time Prakhar's face truly collapsed. "That was private business."

"Why was Vijay Mallik calling you on the morning after the death?"

"He must have heard the news."

"At 5:02 a.m. he sent you the message: 'The paper?' You replied: 'Didn't find it.' What paper was that?"

Prakhar gripped the arm of the chair.

Madhavi was not in the room. She sat outside with Rachna. The questioning beyond the closed door could not be heard clearly. She was glad of that. Truth was not a spectacle.

Vinay opened the next page. "In identifying the person who drank tea at 4:10, Kamli Devi initially selected Arun. The timeline made that impossible. In the second neutral procedure, the photograph about which she said, 'the walk looks like this,' was yours. She was not certain, so we are treating that only as a supporting indication."

Prakhar's lips went dry. "Kamli sees hundreds of people."

"Correct. So by itself this proves nothing."

Jaynarayan tapped three slow beats and two quick ones on the table with his finger. Prakhar's gaze went immediately to his hand. Jaynarayan had remembered that rhythm from Prakhar's fingers on the window ledge on the first day. "When your mind becomes anxious, your fingers move in this rhythm."

Prakhar folded his arms. "Is that a crime?"

"No. It is a habit. Evidence will say what the crime is."

Vinay placed the last page down—a copy of the land group's internal accounts. "If the Seven Hamlets case was 'stopped', six lakh rupees of your private liability would be waived. This note was found in a lawfully seized copy from Vijay Mallik's accountant's device. Date—five days before Vasudha's death."

Prakhar remained silent for a long time. The fan creaked outside.

Jaynarayan said gently, "Your sister was not prepared to abandon those papers."

Prakhar's eyes suddenly filled, but he turned his face away. "You all think I killed her?"

"I am not thinking," Jaynarayan said. "I am asking. You were not at home that night. You were near the courthouse before dawn. You were in debt. You had reason to stop the papers. Your family hid your absence. Now tell us—why did you go to the courthouse?"

Prakhar's chest rose and fell rapidly. The first thing he said was, "I want a lawyer."

Vinay stopped questioning immediately. "All right. Not one more question now."

Jaynarayan stood up. As he reached the door, Prakhar spoke from behind him. "I did not go there to kill Didi."

Everyone in the room stopped.

Vinay turned. "You asked for a lawyer. I will not take a statement now."

Prakhar pressed his head between both palms. "Only that much..."

"Not now," Vinay repeated. "It is your right. When your lawyer comes, then."

Outside, Madhavi rose at the sound of the door opening. She tried to read Jaynarayan's face, but he said only, "The family's circle has broken."

"Prakhar?"

"He wants to speak. He will speak through lawful procedure."

"Didi's mother?"

Jaynarayan's eyes went to the floor of the veranda. "She has already spoken. Even against herself."

By evening Prakhar's lawyer arrived. His formal statement was not completed that day. But before that, a new fact emerged. Prakhar's second phone had brief contacts with the same number at 10:27 p.m. and 4:23 a.m. The number was registered to an old employee of the records department—Navalkishor Jha, Senior Records Assistant, known throughout the courthouse as the 'old records clerk.'

Madhavi started at the name. "The same man who said on the first morning that he had seen the clock running all day the previous day?"

Vinay nodded.

Ramcharit had also said that one of the people who knew the old air duct and its inspection panel was an old records clerk.

Jaynarayan said nothing. Three small details from Dulari's statement rose together in his mind—a left foot that turned outward while walking, a bunch of keys with a large round brass ring, a dry cough.

"Where is Navalkishor now?" Vinay asked.

A constable answered, "At the service quarters. He has sent a leave application since morning—chest tightness and cough."

Jaynarayan's eyes lifted, but he said immediately, "A million people cough. A million people's feet turn

outward. Employees carry keys. If all three meet, it makes a question, not an answer.”

Madhavi asked softly, “Then the next question?”

Jaynarayan looked out of the window toward the deepening evening. “What actually happened at 4:17—we will now assemble it piece by piece. But not as a story. Under every piece, write the source.”

Chapter 38 — Four Seventeen

Navalkishor Jha's official residence stood half a kos from the courthouse's new building. When the police arrived, he was sitting outside on the veranda beside a tulsi plant, a shawl over his shoulders and a lota of warm water in his hand. The moment he saw Vinay's vehicle, he rose, and on his very first step his left foot turned slightly outward.

Jaynarayan's eyes went there, but no triumph showed on his face. Dulari's memory was still a memory, not an identification.

Navalkishor coughed. Dry, two short spasms. Then he said, "So many people? I am ill."

Vinay showed him the search-authorisation papers. "There is an order to inspect the inventory of your house and the government keys in your charge. If you wish, you may call a representative."

Navalkishor's wife came out from inside, alarmed. "What happened?"

"Nothing," he said at once. "It is about office papers."

Jaynarayan stored away that 'nothing' in his mind. In the first moment of calamity, families often choose those very two words.

While the inventory was being prepared, an iron cupboard was opened. There was a separate register for government keys. In Navalkishor's charge were five keys to the old building, two to the new records room, and one small key to the maintenance panel. All were present, together on a large brass-coloured circular ring.

Saroj Devi lifted the ring. Jaynarayan stopped her at once. "Do not show Dulari a photograph of this object yet. First there will be an independent identification procedure."

Vinay agreed.

No blood, burned papers, or miraculous proof was found in the house. Jaynarayan preferred it that way. A crime story that was too clean frightened him. Real life does not sort objects neatly into clues.

But in the bottom of the right pocket of a heavy government coat that might have been worn on the rainy night, minute particles of black dust were found. The police attached no meaning to them on the spot; the garment was sealed and sent to the laboratory.

Meanwhile, Prakhar agreed to give a statement in the presence of the lawyer he had retained. Rachna Jha, who had fought Dulari's bail, remained separate from this process; the family had called another lawyer for Prakhar. When the formalities began, Prakhar's first sentence was: "I went to Didi, but I did not go intending to kill her."

Vinay noted the time. “Are you giving this statement of your own free will?”

“Yes.”

“Is your lawyer present?”

“Yes.”

Then the questioning began.

At 3:17 in the morning, Vijay Mallik of the land consortium had called Prakhar on the smaller number. The call lasted fifty-four seconds. At first Prakhar said it concerned a business debt. When Vinay asked whether the word ‘paper’ had come up, he fell silent. Then he said, “He told me to find out where the paper was before dawn, or the agreement was over.”

“What agreement?”

“Debt forgiveness.”

“In return for?”

“Weakening the main basis of the Seven Hamlets case.”

“How?”

Prakhar lowered his eyes. “The old copy Vasudha relied on was not to be filed. I would persuade her, stop the paper. That was all.”

Jaynarayan asked, “Navalkishor?”

Prakhar's jaw tightened again. "He had already been doing jobs for people in the land consortium. Fetching old copies quickly, pushing wrongly sequenced pages back—small things like that. He took money."

"Why did you call him at 10:27 that night?"

"He said Vasudha had the copy. I told him—remove the paper, do not lay a hand on Vasudha."

Silence held the room for a moment.

Vinay's voice hardened. "Remove the paper—meaning steal it?"

"I... yes. The paper. Not the person."

Jaynarayan said, "Do not shorten the sentence to make the crime smaller. You told someone to steal another person's papers. That is a crime too."

Prakhar bowed his head.

Around ten that night Navalkishor reached the old building. Dulari was there. Buchchan's son had brought two cups of tea—the blue cup for Vasudha, without sugar; the white cup for Navalkishor, with two spoons of sugar. This was later supported by Kamli's old account of Navalkishor's regular tea habit: "Munshi Babu never drinks it unless it's sweet."

During his first questioning, Navalkishor denied being there that night. But a half-broken handwritten mark on the staff entry sheet, Buchchan's son's statement, and the

signal from Navalkishor's smaller phone placed him near the old building. Then he said, "I had gone to collect papers; Vasudha herself had called me." There was no message on Vasudha's phone calling him there.

After Dulari left, she saw Navalkishor burning papers beside an iron drum. Those papers were not the original document, but some photocopies Vasudha had with her and copies of correspondence connected to the land consortium—this matched two words recovered from the ash and one file number. But the principal photocopy Navalkishor had been looking for had already been hidden by Dulari inside her clothing.

"So he told you the paper had not been found?" Jaynarayan asked Prakhar.

"He said half the job was done. Not the main copy."

"Vasudha?"

"Alive. Angry. She threw Navalkishor out."

"Who told you that?"

"Navalkishor."

Until dawn Prakhar kept pacing inside the house. Debt, sister, family, land consortium—pressure from all four sides. After the 3:17 call, he went to the small office and picked up the second phone, leaving his main phone at home so the family would think he was still there. At 3:31 he took the motorcycle out of the office.

At around 4:10 he stopped at Kamli's stall. Kamli's first mistaken identification had been Arun; in the second neutral line-up she had paused at the gait in Prakhar's image. Prakhar now admitted: "I drank tea there. Two spoons of sugar."

In a separate room Madhavi was reading a copy of the statement. At this line she closed her eyes. Seven minutes. The time on which the story had been stuck since the first day was now acquiring a human pair of feet.

Prakhar said, "Didi's room was open. The door was not locked from inside. She was alone."

"Navalkishor?"

"Behind the new building. I told him I would call if I needed him."

"Why?"

"Because he knew the keys to the old building, the duct, everything. I was afraid Didi might have kept the paper in some locked box."

Jaynarayan's voice grew quiet. "You did not go to talk to your sister. You went to search."

Prakhar's eyes filled. "Both."

Vasudha was beside the table. The blue cup was empty; the white cup from the night remained there. Papers were spread out. For the first five minutes after

Prakhar entered, they argued. Vasudha said, “Your debt is not my lawsuit.” Prakhar said, “The house is drowning.” Vasudha replied, “Are the Seven Hamlets not a home?”

At that sentence Prakhar began to cry. The statement was paused and he was given water. After a while, he himself continued.

“I grabbed the bag. Didi pulled it away. I grabbed the file. She knocked my hand aside. I... I pushed her back.”

“How hard?”

“In anger. I don't know.”

“Where did she fall?”

“Her head struck the corner of the old iron cupboard between the table and the wall. There was a sound. The clock shook too—the thin strip above the cupboard struck the wall.”

The medical opinion was consistent with the injury on the right side of the head. On the left corner of the old cupboard at the scene, minute traces of blood protein had remained in a deep crack even after the first cleaning. The initial report had dismissed them as too slight to be significant, but once the homicide inquiry reopened, the sample was re-examined. Genetic comparison matched Vasudha's blood.

“The clock?” Vinay asked.

Prakhar said, “I didn't see it then. When she fell, something clanged against the wall. Later I looked—the time was 4:17.”

So the clock had possibly stopped at that moment from the vibration of the shove. The time that later became the centre of a staged scene had first been a real point in the accident.

Prakhar could not say with certainty whether Vasudha remained conscious for some moments after she fell. He said, “She opened her eyes and looked at me. Her lips moved. No sound came out. I was frightened.”

“A doctor?” Jaynarayan asked.

Prakhar lowered his face.

“An ambulance?”

No answer.

“You injured your sister. She may still have been alive. Instead of calling for help, you called Navalkishor?”

Prakhar fought back sobs. “I could not think.”

For the first time Jaynarayan's voice became hard. “Fear is not the absence of thought; it is a test of choices. Your first choice was not your sister's life. It was your own safety.”

The lawyer present in the room said softly, “Please keep the language of the questioning restrained.”

Jaynarayan fell silent at once. Vinay continued.

At 4:23, a call to Navalkishor from the smaller phone. Duration: twenty-three seconds. The phone signal was behind the new building. At 4:27, Navalkishor's device connected to the tower serving the inside of the old building.

At first Navalkishor continued to deny this exchange. Prakhar's statement was not read out to him; only the telecommunications record was shown. After a long while he said, “Prakhar told me—Didi has fallen.”

“Did you go?”

“Yes.”

“Alive?”

Navalkishor lowered his eyes. “I do not know how to check a pulse. Her body was warm.”

“Why didn't you call a doctor?”

“I was afraid.”

“Of what?”

“Everything. My job, the papers, the money... I had already burned papers that night.”

Here another door of the crime opened. Navalkishor understood that if Vasudha survived, his destruction of documents would come out; if she died, his presence there that night would surface in a murder investigation. His interest did not lie in saving Vasudha's life, but in changing the scene.

He admitted that he rearranged the papers on the table. He tore off the lower part of Vasudha's unfinished warning note, which contained the names of two people connected with the land consortium, and burned it in a small container; some ash fell beneath the table. While searching through the files, he moved the betel-nut box from right to left. The piece of betel nut from the night had been taken by him from the box while speaking with Vasudha, because he himself had the habit of chewing betel nut. This small detail had bothered Jaynarayan from the first day—Vasudha did not take betel nut at night, but a visitor might.

“The chair?” Vinay asked.

“I moved the chair while trying to lift Vasudha. Then I placed it in front of the table.”

Vasudha wrote with her left leg folded; a chair turned to the right was uncomfortable for her. Navalkishor did not know her writing habits.

“How was the door locked from inside?”

At this question Navalkishor remained silent for a long time. Then he said, "The old air duct."

Something tightened in Jaynarayan's throat. One piece of inference had finally come from a human mouth, but it was no victory.

Navalkishor had retained the key to the inspection panel from the time of repairs. He sent Prakhar out through the rear corridor, locked the room himself, and went to the storeroom. Using thin strong cord and a small hooked wire through the air duct, he pulled the latch ring and seated the latch inside. Then he pulled the cord back out. The basic details of this technique matched the possibility demonstrated in the replica test.

"The cord?"

"Cord from the repair room. White."

The thin white line first seen on the outer wall amid the rain streaks might have been a temporary contact mark from that cord or tool. The laboratory gave no definite opinion on this, but the method was consistent.

"Did you stop the clock?"

"No. It was already stopped at 4:17 when I came inside."

Prakhar had said the same. The impact mark on the clock's mechanical tooth and the replica testing of the

cupboard's vibration path were consistent with this account.

“What did you do to make it look like suicide?”

Navalkishor said: the appearance of a door locked from inside, the unfinished page on the table, the chair set in front, the stack of papers arranged. He could not construct a complete medical story explaining how Vasudha's death would look like suicide. He relied on the locked door, the half-written page, her solitude at night, and Dulari's disappearance—the rest of the story, he believed, people would make for themselves.

Jaynarayan said softly, “And people did.”

Navalkishor lowered his head.

“So did Sutra,” Abhiram, watching from outside the procedure room, said very softly.

“Sutra read data created by people,” Jaynarayan replied. “The data was filled with the scene people had staged.”

Now the question was the legal name to give the cause and circumstances of death. Was the shove intentional? Was there an intent to kill? What was the legal effect of failing to call for help after a potentially fatal injury? Destruction of evidence? Conspiracy? The court would decide those matters. The investigation team did not end its report by reducing the event to the single word ‘murder’. Each stage was written separately

—arrival, quarrel, shove, injury, failure to call for help, call to Navalkishor, destruction of documents, alteration of the scene, creation of a false locked room.

Late into the night Madhavi read the draft report. Her eyes stopped on one line: “Vasudha Karn may have been alive immediately after the injury.”

She closed the page. All this time her mind had been searching for a murderer. At this line the crime became more terrible: between Didi's life and death there may have been a few minutes in which help could have been called.

Abhiram entered the room but asked nothing. He sat on the other side of the table. After a long time Madhavi said, “What if he had called a doctor?”

Abhiram drew a breath before answering. “I don't know whether she would have survived.”

“Yes. We don't know.”

“Not knowing that is important too.”

Madhavi looked at him. Earlier Abhiram would have searched for a probability percentage in an empty space like this. Today he was leaving the empty space empty.

“You've changed,” she said.

Abhiram smiled faintly. “So has Sutra.”

“And me?”

“You... no conclusion yet.”

For the first time in many days a genuine smile came to Madhavi's face, for only a moment. “All right. Data incomplete.”

At night the courthouse clock was running again. After repairs its hands moved at an ordinary pace. Four seventeen had now become history—not a seal of suicide, not a machine's magical answer, but a violent moment in a quarrel after which human beings, each trying to save their own fear, altered the scene, their statements, and their silences.

But one witness still had not given a complete name—Dulari. She had not seen the killing. She had seen papers burning. And the more clearly the court kept the distance between fire and murder, the more possible justice would become.

Chapter 39 — Dulari's Eyes

When Dulari was called to the police station again, her first question was, “Am I an accused person or a witness?”

Saroj Devi said, “A witness. And this time your statement will not alter your earlier statement; anything new shown to you will be recorded separately.”

“Then that's fine.”

She had brought her notebook too. Her night-school homework was half written—“One Day in My Village.” Two lines at the top, then blank space. Saroj asked, “Not finished?”

“Police homework has become too much.”

Both of them laughed. For a little while, the station walls, the hard chair, and the statement papers became ordinary things.

This time the identification procedure was not about a face but a gait. Rachna had insisted that Dulari not be told Navalkishor's name or that he had been arrested. There were short videos of five men, all filmed from the same distance, faces blurred, no distinctive object in anyone's hands. Each person crossed the veranda three times at an ordinary pace.

Vinay remained outside. Jaynarayan too. Inside were Saroj, a magistrate, a clerk, and Dulari.

First video. Dulari watched and shook her head. “I don't know.”

Second. “No.”

At the third she leaned forward, then immediately back. “Play it again.”

The video ran again. When the man placed his left foot, it turned slightly outward, but only very slightly. Dulari said, “The walk seems to match. The face isn't shown, so I can't be certain.”

“Number?”

“Three. But write this too—not certain.”

Fourth, fifth—no.

Number three was Navalkishor.

The magistrate sealed the result. Then, on a separate table, Dulari was shown photographs of six key rings—all brass-coloured, different in size. She paused over two. “Like these two. In the firelight I saw only a glint. It was a large round ring.”

Navalkishor's government key ring was one of those two. Still not certain.

Saroj Devi looked toward Dulari. “The cough?”

The magistrate stopped her at once. “Not yet. That could be a leading question.”

Dulari smiled at Saroj. “I remember it. But if you give me the word first, later people will say I only repeated your word.”

Saroj lowered her head. “You’re right.”

After the procedure ended, Vinay came inside. Only then was Dulari told that number three was Navalkishor Jha—the same records assistant who had been present near the scene on the first morning.

No triumph appeared on Dulari’s face. Instead, she became quiet.

“Do you recognise him?” Madhavi, who had been waiting outside, asked.

Dulari said slowly, “I’ve seen him at the courthouse. I didn’t know his name. He carried files around many times. Once Didi told him, ‘If you change the sequence of pages in a copy, I will make a written complaint.’ That day he just laughed.”

“Why didn’t you say this earlier?”

“Because I didn’t remember that much then. Today, after hearing the face identified, the old thing connected in my mind. So don’t make this part of the identification. Write it separately.”

Jaynarayan was listening from outside. Something like pride rose in him for Dulari, but he refrained from saying it. Decorating a poor young woman's truth with the word 'bravery' can also turn ordinary good sense into a spectacle. What Dulari was doing was preserving the limits of her own statement—a right every witness ought to have.

The laboratory report arrived that afternoon. The black particles from the pocket of Navalkishor's coat contained burned paper cellulose, residues of old carbon ink, and two minute minerals in the same category as those found in the ash from the iron drum. The expert had written clearly: "Similarity supports an association; a common source is not established."

Hearing the report, Dulari said, "So the fire is not being spoken of by my eyes alone."

"Yes," Vinay said, "but science is not yet saying, 'the same fire'."

"Good. Everyone has their limits."

At that sentence Abhiram smiled. "Sutra too."

Dulari looked at him. "Write its limits first. Then fewer poor people will go to jail afterward."

Abhiram's smile vanished. He grew serious and nodded. "They are written. I'll make them clearer still."

Dulari's first statement was opened again. In it she had said, "The person seemed familiar, but I will not give a false name." In court the prosecution might say of that line: the witness was frightened. The defence might say: the witness was uncertain. Each would contain part of the truth.

Rachna, who was still connected with Dulari's legal assistance, explained to her, "In court they will ask you—did you see the killing?"

"No."

"Did you see Prakhar in the room?"

"No."

"Did you see Navalkishor burning papers, with a clear view of his face?"

Dulari paused. "Half the face. The walk, keys, build—those matched. Today the gait matched in the procedure. But I will not say 'I saw him clearly'."

"Give exactly that answer."

"People will say I remember nothing."

"Let people say what they want. In court, say only what you remember."

Dulari closed her notebook. "Didi taught me this too—don't let more be written on paper than came from your own mouth."

Madhavi's throat tightened.

Dulari looked at her. "Going to cry again?"

"No."

"Your face says yes."

"Your eyes see too much."

Dulari's face grew serious. "That is exactly what caused the trouble."

After a while she began telling again what had happened on the night she left. The police were no longer questioning her; the story was coming out of her on its own.

"I saw the fire near the drum. The person turned back. I felt as if our eyes met. I'm not certain. But at that moment, the first thing that came into my mind was not that I should tell the police. The first thought was—no one will believe me. Second—if he is a courthouse person, whom will the police question first, him or me? Third—Didi had given me the paper. If they found it on me, they would say I stole it. So I did not run away—I changed where I was staying to protect my statement."

Rachna asked, "Can you use those words in court too—I changed where I was staying?"

"Yes. If you say 'ran away', people's minds make you a criminal first."

Jaynarayan said quietly, "Words are crime scenes too."

Dulari laughed. "Now you're starting the heavy talk again."

The room lightened.

But she immediately became serious again. "One more thing. When I was on the river island, I wasn't afraid only of the police. People from the land consortium had thrown stones near my mother before. I thought—if Didi was dead, whoever wanted the paper would look for me too. I went to Phulmati Dadi's house because there nobody knew me as Vasudha Didi's girl; they knew me as Phulo's daughter."

Madhavi stored that sentence in her mind. The main story kept moving Dulari around under the name 'witness', but in her own life she had first been a daughter, a student, a labourer, a neighbour, a friend. Criminal investigation often shrinks a person's whole name into a single role.

After noon Dulari went home. Phulo was drying clothes at the doorway. The moment her daughter stepped down from the police vehicle, she glared. "The station again?"

"Witness."

"Will that word fill your stomach?"

“Is there rice today?”

“Not for you.”

“Then I’ll go back to Chunki Dadi.”

Phulo immediately left the doorway and went inside.
“Go wash your hands. I’m heating the rice.”

Mother and daughter’s love filled the house once again in the form of an argument. Madhavi, who had come to drop Dulari off, sat on the veranda and watched. When Didi was alive, she too had sat in this house many times. The tin roof, smoke, notebook, smell of rice—the papers of justice were meant for all these things. The language of the court seemed very far from them, yet in the end its meaning returned here.

While eating rice, Dulari opened her notebook. Homework—“One Day in My Village.” She began to write: the crowd at the tap in the morning, her mother washing clothes, children running to school, the cries of fish sellers, evening school. Murder, police, land—nothing.

Madhavi asked, “No police station in this day?”

“Not every day in a village has a police station in it.”

“True.”

“And not every page of my life is Vasudha Didi’s death.”

Madhavi fell silent. The sentence stood before her like Dulari's whole character.

In the evening a message came from Vinay: applications for formal charges under separate provisions had been sent to the court against Prakhar and Navalkishor. Against Prakhar: the violent shove, failure to call for help, conspiracy to destroy evidence, and acts intended to misdirect the investigation; against Navalkishor: destruction of evidence, alteration of the scene, unlawful interference with records, and conspiracy. The court would determine the final legal classification.

Madhavi showed the message to Dulari.

Dulari read it and said, "My name?"

"Principal witness."

"Again this 'principal'."

"What should I have them write?"

"Dulari Sadai. That's all."

Madhavi laughed. "That isn't possible in the file."

"Then I'll tell the court."

When Dulari reached night school, for the first time the teacher asked her nothing about the case. She only looked at the notebook. "Homework complete?"

"Half."

“Why?”

“The day became long in the middle.”

The teacher said, “Finish it today.”

Dulari sat down. Yellow lamplight fell across the page of her notebook. The same eyes that had seen fire now looked at letters. The matter of the fire would go to court; the letters would carry her along her own road. The two had different work.

On the other side of the courthouse, Jaynarayan was arranging four piles of facts for the final arguments—human testimony, physical evidence, the documentary chain, and Sutra's analysis. Abhiram asked, “Why not put everything in one file?”

Jaynarayan replied, “So the court can understand who is speaking, what the objects say, where the papers came from, and how the calculation was made. Mix them all together and it will become another shining story.”

Madhavi stood at the doorway. “And the Seventh Witness?”

Jaynarayan looked over the four piles and smiled. “Let the phrase keep doing its work in the story. In court, only what is proved will go.”

Night was falling outside. The old courthouse clock was running. It had travelled far beyond four seventeen.

Chapter 40 — Final Arguments

Eight months had passed since Vasudha's death. The rains had returned, but this time the old courthouse clock was running. Its hands no longer stopped at four seventeen; all day they measured their circular path. To Jaynarayan even this small fact mattered. Once a time has been turned into a story, it takes a long while for it to become ordinary time again.

Much had happened before the case reached final arguments. Kamli Devi had testified under oath about serving tea at dawn. Dulari did not shift her limits—she had not seen the killing, had not seen Prakhar inside the room, had not seen Navalkishor's full face; but she testified about the fire, the gait, the glint of the keys, and the bodily manner she had seen before at the courthouse. The laboratory supported an association between particles from Navalkishor's coat and ash from the drum, but did not claim they came from the same source. The medical expert said that Vasudha's head injury was sustained during life and that such an injury could result from a fall.

Prakhar's phone location, vehicle, bank debt, payments from the land consortium, and contradictions in the family's first statements came before the court as separate pieces of evidence. Arun admitted that he had earlier given an incorrect time to protect his brother. Vasudha's mother also admitted that, out of fear of

protecting the ‘name of the house’, she had concealed Prakhar's absence at dawn. The family's lies did not prove murder, but they did break the protective circle built around the event.

Against Navalkishor there stood the sequence of altered old record copies, page numbers, the red-pencil notation ‘boundary corrected’, and the later ash evidence. The old key ring found at his house could open the outer service door of the room at the scene. The main door appeared to have been locked from inside, but the old service door and ventilator arrangement made it possible to stage that appearance. Replica testing demonstrated the possibility; it did not prove that the same method had been used that night.

Rachna Mandal was no longer merely Dulari's defence lawyer; with the court's permission, she also appeared as assisting counsel on questions concerning the treatment of evidence. The prosecution against Dulari had already been formally withdrawn. Ira Sinha had written in the order: “An initial suspicion has no right to remain a permanent shadow of guilt.” On hearing the line, Dulari had only said, “Good. Now don't write this thing in my notebook.”

The courtroom was full on the day of final arguments. But at the outset Ira Sinha said, “This case is not for spectators. Those standing may sit. Anyone whispering will go outside.” The room became quiet at once.

The prosecution placed four bundles before the court. First—human testimony. Second—physical evidence. Third—the documentary chain. Fourth—technical analysis. Jaynarayan sat at the back. Eight months earlier he had made four similar piles; seeing almost the same structure now in court brought a faint smile to his face.

The prosecutor said, “The State does not rest this case on any single witness. Kamli Devi identifies Prakhar as the person who took tea at dawn. The family's first statements placed him at home; location information, the vehicle, and his later admission contradict that. Vasudha Karn was preparing to make public the original chain of land records. Prakhar was caught in a debt network connected to the land consortium. There was a confrontation between them. After a violent shove, Vasudha struck a hard edge. Instead of calling for help, Prakhar called Navalkishor, who was already linked to manipulation of records. Navalkishor altered the scene, burned papers, and tried to create a suicide narrative.”

Defence counsel rose. “It is a well-shaped story. But a well-shaped story is not proof. Kamli Devi saw someone for a few moments in the darkness before dawn. Phone location identifies an area, not a room. The injury could have resulted from a fall. Prakhar's debt is not a crime. A family's lies can arise from fear and shame. The ash on Navalkishor's coat is of the same category, not proven to come from the same drum. Dulari herself says she did not see the whole face. And Sutra's first conclusion was

wrong—it once treated Dulari as a risk, then changed its own conclusion. No crime can be proved by relying on such a tool.”

Ira Sinha asked, “Does the State treat Sutra's conclusion as independent evidence?”

The prosecutor paused. “No, Your Honour. It is assisting analysis for correlating the timeline and documents.”

“Then keep it separate in final argument. State the facts proved from the original sources. Do not increase their weight by using the language of a machine.”

The prosecutor bowed his head.

Abhiram had already faced cross-examination in the witness chair. Today he sat at the back beside Madhavi. His laptop was closed. No percentage glowed on any screen. Madhavi asked softly, “Uncomfortable?”

“A little.”

“Why?”

“I used to think the clearer the map, the closer the truth. Now I understand—sometimes the map becomes perfectly clear, while human intention remains blurred.”

Madhavi said, “Did you write that in Sutra?”

“No. That's something I have to write in myself.”

The arguments resumed. The prosecution separately read out the plaster beneath Vasudha's nails, the head injury, the clock's jolt, the sugared tea at dawn, the two cups, the service door, the burned papers, and the source interruption between 4:09 and 4:22. After each point Ira Sinha asked: "Who authenticated this?" "Where is the chain?" "Date of first inspection?" "When was the photograph taken?" "Whose signature?"

At one point the prosecutor said, "Sutra's timeline shows—"

The judge stopped him. "Sutra did not see time. It joined the times from cameras, telephones, the entry register, and human statements. Name the sources."

Silence returned to the room. Abhiram lowered his eyes, but this time not from shame. It seemed to him the court was not insulting the tool; it was placing the tool at its proper measure.

Navalkishor's defence said, "Dulari's identification is uncertain. The ash is uncertain. The keys are generic in form. From all this, a conclusion of evidence destruction cannot safely be drawn."

Rachna, who had the court's permission to make a brief submission on the limits of Dulari's testimony, rose. "The weight of Dulari's evidence is not reduced by her uncertainty; its credibility is increased by it. Where she did not see, she did not say she saw. The court should accept her statement only to the extent she gives it—she

saw fire; she saw a man whose gait later matched Navalkishor in a lawful procedure; she saw the large round glint of a key ring; and she had previously heard Vasudha argue with this records employee about the sequence of pages. The link beyond that must come from physical evidence and records, not from the witness.”

The judge asked, “Where is Dulari now?”

Rachna looked back. Dulari was sitting on the last bench beside her teacher. In her hand was not a legal note but a school notebook.

“She is present.”

Ira Sinha asked Dulari only one question. “Between your first statement and what you say today, is there anything you added because someone later told you something and then you remembered it?”

Dulari stood. “Yes. I had seen Navalkishor earlier at the courthouse arguing with Vasudha Didi; I learned his name only after the identification procedure. I stated that separately. I still do not say that I clearly saw his face on the night of the fire.”

“Good. Sit down.”

The hardest part of the final arguments concerned Prakhar's intention. Had the killing been planned in advance, or had violence occurred during a confrontation? The prosecution had payments from the land consortium, the debt, Vasudha's draft complaint,

and Prakhar's presence at dawn. But it was difficult to prove a prior plan to kill Vasudha. Navalkishor had been called in the morning—that contact was recorded; it was not proved that Prakhar had positioned him in the room beforehand.

The defence seized upon this point. “Do not turn cowardice after an accident into a pre-planned murder.”

The prosecution replied, “The shove was deliberate. No help was called after the fall. Instead, the scene was altered. This was no ordinary accident.”

Jaynarayan sat at the back listening with his eyes closed. He remembered the first sight of Vasudha—a woman found dead among legal papers, while everyone immediately built the story they preferred. Himself included. It is easy to call old experience insight; harder to see the bias inside it.

When arguments ended, Ira Sinha said, “Judgment will be delivered the day after tomorrow. Both sides will file written summaries. On technical material, one thing is already clear—the court will not treat any machine as a witness. Machine analysis is useful only when its original sources are authenticated, its process is testable, and human responsibility is identifiable. The burden of judgment belongs to human beings.”

The day after tomorrow the court was full again. This time Jaynarayan arrived early. Dulari did not come; she

had an examination at school. She had sent word: "The court knows how to give a judgment without me."

Ira Sinha did not read out the entire long judgment. The principal conclusions were read.

"Pre-planned murder is not sufficiently proved against Prakhar Karn. However, financial interest, confrontation with Vasudha Karn, a deliberate violent shove, failure to call for immediate aid after the injury, and participation thereafter in altering the scene form an integrated chain. The death is proved to be the direct result of his violent act. Accordingly, separate from pre-planned murder, guilt is established for a grave offence causing death and for conspiracy to destroy evidence."

Prakhar's face emptied. Vasudha's mother began to cry. Arun closed his eyes. The family circle had finally broken in the language of law.

"Against Navalkishor Jha, alteration of the scene, burning of documents, interference with the sequence of record pages, and acting with Prakhar to misdirect the investigation are proved by the combined chain of human testimony, key access, the ash association, particles on clothing, contact timing, and archival irregularities. There is no direct evidence that Navalkishor inflicted Vasudha's original injury; the judgment expressly preserves that limit."

Then the judge turned to Dulari. "The suspicion earlier raised against Dulari Sadai is wholly

extinguished. The court directs the police to make a clear notation in all records concerning bail, arrest, and the later withdrawal of charges, so that in any future verification the incomplete shadow of ‘murder accused’ does not remain attached to her name.”

Rachna bowed her head gravely. Such a line is small on paper, but large in the future of a poor person.

The final passage concerned technical material. “The use of Sutra's first erroneous conclusion is a warning from this case. Its later corrections were useful; usefulness is not omniscience. Judicial decision rests on sources, testing, cross-examination, and accountable human beings.”

Abhiram drew a deep breath. It seemed to him that the tool he had built had not lost today. For the first time, it had been given limits.

Outside, reporters ran in every direction. Questions came from all sides—Prakhar, Navalkishor, artificial intelligence, the land consortium. Vinay said only, “Read the judgment. A case does not fit into one sentence.”

As they descended the steps Jaynarayan said, “A lot of people want truth in a single line.” Abhiram laughed and added, “Sometimes it needs an entire volume, along with the version history.” Outside the gate, Kamli Devi's tea was boiling.

The criminal knot of the case had been opened. But the real life of the papers Vasudha had tried to save was still waiting on the road to another court—Seven Hamlets, seven marks, and the soil whose name had been changed again and again on paper.

Chapter 41 — The Soil Finds Its Name Again

The criminal judgment did not make the land return by itself. Rachna made that clear to the Seven Hamlets families at the very first meeting. “The convictions of Prakhar and Navalkishor have strengthened the suspicion of tampering with the records. But land rights are a separate proceeding. Here the origin of every paper, the boundaries, possession, tax receipts, family succession, and the history of government copies will all have to be examined again.”

The meeting took place in Rahmat Kaka's courtyard. Coloured binding cloth hung drying on a bamboo line. People came from all seven hamlets—some with old sacks of papers, some with receipts in tin boxes, some carrying nothing but the names of their grandparents. Dulari sat at the back among the children, yet she was taking the best notes of anyone there.

“How will my name come onto the list?” an elderly woman asked.

“First we will read what is already there,” Rachna said. “Whatever is not there, we will not invent a new story ourselves and add it.”

Jaynarayan looked toward Rahmat Kaka. “We should write that sentence into every project.”

Tightening a knot in a length of thread, Rahmat Kaka said, “You’ll starve the writers.”

Everyone laughed.

It took another two months to complete the expert examination of the seventh authentication mark. The circle with seven dots, mentioned in Kusuma’s letter, was found in two preserved 1934 copies, on the fragment discovered in the pocket of the 1935 filing register, and in images of private household papers from three families. In five amended copies made after 1941, the mark was broken, displaced, or entirely absent. The paper, ink, and handwriting experts did not all say the same thing; but their combined opinion was clear—the old seven-mark chain predated the later copies and the documents in it were mutually related.

In its first response, the government records department was careful: “This does not by itself establish ownership.”

Rachna said, “Quite right. I am not saying ownership is automatically established either. But the authenticity of the copies on which the eviction notices rely is now under serious question. To remove people first and investigate afterward would not be justice.”

The interim hearing on land rights took place in the district civil court. This time there were no cameras and the crowd was smaller. A land case does not become an immediate spectacle the way a criminal case can; it may

drag on for years. But even one day weighed heavily on the Seven Hamlets families, because the land consortium already had a bulldozer contract prepared.

The government side said, “In the present records, the plots stand in the name of the project. Authentication of the old documents remains under examination. The petitioners' possession is mixed; some portions may also constitute encroachment.”

Rachna replied, “We are not asking for final ownership today. We are asking for maintenance of the status quo. A records employee whose criminal interference has been established was involved in the chain by which the copies relied upon by the State were created. The old seven-mark authentication chain is broken in the present copies. These families have been present for decades in residence, tax, water-use, school, and panchayat records. Displacement before the inquiry is complete would cause irreversible harm.”

The judge asked, “Why does the government require immediate possession now?”

The officer turned the pages of the file. “The project has a binding timeline.”

“A person's home is not an empty box on a schedule,” the judge said, then immediately added, “But the court will issue orders on records, not emotion. The State shall produce within seven days the original land records,

amendment orders, inspection register, and the chain by which the copies were created.”

At the final line of the order, the people of the Seven Hamlets seemed to breathe out together: “Until then, status quo. No demolition, forced displacement, or creation of new third-party rights.”

When they came outside, no one raised slogans. Old Parvati Devi sat down on the ground and opened her bag to touch an old receipt again. “Have we won?”

Rachna sat beside her. “For now, the house is safe. This is not the final victory.”

Parvati Devi said, “If the house is safe, we can fight the case.”

That sentence travelled through the Seven Hamlets until evening.

The survey team came the following week. This time there was no secret measurement. At every boundary point there were local families, a government surveyor, a court-appointed observer, and photographic documentation. Abhiram brought his system, but first wrote on paper: “Sutra's map is an assisting visualisation; not a statutory survey.” Dulari read it and laughed. “Now your tool writes its own limits first.”

“Your contribution.”

“Will you pay my jail fee?”

Abhiram's face tightened. Dulari immediately said, "A joke. But remember it."

"I will."

Madhavi went house to house with the survey team. One mother who did sewing pulled an old box out from beneath the thatch. Inside were two letters written by Vasudha—one a draft request for a school-fee waiver, the other a list of women from the Seven Hamlets. Vasudha had not seen the land case merely as a dispute about field boundaries; for her the soil meant home, school, hearth, pond, the path to work, a place for the dead to be cremated, and ground for children to play.

Madhavi read the letters and remained silent for a long time. The mother asked, "Going to cry again?"

"No."

"Your face gives away lies like Dulari's."

They both laughed.

The old blue thread on Rahmat Kaka's household paper was not cut for scientific testing. The experts used only imaging, fibre-direction analysis, and non-destructive colour testing. Kaka had said plainly, "If cutting an ancestor's thread isn't necessary to preserve an ancestor's paper, then don't cut it." The court agreed.

One day word came from the government copy office: the order register used to create the certified 1972 copy

had been found. On the original order page there was no lawful approval for ‘correcting’ the Seven Hamlets boundary. Someone's later hand had added a note in the margin. The signature was illegible, but the ink belonged to a later period. This did not establish final ownership, but it weakened the foundation of the present project records still further.

Rachna placed the paper on the table and said, “The biggest point now is not simply that the old paper is true. The bigger point is that the new paper cannot prove itself true.”

Jaynarayan said, “In many cases, catching the lie is easier than finding the truth.”

“But people need the truth about land,” Madhavi said.

“Which is why it takes time.”

Three months later the interim order was extended. The State was directed to carry out a fresh survey, give the Seven Hamlets families individual hearings on their claims, and decide upon the expert report concerning the old seven-mark chain. The land consortium's construction permission remained suspended in the meantime.

On the day of that order, Dulari came outside the courthouse carrying her examination result. She had passed into the higher class at night school. Waving the

paper in her hand, she said, "Today this is bigger news than the order about our land."

Phulo immediately said, "Find a job first."

"Study first."

"Your stomach?"

"Both."

Kamli Devi served tea. Rahmat Kaka had made a small cloth cover for Dulari's notebook—not blue, but green. "Blue thread has caused enough lawsuits," he said.

Dulari burst out laughing. "The green-thread lawsuit can come later."

On the road back to the Seven Hamlets, a new government signboard had been installed: "AREA UNDER RESURVEY; COURT-ORDERED STATUS QUO IN FORCE." It was not a title deed. But for the first time another colour of law had been painted over the bulldozer's red mark.

Parvati Devi could not read the signboard. Dulari read it aloud to her. The old woman touched the earth. "Is my name written?"

"For now, the area's name is."

"When will my name be?"

Dulari said, “When you submit your papers at the hearing.”

Parvati Devi smiled. “Then I will stay alive.”

Hearing this, Madhavi remembered Vasudha. Some lives end before the whole result can be seen. That does not mean their work is unfinished; sometimes other people make that incompleteness the work of their own day.

In the evening children were playing beside the Seven Hamlets pond. The surveyor's white lime marks were still visible on the soil. Abhiram opened the map on his phone, then closed it again. Madhavi asked, “Won't you look?”

“Today I'll look with my eyes.”

“Progress.”

“Should Sutra record that?”

“No. Not every improvement is data.”

They walked some distance together. The space between them was no longer as taut as before. Affection did not immediately return to its old shape. The soil of trust, too, demanded a resurvey—which boundary was true, which line had been drawn in fear, which word had been added later.

Abhiram said, “I want to tell you something now without hiding behind anyone's papers. I like being with

you. But I don't want Vasudha Didi's death, the case, or our shared work to force the two of us into one story."

Madhavi looked toward the pond water. "I like being with you too. But if you hide something again—"

"Then?"

"Then first I'll be angry, and after that I'll ask questions."

"Can't the order be reversed?"

"No."

Abhiram laughed. "All right."

Madhavi took his hand, only for a few steps. No promise, no prediction. An evening road, two hands, and a little less fear.

Behind them, people in the Seven Hamlets were returning to their homes. The soil had not yet fully returned, but its name had begun to be spoken again—in receipts, hearings, maps, children's homework. Names erased from paper were slowly finding their voices again.

Chapter 42 — Where Reason Falls Silent

Six months had passed since the main room of the mansion was sealed again. The criminal case was over, the land case was still proceeding, and the old building was now treated, by court order, as a protected archival site. Entry required two keys, signatures, a time register, and the corridor camera. Since Vasudha's death, no one had entered alone.

Madhavi was now working on contract at the district archives centre. Her work was to build bridges between the local names in old documents, dialect, family memory, and official indexes. Abhiram was working on a new version of Sutra—now every conclusion had to display three things in front of it: source, uncertainty, and “Reviewed by which human being?” Jaynarayan had once again announced his retirement, which everyone understood to mean that he would no longer come to court every day, but the moment someone said, “There is one thing I cannot understand,” he would appear.

Dulari had enrolled in regular school classes. She had not left night school; she said, “That is where I first wrote my own name.” Phulo still grumbled at the expense of her studies, but whenever her daughter came home late, she was found standing at the door. Kamli Devi had not changed her habit of asking how much sugar to put in

the tea. Rahmat Kaka was now sewing conservation cloth for the Seven Hamlets documents.

Life continues even after a mystery. That was the hardest and the most consoling thing of all.

One evening a message came from the conservation department: damp had been noticed in the ceiling of the mansion's main room; an inspection was necessary before the rains. Vinay Thakur, archivist Shashibhushan Mishra, a building engineer, Madhavi, Abhiram, and Jaynarayan were given permission for a joint inspection.

“Why me?” Jaynarayan asked.

Vinay replied, “Because if you are not there, later you will ask—how did you see it?”

“Fine. A new way to insult an old man.”

The next morning they checked every seal before entering. The camera register was correct. The previous entry had been eighteen days earlier for measuring the ceiling, and five people had been present then too. The seal on the main room was intact. The window was locked from inside. A new metal seal was on the service door. There was mesh over the ventilator.

The old shiver returned to Madhavi's body, but the fear was no longer as sharp as before. The room now felt less like a crime scene and more like a place of memory. The table stood where it had stood, the mark on the wall had been preserved, and the clock had not been rehung

after the laboratory examination; only a faint circular patch remained.

The engineer began examining the corner of the ceiling. Shashibhushan placed the moisture meter. Vinay kept writing in the seal register. Abhiram was correlating the camera times. Jaynarayan stood by the window looking out at the peepal tree.

Madhavi went near the table. At first she thought someone had left the conservation cloth folded there. In the middle of the white cloth lay a brown sheet of paper. A blue thread ran once around its four sides and was tied in a small knot.

She stopped.

“Vinay.”

Her voice was so quiet that everyone turned.

“No one touch anything,” Vinay said immediately.

The room became still. Abhiram’s hand stopped in mid-air. Jaynarayan came slowly toward the table but remained two steps away. Shashibhushan was wearing gloves, yet even he moved his hands behind his back.

Vinay first made a video of everything around it: the tabletop, the paper, the thread, the line of dust, the window, the door. “Was this in the inventory from the last inspection?”

Shashibhushan’s face went pale. “No.”

“Did the conservation team leave anything?”

“No. Every object was inventoried. Nothing tied with blue thread.”

Abhiram said, “I’ll check the cameras.”

“Not yet,” Jaynarayan said. “First record everything that is in front of us.”

Vinay looked at him, then nodded.

The decision to open the sheet was not made at once. An unidentified object had been found inside a court-sealed room; telephone permission from a magistrate, an independent witness, and the conservation procedure all had to be set in motion again. Two hours later, after every formality was complete, the blue-thread knot was not cut. Rahmat Kaka was shown it over video. He said, “Untie the knot. Do not cut it. It resembles Kusuma’s binding, but write ‘resembles’. The original is not in front of me.”

With a thin tool, Shashibhushan loosened the knot. The sheet opened.

Madhavi stopped breathing.

It was the complete text of the same letter whose two physical fragments still lay sealed in separate protective sleeves in the district archives. The first six marks, the seventh household-paper mark, the circle with seven

dots, Kusuma's name "Seventh Witness", the private mark of the blue thread—everything. The final line too:

"Where in the record do we place the one who sees but does not name?"

But this sheet was not torn. It was intact.

For several moments no one spoke.

Abhiram moved toward his laptop to open the already preserved digital image, then stopped. "First the seals on the two original fragments need to be checked."

Vinay immediately called the archives. On live video, the protective sleeves were shown—both fragments inside under their own numbers. The seals were intact. There was nothing unusual in the access register.

Shashibhushan sat down in a chair. "Then this could be a third copy."

Jaynarayan said, "It could be."

"We'll test the age of the paper."

"We will."

"The ink."

"We will."

Now Abhiram opened the camera register. Three sources: the mansion's outer gate, the main corridor, and the room door. He searched the motion markers for the

previous eighteen days. Everyone who had entered appeared in the list. No shadow at night. No interruption in any source.

“The cameras show no one entering,” Abhiram said softly.

Vinay immediately said, “That does not yet mean no one entered. Blind angles, old recordings, access through the roof, technical failure—we examine all of it.”

Abhiram looked at him. “Right.”

A smile came involuntarily to Madhavi’s lips. “We’ve all improved.”

Jaynarayan said, “No. We’ve all become afraid.”

A light laugh passed through the room, then quiet returned.

At the sight of the blue thread, Madhavi remembered the dream—the red dupatta, the anklet, the dark veranda, the back of a woman whose face she had never seen clearly. Now she did not turn the dream into evidence. She told herself: a dream is a dream. The paper in front of us is paper. The shiver between the two has another name.

“What do you think?” Abhiram asked softly.

“I think I know nothing.”

“That was not your answer before.”

“Nor yours.”

They looked at one another. In affection, sometimes the safest sentence is “I don’t know.” There is no deceit in that sentence, no performance, only space—for another person, for a new fact, for a different future.

By the time the inspection ended, evening had come. The sheet was placed in a new, separate evidence folder; the blue thread as well. Nothing would be said until testing was complete. Vinay wrote clearly: “Origin unknown; historicity unverified; visual similarity only.” Abhiram took a photograph of the sentence.

“Why?” Madhavi asked.

“For Sutra’s training.”

“Again?”

“This time the first lesson of the training is: write the unknown as unknown.”

Jaynarayan came out onto the veranda. The rain had stopped. In the wet courtyard, light clung to the leaves of the peepal tree. From the distant courthouse came the sound of the clock—five strokes.

Madhavi and Abhiram stood beside him. Behind them, Vinay was closing the papers.

Abhiram asked, “Jaynarayan Babu, the cameras are clean. The seals are clean. The two fragments are in the

archives. Here is an intact copy. What does your intuition say?”

Jaynarayan looked at him as though a very old question had returned wearing new clothes.

“My intuition is silent for now.”

“Really?”

“Yes. When facts are few, silence is part of intelligence.”

Madhavi laughed. “Why didn’t you learn that earlier?”

“Age was not wasted.”

The three of them began descending the steps. Halfway down, Jaynarayan stopped. He looked back at the mansion’s closed door. Behind it, a new question was now sealed—not to solve a crime, not to establish a right to land. Simply a question.

Madhavi looked at him and asked, “Must every witness have a name?”

Jaynarayan smiled.

“Not every witness gives testimony in court.”

With that, he moved on.

The rain clouds broke and a pale light appeared in the west. Madhavi took Abhiram’s hand. This time not

merely for a few steps; but neither did she imagine it was forever. A hand in the present was enough for the present.

Behind them the mansion was silent. The cameras were running. The seals gleamed. The sheet lay inside its folder. The blue thread was in a separate sleeve. Reason had done its work and gone as far as it could. Beyond it was not darkness, but an uncertain light—where a question could remain alive without a false answer.

The Seventh Witness remained silent in that light.

The door was locked from inside. So was the truth — until now.

When advocate Vasudha Karn is found dead in her own chambers at four seventeen in the morning — the latch fastened from within, the lamp still burning over an unfinished sentence — a small courthouse town in the Mithila countryside is left with an impossible question: how does a woman die alone in a room no one could enter?

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